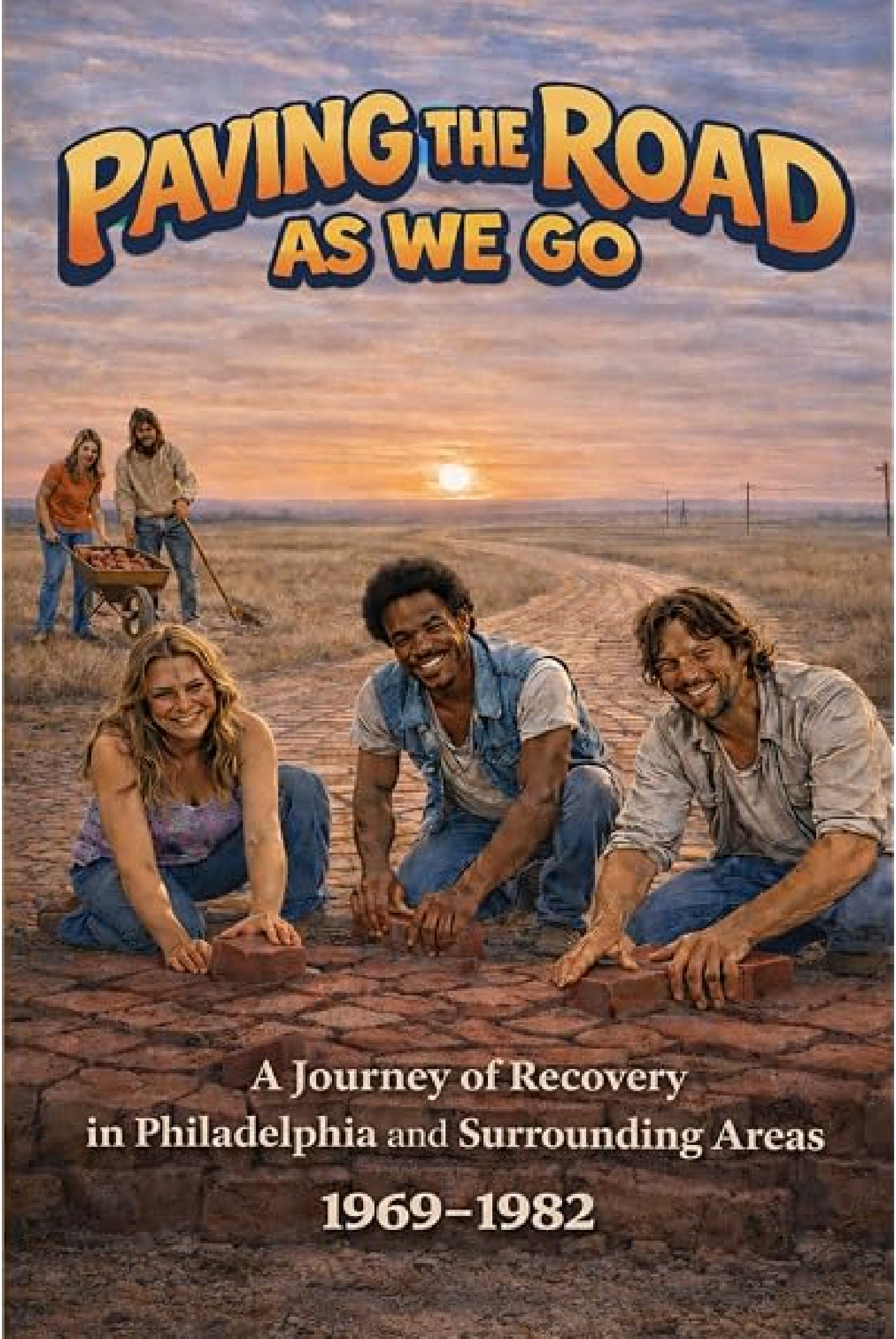

PAVING THE ROAD AS WE GO
A Journey of Recovery
in Philadelphia and Surrounding Areas
1969–1982

CONTENTS

Page references follow the printed book. Larger type for co-author review.

DISCLAIMER	—
ACKNOWLEDGMENTS	—
PREFACE	—
INTRODUCTION	1
ALTERNATIVES	7
EARLY GARDENERS	37
NA’S PRESENCE IN PENNSYLVANIA	63
IDENTIFICATION	117
INTERGROUP	131
BEING OF SERVICE	159
THE SERVICE STRUCTURE	187
FELLOWSHIP	211
CUSTOMS	229
LITERATURE	237
THE EAST COAST AWAKENS	261
AFTERWORD	271
QUESTIONNAIRE	277

DISCLAIMER

This book attempts to provide a comprehensive history of the beginnings of Narcotics Anonymous in Philadelphia and surrounding areas from the late 1960s to the establishment of the Greater Philadelphia Regional Service Committee in 1982.

The views and opinions found in this book belong solely to the individuals interviewed and do not necessarily reflect the positions or opinions of any organization, institution, or individual with which the material is affiliated. Moreover, the information presented herein does not belong to or represent any group or service body of Narcotics Anonymous or to Narcotics Anonymous as a whole.

Exhaustive research was completed to verify the accuracy of the material presented and although cross-checking of information was undertaken, errors may still exist.

Neither the publisher nor any associated parties shall be held responsible for any consequences arising from the opinions or interpretations expressed within this book.

The Philadelphia NA Book Project members believe deeply in disseminating the history of how NA came to be in Pennsylvania and have agreed that they will not accept any profit from this publication. The Project members provided their own funding to cover editing and publishing costs.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

We express our gratitude to the addicts whose participation made this book possible, especially those who shared their time and were willing to be interviewed, offering their experience, strength, and hope. Without their willingness to share, this book may not have been written.

Many addicts were not interviewed for this book, yet their efforts and service helped shape the early growth of Narcotics Anonymous in Philadelphia and the surrounding areas. We acknowledge all those who played a part in NA's beginnings and hope this book reflects their contributions with honesty and respect.

Members of the Philadelphia Book Project are identified in bold.

AJ, Al R., Alice C., Bill O., Bill B., Bob P., Brian T., Carl W., Charlie F., Cindy R., Craig L., Danny F., Danny M., Dave F., Dave S., Debbie K., Dennis D., Denny S., Dwayne, Eileen G., Gary F., George R., George W., Gerry S., Harry P., Henry D., Jack C., Jeanne S., Jeff C., Jeff S., Jill F., Jim D., Jim F., Jim H., John D., John S., John Sw., Julie, Kathy H., Ken E., Kur B., Kurt E., Margie C., Maria R., Mary Mc., Mary R., Maureen M., Mike B., Mr X., Neil M., Noel F., Patti Ann, Patty M., Paul Z., Paula B., Pete B., Phil S., Ray D., Ray T., Reggie M., Rob U., Sharon B., Tommy C., Toni C., Wayne P., William L. White.

Those who have passed away and whose stories contributed to this project:

Barb. B., Bob Mc., Danny S., Dick B., Dick F., Don L., Dr. Donald Ottenberg, Dutch H., Jay M., John F., Kathy B., Mary R., Mike S., Pat P., Rich M., Roy P., Stan B.

PREFACE

Over the years many Narcotics Anonymous history symposia have been held in and around Philadelphia. Members with long-term recovery recorded their stories about “how it was back in the day.” Others have documented fragments of history focused on the Philadelphia area. Yet, no one has attempted to compile a more comprehensive history that traces how the recovery message spread within and beyond Philadelphia, and the struggles and the strengths members experienced.

We often heard the question, “When did the Greater Philadelphia Region start?” One member was asked this question at a Greater Philadelphia Regional meeting in early 2023. He then contacted others interested in documenting the history and the Philadelphia NA Book Project began.

Our mission statement: The Philadelphia NA Book Project is a non-profit grass-roots effort to write a definitive history of NA in Philadelphia and surrounding areas.

The region’s roots can be traced to 1969, when Roy P. brought a White Book from California to Philadelphia. We gathered source material from just before 1969 through 1982, when the Greater Philadelphia Region met for the first time.

We defined the geographic scope as eastern Pennsylvania-from communities near the Susquehanna River to the state’s eastern border. We also included most of southern New Jersey and northern Delaware. This boundary helped prevent scope drift as we wrote the book.

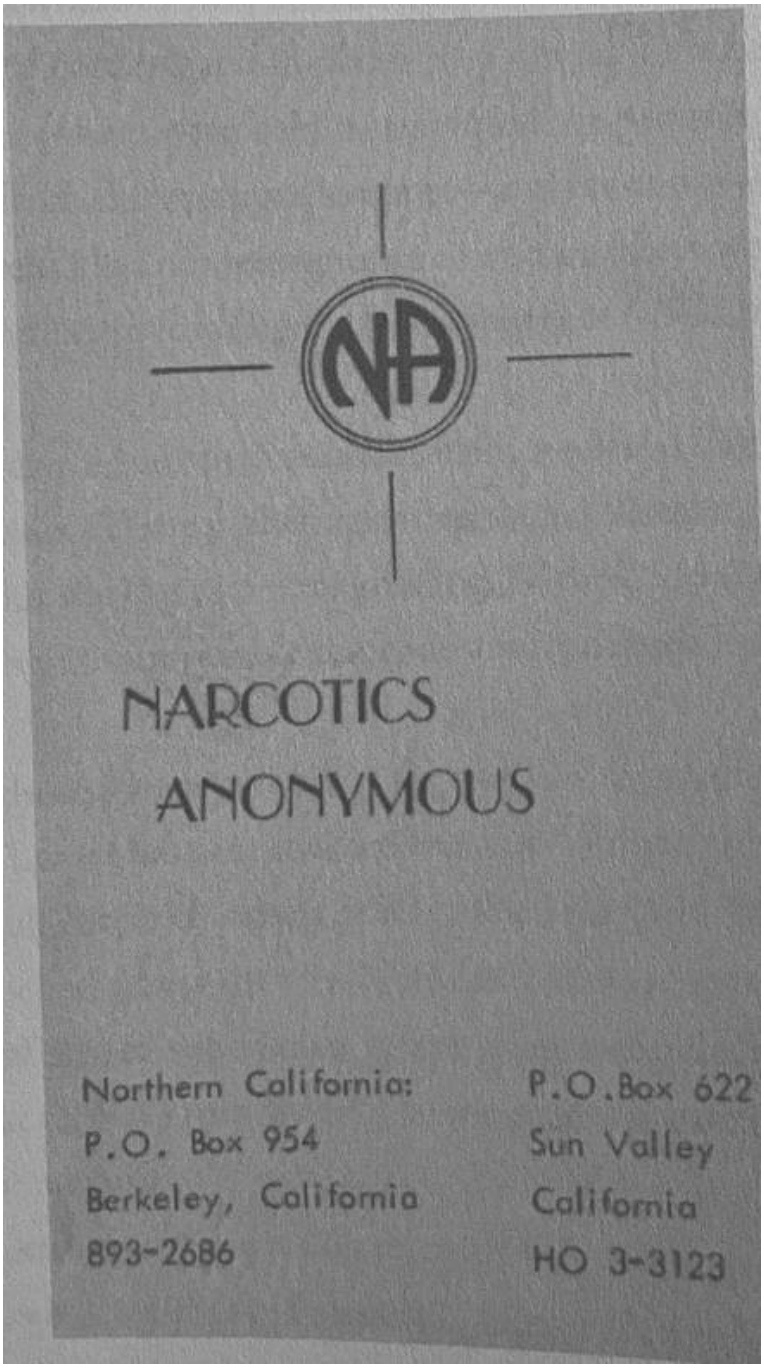
The history draws on fellowship archives, memorabilia, and group, area, and regional records. We also used books, magazines, newspapers, and internet sources as well as member interviews to verify information. Despite our exhaustive efforts to verify all materials and accounts, factual or interpretational errors may remain.

Because communication was much slower at the time, many meeting and event dates are estimated. More meetings were shared by word-of-mouth rather than printed in directories. We lacked reliable source material from the late 1970s. When possible, we used verified dates; otherwise we referenced approximate months or years to avoid inaccuracies.

This publication acknowledges the many contributors to NA in Pennsylvania and beyond. To maintain anonymity, we used only first names and last initials, whether individuals are living or deceased. We make exceptions only for individuals whose full names already appear in public. This approach also guided our selection of photographs.

Names appear as they were known at the time; in cases of marriage, last initials may differ. Although Narcotics Anonymous takes no position on external matters, we include some factual statements for historical clarity. These references are supported in the Bibliography, which cites sources outside of NA literature and member contributions. We verified all information to the best of our ability, though future discoveries may lead to corrections.

INTRODUCTION



The story of Narcotics Anonymous in Philadelphia began humbly—with one addict, a White Book, and a desperate desire to save his own life. In 1969, a presentation at Eagleville Hospital ignited a spark. From that moment, the first NA meeting was born, marking the beginning of a movement that would grow into a cornerstone of recovery in the region.

In those earliest days, there was no roadmap—just a raw, collective determination. Members knew instinctively that the future of NA depended on reaching out, bringing others in, and spreading the message one addict at a time. The sense of discovery was palpable. This wasn't just recovery—it was the building of something new, something essential.

In the early 1970s, before NA had taken root in Philadelphia, recovering addicts sought refuge wherever they could—on porches, in church halls, in upstairs rooms, in borrowed corners, and in places they were not always welcome. Some were told to leave; others were told to stay quiet or pretend to be something they weren't. Yet from this scattered support—and resistance—emerged the first glimpse of a different kind of meeting: a space where addicts could identify freely, speak honestly, and begin forming the fellowship that would become the NA of today.

NA meetings existed in institutional settings—detox units, state hospitals, and military facilities. These gatherings often served Vietnam veterans wrestling with addiction, but the logistics were grueling. With all meetings located outside the city, members without reliable transportation endured long drives to simply attend.

Everyone on those journeys lived in the city. Yet they were traveling miles to find recovery. That realization sparked the first Philadelphia-based NA meetings. While not all survived, others quickly filled the gaps. By late 1972, several meetings had opened across the city. With each new gathering, a broader vision emerged—one of shared experience, growing open-mindedness, and a deepening commitment to NA's principles. The message was catching on, not only in Philadelphia but beyond.

Before 1973, scattered reports documented NA meetings in Springfield, Bellmawr, Norristown, Lewisburg, Pottstown, Upper Darby, Williamsport, and of course, Philadelphia. NA activity also appeared inside institutions such as Haverford

State Hospital, Walson Army Hospital at Fort Dix, and Trenton State Health Facility.

Then came a surge. In 1973, NA's momentum accelerated. Members launched meetings everywhere they could—rehabs, jails, hospitals, detox units. They established an NA Hotline, formed an Intergroup, created early public relations efforts, and organized a Steering Committee. With little service experience, they forged ahead-isolated, but determined-doing things no one had done before.

As NA spread into north-central Pennsylvania and neighboring states, friction sometimes followed. In towns like Lewisburg and Williamsport, a wave of newcomers overwhelmed several AA groups, creating what some described as a "hullabaloo." Separate meetings were created under the name "Drug Abusers Anonymous," complete with mandatory urine testing. Philadelphia's Intergroup reached out, reminding these groups that such practices violated NA's spirit—an early sign of organizational maturity and loyalty to core principles.

Outreach expanded rapidly. Members spoke at community events and celebrated clean time—first in months, then in years. Local newspapers began publishing meeting schedules, hotline numbers, and articles about the fellowship. NA was gaining legitimacy.

During these years, meetings still relied heavily on AA literature. But NA's voice remained distinct: the focus was recovery from addiction, not from any specific drug. That distinction allowed members to speak freely and attracted those who hadn't found a home elsewhere.

There were setbacks. Some meetings closed as quickly as they opened. Spaces were hard to secure, and in some cases, groups were asked to leave due to disruptive behavior. But persistence won out. Churches eventually offered more consistent meeting places, and a sense of order slowly emerged. Early meetings were rarely named; instead, they were known by their street corners—Broad & Duncannon, 13th & Ruscomb, 10th & the Boulevard. In Lewisburg, it was simply the Monday Night Meeting.

As NA gained stability, a unique East Coast identity took shape. All-night "Addithons" became a local hallmark—marathon meetings fueled by the energy of a growing community. Meanwhile, service structures inspired by California's

The N.A. Tree began to appear. These early efforts laid the groundwork for future areas and, eventually, regions.

This growth contributed to the formation of the Mid-Atlantic Region, which stretched from Virginia Beach to Connecticut—a sign of NA's expanding unity. Philadelphia was becoming an essential part of something much larger.

When the World Service Office called for personal recovery stories for a forthcoming "NA Big Book," Philadelphia members answered. For the first time, they traveled to NA World Conventions outside California, planting the seeds for an East Coast Convention of their own. NA was no longer in its infancy—it was maturing, and Philadelphia was helping lead the way.

From a single meeting in 1969 to more than 400 in the Greater Philadelphia Region today, the growth is staggering. But numbers alone don't tell the story.

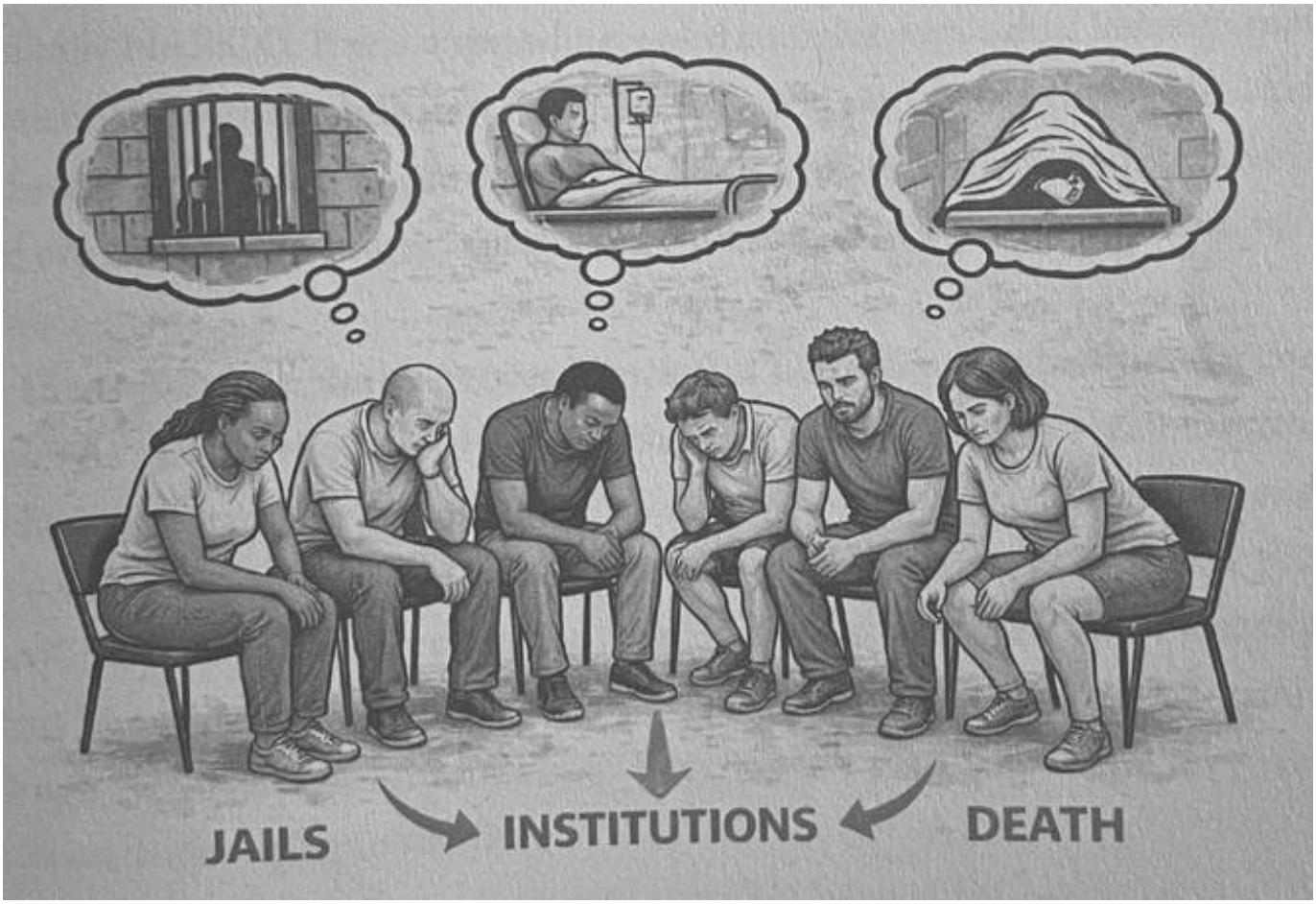
As Dutch H., one of the early members, reflected:

Philly needs to understand where its roots came from ... I used too much, and I ended up here because I had nowhere else to go. And I don't want to be anywhere else. I lost a lot of good friends—the only people I had in my life. At that time, I really had no one else. And for those people, at least for today—I want their legacy to mean something ... If anything is ever written, I hope it won't be the kind that makes a lot of money. It should be for those guys—the ones who paved the way, who kicked the doors in. I'll never forget them ... I can't talk about history without asking—what do we still need to do?

Another member may have said it best: "We were paving the road that we were traveling on."

This is that road. These are the people who laid it. And this is the story they gave to all of us.

ALTERNATIVES



Lexington Hospital

Long before the name Narcotics Anonymous echoed through church basements and hospital chapels, another experiment in addiction treatment was unfolding behind the walls of two federal institutions. These were the narcotic farms—large compounds that blended hospital, prison, research center, and labor colony. Operated by the U.S. Public Health Service during an era when addiction was viewed less as illness and more as moral weakness or social danger, these institutions represented the government's most significant attempt to manage addiction before modern treatment emerged. In 1935, under the leadership of Dr. Lawrence Kolb, the first facility opened in Lexington, Kentucky. Officially known as the United States Narcotic Farm, or simply NARCO, it was a sprawling, co-ed complex with a dual identity: part penitentiary, part rehabilitation hospital. A second site opened three years later in Fort Worth, Texas. Together, they embodied the federal government's early and often conflicted strategy for dealing with addiction—part compassion, part containment.

The U.S. Public Health Service Hospital at Lexington, Kentucky, was a crucible. As early as the late 1940s, graduates of that institution began carrying something intangible with them when they left: a seed. Wherever they landed-whether in their home neighborhoods, halfway houses, or even new prisons-they planted that seed in the form of 12-Step meetings. These meetings went by various names: Addicts Anonymous, Narco Group, Habit Forming Drugs, even Narcotics Anonymous. They weren't yet a fellowship; they were isolated flames trying to stay lit.

Of the two federal farms, Lexington quickly became the better known. For decades, it was the country's most prominent addiction research and treatment site. Its mission, however, was divided. Federal prison authorities saw Lexington primarily as a place to isolate "incorrigible" addicts; Public Health Service doctors envisioned it as a psychiatric hospital for people with substance use disorders.

Patients—many of whom were also inmates—held their own mixed opinions.

Some viewed Lexington as a haven: a clean, structured place where they could

detox, eat regularly, receive medical care, and attend counseling. Others dismissed it entirely. Among old-timers, the phrase "I never went to Lexington" carried a certain pride, implying toughness or refusal to be institutionalized. Yet even with its resources, Lexington rarely offered lasting recovery. Many returned repeatedly, each detox followed by relapse. For some, these cycles provided brief relief from the pressure of street life but no meaningful change. This revolving door deepened public skepticism toward institutional treatment and reinforced the harsh belief of the era: "once a junkie, always a junkie, "

Amid these struggles, something unexpected emerged-not from federal policy, but from personal conviction. In June 1944, Houston S., an alcoholic from Montgomery, Alabama, got sober in Alcoholics Anonymous. As his recovery deepened, so did his belief that AA's Twelve Steps could help addicts of all kinds. "I was convinced," he later wrote, "that the Twelve suggested Steps would work as well for drugs as for alcohol if conscientiously applied."

Houston approached Dr. V.H. Vogel, the chief medical officer at the National Institute of Mental Health located on the Lexington grounds, and offered to start a Twelve-Step-style meeting for the residents. Dr. Vogel approved, and on February 16, 1947, the first Addicts Anonymous meeting was held inside the federal narcotic farm. For more than twenty years, the group met weekly—an early, documented attempt to adapt AA's structure and philosophy to drug addiction, long before NA officially existed.

Craig L., an NA member decades later, shared a stark reminder of what it meant to be an addict in those years:

My sponsor once told me he got locked up in Philly for internal possession. They sent him to Lexington—a federal hospital and prison. He had track marks, and they locked him up. That's what they did to junkies back then.

Despite its limitations, Lexington nurtured a modest publication called The Key to help former patients stay connected. More importantly, it proved that some form of recovery was possible-if not within its fences, then beyond them. The language and structure of the Twelve Steps survived the institution's walls,

eventually migrating into community centers, church basements, and, ultimately, the fellowship that would become Narcotics Anonymous. In February 1974, the U.S. Public Health Service Hospital in Lexington closed its doors, bringing an end to the narcotic farm era. But its influence—complex, controversial, and often painful—continued to echo through the early history of recovery in America.

The Methadone Experiment

Before the 1960s, opioid addiction in America was treated with a single, rigid approach: abstinence. Detox meant cold sweats, vomiting, sleepless nights, and isolation in locked wards or prison-like hospital rooms. Relapse was almost guaranteed. Treatment became a revolving door, and "recovery" often meant little more than surviving the gap between detoxes.

That began to change in 1964, when researchers at Rockefeller University introduced a new approach: methadone hydrochloride as a long-acting opioid substitute. Designed to prevent withdrawal without producing the intense euphoria of heroin, methadone offered something radically different. The goal was no longer simply to detox, but to stabilize the addict. The study was cautious, tightly monitored, and quietly revolutionary. It marked the beginning of methadone maintenance therapy in the United States.

In the years that followed, methadone clinics opened across the country. One of the earliest stood at Broad and Morris Streets in South Philadelphia. By the early 1970s, programs were operating in Kensington, Allegheny, and Norristown—neighborhoods already deeply affected by heroin use.

Ray D. was among the first Philadelphians inducted into methadone treatment. He received his doses in Kensington and remembered the experience clearly: "There was no kick.. you didn't get high on it. It just kind of leveled you off. There was no pleasure in it."

For others, the program provided structure. Paula B., who entered a clinic in Norristown, found a rhythm in the daily routine. For a time, she believed this was as close to recovery as she might ever come: drinking her dose, talking with others at the clinic, staying out of jail. That, she thought, was success. "I thought

my path was laid out," she later said. "Take the methadone, stay mostly clean, and call that living." But in abstinence-based settings—especially at Eagleville Hospital—methadone maintenance was viewed with deep skepticism, if not outright hostility. Eagleville enforced a strict rule: no methadone patients unless they agreed to taper and detox. Dennis D., on a stable 90-milligram maintenance dose, was among those caught in the tension between the two philosophies. He and several others had begun supplementing their methadone with pills from outside the system. When the program director discovered it, Dennis was cut off immediately. No taper. No warning. His family, desperate, dragged him to Eagleville in January 1972. He arrived kicking and screaming, stripped of both dignity and any belief that life without drugs was possible.

This was the divide of the era. To some, methadone offered hope: a way to manage addiction without chaos, hold a job, avoid arrest, and begin healing. To others—particularly early NA members and traditional residential rehabs-it represented compromise, a chemical leash rather than true recovery.

These competing beliefs weren't theoretical debates. They played out in treatment admissions, in social stigma, and in emerging recovery identities. Were you truly clean if you were on methadone? Could someone attending a clinic belong in a Twelve Step meeting? For many early NA members, the answer was simple. For others, the line blurred in the lived reality of suffering and survival.

Ultimately, the methadone debate revealed a deeper truth: people were desperate for something that worked. For some, relief came in a carefully measured dose. For others, it came through abstinence and spiritual transformation. But for all of them, recovery—however defined—was born from unimaginable struggle.

The Synanon Model

In the late 1950s, in a quiet corner of Ocean Park, California, an unconventional experiment was taking shape. Called Synanon, it introduced a radically new form of addiction recovery-one that rejected the clinical detachment of hospitals and the punitive nature of incarceration.

At its center was Charles Dederich, a former alcoholic with no formal medical training but an unwavering belief that addicts could be transformed—not merely stabilized, but remade from the inside out. He envisioned Synanon as a self-contained therapeutic community: more like a family than an institution, and far more confrontational than any clinic of the day.

The environment Dederich cultivated was intentionally authoritarian. He believed that for addicts to recover, they needed discipline, honesty, and intense social pressure—what he called a "mirror strong enough to shatter denial." The hallmark of Synanon became "the Game," a highly charged encounter group where members challenged one another—sometimes ruthlessly. The goal was catharsis, followed by personal responsibility. In Dederich's words, the purpose was to "get straight" to learn to live without drugs or alcohol by confronting life directly.

Out of this experiment grew a broader movement: the therapeutic community. Synanon's approach—structured living, peer confrontation, communal responsibility—quickly spread across the country. Programs inspired by it adopted its core principles even as they softened or reshaped its harsher elements.

By the late 1960s and early 1970s, as the old Lexington-style institutional model lost credibility and addiction rates soared among young people, the therapeutic community gained national attention. Funding flowed in. Buildings were renovated. Staff were hired. New residents arrived in droves.

What began as a fringe idea in a converted beachfront storefront had become a nationwide treatment philosophy. Synanon's legacy endured in the programs that followed: they changed not only how treatment centers operated, but how addiction itself was understood—not simply as a condition managed through medication or confinement, but as something treatable through community, human connection, challenge, and shared transformation.

Prisons, Punishment, and the Addict's Reality

For much of the twentieth century, addiction in America was not seen as a condition to be treated—it was a problem to be punished. Long before treatment

centers lined suburban roads or twelve-step programs filled church basements, the primary institution that dealt with drug addiction was the prison system.

In Pennsylvania, the reach of incarceration stretched across federal and local jurisdictions alike. Addicts found themselves locked inside institutions that were never designed for recovery—only containment. From the austere halls of the Federal Penitentiary at Allenwood to county facilities like Bucks, Lackawanna, and Chester, from the state-run compounds of Graterford, Camp Hill, and Rockview to the bleak and crowded cells of Holmesburg, addicts were warehoused in every corner of the system. For many, the message was clear: society had given up on them.

Therapeutic community leaders of the late 1960s and early 1970s may have criticized the cold impersonality of traditional institutions, but they too clung to the bedrock belief that total abstinence was the only solution. They saw prisons as necessary tools to suppress drug trafficking and protect communities. Few questioned whether imprisonment alone could ever be a foundation for change.

But inside those walls, a different truth was taking shape.

Dutch H. remembered those years with unflinching honesty. “Give people like myself some hope,” he said. “Maybe, just maybe, we could stop.” Yet back then, hope was rare. Detox centers were nearly nonexistent. Rehabilitation programs were reserved for the privileged few. And the public solution to addiction was terrifying in its simplicity: get the addict off the street—lock them away.

“If someone wanted to stop,” Dutch recalled, “nobody believed they actually could. It was as if we were sentenced to die.”

There was no sense of treatment or transformation. Only an endless revolving door: arrest, jail, release, relapse. Repeat. Dutch described a cycle all too common among his peers. “I kept getting sent away—just ‘put him away,’ they said. That was the solution.” Addicts weren’t seen as sick. They were seen as lost causes—criminals who would never get better.

Craig remembered the constant threat of surveillance, even long after release. “In Philadelphia, the police had a squad called the Ferguson Squad. Our literature says, ‘We are under no surveillance today.’ But it wasn’t always like that … Most addicts had records, and if they gathered together, they risked violating parole or probation.”

There was no counseling, no literature, no structured support—only the camaraderie of others who shared the same sentence and the same pain. Yet in these bleak conditions, something profound began to grow. A desire. A faint but persistent belief that maybe change was possible. Not through prison—but despite it.

It would be years before recovery programs gained serious traction behind prison walls, and decades before institutions made room for fellowships like Narcotics Anonymous. But even in those early days, among the locked doors and razor wire, a new kind of hope was starting to flicker—carried not by policy, but by the voices of the addicts themselves.

The Rockefeller Drug Laws

On May 8, 1973, Governor Nelson Rockefeller signed into law a set of sweeping anti-drug policies in New York State. Known as the Rockefeller Drug Laws, they mandated 15-years-to-life prison sentences for both drug dealers and users—even for possession of small amounts of marijuana, heroin, or cocaine.

The laws were a dramatic departure from previous public health approaches. First-time offenders, even teenagers, were not spared. Rehabilitation was no longer the focus. These laws, widely adopted in other states, launched an era of mass incarceration, especially of low-level, nonviolent drug offenders with no prior records. Rockefeller’s language at the time framed the addicted person not as a human needing help, but as a threat to public safety. Surveillance, policing, and fear replaced compassion, treatment, and trust. Ironically, just as grassroots fellowships like NA were beginning to prove that recovery was not only possible but replicable, the larger system doubled down on punishment.

On April 2, 2009, the State Legislature passed ground-breaking legislation that effectively swept away an entire era of notoriously harsh drug sentencing schemes known as the Rockefeller Drug Laws.

Hospitals, Institutions, and the Long Road to Treatment

Those who wanted to stop using drugs often found themselves funneled into a patchwork of hospitals, psychiatric institutions, government programs, and experimental therapeutic communities. For many, the journey began in hospitals. Facilities such as Einstein Medical Center, Saint Luke's Medical Center, Friends Hospital, and Philadelphia State Hospital at Byberry became familiar, if not always welcoming, places. So too were regional treatment centers like Norristown State Hospital, Haverford State Hospital, and Fairmount Institute—each attempting, in their own way, to manage what was then viewed more as a behavioral disorder or psychiatric condition than a chronic disease.

Dr. C. Dudley Saul and Dr. C. Nelson Davis were among the first in Philadelphia to apply the emerging Twelve-Step model to hospital treatment. In 1946, they opened the C. Dudley Saul Clinic at Saint Luke's Hospital, making it the first private treatment center for alcoholism in the nation. Just a few years later, in 1949, the clinic relocated to the suburbs and was renamed Malvern Treatment Center. There, the Twelve Steps began taking a deeper root in clinical settings.

Some institutions sought to combine modern medicine with amenities that mirrored normal life. Haverford State Hospital, constructed in 1964, was seen as state-of-the-art. Patients lived in private rooms, used a bowling alley, and were assigned jobs or activities—sometimes even permitted to leave the grounds regularly.

Eugenia Hospital, known to many as Briar Hill, offered psychiatric care from its Lafayette Hill location. Originally a mansion, it had been transformed in 1948 by Dr. Stephen Deichelmann into a mental health facility-reflecting a growing trend of private psychiatric institutions treating addiction alongside broader mental illness.

Meanwhile, one of the most enduring institutions in Bucks County was taking shape under unconventional circumstances. Advertising executive Standish Forde Hansell had purchased a 44-acre estate with the intention of creating a refined retirement home. But in 1966, persuaded by friends and informed by the growing urgency around alcoholism, he opened the Livengrin Foundation

instead—one of the first non-hospital-based addiction treatment centers in the region. It offered a more humane, residential setting focused on recovery, not confinement. In 1968, another Philadelphia effort took root—— this one directly tied to the rise of the therapeutic community model. Inspired by Daytop Village in New York, local leaders established Gaudenzia as a nonprofit residential program for heroin addicts. Gaudenzia offered not only shelter, but a sense of dignity and purpose to its clients most of whom could not pay for their treatment. Day-to-day Operations relied heavily on community donations. According to Mary Mc., Gaudenzia played a pivotal role in launching NA meetings in Philadelphia's Black communities. Graduates like Alexander S. and Christine went on to start numerous meetings across North Philadelphia.

Other treatment programs pushed the boundaries of conventional therapy. Chit-Chat Farms now known as Caron Treatment Centers was founded in 1957 by Richard and Catherine Caron in a converted hotel in Wernersville, Pennsylvania. It was among the first in the nation to accept female alcoholics, incorporate psychology into Twelve Step work, and later expand to drug addiction. It wasn't just a treatment center; it was a forerunner in inclusive, integrated recovery.

For individuals like Jim H., recovery wasn't linear. His struggle with barbiturates and Robitussin cough syrup began in the early 1960s, and he would cycle through numerous facilities: Willow Grove Mental Hospital, Philadelphia Psychiatric Center, and Temple Hospital. He even participated in methadone maintenance, which offered little relief. Jim H. later attempted the tough-love methods of Synanon and Daytop Village, but found the intense confrontation and sign-wearing too harsh. After just a week at Daytop, he walked away.

The broader system often failed to offer compassion. In the 1960s and early 1970s, addiction treatment included methods now viewed as extreme electro-convulsive therapy (ECT), involuntary institutionalization, and even lobotomies in rare cases. Addicts were often treated as social pariahs or mentally ill rather than as individuals needing ongoing support and recovery resources. Noel F. recalled routinely dropping addicts oft at mental hospitals simply because there were no other options. Norristown State Hospital was often the only destination. Mary

Mc. remembered attending Alcoholics Anonymous meetings at Carrier Clinic in New Jersey, while others sought out help at places like Riverside and Clearbrook Lodge. A small but growing number of public and community programs also emerged. In 1970, MALABAR—a Wilkes-Barre drop-in center named for the substances it addressed (Marijuana, Amphetamines, LSD, Alcohol, and Barbiturates)-provided counseling until it closed in 1979. That same year, the Trehab Community Action Agency began operations in Lackawanna County, offering services to marginalized populations. Trehab's detox unit at Scranton State Hospital often referred individuals to White Deer Run and Clearbrook Lodge. One patient recalled being escorted to a single AA meeting where a well-dressed member scoffed, "I've spilled more alcohol on my tie than you've ever drunk."

His reply? "I only shot whiskey once." His story captured the deep disconnect between alcoholics and intravenous drug users—and the need for a separate space like NA.

A 1971 report titled "Health Care Crisis in America" revealed the staggering lack of resources in Philadelphia. That year, the methadone clinic at Philadelphia General Hospital treated just 155 patients. Meanwhile, eleven other hospitals combined managed about 2,100 cases. And still, addiction treatment in private hospitals remained nearly non-existent. Arrests for drug-related offenses exceeded 3,000 annually, yet most addicts were only taken to the hospital if suspected of overdosing. Addiction, the article noted grimly, was "almost completely ignored by the private sector."

By 1971, Counseling or Referral Assistance (CORA) had been founded with the help of Sister Charity Kohl and the Sisters of the Good Shepherd. Originally focused on family counseling, CORA expanded to offer drug and alcohol treatment services in 1976 through its Fox Chase location.

In time, the NA message would begin to reach those who passed through these institutions, one patient and one meeting at a time. But in those early years, recovery for most was uncertain, unsupported, and often unforgiving. The seeds of change were beginning to sprout-but for many addicts in the 1960s and early 1970s, the road to recovery still wound through locked wards, misunderstood therapies, and a society just beginning to understand what it truly meant to help.

NA in New York and Beyond

In the early years of Narcotics Anonymous, long before its name was widely known, New York played a pivotal role in shaping what the program could become. It was here, in the mid-1950s, that a group of recovering addicts rallied around a man named Danny C.-a figure whose leadership and vision left a lasting, if fragile, legacy. Danny C., a Lexington alumnus and longtime heroin addict, played a central role in establishing NA in New York City. Danny had endured seven trips to the Kentucky hospital before emerging, not cured, but determined. In the mid-1940s, along with Rae L. and Brigadier Dorothy Berry of the Salvation Army, he began building a support structure for recovering addicts in New York.

Brigadier Major Dorothy Berry had begun working with addicts as early as 1946. A woman of fierce compassion and quiet strength, she opened doors-literally. In 1947, Berry secured a room in the Manhattan Men's Social Service Center of the Salvation Army to host one of the earliest known groups called "Narcotics Anonymous." Danny and Rae collaborated closely with her, and by 1948, they had begun facilitating NA-style meetings within the New York prison System.

By 1950, a New York Times article described the growing chapter in the city, led again by Danny. It revealed a network that was beginning to formalize. Danny, calling himself a "former hopeless case," was devoting his life to the organization. He and his peers described NA as "an informal society of former addicts" who stayed clean by helping others do the same. The group was still small—just sixteen members at the time—and met twice weekly in a Salvation Army building at S35 West 48th Street.

Outreach became central to their mission. They worked inside the city's jails and hospitals, carrying their message of recovery to those still trapped. But building something lasting was a struggle. Addicts, even in recovery, were still seen as criminals. Venues were reluctant to host their meetings. Drug peddlers, threatened by NA's message, quietly sabotaged their efforts.

As Danny and Rae's influence spread, so too did the number of groups. By the mid-1950s, Rae had helped establish meetings in at least fourteen U.S. cities. and three foreign countries. She even laid plans to start groups in Philadelphia. though historical records give no details on whether those meetings took hold.

In 1954, a further attempt to bring structure to this growing but uncoordinated movement came in the form of The National Board of Narcotics Anonymous—a group of civic-minded citizens who formed a corporation to publish NA literature. This board claimed no spiritual leadership, but functioned administratively, attempting to guide the expansion of these groups. It was an early forerunner of centralized service—but without a cohesive fellowship behind it, its reach was limited.

Though this version of Narcotics Anonymous would eventually fade, overtaken by the unified fellowship that began in California in the early 1950s and grew into what is now NA World Services (NAWS), its early New York iteration laid essential groundwork. It taught a generation of addicts that recovery through the Twelve Steps was possible even for them. It showed that, with or without recognition, the message could still be carried.

The Fall of NA in New York

In August 1956, Danny C., whose own experience with addiction had become the foundation for the growing NA movement in New York, passed away from cancer. His death marked more than the loss of a leader; it punctured the momentum that had just begun to take shape. But the story did not end there.

Those who had rallied behind Danny now stood behind Rae. With her at the helm, a small band of hard-core members picked up where Danny had left off.

They repeated his efforts, driven by the same passion to bring hope to addicts who had none. The meetings continued, and the message endured.

Yet, despite these efforts, the New York fellowship would not survive the political tides that soon followed. By the early 1970s, the atmosphere in the state had changed dramatically. The passage of the Rockefeller Drug Laws—harsh, mandatory sentencing policies aimed at drug users and low-level dealers—cast a chilling effect over grassroots recovery efforts. Surveillance, stigma, and incarceration

replaced the fragile spaces of hope and healing that people like Danny and Rae had worked so hard to build.

Rae poured herself into the work, guided by a belief in the possibility of change, of freedom, of a fellowship where addicts could recover without judgment or control. But that vision remained just out of reach.

Rae passed away in October 1972, never witnessing the eventual rebirth and expansion of the fellowship she had helped hold together during its most vulnerable chapter.

The Shaping of Today's NA

Jimmy K., born April 5, 1911 in Paisley, Scotland, emigrated to New York, arriving August 8, 1923. Jimmy married Agnes April 7, 1934 and found a home in the Tacony section of Philadelphia on Magee Street. In the latter part of 1939 Jimmy's family took a train to Hollywood, California. Jimmy and his brother Neil worked for the same roofing company. In 1942, Jimmy was drinking quite heavily at this time.

At the close of 1949, Jimmy K. stood at a crossroads. Years of addiction had taken their toll. Though he was still trying to work and hold his family together, the strain was becoming unbearable. Deep down, he truly wanted to stop using. That desire led him—like many others of that era-to the rooms of Alcoholics Anonymous.

But Jimmy's vision was already extending beyond the world of alcohol. He had seen others like him on the margins: drug addicts with no place to go, unable to fully connect with AA's alcoholic focus. Around this same time, a few men from East Los Angeles had formed a group called Addicts Anonymous. But the effort faltered quickly, largely because of a lack of structure and the dominance of one personality—a lesson that would not be lost on Jimmy.

Other efforts surfaced as well. Betty T. in Santa Monica launched the Habit Forming Drugs group, which encouraged its members to attend AA meetings and use AA sponsors, following a hybrid structure she'd developed between 1950 and 1954. Jimmy was also aware of the group forming in New York, under Danny C., but found it out of sync with what he believed to be the core of recovery.

For Jimmy, the Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions—as codified in AA-were non-negotiable. Without them, no effort could hold.

Though the Traditions had only just been formalized by AA in 1950, Jimmy's California-based vision took them seriously from the beginning. The eventual demise of the New York group would only deepen his conviction.

By 1953, the conditions were right. In the San Fernando Valley—an area dotted with clubhouses hosting AA meetings in Burbank and North Hollywood-re- Covery culture had taken root. Although tolerance of addicts in AA meetings varied, the proximity of groups and the tight-knit community made it an ideal birthplace for something new.

That year, on August 17, Narcotics Anonymous as we know it was officially founded.

AA granted permission to use the Steps and Traditions-but not the name.

By 1954, a modest but critical piece of literature appeared: the "Little Brown Book," written by Jack P. with Jimmy K. and Cy M. It was only eight pages, but it Outlined questions like "Do I Need Narcotics Anonymous?," a description of the program, and the Twelve Steps, all beginning with the word "We." The final page listed two PO boxes—one in Studio City, the other in San Diego—quiet evidence of a small but spreading network.

Still, from 1954 to 1959, NA remained fragile. Meetings, referred to as "Rabbit Meetings," shifted locations, often held in members' homes, with word-of-mouth guiding those who wanted to attend. Fear loomed large. Addicts scouted for police surveillance. Some carried a coffee pot and depression glass cups from place to place. Most in AA still viewed addicts with suspicion, and the early NA fellowship operated almost underground.

By the end of the decade, internal disputes over leadership and a breach of the Traditions led to collapse. Jimmy later reflected, "Although we had meetings going for several years, for about four years there was no Narcotics Anonymous. When it became a "one-man rule proposition," the essence of NA was lost. And yet, for those who had lived the program—even briefly—it would not let them go. In 1960, Jimmy made a decision that would change everything. With only four groups remaining, he resolved to begin again. From the ashes of near extinction,

NA would be rebuilt-not around personality, but on principles: the Steps for the individual, the Traditions for the groups.

The same year, Jimmy listed Narcotics Anonymous in the local phone book-creating the first NA answering service. A "Parent Service Board" was formed to safeguard the Traditions and guide NA's growth. That year also saw the birth of foundational literature: "Who Is an Addict?. " "What Can I Do?". "Why Are We Here?", and "Recovery and Relapse," co-written by Jimmy, Silvia W., and Penny K.

By 1961, these pieces were compiled into the "Little White Booklet"-a compact guide that became the heartbeat of early NA. It included the Steps, Traditions, prayers, and core messages of hope. The text earned the nickname "hip pocket program" for its simplicity and portability.

In 1963, the Mother Group sent out a call to all known meetings, requesting representatives. The resulting gathering led to the formal establishment of a Board of Trustees, tasked with preserving NA's unity and fidelity to the Traditions. A literature committee was also formed, and Jimmy contributed a new piece: "Another Look."

The 1966 edition of the White Book added six personal stories, including Jimmy's "We Do Recover," Bill P.'s "One Third of My Life," and Penny K.'s "I Can't Do Anymore Time." Each story brought texture and truth to the message that recovery was possible.

Between 1967 and 1968, NA was still small-only about 10 meetings, primarily in California. But the structure was evolving. The General Service Organization (GSO), operating out of Bill B's barbershop, brought Group Service Representatives (GSR) together with the Board of Trustees each month. It was an early prototype of the service committees that would follow.

In February 1968, "The Voice of NA" began publication. Its stated aims were bold: to share experience, strengthen communication, support literature development, and eventually form a publishing company. Originally titled C.A.R.E. —for Compassion, Action, Respect, Empathy—it was renamed CAR ENA after discovering the acronym was already in use.

By 1969, NA had grown from a few scattered meetings to over 200 members. The Third Tradition—that the only requirement for membership is a desire to

stop using-gave NA a broad and inclusive foundation. As addiction spread, so did the need for a program like this one. Narcotics Anonymous was poised for growth on a scale none of its founders had imagined.

As the 1970s opened, Narcotics Anonymous remained a fragile experiment, The global fellowship counted somewhere between 30 and 39 meetings, with an estimated 200 members worldwide. Group literature consisted of a one-page sheet of the Twelve Steps, the Twelve Traditions, and the familiar third paragraph of "We Do Recover" —a simple but resonant foundation. Structurally, the organization was still in flux.

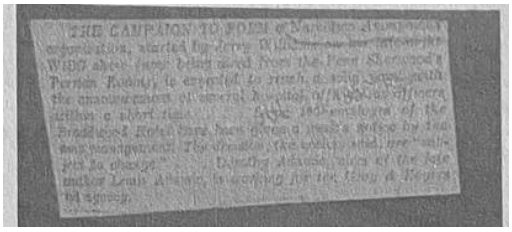
On July 23, 1971, the NA Board of Trustees authorized the creation of a. centralized office and re-established the Parent Service Committee to manage it. This was a key step toward sustainable infrastructure. Yet, records from 1971 show a lack of consensus about the fellowship's true scale. Three sources give different global meeting counts: Bob Stone cited 38 meetings in My Years with Narcotics Anonymous, A. Scott claimed 40 meetings during a 1991 convention in San Diego, and NAWS Inc. later recorded 50 meetings in their Growth of NA What had once seemed impossible—a fellowship for addicts by addicts, rooted in spiritual principles rather than institutions—was now becoming real. Not just surviving, but growing. Slowly. Steadily. Authentically.

Early Mentions of NA in Pennsylvania

Before Narcotics Anonymous had any real presence in Pennsylvania—before its steps were read in church basements, before its literature passed hand to hand-there were only rumors. Mentions. Hints of something forming. A whisper on the radio, a footnote in the paper, a name dropped by someone who had heard of a group that helped addicts the way AA helps alcoholics.

In the summer of 1956, that whisper became public. On June 19, the Philadelphia Inquirer reported that a Narcotics Anonymous group might soon be forming in the city. The idea came not from a treatment professional or public official, but from the airwaves. A hooded addict had appeared

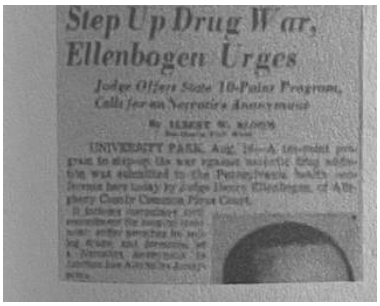
on Jerry Williams' late-night radio show on WIBG, and his interview struck a chord. Within hours, at least a dozen people had reached out—volunteering to be charter members of a group that didn't yet exist.



The momentum carried. A second Inquirer article on July 24 noted that Williams' campaign had gained traction. His show, now airing from the Persian Room at the Penn Sherwood Hotel, had inspired not only public interest but professional support. Several hospital officials were reportedly stepping forward to help organize and lead the emerging group.

Yet despite this promising start, no records survive confirming that a lasting NA group ever came from that first wave of enthusiasm in 1956. It may have dissolved as quietly as it had formed—another of the many early recovery experiments that flickered briefly and went out.

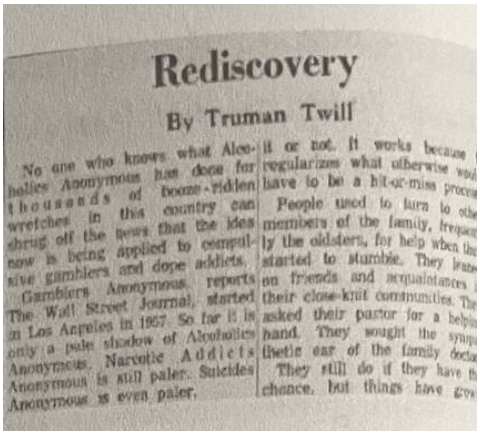
Still, the idea didn't die. In the years that followed, the term "Narcotics Anonymous" continued to surface in Pennsylvania media. These were rarely reported about organized fellowships. More often, they were side mentions—glimpses of an idea gaining recognition, if not yet traction.


Step Up Drug War, Ellenbogen Urges

Judge Offers State 10-Point Program, Calls for an Narcotics Anonymous

In August 1960, Judge Henry Ellenbogen in Allegheny County submitted a sweeping 10-point anti-drug plan at the Pennsylvania Health Conference. Among his suggestions was the formation of a Narcotics Anonymous-style support group for addicts, modeled on Alcoholics Anonymous. It was clear that the AA blueprint was becoming the standard reference, even for drug addiction recovery.

A few years later, in 1962, multiple publications again touched on the concept. On January 8, The Evening Sun in Hanover published a short essay titled "Rediscovery," in which columnist Truman Twill observed that the Twelve Step model was being applied to new populations-gamblers, addicts, even those battling suicidal ideation.



Rediscovery

By Truman Twill

No one who knows what Alcoholics Anonymous has done for thousands of booze-ridden wretches in this country can shrug off the news that the idea now is being applied to compulsive gamblers and dope addicts. Gamblers Anonymous, reports The Wall Street Journal, started in Los Angeles in 1957. So far it is only a pale shadow of Alcoholics Anonymous. Narcotic Addicts Anonymous is still paler. Suicides Anonymous is even paler.

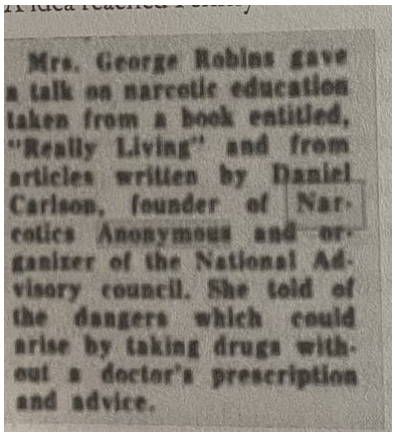
it or not. It works because it regularizes what otherwise would have to be a hit-or-miss process.

People used to turn to other members of the family, frequently the oldsters, for help when they started to stumble. They leaned on friends and acquaintances in their close-knit communities. They asked their pastor for a helping hand. They sought the sympathetic ear of the family doctor. They still do if they have the chance, but things have grown

Twill noted that Narcotics Anonymous, or “Narcotic Addicts Anonymous” as he called it, was still in its infancy, barely more than a pale shadow of its alcohol-based predecessor.

Four days later, on January 12, The Mercury in Pottstown ran a recap of a meeting of the Women’s Christian Temperance Union. There, Mrs. George Robins delivered a talk on narcotics education. She cited a book titled Really Living and referenced articles by Daniel Carlsen—identified as the founder of Narcotics Anonymous and organizer of the National Advisory Council. The details are murky; Carlsen’s name does not appear in NA’s formal origin history. But the article reveals the scattered, sometimes contradictory paths through which the NA idea reached Pennsylvania.

The mentions continued through the 1960s. An April 1963 Berwick Enterprise health column described NA as a group modeled on AA, reliant on mutual aid, group discussion, and spiritual inspiration.



Mrs. George Robins gave a talk on narcotic education taken from a book entitled, "Really Living" and from articles written by Daniel Carlson, founder of Narcotics Anonymous and organizer of the National Advisory council. She told of the dangers which could arise by taking drugs without a doctor's prescription and advice.

A year later, in May 1964, Public Opinion in Chambersburg published a piece quoting Dr. Charles Winick of the American Social Health Association. “If a drug addict wants to be cured,” Winick said, “he can be helped through Narcotics Anonymous, residential treatment centers, and halfway houses.” He went on to describe NA as a voluntary membership group offering hope through identification—one addict helping another.



Self-Help Group To Start Meetings

Narcotics Anonymous, a self-help lay group therapy program, will begin weekly meetings Tuesday night at 7:30 at Kirby Memorial Health Center, it was announced today.

By 1970, the name Narcotics Anonymous had spread far enough that people attempted to launch meetings even where no fellowship structure existed. On May 20 of that year, the Wilkes-Barre Times Leader announced the formation of a local NA group set to begin meeting weekly at Kirby Memorial Health Center. The contact listed was Marilyn Kile. The piece described NA as “a self-help lay group therapy program” claiming a 70 percent cure rate. However, no record of this meeting survives in NA World Services archives, and the health center later reported no recollection of the group’s activity. Looking back, the years between 1956 and 1971 form a kind of prehistory for NA in Pennsylvania. They reveal the cultural fermentation that made NA possible, even if no fully formed fellowship yet existed. The name was known. The model was referenced. But the fellowship—meetings, sponsors, home groups, and service structures—was still just beyond the horizon. What began with a hooded voice on late-night radio would, over the next few years, become a movement. These fragments of recognition were not just footnotes. They were signals—echoes of a message still struggling to find its full form. A whisper that would soon become a call.

In the Shadow of Another Fellowship

The history of Narcotics Anonymous cannot be told without first acknowledging the foundation laid by Alcoholics Anonymous. In 1935, Bill W. and Dr. Bob formed AA, and by 1939, their seminal text, Alcoholics Anonymous, was published. Over the decades, AA would grow to become the world’s most well-known self-help organization for those struggling with alcohol—an enduring fellowship that shaped the very architecture of addiction recovery as we know it.

By the fall of 1940, the seed of AA in Philadelphia began to take root. A small but growing community of 75 members established a clubhouse at 2036 Samson Street. Their numbers steadily increased—by spring of the following

year, 125 members were meeting regularly. Within two years, this burgeoning group had outgrown its original location and relocated to a fraternity house near the University of Pennsylvania. Then in March of 1946, the Philadelphia AA community moved once more, this time into even larger quarters at 4021 Walnut Street. The fellowship was thriving.

By 1945, AA had expanded beyond the city's core. New groups sprouted up across suburban neighborhoods and surrounding regions, including Jenkintown. Ardmore, 69th Street, Frankford, Germantown, Center City, Roxborough, Upper Darby, and across the Delaware River in Camden, New Jersey. The city's landscape of recovery was beginning to take shape.

Yet for those whose primary struggles centered around drugs, rather than alcohol, there were no parallel resources. Narcotics Anonymous did not yet exist, and so, by necessity rather than choice, addicts made their way to AA meetings, In these rooms, they found no judgment from fellow addicts—mostly because they were often the only addicts in the room. They arrived not seeking something different, but simply seeking something.

At some AA meetings, it was estimated that as many as 20 percent of the attendees were cross-addicted-individuals navigating the dual terrain of alcohol and drugs. They came to learn from the old-timers, to hear the experience of those with two decades or more of recovery. In the absence of any other structure, addicts absorbed what they could and carried it back into the fledgling spaces that would one day become NA. But the experience wasn't always welcoming. According to Roy P.:

I moved back East and stayed with my grandmother. Part of my family still lived there. I wanted to learn a trade—something to make money legally. I also wanted to stay sober, so I started looking for AA meetings in Philly. But at the time, AA was very closed-minded. I was just a 19-year-old burnt out speed freak.

People weren't exactly welcoming. They didn't kick me out, but they told me, 'Look, we can't help you. We don't know what to do with you.

The atmosphere within the AA community was complicated—both generous and guarded. Although many AA members were older and rooted in long-established traditions, some meetings for younger people created more room for cross-addicted individuals to find a place. Those identified as "dually addicted" —with histories of both drug and alcohol use—faced varying degrees of tolerance.

For some, this was simply a boundary. For others, it was a dismissal. Addicts were tolerated when they confined their stories to alcohol. When they spoke candidly about drugs, discomfort often followed. Disapproving glances, condescending remarks, and quiet exclusions became the norm. Some addicts were told outright that they didn't belong.

This discomfort extended along gender lines as well. Women who identified as addicts were more readily accepted—viewed as less threatening to the existing structure. Men, by contrast, were more often pushed out. In some meetings, women clutched their purses when addicts walked in, uncertainty in their eyes. And still, the addicts stayed.

They stayed because they needed recovery. They stayed because there was nowhere else to go. They listened, learned, and carried what wisdom they could back to the new spaces beginning to form. As NA emerged, many of its earliest members still had one foot in AA. The process of disentangling the fellowships would take time-and the lines between them would remain complex, even contentious.

Brian T. later reflected on that early support: "There's been a lot of debate about AA, but I'll tell you right now—if it wasn't for AA, I wouldn't be here. And I don't think NA would be in Philadelphia either."

Harvey D. once put it simply: "If it wasn't for AA, there wouldn't be any NA."

That sentiment was later enshrined in the Introduction of the Narcotics Anonymous Basic Text, which reads, "We are grateful to the AA Fellowship for showing us the way to a new life." Whatever tensions existed, there was also deep respect.

Recovery for addicts often began in borrowed corners of Alcoholics Anonymous. In these spaces-sometimes welcoming, sometimes hostile addicts

found one another, shared truth, and laid the foundation for what would become NA's presence in the region.

It was never a perfect fit, but it was a start. Addicts found themselves caught between fellowships-searching for language, space, and understanding. In AA. they found fragments of all three. And in time, they would build something of their own.

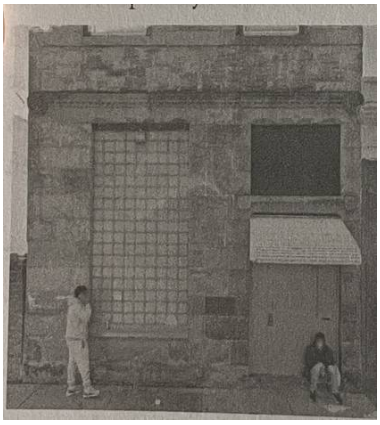
In 1969, when the first NA meetings began to take hold in the Philadelphia area, three AA groups became especially important allies. The Young Men's Group (which will be discussed later in this book), the Northeast Clubhouse, and the Saints Group offered vital early support—ranging from shared spaces to shared experience. These relationships helped stabilize the young NA program.

Northeast Club and the Saints Group

Starting meetings was one thing-getting them accepted was another. Addicts, hoping that NA would be received like AA, approached churches expecting similar hospitality.

But churches were often advised against hosting them-sometimes by AA members themselves. Fear-mongering was rampant.

Rumors spread that NA members would rob the sanitary product machines or steal sacramental wine. The stigma of addiction, particularly narcotics addiction, ran deep.



Even so, NA found sanctuary in two crucial places in Philadelphia: The Northeast Club on Frankford Avenue and the Saints Group at Holy Child Church in the Logan section. These AA-affiliated groups extended a rare welcome to addicts. They offered meeting space, encouragement, and the freedom to gather, even when others warned against it.

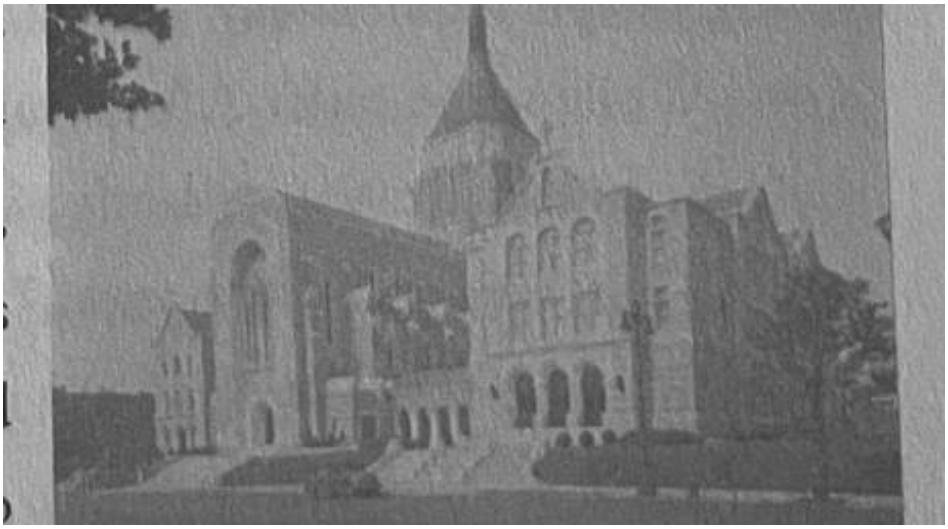
The Northeast Club stood apart from other AA establishments. It was highly Organized, led by businessmen, and cautious in its operations. Yet it made space for addicts—largely because of the consistent presence of Jim S. and his two

sons, who began attending while still at Eagleville. Maureen began showing up there too and found something many addicts didn't expect: kindness. With some members raising children themselves, the environment had a uniquely human touch. Ray T. remembered introducing himself at a step meeting there as both an addict and an alcoholic. A curious AA member asked him afterward, "Are you a double agent?" Ray had no idea what that meant. "What the fuck is a double agent?" he asked. Later, he learned that addicts attending AA were sometimes called "double bubbles," a not-so-subtle label for those straddling both fellowships.

Through his uncle Bill, Ray went to an AA meeting at the Northeast Club in Frankford. But Ray was still searching for something that spoke directly to drug addicts. That search ended when Brian needed help and Ray spoke with someone on the other end of the AA Northeast Club phone line. "The phone line servant said, My name is Ted, I'm a drug addict." Ray knew this was the person he wanted to talk to and got information for a local NA Meeting. Brian was considering going to a methadone clinic, but Ray told Brian I don't think you should do that. Let's try this other thing, let's try this NA thing.

That night, he met people involved in something new—something raw, unpolished, and just beginning to find its name: Narcotics Anonymous.

The Saints Group at Broad and Duncannon also played a pivotal role. Though they officially held AA meetings at Holy Child Church, their willingness to include addicts—especially those already familiar faces from the Northeast Club-made all the difference. Mainly because Mike S. and Danny S. father ran the AA group.



The church basement on Sunday nights hosted a rotating group of ten or more addicts-Roy, Maureen, Ray, Danny, Mike, and others. While AA members met upstairs in comfort, with access to full facilities and coffee, the addicts gathered below, with no access to the rest of the building. Their only entrance was from the outside, and the space had no working toilets. Roy would

later ask Maureen, "What did the women do? I remember having to go outside to pee. I was always worried I was going to get arrested for exposure." Still, those long, sometimes three-hour long unstructured meetings became the proving ground for NA in Philadelphia. Everyone got an opportunity to share, That is, until AA's Intergroup office received complaints and decided to delist the Saints Group entirely from its official meeting schedule-for the sole reason that they allowed drug addicts to attend. That act of exclusion turned out to be a blessing. The addicts moved quickly to form their own independent meeting at 13th & Ruscomb, marking a turning point in NA's journey from a tolerated presence to a fellowship of its own.

Other AA Hangouts

Another such haven was the 12 Keys AA Clubhouse in Levittown. This bustling AA space hosted several daily meetings. Although officially an AA environment, a kind of informal second floor refuge emerged. Addicts would retreat upstairs after the speaker meetings to speak openly, away from prying or judgmental ears. Al R. remembered this sanctuary vividly, recounting the blend of support and resistance: while some AA members welcomed the addicts, others were quick to remind them that NA might be a "better fit." The sting of rejection could be sharp, as Philly Phil described one incident, "I remember one night in particular, when they put somebody on the door and told us there's no room and we knew that that was bull." Yet, camaraderie and the growing bond among addicts often carried them through such slights.

Kathy H.'s mother gathered her women's group and regularly transported young people from Today, Inc. (Treatment of Drugs Among Youth) to the 12 Keys. While some older AA members balked at these newcomers-especially their dual-identification as both addicts and alcoholics—Kathy's mother stood firm. "There was no other option."

Pete B. remembered talking to a man named Steve at the 12 Keys who pointed him toward his first NA meeting. At that moment, Pete said, a heavy wall fell away. For Paul Z., the 12 Keys was hostile terrain-he was asked to leave multiple

times but kept returning until there were enough NA meetings to call home. Starting meetings became his mission.

In Northeast Philadelphia was the 369 Clubhouse on Ryan and Sandy Ford, a modest, one-room home that offered daily detox support and, at times, quiet acceptance. Noel F. remembered hitchhiking there just to sit in silence shaking among strangers who, remarkably, let him be. Sharon B. found warmth on the now-famous porch, where older members never questioned her place. Gary F., despite being told he was "too wild," wasn't turned away. The clubhouse's culture was, in many ways, one of quiet tolerance. Not every place was so forgiving. George W. attended the AA meeting—run by police and firefighters—only a few times. The strict rules against talking near the coffee pot or discussing drugs made him feel like an outsider. At times, the lines of inclusion were explicitly drawn. Their preamble was amended with a pointed suggestion: "If your primary problem is hard drugs, we suggest you go to NA."

In contrast, Stepping Stones on Torresdale Avenue became a beacon for young addicts, many of whom gathered under the wing of charismatic figures like "Jesus Jack." One member of Stepping Stones, Ray N., helped found The Reality Group, cultivating a space where drug users could identify and connect.

In Glenside, the line between acceptance and rejection was clearer. Around 1965, a young man named Jim H. approached the second-floor AA meeting with hope. Told directly, "No, you can't come in," he left undeterred, reporting back to his mother that "this isn't for drug addicts."

Meanwhile, at 4021 Walnut Street in Philadelphia, the Young People's AA Group offered a mixed but meaningful refuge. George W., referred there by Mid County Drug Abuse, recalled trembling at the coffee bar as he dared to admit his drug use. Despite his fear, no one shamed him. He felt safer in this racially integrated setting, surrounded by people who could discuss the gritty realities of addiction. Wayne P. remembered the dances and events at 4021—occasions where young people, often dually addicted, gathered in search of fellowship.

Coatesville, however, offered a painful contradiction. Pat P. described attending a traditional Sunday night AA meeting where attendees would literally skip over him in the sharing circle once he identified as an addict. Though allowed to be present, he was not allowed to speak. Pat P. also remembered back-room

meetings in clubhouses and even gatherings in private homes, like those near. Lincoln University. "There were two counselors who had AA meetings in their house, and we would meet in a separate room," he said. These weren't real NA meetings, but they were the closest thing at the time. Just addicts, gathering where they wouldn't be turned away.

The Darby Young People's AA, on Lansdowne and Chester Pike, would play a pivotal role in the transition from AA to NA. Wayne P. recalled starting an NA meeting there in the early 1980s, amid a wave of newcomers who were cross-addicted. One member recalls that AA members he knew rarely tolerated drug use—even prescribed—yet the Darby group held space for honest conversation. Bill O. first heard about NA through this group, handed a schedule by older AA members who saw his struggle.

George W. found Darby Young People's meetings particularly transformational. Referred there by a woman from Secane AA, he met Nick D., who would later introduce him to NA. At Darby, George discovered a room full of people just like him—what his sponsor jokingly called "the violent ward" of AA. There, honesty wasn't just allowed—it was essential. Meetings began loosely around 8:30 P.M. and often ran late into the night, as members shared openly and unfiltered about drugs, recovery, and survival. That freedom changed lives.

Across the border in Wilmington, Delaware, a group called Alone Together—named after a Dave Mason album—provided a similar experience. John D., newly out of rehab, was brought there by the man who would become his sponsor. Although that man stayed in AA, John didn't feel divided. "He was an addict, but he went to AA. And I didn't have a problem with that, and I still do not."

In Atlantic City, New Jersey, a unique kind of permission took shape—one not written in policy, but extended through acceptance. Addicts could quietly take over a young people's AA meeting and hold their own NA-style gathering. No one objected. People like Barbara Blaze and her sponsor, Delores, were among those who fostered this early spirit of openness. Their welcoming presence offered a rare haven during a time when addicts often found themselves unwelcome in more traditional spaces.

In 1972, Craig L. was one of many searching for something more. He began attending AA meetings at the Parkside Group, located at 51st and Walnut Street in West Philadelphia. He wasn't alone. Others-Bob M., Jerry S., Dutch H., Jimmy B. —gathered at the Malvern Clubhouse, turning to AA not out of choice, but necessity. It was the only game in town. There was no NA yet.

Charlie F. found wisdom in those early AA rooms, despite being significantly younger than most members. "There were more people with longer recovery time, who tended to be more stable," he admitted. But not everyone was welcoming. "There was a lot of controversy about drug addicts going to AA meetings. Some people were nearly hostile, not wanting us to talk about our drug use or anything like that."

Eileen G., a young woman in her twenties, found herself sitting in rooms filled with people twice her age. "Mostly all older people," she recalled. "OK, I was in a group of Young People's groups which were 40 years old, and I was in my 20s." She learned quickly that recovery came with unspoken codes of conduct-cleaning up her language being one of the first lessons absorbed by proximity.

But not every meeting was what it claimed to be. Ray T. stumbled upon one that was publicized as NA. At first, it seemed like hope. Soon, though, it became clear something was off. "It was like one or two therapists in the meeting," he remembered. "They were calling it NA that night, but something was wrong." When one participant was asked to recount therapy topics from earlier that day, Ray had had enough. He spoke his mind, only to be harshly rebuked at the next gathering. That marked the end of that particular experiment.

Mary Mc. found herself navigating similarly confusing waters. At one AA meeting in a church at 4th and Pine, the men's meeting preceded her meeting at 7:00 P.M. "When I was the coffee maker," she said, "I used to think that they wanted to make sure that they knew I wasn't listening to their meeting." Her presence felt tolerated at best, but never truly accepted.

Cindy R. recounted an AA meeting in North Wales at the Church of the Messiah. It met on Tuesday nights, and over the years, it became known as one of the oldest continuous meetings in the area —though its roots were still grounded in AA.

Margie C. was deeply involved in AA, attending roundups and participating in the culture of sobriety. But her voice was muted. "They wouldn't let me speak because I didn't have an alcohol story," she shared. "You can come and you can celebrate clean time, but you cannot open your mouth." She was clean, but not qualified—at least by their standards.

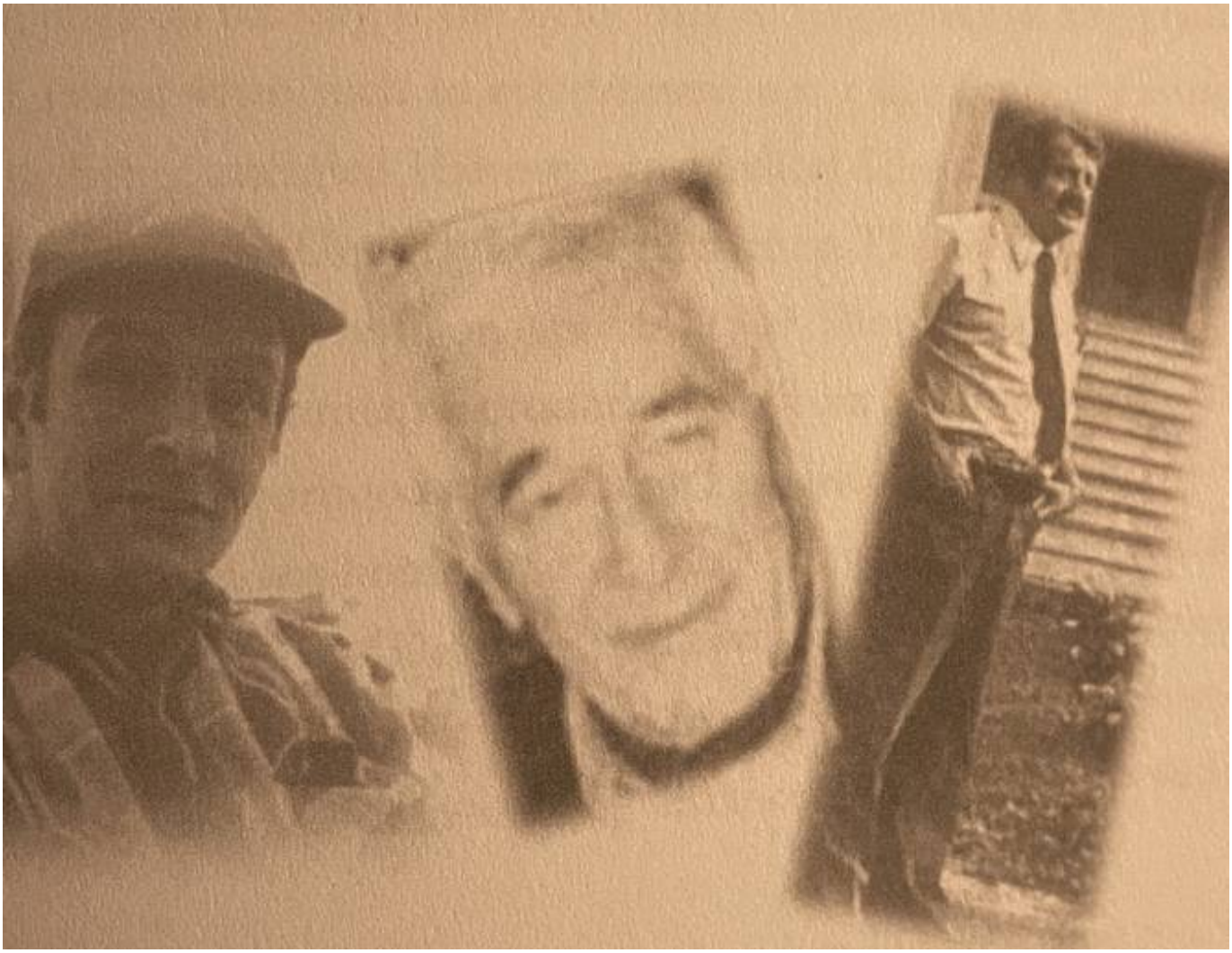
In Norristown and Montgomery County, Paula B. recalled that their role models were almost exclusively AA members. It was the only recovery framework available, and those who had time and stability were respected-regardless of the program they belonged to.

The unease was mutual. Bill D. saw it clearly. "I can see why the other fellowship was afraid of us," he said. "If we'd come with the amount of people tonight, it'd be a mass of confusion in that other fellowship." As NA meetings slowly began to form, a realization grew: one area wouldn't be enough. The fellowship was expanding, and it was becoming clear that drug addicts needed a space of their own.

AJ H. offered a glimpse into how some were funneled into recovery through institutional channels. I brought my alcohol problem to the attention of the United States Air Force," he recalled. Ordered into counseling, he was offered AA meetings. "I went to three meetings until the guy stopped picking me up. They took me out to a diner and treated me like a human being. And nobody had treated me like a human being for a long time."

These early years were marked by displacement and improvisation. Addicts sought shelter in the folds of AA, cobbling together support from scattered corners of the recovery world. They gathered in borrowed spaces, private homes, and back rooms-not quite welcomed, but unwilling to remain silent. And though Narcotics Anonymous had not yet found its footing, the stirrings of a separate fellowship had begun.

EARLY GARDENERS



Narcotics Anonymous in Philadelphia owes its beginnings to three key individuals known as the "Early Gardeners." One was a recovering speed addict carrying the NA message with only a White Book. Another a treatment program advocate who believed in addiction as a disease and in the possibility of full abstinence. The third was an AA member who helped arrange an NA presentation at a local hospital. Their combined efforts, sparked by a simple NA booklet and a shared belief in the Twelve Steps, laid the foundation for NA's growth in Pennsylvania.

Roy P.

Roy P.'s parents were both highly intelligent. His mother was completing her studies in physical therapy at the University of Pennsylvania. She graduated cum laude at a time when such an achievement was a significant milestone for a woman. His father attended Hahnemann Medical School and had earned a football scholarship to the University of San Francisco. They met in Philadelphia, got married, and Roy P. was born on April 14, 1949. Shortly after, they moved to Sam Mateo County, California, one county down from San Francisco, settling in the Hillsborough neighborhood south of San Francisco.

Their neighborhood was home to several notable figures. Caspar Weinberger, Ronald Reagan's Secretary of Defense, lived two properties down. Shirley Temple Black, the former child movie star and former ambassador to Ghana, lived about eight houses away. Within walking distance, Bing Crosby owned one of his homes.

Roy's father was a psychiatrist—and a drug addict. His addiction to amphetamines led to repeated trouble and, ultimately, his death in 1981. He kept samples of various drugs in a closet at home. In 1964, when Roy was just 15, his father gave him a bottle of Benzedrine while he was studying for his school finals. Roy took it and felt incredible—full of energy and hyper-focused. From that moment on, he was hooked. His behavior at school changed dramatically, and he began having discipline problems. With unlimited access to drugs in his home, he quickly spiraled into addiction.

Roy was drawn to bikers and hippies. He stole his father's drugs and traded them for street drugs. This was during the peak of the Haight-Ashbury era, a time of free love, long hair, and psychedelic experimentation. After three years of heavy drug use, he was overwhelmed by pain and emptiness. To escape those feelings, he used even more drugs. One day, while injecting LSD, Roy suffered a severe breakdown. He collapsed and withdrew from society, behaving strangely for eight to nine months. Roy said:

I was in bad shape mentally from LSD and methamphetamine.

I started seeing articles in newspapers about the beginnings of rehabs—places trying to help non-traditional addicts. At the time, "traditional" addicts were all heroin users. We used methamphetamine, but we didn't consider ourselves real addicts. Yeah, we used needles, but we weren't like the heroin guys. Then I started seeing articles about places opening up for non-heroin addicts. I got chased out of the Bay Area—both by the police and some guys I knew from drug deals. The police told my father, 'If he comes back to the Bay Area, he's gonna disappear.' I knew what that meant. I'd be fertilizing almond trees out in San Fernando Valley. So I left. My mother was living in Palm Springs, so I went there.

In 1967, Roy's parents feared for his life. They petitioned the court, which Ordered Roy to be committed to a private psychiatric institution in Santa Monica, California. The facility was filled with alcoholics, drug addicts, and burnouts. The doctors experimented with extreme treatments—partial and full lobotomies, insulin shock therapy, and electric shock treatments—to try to "cure" addiction. Roy was terrified. He underwent between 20 and 30 electroshock treatments. When he fought back against the hospital staff, he was forcibly restrained, placed in a straitjacket and shackled to a bed. Lying there, hopeless, he thought about God for the first time in years. He asked himself what he had done to end up in such a place.

By 1968, Roy stopped resisting. He began volunteering for tasks—cleaning latrines, scrubbing the kitchen. He witnessed the devastating effects of excessive electroshock therapy. Some patients in their early twenties had undergone 70 or 80 treatments and were left in a vegetative state. Many were transferred to Camarillo State Mental Hospital for lifelong custodial care. Whatever had damaged them before—whether drugs or mental illness—the treatments finished them off. One positive thing happened during Roy's time in the hospital: he met a man from AA. The man had relapsed and ended up in the facility, but he told Roy about the 12-step program. Roy was intrigued by the idea of conscious contact with a Higher Power, spiritual awakening, and a community that helped each other without judgment. A couple months later, Roy's mother came to visit. He pleaded and begged her to take him home. Against medical advice, she agreed. The psychiatrist warned that Roy was not ready, and he was right—Roy got high the very night he was released. To make matters worse, he suffered a Grand Mal seizure. That moment was a turning point for him.

Roy told his mother about the AA member who had shared his story. He explained that the man had said, "It works." Roy wanted to try it, but he had no idea where to find meetings. His parents contacted an old friend, Bob L., who had been sober in AA for over 20 years. Bob was a jazz musician and knew where all the meetings were. That summer, Bob took Roy to his first AA meeting in Palm Springs.

Roy felt uncomfortable—everyone there was much older, in their 30s and 40s.

They treated him like a kid. But Roy knew he was facing life or death, so he kept attending meetings. Roy reflected:

Bob L. had an art gallery in Palm Springs. I had seen him around over the years. He seemed like a good-hearted guy. He 12-stepped me and started taking me to meetings. I was a drug addict, but Bob was respected, so I was somewhat accepted at those meetings. Bob had over 20 years sober and was a big-time jazz musician. People didn't really say much, but I could tell they were put off by me.

I'd introduce myself and say, 'My name's Roy. I'm a speed freak.'

didn't know what else to say. But people cut me a break, probably because Bob was there, and they didn't want to disrespect him.

Roy's mother could no longer handle the chaos of both her husband and son's. drug use so she moved back to the Frankford section of Philadelphia, settling on Overington Street. Roy remained in California with his father, but he knew that staying there would kill him. He was soon on a plane back to Philadelphia to live with his grandma Eventually, through word of mouth, Roy found an AA meeting in Glenside, Montgomery County. After the meeting, a woman named Annette approached him. They struck up a conversation, and Roy told her bluntly, "I was a skinny speed freak. They basically ran me out of AA."

Annette told him about the Young Men's Club, a meeting in the Kensington section of Philadelphia where younger guys gathered for support. She asked for his phone number and passed it along to Dick Flanagan, a member of the Young Men's Club. Within days, Dick contacted Roy and offered to take him to a meeting.

Dr. Donald Jay Ottenberg

Louis Gerstley, a whiskey manufacturer, came to this country in the 18605. In 1909, Louis, along with a group of philanthropists, opened the Philadelphia Jewish Sanatorium for Consumptives. Originally affiliated with Temple University's medical school, the sanatorium was built to treat tuberculosis patients. Located in Eagleville, Montgomery County, a suburb of Philadelphia, the facility was a white-painted masonry building situated on 75 acres of tree-shaded grounds. The cottages were constructed with large windows that swung open, based on the belief that tuberculosis could be treated with an abundance of fresh air.

Dr. Donald J. Ottenberg served as the medical director when only tuberculosis patients were admitted. He left when Eagleville closed and later became a pulmonary consultant for the Diagnostic Relocation Center (DRC) located at 3rd

and Arch Streets. Today, DRC is widely known as the Diagnostic Rehabilitation Center, but its original mission was as the Diagnostic Relocation Center. Around 1964, DRC was established as a research-action agency to address the relocation, medical, and social needs of the Skid Row population, which was about to be displaced by the construction of the Vine Street Expressway near Franklin Square and the Independence Mall area. Many of these men suffered from alcoholism, lived in terrible conditions, and had contracted tuberculosis. DRC staff recognized that there was no place to treat alcoholics. At the time, private treatment centers existed for the wealthy, but there were no affordable options for the poor or middle class. Dr. Ottenberg proposed converting the hospital into a treatment center for alcoholics. Despite facing significant resistance, he successfully persuaded Eagleville's board to change the nonprofit facility's mission, and on July 28, 1965, DRC began treating men suffering from alcoholism. In June 1966, the sanatorium officially changed its name to Eagleville Hospital and Rehabilitation Center, coinciding with the arrival of its first busload of 18 patients relocated from DRC to Eagleville.

The hospital was a direct outgrowth of DRC, led by Dr. Ottenberg. He stated, "We are treating alcoholics and not drug addicts or mental patients with problems that we have feared. We screen out the ones that might have such problems. Men find their way to Skid Row the way a pinball finds its way to the pocket on the bottom." The Eagleville Hospital and Rehabilitation Center aimed to help men escape from the depths of alcoholism.

In 1967, Eagleville staff members visited Daytop Village in New York City and participated in a therapy marathon. As a result, confrontational "marathon therapy" was adopted as the standard treatment for alcoholism at Eagleville. In response to growing public concern about drug addiction, the hospital expanded its mission in 1968 to include drug treatment, making it one of the first programs in the United States to provide integrated treatment for alcohol and drug addiction in the same facility.

Dr. Jerome F.X. Carroll said Dr. Ottenberg recognized that drug addicts often had alcohol problems and worked to integrate their treatments. He developed a fully comprehensive program, incorporating psychologists, social workers, vocational

counseling, and recreational activities. Additionally, Dr. Ottenberg established Eagleville Family House in Norristown, which provided accommodations for women with young children while they received treatment. Dr. Ottenberg was at the forefront of this movement. He explained;

The message I am trying to bring is that one must understand and appreciate the nature of addiction to work effectively with addicts, whether the addict is alcoholic or is dependent on barbiturates, heroin, or any other substance. One must understand not only what the addiction does to the addict but what it does for him. It's almost as though there are three persons involved in the therapeutic relationship, whereas we are used to dealing with two-ourselves and the patient or client. Unless addiction is understood and neutralized in some way, the addiction will constantly stand between the therapist and the patient.

Eagleville operated different therapy groups led by various counselors. One such group was run by Dr. Ottenberg's wife, Martha, who worked with patients dealing with mental health issues. Martha's group consisted of about ten individuals with dual diagnoses. While their specific conditions were not openly discussed, it was understood that they required special attention. Martha assisted psychologist Doris Fisher, who specialized in this type of care.

One of the patients, Dennis, was placed in a group primarily composed of older alcoholics, many of whom suffered from alcohol-related brain damage. Martha implemented unique therapeutic methods, requiring patients to keep a logbook and write down everything they heard in group sessions. When Dennis stopped writing, Martha asked why. He replied, "I can tell you everything that happened in this group verbatim for the last 15 minutes." She challenged him to prove it, and when he did, she told the group, "Dennis is younger, faster, and improving more quickly. He doesn't need to write anymore."

Dr. Thurman Booker reflected on Dr. Ottenberg's impact, stating:

If it wasn't for Don Ottenberg, Eagleville would have been just like any other facility and would have died long ago. Don Ottenberg was a genius; he was human; he wasn't afraid of people who were dirty; he wasn't afraid of the pariahs. He welcomed them and made it possible for us to realize our own humanity and resemblance to Our patients. And he didn't do a lot of lecturing about this stuff—it was just there for us. It was a marvelous experience.

Dr. Ottenberg was known for his compassionate approach, sometimes even eating lunch with patients, reinforcing his belief in the dignity and worth of those struggling with addiction.

Dick Flanagan

Dick Flanagan was born in Philadelphia in 1932. After World War II, he served in the U.S. Coast Guard. By March of 1959, Dick, an alcoholic living in Philadelphia, had reached the end of his drinking days. Upon discovering AA, he became an active member and dedicated himself to helping others find their way to recovery.

Dick often spoke about his own struggles, including a suicide attempt when he jumped from the Tacony-Palmyra Bridge in Philadelphia. He described the experience not as falling into the river but as though the water had rushed up to meet him. Miraculously, he survived.

He also shared stories from his time as a Philadelphia police officer. In one instance, he was tasked with arresting an intimidatingly large, drunken man in a bar. Nervous about the situation, Dick warned the man that he was so on edge his gun might "accidentally" go off.

Another painful memory he recounted involved his family. He recalled how he had always promised to take his children on special outings. One morning, he went to a bar, drinking as he proudly told patrons about his plans to take his kids to the zoo. The more he drank, the more he congratulated himself on being a great father. However, as the day turned into night, he never left the bar. When he finally stumbled home, drunk, his children asked about the trip. Instead of

apologizing, he berated them. Though he couldn't recall if he became physically aggressive, the experience haunted him. Dick's first AA meeting came either after his suicide attempt or another alcohol-fueled binge somewhere around 1959. He recalled walking up the steps to the. meeting location but hesitating. At that moment, another recovering alcoholic. already on the steps, turned around and told him, "Dick, for people like us, there is no tomorrow." Determined to stay sober, Dick joined the Philadelphia Young Men's Club, a well-known AA group with a rigorous, almost militant approach to sobriety. He became deeply committed to the AA philosophy and made it his mission to help others struggling with addiction.

In the book, My Years with Narcotics Anonymous, Bob Stone, pointed out how Dick F. became the father of Narcotics Anonymous in Pennsylvania as well as much of the eastern fellowship." Dick became the modern-day Houston S. yet he was unaware of his impact and his place in our history. Dick F.

believed in the power of the Steps and meetings for addicts seeking recovery. Roy observed:

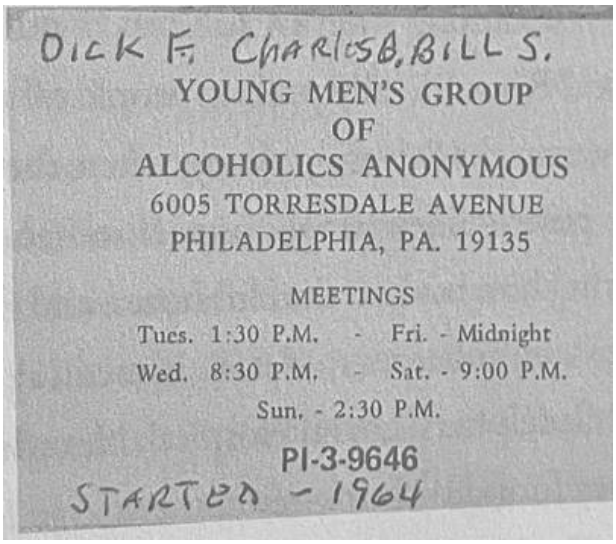
Dick was highly respected, but in Philly, most people didn't know him. The Sheehan brothers, Maureen, and a few guys in Norristown knew him from Eagleville, but the average NA member in Philly had no idea who he was. To them, he was as unfamiliar as Archie Bunker.

As best as he could remember, one day the Philadelphia Intergroup office called Dick for a routine twelve-step call—something he regularly did. This time, however, the office mentioned that the young man in need of help might be a heroin addict rather than an alcoholic. Following his usual practice, Dick tried to find another AA member to accompany him, but when no one was available, he went alone, He arrived at the given address in an affluent neighborhood on the north side of the city and met Roy P., a young addict. Although Dick initially disliked him—seeing him as just another junkie—he quickly recognized Roy's pain and self-destruction. That recognition softened his judgment, allowing him to relate

to Roy's suffering in a way he hadn't expected. Through Dick's support, Roy began attending AA meetings at the Young Men's Club, marking the beginning of his journey to sobriety.

Young Men's Club

Young Men's Club, located at 6005 Torresdale Avenue, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, started April 15, 1964 and the last meeting at this location was held On October 12, 1969, with Dick F. chairing. The Young Men's Club was not an orthodox AA group. Located in the Frankford section of Philadelphia, it was known throughout the area as renegade AA. Their philosophy was that they were the only true believers in AA—the only ones spreading the real message. Therapy was bullshit. Rehabs were bullshit. Psychology was bullshit. Everything was bullshit—except the Young Men's Club. That was hardcore AA. When they showed up at other AA meetings, they were not welcomed. People would groan, "Oh man, here come those A-holes from the Young Men's Club."



Despite their extreme approach, they welcomed anyone—schizophrenics, street people, real hobos, skid row drunks. The club attracted guys from the streets of Kensington, trying to make recovery as accessible as possible. But with the addict mindset, this open-door policy also allowed for reckless behavior. Long-term sobriety was difficult in an environment where "just don't pick up" was the only real rule.

Roy got a distorted view of the program at the Young Men's Club. They believed only Steps 1 and 12 mattered—admit you're powerless and help others. The rest? Do whatever you want. And they meant that literally. At meetings, they would say things like "If you're a burglar, you'll be a better burglar sober." Some of these men were professional criminals-Irish Mafia guys from Kensington, Teamsters enforcers, members of Local 107 and 30B.

At traditional AA meetings, members were older-mostly in their 40s, 50s. and 60s. But at the Young Men's Club, guys were in their 30s, making Roy (then 19) feel more at home. Roy didn't have to change the way he spoke. He introduced himself as, "My name's Roy. I'm a speed freak." And unlike traditional AA meetings—where drug addicts were either banned or not allowed to speak—the guys at Young Men's didn't mind Roy. Some of them knew about shooting meth. Many were criminals and hustlers who had firsthand experience with drugs. That's why he was accepted there but not in other AA circles.

There was a sign-in book at every meeting. If you wanted your name on the wall, you had to make 90 meetings in 90 days—even if you were 10 years sober. Roy completed his 90-in-90 and got his name up on the wall. Later, he saw that someone had written "Junkie" under his picture. He crossed it out.

The Young Men's Club was committed to 12-step work. They would go to Skid Row, literally pulling people off the streets. They had an ongoing commitment at the Salvation Army, where they'd bring coffee, cigarettes, and doughnuts to guys living in flophouses. If someone showed interest in getting sober, they'd bring him back to the clubhouse and find him a place to stay. They even chained guys to radiators to detox. If medical attention was needed, they took them to Philadelphia General Hospital. Next door to the club was a rooming house where they found beds for newcomers.

The Young Men's Club also dominated commitments at prisons and mental institutions, often pushing other AA clubs out of the way. Because these guys were street enforcers, they didn't face much resistance. At the club, personal conflicts didn't matter—when it came to helping the newcomer, everyone was on the same team, The clubhouse provided a drug-free environment where men could hang out, drink coffee, and talk. It was open 24/7, offering a place to sleep-guys would crash on window sills with a pillow and blanket. Bill D. got clean with a sponsor from the Young Men's Club. Back then, detox was brutal—they would tie you to a chair for 3 to 4 days until withdrawal passed. They took control of your money, cashed your check, and rationed your cigarettes. Bill had to attend AA meetings constantly. He was an arrogant addict, calling himself "cross-addicted, dual-addicted, double-bubble." No one in AA told him he couldn't use those

words, and he was grateful for that. He noticed that AA old-timers never went to NA meetings-only newcomers bounced between fellowships. That helped him decide where he truly belonged. Dick Flanagan eventually left the Young Men's Club and took a job as a principal counselor at Eagleville Hospital. This was the ultimate betrayal. In the Young Men's Club, rehab was bullshit and working for one made him a pariah. In 1969, Dick started bringing Eagleville patients to meetings. They were healthier than the guys from Skid Row, but they used different language—they talked about addiction, not just alcoholism.

At first, the AA members tolerated this. But soon, AA purists pushed for a vote: No more drug addicts at meetings. And Roy? When the vote passed, Roy was officially kicked out—he was not considered an alcoholic, so he didn't belong. Outside the meeting, Roy was in tears. He turned to Dick for guidance. Dick, ever the pragmatist, suggested: "Why don't you have a few drinks? Then you'll qualify as an alcoholic." Roy refused. He knew that one drink meant total relapse. At that moment, Dick had an epiphany-alcohol is a drug. He changed his mind and declared that Roy was an alcoholic. They returned to the meeting despite the vote. Roy stayed abstinent and kept attending AA with Don H. as his sponsor.

By this point, Roy had had enough. "I don't want to live on the East Coast anymore." He missed his father and wanted to return to California. Ray L., a friend from the Young Men's Club, had heard about the growing NA movement in California. He encouraged Roy to look them up and see what they were all about.

A Trip to California

After a few months, Roy planned a trip to California to visit his father. He went back sometime around March, or April of 1969. While there, he looked up his old friend Bob L., the man who had originally 12-stepped him. Roy vented to Bob about the trouble back home—how out of place he felt, how lousy AA was, and how hurt he was after the Young Men's Club voted him out. Bob listened as Roy ranted about the hypocrisy, unkindness, and overall bullshit of AA. Eventually, Bob lost his patience. "Shut up," he snapped.

He told Roy about an AA convention happening that weekend in Coachella Valley/Imperial Valley. Some early members of NA would be there-people Bob knew personally. This was possibly the Desert Round-Up that took place on June 6-8, 1969. At the convention Bob introduced Roy to a small group of NA members: two older men—one of whom was Jimmy K. —and a younger woman named Marie P. At the time, Jimmy K. was 58 years old. To Roy, who was still a few months shy of turning 20, they looked ancient. NA members held impromptu meetings throughout the weekend—real NA meetings for drug addicts. At these meetings were Roy, Bob, the NA members, and even one of the founders of Gamblers Anonymous. This was the first NA meeting Roy ever attended. The NA members were fired up about spreading the message and growing the program. Roy shared his struggles with not fitting in at AA and his plans to return to Philadelphia. The NA members responded, "This program is for drug addicts. Welcome." They handed Roy one or two copies of The White Book titled Narcotics Anonymous. The cover featured the NA logo—two interlocking circles—and listed two addresses. Roy remembered:

When I met Jimmy K., he didn't introduce himself like, 'I'm Jimmy K. I started this program. I was involved in this and that,' He was just another clean drug addict—a clean smackhead. He was just about the program, about carrying the message. It was all about how the program could help me and how I could carry the message to the next addict on the street. That was his only focus.

Roy felt energized-for the first time, he had something real for drug addicts. A book. A name. A program. He stayed at the convention for the next two days, absorbing everything he could from the recovering addicts. They understood him. They knew what it was like to be treated as a second-class citizen in AA. He heard the same message all weekend long: "You've gotta go back to Philadelphia and start meetings. Copy these books and get things going." Roy believed it was divine intervention—or at the very least, an incredible coincidence. He left the convention determined to bring Narcotics Anonymous to Philadelphia.

Roy rushed back to tell Dick Flanagan and Ray L. about what he had experienced. He told them about the two recovering addicts he met-how cool they were, how they understood him, and how they gave him NA literature to start meetings. The next day, Roy showed Dick the books, and they agreed to print copies themselves. Dick knew a guy from the Young Men's Club who worked as a printer. At the Young Men's Club, everyone had a moniker. The guy they needed was Bill the Printer. Roy only wanted 500 books, but Bill convinced him otherwise. "If you print 500, you print 5,000—the cost is the same," Bill said. He cut them a deal, using leftover stock and overruns to print the books at a discount. Whatever stock he had left over he used for the cover. The first White Books changed color depending on what stock the printer had; yellow, pink, gray, but it basically was a reprint of the White Book. So, Roy and Dick pooled their money to print 5,000 copies of the White Book. Bill made it in a shirt pocket shape, taller and thinner and often it had a yellow cover but not always.

Years later, Danny M. and Roy went looking for remnants of the old Young Men's Club. They ran into an old-timer from the 1960s, who gave them Bill the Printer's number. Roy called. Before Bill even said hello, the first words out of his mouth were: "I didn't vote to throw you out."

Now armed with 5,000 copies of the White Book, Roy started hitting the streets—going to churches, YMCAs, hospitals—anywhere that might host an NA meeting. AA members helped him find leads, but most people were too afraid to let drug addicts use their facilities. When asked where NA meetings were held, Roy told them there were already meetings happening out in California. The common response? "Come back when you have more meetings and references."

It was a hard sell. Society didn't want drug addicts congregating anywhere. Roy was the frontman for NA's expansion.

His energy, perseverance, and persuasive nature kept him going despite countless rejections. One of the worst encounters happened in Riverside, New Jersey.

Roy approached a youth center, hoping to start a meeting. The man in charge—a former state trooper—lost it when Roy mentioned NA. "There's no way in hell addicts are allowed to meet here. It's against the law!" He rattled off legal codes and regulations, warning that if Roy tried to start an NA meeting, he'd call the

state troopers and have them all locked up. Roy was stunned. "We're not using drugs anymore. We're trying to change our lives. We just want to get better," he protested.

Instead of a pat on the back, he got a boot in the ass. There were many rejections like that. People feared drug addicts gathering together, and it made launching NA incredibly difficult. This was 1969-1971. President Nixon was cracking down on drugs, blaming them for all of America's problems. Anyone associated with drugs—even recovering addicts—was seen as a threat. The public mindset was: "You want to help yourself? Great. Go jump off a building— that would help us." Despite the setbacks, Roy refused to give up. After months of hitting dead ends, he finally got a break—an opportunity to start an NA meeting at Eagleville Hospital. And with that, NA was about to take root in Pennsylvania.

NA at Eagleville Hospital

Even though Eagleville Hospital had been treating drug addicts, they were initially reluctant to let Roy start a meeting at the facility. In the early summer of 1969, Dick F. arranged an interview between Roy and Dr. Ottenberg, the head of Eagleville Hospital. By then, Roy was 20 years old—an uneducated high school dropout with a rebellious attitude.

At the first interview, Roy immediately launched into a passionate speech about how Narcotics Anonymous was the solution for every addict at the facility. He told Dr. Ottenberg that if NA meetings were held there, the hospital might as well shut down because NA alone could solve drug addiction. Roy continued, "All you need is NA. You don't need rehabs. Therapy is bullshit. Rehab is bullshit. Psychiatry is bullshit." Dr. Ottenberg listened but was taken aback. He thought, what are you talking about? This is my profession. Not surprisingly, nothing came of that meeting—Dr. Ottenberg essentially threw Roy out.

On the ride back, Dick turned to Roy and said, "Look, I'm going to try to get you another interview with this doctor. Maybe take a Valium or something before you go back." It took weeks before Dick could arrange a second meeting. This time, Dick coached Roy beforehand: "Roy, cut out all the criticism of the facility, psychiatry, and rehab. Just lay it out simply."

At the second interview, Roy adjusted his approach. He said to Dr. Ottenberg, "Look, we need a place to meet. This is a 12-step program. It works for people. Can you give us a chance and let us hold meetings here? If it doesn't work out, you can tell us to leave." Despite Roy's earlier outburst, something touched Dr. Ottenberg's heart. He agreed, allowing Roy to hold an NA meeting at Eagleville Hospital. Through the combined efforts of Dick and Roy, the first East Coast Narcotics Anonymous meeting was launched at Eagleville Hospital in the early summer of 1969. Was this an uncontrollable pinball or a Higher Power's hand in action? From day one, the residents themselves formed the steering committee. There was a secretary, treasurer, and chairman. A speaker would be introduced and then share their experience. However, the meetings weren't always orderly. At one point, they even had a self-proclaimed "President of NA," but this individual eventually absconded with the treasury. Intent on doing things the right way, Dick presided over most meetings, though not all addicts at the facility participated. To bring structure, he introduced the White Book as part of the literature distributed to those in the addiction program.

Roy, who was in the Elevator Union, recalled the first drug addict to attend the NA meeting—a Jewish man from Mount Airy. Soon after, the meetings grew, with about 10 to 12 people regularly attending. Copies of the White Book were kept and used alongside AA literature.

People from outside the rehab also began bringing information about Narcotics Anonymous into the facility. Eagleville hosted canteen presentations—lectures, role-playing, and evening AA and NA meetings Six or seven months into recovery, Roy relapsed. By early 1970, he had started using drugs again. He wasn't sure what happened to the meeting afterward, but he believed it folded soon after his departure. Some say it lasted about six months; others believe it survived for two years.

Bob arrived at Eagleville in September 1969 just months after Roy introduced the White Book. Bob remembers that they had AA and NA meetings in the Fellowship Hall of the old hospital building. He was skeptical of NA. He didn't consider himself an alcoholic, nor did he think he was a drug addict. His first

counselor, Dick Flanagan, was an alcoholic, which Bob questioned, "Why did they give me an alcoholic for a counselor?" Bob was among the first patients admitted for drug addiction at Eagleville, which had previously only treated alcoholics. The therapists, most with long hair, experimented with different approaches-one day trying Gestalt Therapy, the next day Cognitive Therapy-often based on something they had read in Reader's Digest. There was little consistency or clear direction.

Eagleville held one alleged NA meeting per week in the Gerstley Building, lasting about 45 minutes to an hour. The NA meetings at the time were chaotic. Somewhere around 30 to 50 people packed into a room, but the closest thing to recovery was what they learned in group therapy. People confronted each other aggressively, creating a madhouse atmosphere. However, these meetings focused less on recovery and more on planning activities like washing cars for money, attending B.B. King concerts, or debating participation in peace marches. There was little structure, and attendees had no real understanding of what they were doing.

Initially, NA meetings were mandatory for only patients. Later, outsiders and Eagleville graduates were allowed to attend. Debbie, who was at Eagleville in the summer of 1970, described the NA meetings as more of a clubhouse than a structured recovery program. There were cookie sales to raise money, but they didn't even read the preamble.

Charlie F. arrived at Eagleville on July 16, 1971. He was housed in the Louch-heim Building, where he would overhear older alcoholics holding their own AA meetings at night. NA meetings, held in the canteen, had a mix of recovering addicts and professionals with academic backgrounds. Those who had recovered through 12-step programs strongly emphasized their importance, while some professionals discouraged them, believing addiction could be "fixed" without lifelong participation in a recovery group.

At the time, other treatment facilities like the Caron Foundation and Valley Forge only admitted alcoholics. Eagleville was the only combined program for drug addicts and alcoholics, and it was the first to tell narcotics addicts that they shouldn't drink.

Between 1972 and 1974, meetings were held in the canteen and Gerstley Building. NA met on Monday and Wednesday nights, while AA met on Tuesdays and Thursdays. However, there were few people involved in NA outside the facility, and sometimes the only speakers were inpatient residents. Treatment lengths at Eagleville varied: Alcoholics stayed for 28 days. Dually addicted individuals stayed for 45 days. Drug addicts stayed for 60 days. Dutch H., who arrived at Eagleville in February 1971, struggled to identify with the program. He saw it as a guinea pig experiment for addicts, believing nobody truly got clean back then. He recalled visitors from another 12-step fellowship but found them unrelatable because they were much older. At the time, most addicts were in their 20s and never thought about getting old. There were no rules—it was like the "wild west." No one taught them how to run a meeting.

Dwayne recalled Dr. Booker at Eagleville once saying that the first thing addicts think about after quitting drugs is sex. As a result, the hospital implemented sex contracts, allowing relationships as long as both parties were honest and in agreement.

In 1970, Eagleville Hospital launched the first non-hospital residential program, known as the Candidate Program. This program combined residential therapeutic community treatment with a vocational training component, including paid employment.

"Anyone can walk away whenever he thinks he's had it," said Dr. Ottenberg, but in reality, few actually did.

Dr. Rosen emphasized the interdisciplinary approach to treatment, which allowed patients to take jobs within the institution for training and self-confidence. And doctors developed programs where patients could leave the grounds for work during the day and return at night.

Dr. Thurman Booker, described the hospital's approach, "We got people their GEDs. We got them jobs. We taught them how to go for an interview, how to dress, how to be accountable, how to rebuild their lives. And that took time."

Rich M. was the first candidate in the program, followed by Ed F. Candidates had privileges to leave the facility whenever they wanted. Dennis eagerly anticipated

moving from Eagleville into the Candidate Program, where he later found a job and entered a halfway house while continuing to attend NA meetings. Eagleville allowed candidates to drink alcohol after being off heroin for a year-many took advantage of this. Two distinct groups formed: Those who embraced the rehab philosophy but didn't attend NA meetings. And those who followed the NA program and remained actively involved in meetings. Craig L., who was at Eagleville from 1974-75, had drinking privileges. He recalled going home with his wife, discussing responsible drinking while unaware of the potential consequences.

Some addicts, like Ralph, were in a different residential program after the Candidate Program. He lived in Pottstown, where Eagleville operated a fellowship house for about 12 recovering addicts.

After being discharged from Eagleville, some addicts moved into a halfway house in Norristown, where attendance at NA meetings was required to remain in the program. Debbie K. lived at 901 DeKalb Street for three months. She recalled realizing that some people she had gone through rehab with-who initially claimed to be "social drinkers" —had become alcoholics. Though she never had a personal issue with alcohol, she remembered older members warning her about drinking. Charlie F. spent 60 days at Eagleville, six months in the Candidate Program, and later stayed at the Norristown Halfway House.

Women in the program lived in a separate residence called "The Farmhouse", which was centrally located near the cafeteria. Because of the lower number of female patients compared to men, the facility was relatively small.

Eagleville Hospital was built on Jim Madison's farm, and he continued running it as part of the hospital grounds. Many residents participated in farm work under Farmer John's guidance. One addict, Charlie F. remembered:

As you recall, when you were in the Candidate Program, there were different areas that you could work in, and I worked with the guy named Bill T. I did carpentry work. I started working for Farmer John. I think I filled Dutch's position after he moved on.

Jim H. had the option to join the Candidate Program or work on the farm but chose not to. However, he spent half his days on a tractor, working for Farmer John, pretending to be a carpenter. Farmer John, a tall, thin man, lived upstairs in a hotel down the street. Tragically, a few years later, he died by suicide, shooting himself with a rifle in that hotel.

Long before outside NA meetings were available, residents of Eagleville Hospital seeking fellowship had only one destination: AA meetings. These outings, modest and often makeshift, became crucial early steps in recovery.

Dennis D. remembered the simplicity of it: "I went out to an AA meeting two times on the little yellow school bus that Ed F. drove. There were no outside NA meetings at that time to go to."

AA was the only spiritual framework accessible off-campus, though it wasn't always a natural fit. Bob M. attended AA meetings while at Eagleville but recalled a stark contrast. "There were no NA meetings. The therapy sessions were all confrontational—nothing like what we know in AA." Still, AA offered something more stable than the institution's experimental group therapy. "They didn't know what the fuck to do," Bob said. "Bob Mack was going to AA. He'd talk about these things called steps."

With guidance from men like Dick F., Bob and others found themselves at more meetings. Bob, proud of his progress, once stood in an AA room and introduced himself: "My name is Bob and I'm an addict!" The response was swift and harsh. "They burned and sizzled me—guy after guy shooting me down."

Not everyone was as openly rejected. Charlie F. remembered Howard P., a quiet presence who offered rides without fanfare. "He worked at Valley Forge. Sometimes he'd just show up at the annex and say, 'Does anybody wanna go to a meeting?' and he'd take whoever fit in his car." Some meetings were more tolerant of addicts, and Howard prepared newcomers gently. "He explained that on the way over," Charlie said. "I don't recall being shunned personally."

These early journeys-imperfect, awkward, sometimes painful-planted seeds for what would later grow into a more inclusive fellowship. They weren't Just trips to meetings. They were acts of courage, taken by people who had no clear path—only the willingness to take the next right step. On June 10, 1973, an article published in the Wilkes-Barre Times Leader reported:

Norristown - Widespread disagreement was the product of a three-day discussion on whether alcoholics and narcotics addicts could be successfully treated by the same methods... Many of the therapists present at the conference who have academic credentials took the view that Eagleville's system of treating alcoholics and drug addicts together is feasible, if the therapists and program was chosen carefully. On the other hand, therapists without academic credentials, many of them addicts and alcoholics who have been in Alcoholics Anonymous and Narcotics Anonymous took the opposite positions. They argued that the key factor is for the therapist to have gone through the problem. One Montgomery County social worker noted that senior members of AA are strongly against dealing with narcotics addicts. Dr. Donald J. Ottenberg, Eagleville's medical director, said he did not expect to see much agreement.

A Study in Unity

Between June 1974 and November 1975, Eagleville Hospital—an innovative treatment facility just outside Philadelphia-undertook a groundbreaking study that would ripple through the landscape of addiction recovery for decades to come. Known formally as the Eagleville Combined Treatment Research Project, this research effort sought to answer a pressing and controversial question of the time: Should alcoholics and drug addicts be treated separately, or could they recover together? At the heart of this inquiry lay both scientific curiosity and a challenge to longstanding cultural assumptions. Traditionally, alcoholics and drug addicts had been viewed as distinct populations, both in behavior and in treatment approach. The Eagleville project put that assumption to the test. The study divided patients into four distinct groups, each designed to isolate and analyze the impact of separate versus integrated care: Group 1 consisted

exclusively of individuals diagnosed primarily with alcoholism; Group 2 included only those whose primary diagnosis was drug addiction; and Groups 3 and 4 were mixed groups, composed of equal numbers of alcoholics and addicts, intentionally blended to observe any impact of integrated treatment. For over a year, patients in all four groups participated in the same therapeutic environment under controlled conditions, while researchers closely monitored progress, interactions, and outcomes. The goal was clear: to gather data that could illuminate whether addiction treatment models should continue to segregate patients by substance or whether shared recovery was just as effective—or perhaps even more so.

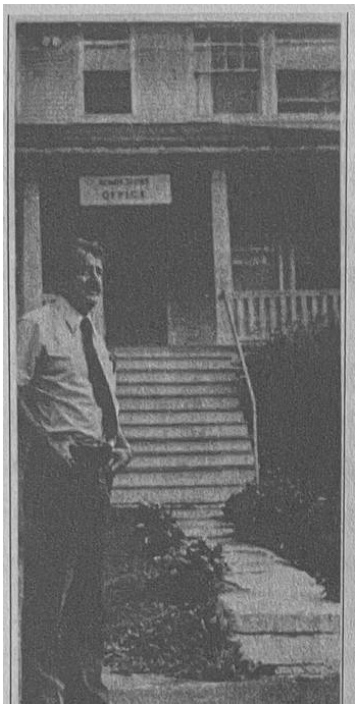
When the analysis was complete, the findings were both surprising and affirming. The data revealed that the differences between alcoholics and drug addicts—at least by the criteria the study employed—were minimal. Moreover, the outcomes among patients in separate versus integrated groups were remarkably similar. There were only slight variations in treatment success between the specialized and the blended settings.

In the end, Eagleville's research offered a compelling case for unity in treatment. It provided early clinical evidence that what united those suffering from addiction was far greater than what divided them. Though it would take time for the wider treatment world to fully absorb and act upon these findings, the study's implications planted a seed—one that would eventually bear fruit in fellowships like Narcotics Anonymous, which came to embrace the concept of addiction as a singular disease, regardless of the substance.

Eagleville's work in those years marked a pivotal turning point. In challenging the need for separation, the hospital helped forge a path toward integrated recovery-one based not on the drugs people used, but on the shared experience of addiction and the hope of a common solution.

White Deer Run

Far from the cities, tucked into the forests and ridgelines of Allenwood, Pennsylvania, stood a re-purposed tuberculosis camp reborn as a revolutionary treatment center: White Deer Run. It was the dawn of the 1970s, and the world of addiction treatment was undergoing quiet but significant changes. White Deer Run opened its doors in 1970 with a mission as bold as the landscape surrounding it. Central to its vision were Dick Flanagan and his wife Donna—veterans of Eagleville Hospital, both shaped by their years of hands-on work and a shared belief that the old models needed reimagining.



The center is on the grounds of the former Devitt Home of the United Church of Christ. There are 170 acres of land surrounding the home grounds. Originally only three of the 26 buildings would be used in the program. There are beds for 22 patients in two completely finished buildings. By October 1971 they'd have another 80 beds available. Where others saw pathology, Dick saw potential. His philosophy rejected over-emphasis on backstory and origin—on what had happened to people—and instead focused relentlessly on what they were doing now. Addiction itself, not merely its causes, became the focal point. Under Dick's leadership, White Deer Operated with a 2-to-1 ratio of alcoholics to addicts, a deliberate strategy that blended traditions but placed new emphasis on the addict's experience. The Twelve Steps were introduced through both Alcoholics Anonymous and Narcotics Anonymous literature, with the latter emerging as a quiet but growing force. White Deer became one of the first centers in Pennsylvania to sponsor institutional NA meetings outside of Eagleville's orbit. Ray D., reflecting on the

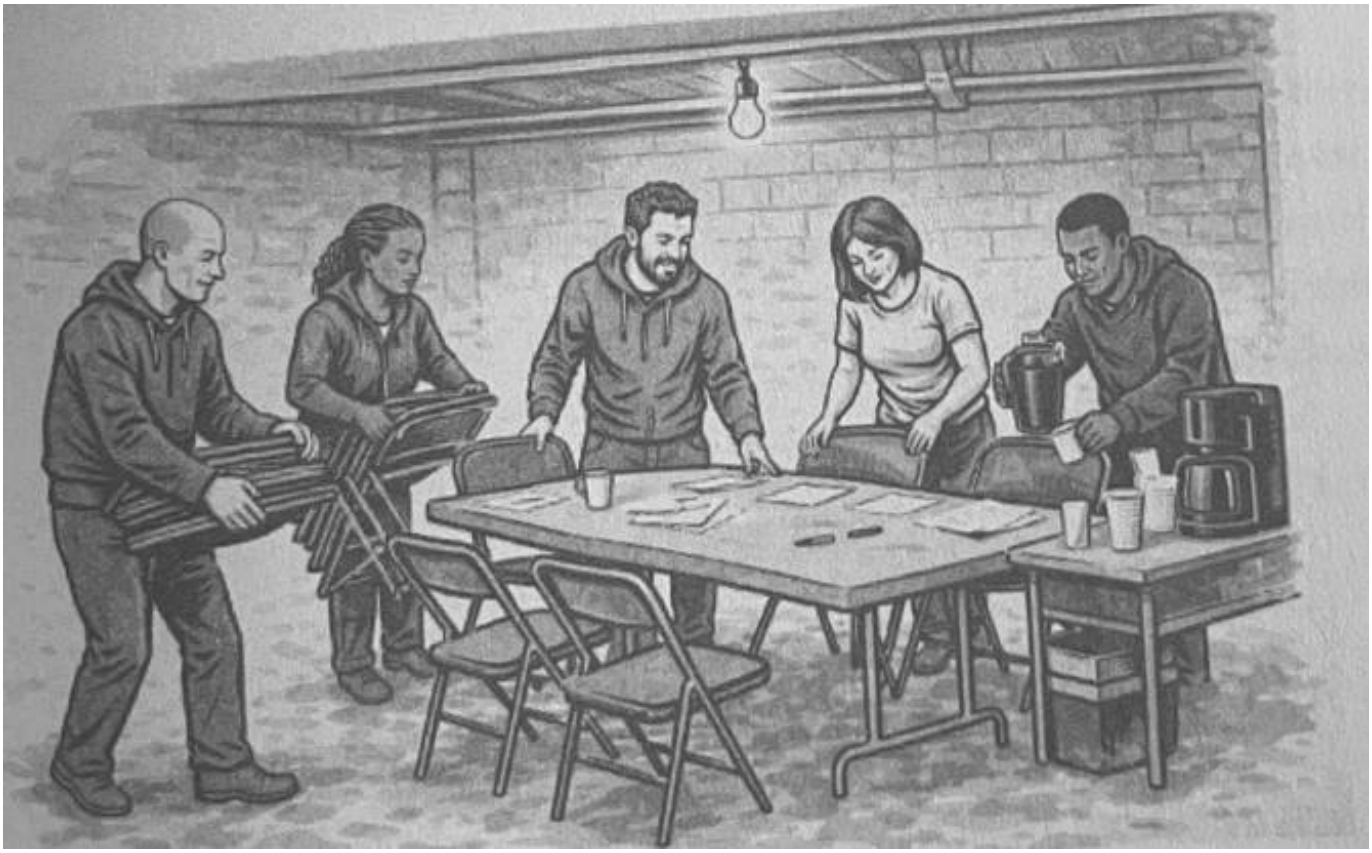
leadership style that drove the center forward, famously called Dick "the General MacArthur of addiction." He wasn't wrong. Dick commanded attention. He inspired admiration and unease in equal measure. "You either loved him," said one member, "or hated him. Or both."

His methods could be provocative. In one now-legendary episode, Dick handed a baby doll to a young man in treatment, an individual he believed had stopped aging emotionally around the time he started using. "Carry this everywhere " Dick told him. "To groups. To lunch. To every meeting." The message was piercing in its simplicity: You're not as grown up as you think.

When Dick brought in four Philly-area addicts—Bob K., Ronnie M., Dutch H., and Brian T. —to help form an NA presence in the area, he imposed a controversial condition: mandatory urine tests. Roy P., a person of strong principle, declined to participate. "You're saying we're more dishonest than alcoholics," he protested.

Though the meetings at WDR eventually dissolved under the weight of this tension, the effort itself bore lasting fruit. Hundreds of addicts passed through White Deer Run. Some settled in nearby towns, building small transitional communities where hitchhiking to meetings became the norm. Every White Book distributed at White Deer bore a quiet but enduring inscription: "Courtesy of White Deer Run."

NA’S PRESENCE IN PENNSYLVANIA



The early groups reflected a broad spectrum of approaches: some relied on AA models, and many operated under legal scrutiny that required non-addict chaperones just to meet without violating probation. Yet beneath all the variations was a single thread: addicts trying to help each other stay clean.

1970 - Rooted in Recovery

In the early 1970s, Narcotics Anonymous in the Philadelphia region had not yet found firm ground. Meetings were sparse, and clean social spaces were even rarer. After gatherings, addicts often lingered in search of connection, not wanting to return to the silence of empty homes. One unlikely sanctuary emerged in the Kensington section of the city—Maureen's mother's house. A longtime Al-Anon member, Maureen's mother didn't just tolerate the presence of recovering addicts—she welcomed them. Her large breakfast room and perpetually warm coffee pot became the backdrop for late-night conversations, laughter, and the slow rebuilding of trust in themselves and each other.

As the circle around Maureen grew —from ten to fifteen, then twenty-they began imagining a different kind of recovery life. They were clean, they were together, and they were restless. What if they could go out—bowling? Miniature golf? Late-night diners? For people who'd only ever socialized while using, this was radical. Yet these simple outings turned into powerful affirmations: joy could be found clean. Fun was possible. Life didn't have to be muted by addiction.

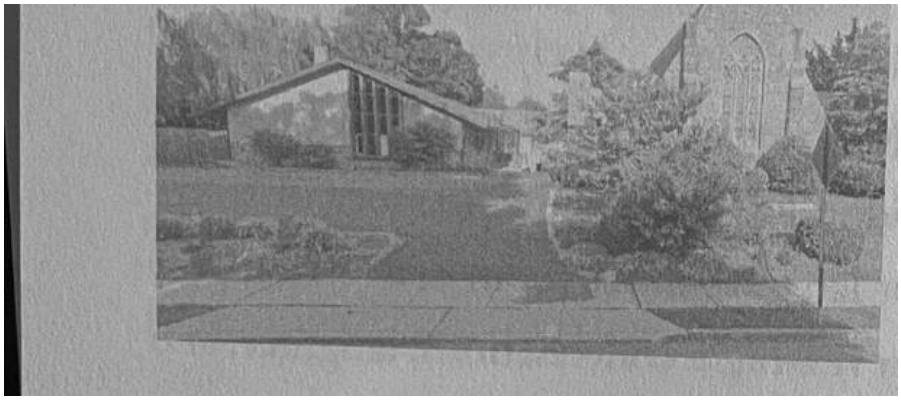
That blossoming energy led to a new idea—why not start a meeting of their own?

Springfield, Delaware County, Pennsylvania

So, they did. The group began gathering on Friday nights at 8:00 P.M. in the second-floor meeting space of the Church of the Redeemer in Springfield, Delaware County, just south of Philadelphia. It was one of the first NA meetings in the region. According to Roy P., the effort was spearheaded by two brothers, Mike S. and Danny S., both introduced to recovery through the Eagleville Hospital. Their father, Jim S., a seasoned AA member, had urged Roy to talk to them.

Roy recalled, "I think I first met them in '69, and they got straight in '70. They were a huge part of early NA."

im S.'s influence extended beyond his sons. He helped secure the Springfield church as a meeting location, and alongside Maureen, and others, set the foundation for what would later become NA's foothold in the Philadelphia area. Jim H., another early member, remembered the night it all started for him—meeting Jim, Mike, Danny, Roy, and Maureen at the Northeast Clubhouse on Frankford Avenue and heading out together to the Springfield meeting.



But early growth came with resistance. The Springfield gathering soon attracted unwanted attention from local police. Cruisers parked outside, officers recorded license plate numbers, and some members were followed out of town.

The suspicion and surveillance created an atmosphere of tension and unease. Eventually, the group made the difficult decision to shut down the Springfield meeting.

Ray T. remembers, "We all used to drive to the Springfield meeting from Philly. At a business meeting one night Matt S., who kept that meeting going and had more experience with the program, said you all drive out here from Philadelphia each week. Why don't you start meetings in Philadelphia?'" And we looked at each other like wow, that's a brilliant idea.

Bellmawr, New Jersey

Across the river in Bellmawr, New Jersey, another Saturday night meeting was born, likely around 1970 or 1971. Though little is known about its precise beginnings, Jim S., and sons Mike and Danny, along with Maureen are all credited with its formation.

Some early leaders recalled that certain elections had been quietly decided in advance, a reflection of the deep ambition many felt to help steer this new movement. Maureen remembers: "When we were setting the meeting up, before everybody started coming, we decided who was going to get the positions. We

all wanted to be the chairperson or the secretary. And we had already rigged the elections before they even happened. We were arguing over that. It was just insane" Ray D. was in a dark place mentally when two guys from Philly showed up at his house and offered to take him to a meeting. "Yeah, I'll go anywhere, because I'm losing my mind," he told them. They drove him to a church near Camden. The moment Ray walked in and heard others share their stories, he knew he had found something different. "When I listened to people talk, I knew I was home. I related to their stories. They had the same experiences with addiction as I did. I wasn't alone anymore."

1971 - A Movement Begins

A quiet but powerful shift began in the recovery landscape of southeastern Pennsylvania in 1971. What started as informal gatherings among former patients of the Eagleville Hospital outpatient clinic evolved into the early stirrings of NA in the Philadelphia area. Frustrated with the limitations of rehab-centered recovery and the disconnect they felt in AA meetings, a small group of determined addicts began forging a path of their own. Fueled by shared experience, raw honesty, and a belief in something more, they laid the groundwork for what would become a lasting NA presence in the region.

Eagleville Outpatient

Around the fall of 1971, nestled at 6 East Basin and Powell Streets, in Norristown, Eagleville Hospital had opened an outpatient clinic—an annex to its inpatient treatment facility just a few miles away. The Montgomery County Suburban Center for Alcoholism and Addiction occupied the front of the building, while the outpatient program operated discreetly in the back.

Bob M., who had first been through Eagleville in 1969, returned in July 1971 after a relapse. Unlike others who introduced themselves with admissions of powerlessness or pain, Bob had a different refrain: "I'm Bob. I'm here to become a therapist." It was disarming, and for many new members, it was convincing.

Bob left Eagleville in September 1971 and began inviting others into his home for informal conversations—not official meetings, just men talking honestly.

Among them was Rich M., once a patient himself, now assisting as a counselor He and Carl W. became close with Bob. All had passed through Eagleville's intense group therapy regimen. And though Eagleville had NA meetings on hospital grounds, many who cycled through didn't feel that the rehab's version of recovery truly belonged to them. Outside those walls, the structure vanished Many left confused, floating between AA meetings that didn't quite fit and memories of the shouted affirmations in group therapy that no longer applied.

By mid-to-late 1971, a new clarity emerged. They needed their own path—something independent of Dick Flanagan's rehab-rooted philosophy. Out of this realization came one of the first independent NA meetings: Wednesday nights at 8:00 P.M., hosted right in the outpatient clinic. They didn't have any NA literature. All they needed was a chairperson and a speaker. The attendees were from Eagleville Hospital; no one from the streets.

Tom D., a seasoned member of the Eagleville staff, knew about NA and recognized the potential. He began bringing two full busloads of patients to the Wednesday night meetings, flooding the room with addicts—many unsupervised, some skeptical, all searching.



Bob Mack, Carl, Rich, Kenny, and Jim B. were regulars. Jennifer L., the night counselor from Eagleville's women's unit, brought women to the clinic starting in March 1971. A simple shout- NA meeting!" -was enough to call them. Even those not required to attend often came anyway, drawn by a glimmer of hope.

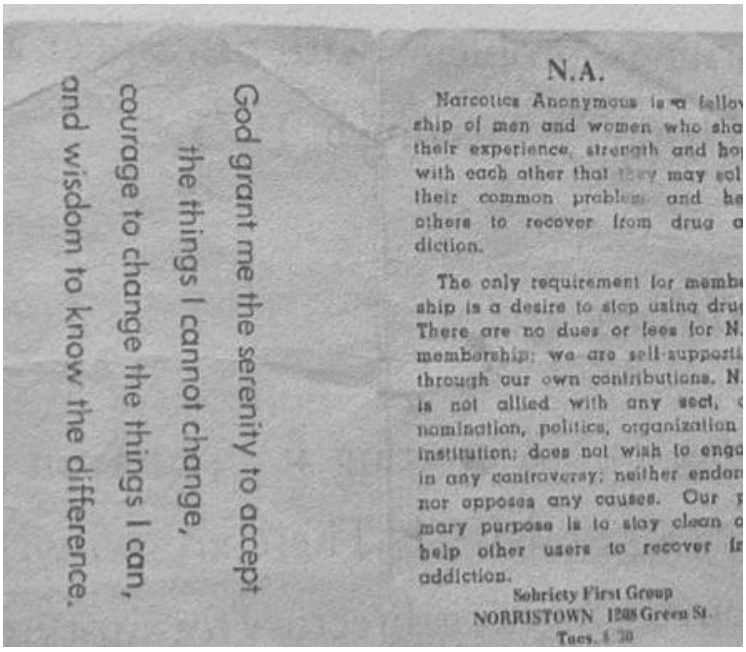
The meetings were rough and unstructured, but meaningful. "There were no real guidelines," one member remembered. "We were just figuring it out as we went." One of those early members, Bill, joined a group called the Senior Group—graduates with some clean time. He wasn't drawn to the readings, but he wanted to belong. Dave F. recalled NA members from the clinic occasionally

popping into meetings, bringing with them the unpolished but potent energy of true recovery.

Green and Basin

As 1971 turned into 1972, the Eagleville Outpatient meeting moved to Saint Augustine Church at 1208 Green and Basin Streets in Norristown on Tuesday night at 8:30 P.M., A kind-hearted minister-bearded and welcoming-opened his doors when others had shut theirs. Sometimes meetings were held in the main sanctuary, other times in the choir loft. Founders Bob Mack and Rich M. ran the group, with Ralph S. attending that very first night. "All you needed was two people and a coffee pot," said Bob. They rewrote the AA Preamble and called it Narcotics Anonymous.

Charlie F. noticed something different at Green Street. Many had been through institutional programs, but some had not. For the first time, he met people who were staying clean solely through NA-no rehab, no program managers. Just addicts helping addicts.



By April 1972, the message was spreading fast. Bill B., nearly expelled from Eagleville, sat in the canteen, unsure what was next, when Bobby Mack and Kenny told him about a meeting in Norristown. Bill decided to go. There, in Saint Augustine's, he saw something he'd never seen before: ex-addicts smiling. People like him, living clean. He didn't know if it would work, but he wanted to believe. "If they could do it, maybe I could too."

Bob was not yet the gentle elder he would later become. He was strict-focused. When someone left a college textbook at a meeting, Bob scolded, "Get

that book off of here. The only books here are recovery literature!" Structure was forming.

As early as 1972, members like Ray T. and Brian T. stumbled into NA unaware of the wider network. They had never heard of the Green & Basin group or Norristown. It was Roy P. who connected them, knitting isolated threads into a stronger web.

The meetings weren't without threat. For several months, police surveyed Green & Basin. Officers parked outside, recorded license plates, and scrutinized attendees. One night, a knock came. Bill B. opened the door to find two cops with a man between them. "Here, see what you can do with this guy," one said. "We're tired of arresting him. He's a junkie. You guys take care of it." The man stayed clean for months. The cops never came back. The group, known for its loyal attendees, faced eviction because of behavioral issues around the church property. Despite warnings, problems with disrespect and disorder led to the group's relocation to Plymouth Meeting in 1975.

Trenton State Building

Roy P. recalls starting an NA meeting at a state-run public health building in Trenton, New Jersey around 1971. There are no written records since the group was withheld from the meeting directory for supposed tradition violations. The building was associated with substance abuse treatment and outreach efforts. Notwithstanding the group managed to meet once then twice a week attracting many addicts, black, white, Puerto Rican, for most of a year.

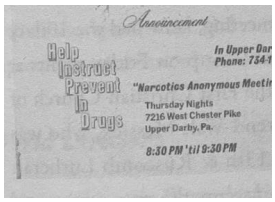
1972 - Building in and around City Limits On May 11, 1972, the Pottstown Mercury announced a new NA group meeting at INSIGHT, a local center at 252 High Street. A column by Dr. Richard Horman described NA as a self-help adjunct to therapy, emphasizing the social and therapeutic value of recovering addicts sharing their experience. The local chapter, supported by recovered addicts, welcomed new members on Wednesday

nights. Unlike the institutional models, this group embraced NA's spiritual and voluntary nature-an open door for those needing hope and community.

Meanwhile, in Philadelphia, NA's energy found another anchor. On June 5, 1972, the Logan Group opened its doors on Tuesday nights at the Muhlenberg Memorial Lutheran Church at 13th & Ruscomb. The meeting stemmed from close bonds formed between Roy P. and the Sheehan brothers—Mike and Danny. They modeled their meeting format on what they had learned in AA, introducing practices such as having candlelight and a structured flow of sharing, but it is possible that the candlelight meeting only occurred once. From just three attendees, the Logan Group grew into a vital link in NA's Philadelphia network.

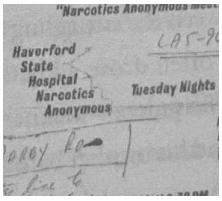


As Roy later said, they may never have made it to 13th & Ruscomb if it hadn't been for the support and open arms of people like Danny F. and Dick F.— AA members who saw them not as liabilities, but as people worth saving. Outside the city, Mike and Danny's reach expanded.



On April 20, 1972, an NA meeting was launched in Upper Darby under the H.I.P.I.D. (Help, Instruct, and Prevent in Drugs) banner, with sessions at 7216 West Chester Pike on Thursday evenings.

On June 20, 1972, a meeting started at Haverford State Hospital, held in Room 112 of the main building—again led, at least early on, by Linda and a small group of brave participants, four men and two women, determined to start something meaningful in an inhospitable environment.



Though details are scarce, Bucks County saw its own stirrings of NA presence. Roy mentioned meetings at Bucks County Prison and another supposedly launched in a church north of Bristol and Levittown. Other sources mentioned

a Thursday NA meeting at a drug outpatient drug rehabilitation center located on County Line Road, which presumably relocated to Doylestown. August brought a new Thursday night meeting to Friends Psychiatric Hospital at Roosevelt Boulevard & Adams Avenue. Listed officially by August 1973, the meeting drew a mixed crowd of alumni and outsiders but folded after about a year. Like many early meetings, its short lifespan was no measure of its importance. Every new attempt, whether short-lived or sustained, carried NA further into public consciousness. September 1972, East Germantown became a short-lived home to another NA meeting. Hosted by church at 65th and Chelton, it was one of the few spaces in Philadelphia where a Black congregation welcomed NA meetings wholeheartedly, without conditions. Though it didn't last, its message of inclusivity-radical for the time—remained a spiritual precedent.

10th and Boulevard

In September 1972, folks from the 13th & Ruscomb meeting, launched the 10th & The Boulevard Group on Friday nights at 8:30 P.M. in the First Christian Church of Christ. Reverend Walt Messick, who was the pastor at 13th & Ruscomb Lutheran Church, helped secure the space, acting as a bridge between the struggling and the spiritual.



Bob M. often drove addicts from Norristown to Philadelphia in his beloved Plymouth Belvedere-nicknamed "Proud Mary."

He'd stop at Eagleville to collect Dave and his brother before heading to the city. The Norristown crowd soon realized NA was much bigger than they'd imagined. Barb B. described that night like a calling. "We hopped in the van and went up to Philly. In a church, I went into a room for kids. And we talked about our drugs. For the first time in my life, I felt at home"

Financing remained a challenge, so the group adopted a tradition borrowed from AA: 50/50 tickets. These raffles funded the phone line, literature printing ,

and rent. But it sparked debate. Was it gambling? Some felt it contradicted spiritual principles. Still, they persisted, with Bill B. becoming the king of the 50/50—always convincing winners to reinvest their prize. Eventually, to maintain unity, the group retired from the practice. Holidays brought celebration. The group hosted Thanksgiving and Christmas dances—proof that joy could be clean and communal.

Yet not all moments were joyful. Women like Maria and Noelle struggled with the male-heavy meetings. "I'd look around and see 25 men," Maria said. "I was paranoid. I wanted to run-but I was too scared to run." Noelle came expecting a movie night and instead got Chalk Talk, an addiction film by Father Martin.

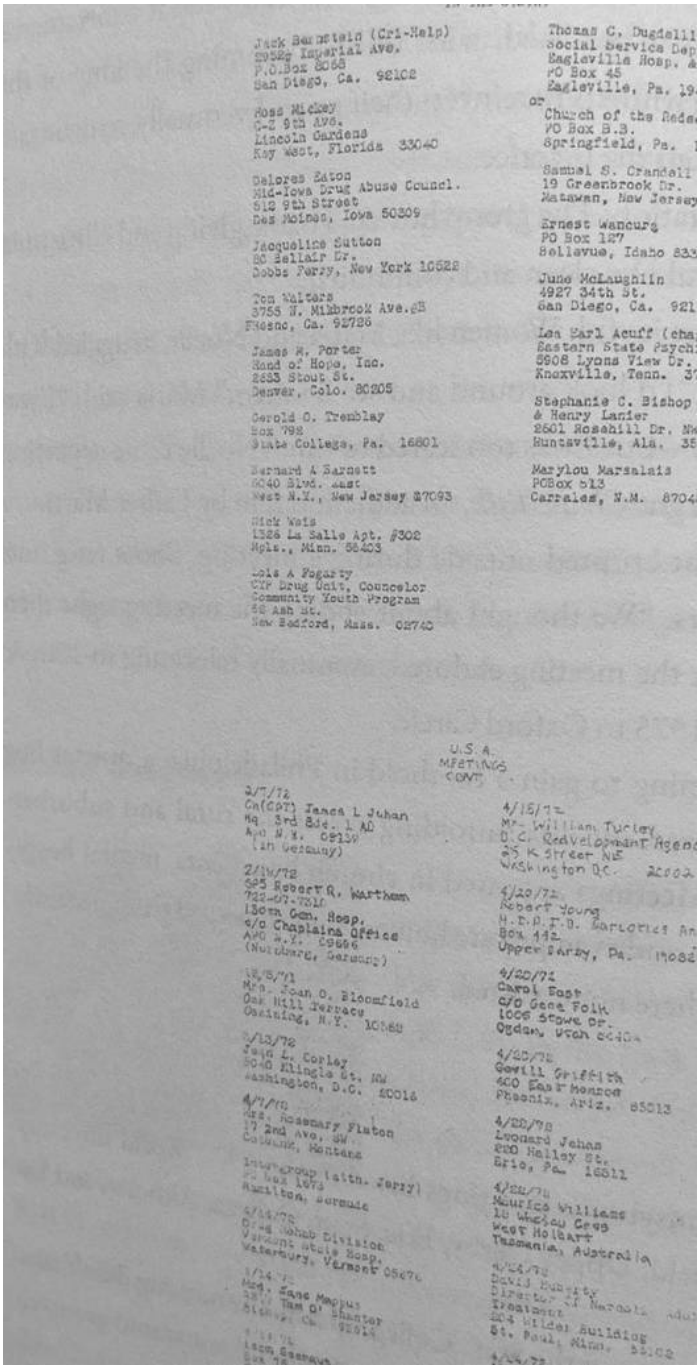
One night, a gang fight erupted outside during a meeting. Shots rang out. Members dove under cars. "We thought about ending the meeting right then and there," one said. But the meeting endured, eventually relocating to 13th & Ruscomb, then, in mid-1975 to Oxford Circle.

While NA was beginning to gain a foothold in Philadelphia, a quieter but equally determined movement was unfolding across the rural and suburban edges of Pennsylvania. Meetings appeared in church basements, mental hospitals, halfway apartments, and even private homes. Some emerged from necessity, improvising structure where none existed.

World Directory

Among the early Pennsylvania meetings listed in the 1972 World directory were groups in Springfield, Upper Darby, Erie, State College, Altoona, and Eagleville.

While Jerry T. had registered the State College group, the meeting didn't take root until 1977-1978. His attempt to launch an Addicts Anonymous group at Eisenhower Hall had also failed to gain traction.



Jack Bamfield (Cri-Help)
3952g Imperial Ave.
P.O.Box 8068
San Diego, Ca. 92102

Ross Mickey
C-Z 9th Ave.
Lincoln Gardens
Key West, Florida 33040

Delores Eaton
Mid-Iowa Drug Abuse Council
512 9th Street
Des Moines, Iowa 50309

Jacqueline Sutton
80 Bellair Dr.
Dobbs Ferry, New York 10522

Tom Walters
3755 N. Millbrook Ave.#8
Fresno, Ca. 92726

James M. Porter
Hand of Hope, Inc.
2553 Stout St.
Denver, Colo. 80205

Gerold O. Tremblay
Box 798
State College, Pa. 16801

Bernard A Barnett
6040 Blvd. East
West N.Y., New Jersey 07093

Nick Wels
1326 La Salle Apt. #302
Mpls., Minn. 55403

Lois A Fogarty
CYF Drug Unit, Councelor
Community Youth Program
42 Ash St.
New Bedford, Mass. 02740

Thomas C. Dugdell
Social Service Dep
Eagleville Hosp. &
PO Box 45
Eagleville, Pa. 19
or
Church of the Redee
PO Box B.B.
Springfield, Pa.

Samual S. Crandall
19 Greenbrook Dr.
Matawan, New Jersey

Ernest Wancura
PO Box 127
Bellevue, Idaho 83

June McLaughlin
4927 34th St.
San Diego, Ca. 921

Lea Earl Acuff (cha
Eastern State Psych
6908 Lyons View Dr.
Knoxville, Tenn. 3

Stephanie C. Bishop
& Henry Lanier
2601 Rosehill Dr. NW
Huntsville, Ala. 35

Marylou Marsalais
POBox 513
Carrales, N.M. 8704

U.S.A.
MEETINGS
CONT

2/7/72
Cn(CPT) James L Juhan
Hq 3rd Bde. 1 AD
APO N.Y. 09139
(In Germany)

2/14/72
SFC Robert R. Warthem
722-07-7511
130th Gen. Hosp.
c/o Chaplains Office
APO N.Y. 09696
(Nurnberg, Germany)

12/8/71
Mrs. Joan O. Bloomfield
Oak Hill Terrace
Ossining, N.Y. 10562

2/13/72
Jaig L. Corley
3040 Klingle St. NW
Washington, D.C. 20016

4/7/72
Mrs. Rosemary Flaton
17 2nd Ave, SW
Columbia, Montana

Intergroup (attn. Jerry)
PO Box 1673
Hamilton, Bermuda

5/14/72
Drug Abuse Division
Vermont State Hosp.
Waterbury, Vermont 05676

1/14/72
Mrs. Jane Meppus
33[illegible] Thos O. Hunter
Bronx, N.Y. 10514

4/15/72
Mr. William Turley
D.C. Redevelopment Agenc
25 K Street NE
Washington D.C. 20002

4/20/72
Robert Young
H.D.P.I.D. Carlisle Ar
Box 142
Upper Darby, Pa. 19082

4/20/72
Carol East
c/o Gene Folk
1008 Stowe Dr.
Ogden, Utah 84404

4/20/72
Gerald Griffith
400 East Monroe
Phoenix, Ariz. 85013

4/22/72
Leonard Jehan
220 Halley St.
Erie, Pa. 16511

4/22/72
Maurice Williams
10 Wheatou Crest
West Hobart
Tasmania, Australia

4/24/72
David Duffy
Director of Narcotic
Treatment
804 Wilder Building
St. Paul, Minn. 55102

Sources from 1972 again varied from 36 to 63 to 70 meetings worldwide.

1972 to 1973 - The Rise of NA in Central Pennsylvania

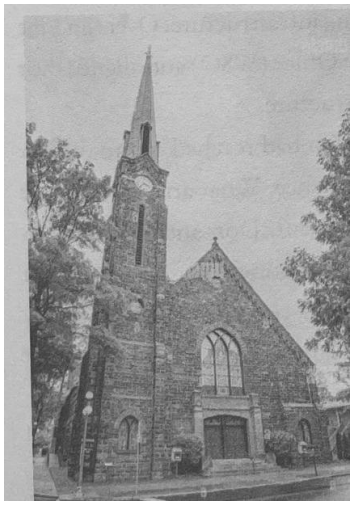
In the rolling hills of central Pennsylvania, long before Narcotics Anonymous had taken root in most of the state, one man's quiet commitment helped sow the seeds of a fellowship that would eventually change countless lives. One of the more curious outgrowths of this era began not as NA, but under the banner of Drug Abusers Anonymous-a name born more from necessity than identity.

Among the earliest participants was Don L., a recovering alcoholic and active member of Alcoholics Anonymous. who had come through the White Deer Run facility. His transition from inpatient to independent living led him to an apartment in Sunbury, Pennsylvania, where a rotating cast of recovering roommates passed through. The apartment served as a halfway step for many—a space somewhere between institutional control and full autonomy. He began by sponsoring a small group of recovering addicts who had cycled through White Deer Run and other local facilities. These addicts had nowhere else to go. Together, they founded a pair of peer-led groups.

Out of this modest setup, and with guidance from Dick F., two meetings were born:

first in Lewisburg, and then in Williamsport.

At the time, these groups operated under the name "Drug Abusers Anonymous," a title more practical than ideological. They were doing the best they could, creating a space for recovery in towns where even the word "addict" was often whispered. While not formally NA, they laid foundational stones for what would soon become independent, spiritually driven NA fellowships.



In Lewisburg, the First Baptist Church Opened its doors on January 24, 1972 for a Tuesday night meeting. Don L. served as the group's sponsor. In that era, addicts couldn't even legally congregate without oversight; many were on probation or parole and risked jail time simply for

attending. Consequently, some early meetings had to be "sponsored" by someone. without a criminal record—often a non-addict—to avoid legal jeopardy.



On September 22, 1972, a Friday night meeting was launched at Divine Providence Hospital, a dozen miles from White Deer Run. One attendee, Mary, remembered vividly the legal restrictions in place: drug addicts weren't legally permitted to gather unsupervised. To comply, a Catholic nun attended the meetings as a chaperone. Despite the group's raw emotional sharing—often laced with profanity and rage—the nun never flinched. She simply sat and prayed, bearing silent witness to their struggle.

These meetings carried over some of White Deer Run's controversial practices—particularly the requirement that voting members submit to urine testing twice weekly. While these policies mirrored WDR's institutional framework, they also alienated some who saw them as incompatible with the principles of personal autonomy and mutual trust found in NA. Still, they filled a gap for addicts needing support in isolated areas with little existing infrastructure. Over time, the groups sought connection to NA's World Service Office (WSO) and aligned their meetings more closely with NA traditions and structure.

Something began to shift in February 1973. Don had reached out to the NA WSO in California, requesting literature and guidance. What arrived was more than a box of pamphlets. It was a spiritual alignment. Don and the members of both groups voted to adopt the name Narcotics Anonymous, rewriting their by-laws to reflect NA's principles, and pledging 25 percent of their monthly treasury balance as donations to support WSO. Don also formally requested that both groups be listed in the NA World Directory.

His first letter to WSO, dated February 19, 1973, expressed both gratitude and a sincere desire to build a legitimate NA presence in their area. He noted that nine addicts regularly attended meetings in Lewisburg and Williamsport, and that five of them had already stayed clean for over a year-a remarkable feat in an era where institutional support for recovery was sparse and legal risks for drug addicts were high

Just days later, on February 23, Don wrote again. This time, the tone was more urgent. The groups were growing, and he requested 50 copies of the White Booklet to support the rising demand. But cracks in the system were beginning to show. Multiple literature orders went unanswered, despite checks being sent. Communication with WSO had become inconsistent. And within the groups, other challenges surfaced: members relapsed. Some took the group treasury with them when they left.

But Don's response wasn't to close ranks or build barriers. Instead, the groups chose generosity and celebration. For their one-year anniversary in Lewisburg, they used what funds they had to host a buffet supper—a symbolic act of gratitude and community, valuing spiritual progress over financial purity. For Don, these young recovering addicts weren't liabilities. They were miracles in progress. The group's concern was never just about the money; it was about whether the struggling addict would make it back through the door.

By May 20, 1973, Don's third letter carried a sharper tone. Literature orders still hadn't arrived, despite the fact that checks had been cashed. The groups, frustrated, made the decision to pause further donations to the WSO. Yet even amid this breakdown in infrastructure, the groups themselves were thriving. Don reported that membership had risen to 20, with six members celebrating two full years clean.

Don L.'s letters are more than correspondence. They are primary documents of hope, frustration, and perseverance. They chart the early expansion of NA into communities that had no precedent for such recovery work. And they reflect a larger truth of the time: that while the world was turning harder against addicts, a few people-quiet, stubborn, and driven by service—were building something entirely different. Something that would last.

Don's vision extended beyond logistics. A newspaperman by trade, he offered to help local members write their recovery stories in hopes of contributing to a future NA "Big Book." One story stood out to him—a 16-year-old girl with 15 months clean. Her journey symbolized what NA was slowly becoming:

a lifeline not only for seasoned addicts, but for young people with nowhere else to go. He saw NA not as a mirror of AA, but as something that needed its own space, its own literature, and its own voice.

Throughout the summer of 1973, questions about policy and philosophy deepened. One of the more divisive issues arose when groups in Williamsport and Lewisburg implemented urinalysis requirements for meeting attendees. The Philadelphia fellowship took this seriously. After weeks of discussion and input from surrounding towns, a vote determined that the practice violated the Third and Fourth Traditions. As a result, those groups were no longer officially recognized by the Intergroup, a disconnection that would last over a year. An attempt to reunify came months later, with letters and phone calls inviting them back into fellowship—so long as the Traditions were respected. For a time, the invitation went unanswered.

Jeff S., a contemporary, later reflected on the early days of Don's work in Lewis-burg. The original meeting—then still called Drug Abusers Anonymous—had run into resistance from local AA members. "You can't talk about that stuff here." they had told him. But rather than shut the door, the local AA noon meeting pointed the way forward, encouraging Don and his group to find their own space "across the street." That kind of quiet support helped bridge the divide between fellowships, and others like Dick F. and Steve S. played crucial roles in helping NA gain a foothold.

These early NA meetings, whether named "Drug Abusers Anonymous" or officially NA, operated in the tension between survival and legitimacy, between institutional control and spiritual autonomy. They were fueled by the same truth: that addicts helping one another could accomplish what institutions alone Could not. And slowly, from rose gardens in Lewisburg to hospital basements in Williamsport, Narcotics Anonymous took root in Central Pennsylvania soil.

1973 - The Fellowship Begins to Take Root

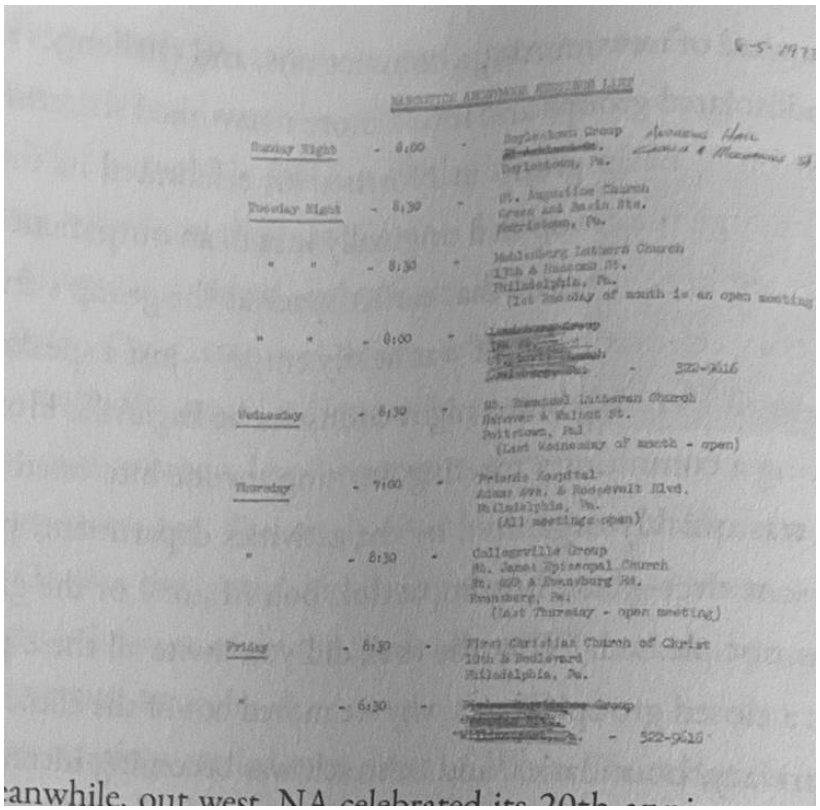
In the early months of 1973, the slow flickers of a new, growing recovery movement began to illuminate unexpected corners of Pennsylvania and surrounding states. On St. Patrick's Day-March 17, 1973—a small group of addicts including Brian T., Ray M., Emmanuel L., Jay M., and Jennifer L. launched a new Saturday night Narcotics Anonymous meeting at the Horizon House, located at 2137 North 33rd Street in South Philadelphia. This marked the beginning of

what would become a wave of new meetings, connections, and challenges as NA began to move beyond isolated groups and into a more networked structure.

Meanwhile, the Green & Basin group in Norristown celebrated its first anniversary in April. Although the group had originally met in an outpatient clinic before relocating, its members honored that earlier space as the group's true beginning. The anniversary celebration itself was nearly empty-just a speaker and one lone attendee—until Dennis, then a night counselor at Eagleville Hospital, took to the mic during a community meeting, inviting anyone interested to the celebration. A bus was quickly organized by the activities department, packed with patients, and sent over—late, but impactful. Bob M., one of the group's early members, was not pleased. "Why the fuck did you invite all these people down here? This is a closed group! That's why we moved out of the clinic!" The friction between privacy, boundaries, and outreach was becoming increasingly evident as NA grew.

On May 3, Rich M. and Bill B. started a Thursday night meeting in Collegeville at St. James Episcopal Church, nestled at the intersection of Germantown Pike (Rt. 422) and Evansburg Road. Then, in early June, a new group called Never Alone began meeting in Sunbury at Saint Matthews Episcopal Church, serving a community about eleven miles south of Lewisburg. Bob K. and Joe K. launched another Wednesday step meeting in Pottstown on June 20. For weeks, they were the only attendees, switching back and forth between speaker and chair roles, diligently logging their efforts in a notebook. Eventually, desperate for participation, they took to the streets and coaxed addicts inside. It was stubbornness, not popularity, that kept many early meetings alive.

Doylestown soon joined the growing map of groups, starting a Sunday evening meeting on July 15 at Andrews Hall. As the meeting list expanded, an August 5 snapshot captured the extent of the network. Philadelphia, Norristown, Lewis-burg, Pottstown, Collegeville, and Williamsport were all represented, along with Doylestown's new group. These nine groups, although small, were budding signs of a movement taking hold.



NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS MEETING LIST

Sunday Night - 8:00 - Doylestown Group Anderson Hall
Doylestown, Pa.

Tuesday Night - 8:30 - St. Augustine Church
Green and Buck Sts.
Norristown, Pa.

" " - 8:30 - Muhlenberg Lutheran Church
17th & Hanover St.
Philadelphia, Pa.
(1st Tuesday of month is an open meeting

" " - 8:00 - [redacted] - 322-9616

Wednesday - 8:30 - St. Thomas Lutheran Church
Hanover & Walnut Sts.
Fairtown, Pa.
(Last Wednesday of month - open)

Thursday - 7:00 - Pelaris Hospital
Adams Ave. & Roosevelt Blvd.
Philadelphia, Pa.
(All meetings open)

" - 8:30 - Collegeville Group
St. James Episcopal Church
St. 6th & Pennsburg Rd.
Pennsburg, Pa.
(Last Thursday - open meeting)

Friday - 8:30 - First Christian Church of Christ
10th & Boulevard
Philadelphia, Pa.

" - 6:30 - [redacted] - 322-9618

anwhile, out west, NA celebrated its 20th

Meanwhile, out west, NA celebrated its 20th anniversary in Los Angeles on August 18. Jimmy K., delivering the keynote at the Islander Restaurant on La Cienega Boulevard, reflected on the momentum: "We're growing faster now than we ever did before. There are more opportunities for each and every one of us to find our place in Narcotics Anonymous and carry the message.. all over the world." What had once seemed like a fragile seed in California was now clearly blooming far beyond its roots.

On November 14, Dutch H. launched the Southampton Group at Today, Inc.'s outpatient clinic. For several years, this meeting remained steady, but as facility controls tightened-requiring approved guest lists and security protocols-attendance waned, and eventually, the meeting dissolved. Still, many remembered it for its early commitment. George R. would later describe his first visit as bewildering: "I was very confused. And I still thought the facility was in charge... The only thing I do remember coming out of it is they asked me to keep coming back."

Late November saw another change as the Doylestown Group moved its Sunday meeting to Byberry State Hospital, settling into Anderson Hall.



Under the steady presence of Joe M., a seasoned AA member who had a deep care for young addicts, the meeting flourished. Weekly attendance grew to around 20. Reports were that there were NA meetings that continued through 1979.

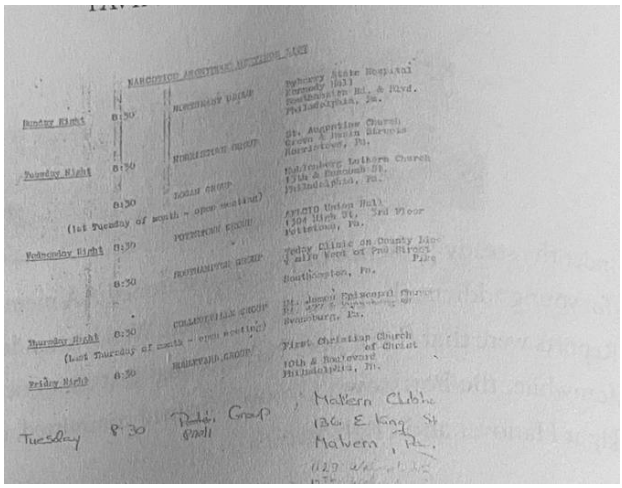
Meanwhile, the Pottstown Group remained committed, continuing to meet weekly at Hanover and High Streets.

1974 - Carrying the Message - One Meeting at a Time

As 1974 gained momentum, other efforts continued to thread across southeastern Pennsylvania. In late February, Bobby was bringing Dave F., Johnny, and Jim H. to Tuesday night meetings at 13th and Ruscomb and Friday meetings at 10th and the Boulevard. Though small and unassuming, these gatherings were steady points of light in the city's recovery landscape.

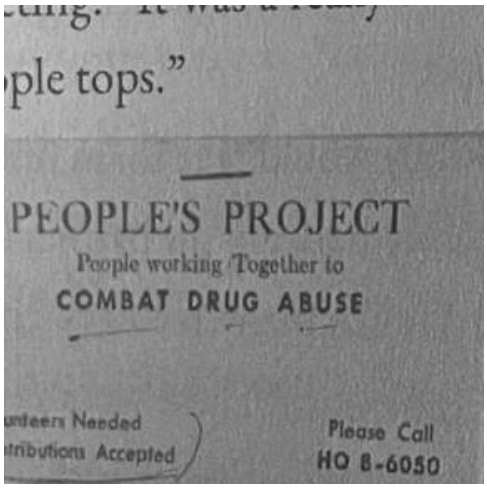
When the drive into Philadelphia felt too far, Bobby would take them instead to the Norristown meeting-a group that was barely hanging on by then. Yet what struck him most was who he found there. Unlike many recovery circles dominated by Eagleville alumni, this group was different. "These were people everybody I knew in recovery wasn't affiliated with," Bobby remembered. These were NA people-raw, unfunded, and deeply committed.

By April 3, 1974, the Pottstown Group had relocated to a new home at the AFL-CIO Union Hall at 1304 High Street, affirming its place as one of the region's more resilient communities. Around the beginning of June, Bob G. and June H. opened a new Thursday night Paoli Group meeting at the AA Clubhouse on East King Street in Malvern, giving the area another vital hub. Just days later, On July 4, a new Thursday evening meeting began at Thomas Jefferson University in Philadelphia, broadening NA's city footprint into the academic and medical core of Center City.



Then, in mid-July, Mary Ann J. and Vicky M. launched a Monday night meeting at the Holy Trinity Episcopal Church in Lansdale, tucked into the church's Fireside Room. Mr. X recalled that some members would hitchhike from Doylestown just to attend. Cindy R. remembered it vividly as her first meeting: "It was a really small room with a fireplace in it. You know, maybe 10 people tops."

August 4 saw the start of a new Friday night meeting in South Philadelphia: The Principles Above Personalities Group, hosted at the People Project Building at 7th and Moore. NA's footprint was becoming pronounced and diverse, with new meetings forming in neighborhoods across class and racial divides.



In Pottsville, a Wednesday morning meeting was established on September 4 at the Masonic Building Schuylkill County Council Room. Then, on September 10, the Doylestown Group returned to its original location at Andrews Hall on East Court Street, restarting its Tuesday night gathering. Their 1973 meeting had since moved to Byberry Hospital, but this return felt like a restoration of its roots. In September of 1974 Endless Mountains Treatment Center for Alcohol/Drug Addiction in Blossburg, Pennsylvania opened its doors. Alice C., a teenager at the time, struggled with addiction but was misdiagnosed with mental

illness. With no treatment options for youth, she cycled through psychiatric hospitals. Her parents resisted the idea of addiction, but members of Narcotics Anonymous encouraged her: "Don't listen to your parents. Get in the car." She did and found hope in the mountains. The center closed in 1988.

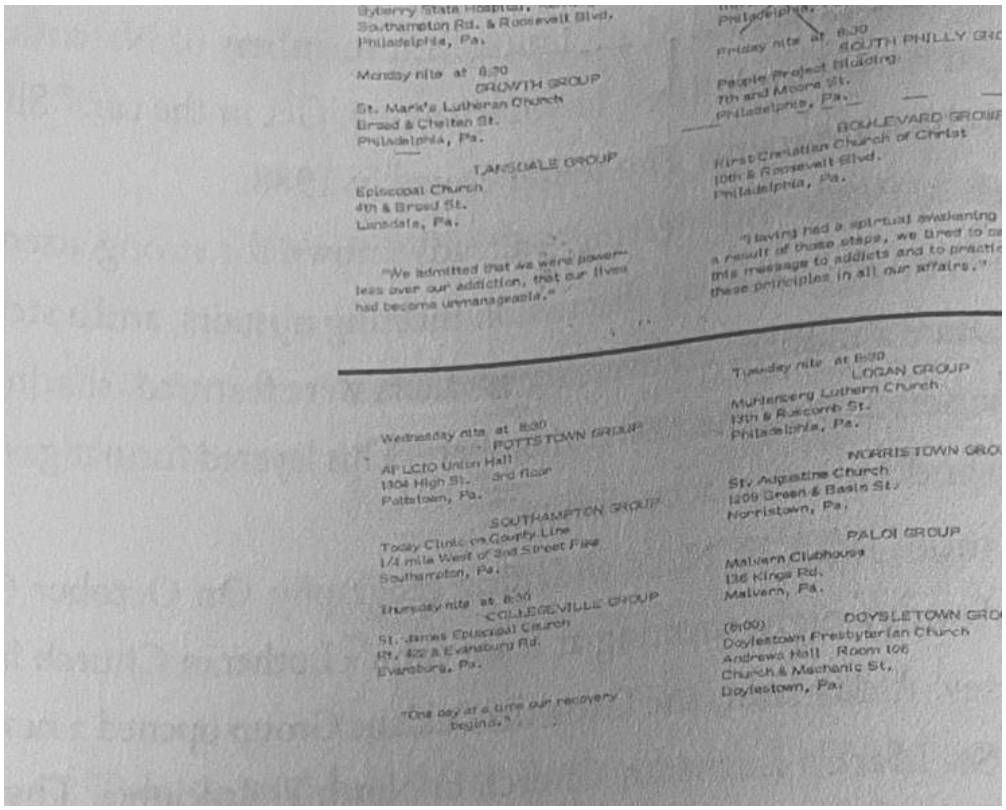
Meanwhile, the 10th & Boulevard meeting—already known for strong attendance-split into two formats: a speaker discussion meeting upstairs, and a step meeting downstairs. Once a month, anniversary speakers were featured, sharing the depth of their experience with the newer members. This layered format gave the group new energy and increased accessibility.

October brought more signs of NA's widening geography. On October 6, Dutch H. started a Monday night meeting at Saint John's Lutheran Church in Ocean City, New Jersey. A day later, the Growth/Oaklane Group opened a new Monday meeting at St. Mark's Lutheran Church in North Philadelphia. They called it the "Golden Book Meeting", incorporating Father Ralph Pfau's "Golden Books" into the meetings. The meeting was listed originally as the "Growth Group" and later as the "Oaklane Group" on the meeting directories.

By October 19, the Sunnyside Group opened in Chester, with a Saturday night meeting at Crozer Chester Medical Center. With it came NA's presence in another hard-hit community, and another testament to the grassroots spread of the fellowship.

A published meeting list from mid-1974 captured the scope and diversity of the fellowship's presence at that time.

Meetings were running every day of the week in locations ranging from state hospitals and union halls to churches.



New meetings continued to appear. On November 4, a Wednesday night speaker meeting opened in Mullica Hill, New Jersey, at Trinity Methodist Church. The Intergroup meeting minutes in December noted information of an Open meeting in Wilmington, Delaware, at Saint Paul's Church on West 4th and North Jackson Streets.

By the end of 1974, the NA community across the region had evolved into something sturdy and self-aware. Many meetings were still fragile, some experimental, and others had already folded. But the overall direction was unmistakable: recovery was being passed person to person, meeting to meeting, room to room. And the message was reaching more people than ever before —not through institutions, but through the steady work of those who kept showing up.

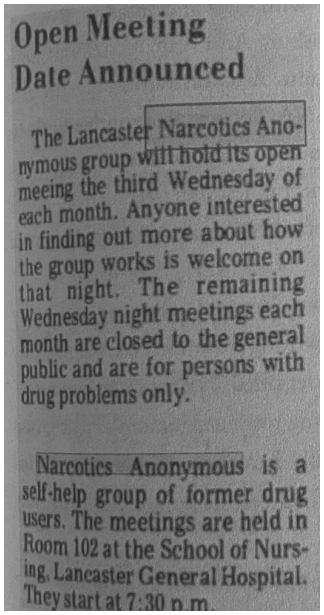
1975 - NA Broadening

By 1975, Narcotics Anonymous was steadily broadening its presence across Pennsylvania and neighboring regions, reflecting both the increasing demand for recovery and the dedication of local members to build new meeting spaces. The year opened with a new gathering in Coatesville, where Larry P. launched a Wednesday evening speaker-discussion meeting at the Chester Valley Learning

Center. This initiative marked an ongoing commitment to making NA accessible beyond the urban hubs.

A few months later, in early March, the Mullica Hill Group in New Jersey moved their Monday night meeting to the United Presbyterian Church in Glassboro, New Jersey, reflecting a growing formalization of meeting venues and a commitment to stability. Spring also brought exploratory efforts beyond Pennsylvania's borders. Dutch H. and Brian T. ventured to Manhattan to attend an NA meeting, seeking connection and insight into recovery efforts in New York City. While the meeting seemed open and free flowing, it felt different from the NA groups in Norristown and Philadelphia in that those groups had longevity in their structure.

Back in Pennsylvania, expansion continued apace. April saw the establishment of a Wednesday evening meeting at Lancaster General Hospital's School of Nursing, with a prominent article in the Lancaster Sunday News announcing monthly open meetings designed to welcome interested newcomers and curious community members. These efforts underscored NA's growing outreach beyond strictly closed circles.



Open Meeting Date Announced

The Lancaster Narcotics Anonymous group will hold its open meeing the third Wednesday of each month. Anyone interested in finding out more about how the group works is welcome on that night. The remaining Wednesday night meetings each month are closed to the general public and are for persons with drug problems only.

Narcotics Anonymous is a self-help group of former drug users. The meetings are held in Room 102 at the School of Nursing, Lancaster General Hospital. They start at 7:30 p.m.

May brought new life to Mount Penn, Pennsylvania, where a Monday meeting began at Faith Lutheran Church. Though this group dissolved by late 1978, its influence endured—one of its members would help start a new meeting in 1979, demonstrating NA's cyclical growth and resilience.

Significantly, the spring of 1975 also saw the founding of what would become the first Narcotics Anonymous meeting in Northeastern Pennsylvania: a modest gathering in the back of a pizza parlor in Plymouth. John S. recalled that two men, fresh from the White Deer Run program, initiated this meeting despite tragic circumstances, including the untimely death of one of the two members (who

was also the pizza parlor's owner). This grassroots beginning was emblematic of NA's ability to grow in unlikely places, fueled by commitment and shared experience.

Philadelphia continued to evolve as a center of activity. The 10th & the Boulevard meeting relocated to 13th & Ruscomb Streets in June.

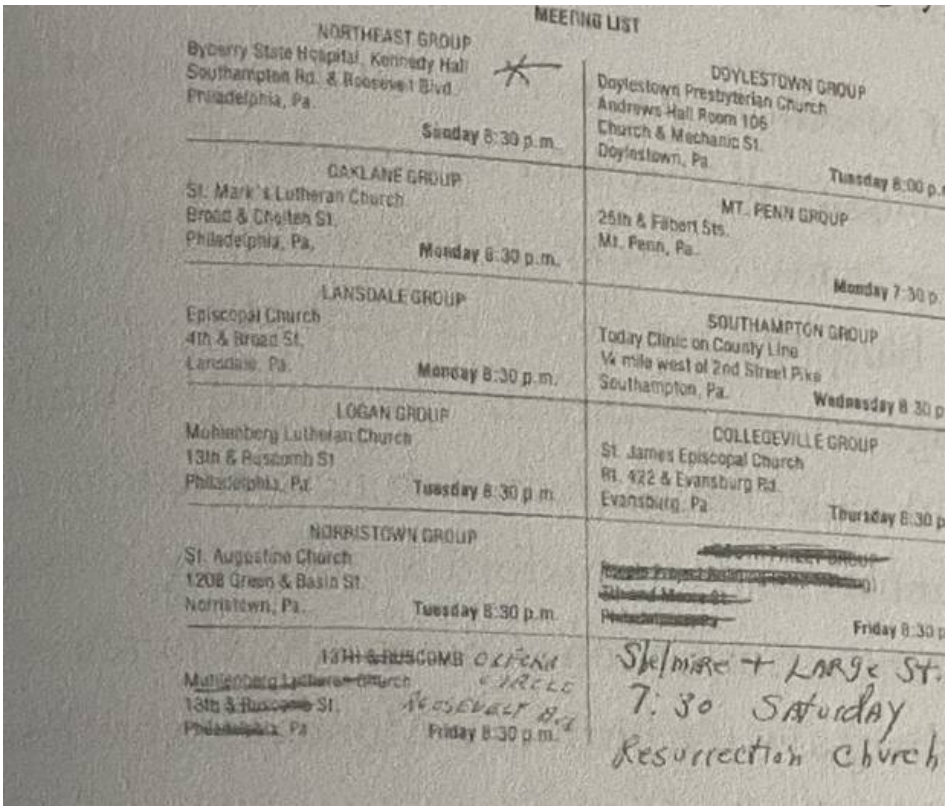
Late July saw the founding of a Thursday evening meeting at the Navy Yard and by August, a Friday night meeting started at Saint Luke's Lutheran Church in Sunbury, further extending NA's reach.

The Green & Basin group relocated to the Church on the Mall in Plymouth Meeting on August 19, 1975. Its renaming as the Sobriety First Group, illustrates the ongoing negotiation between fellowship needs and community expectations.

September marked significant growth with new meetings in Roxborough/Manayunk and the founding of Harrisburg Area Narcotics Anonymous (HANA) at Holy Spirit Hospital's detox unit. Administrative diligence also became evident; Wanda B., secretary for HANA, documented routine business affairs including literature purchases and group correspondence arrangements, while establishing a chip system to mark sobriety milestones ranging from under 30 days to over one year. These practices reflected NA's maturing organizational structures.

On October 6, 1975, a letter was sent from Wanda B., secretary of a newly formed group in Harrisburg, Pennsylvania. Writing from HANA, she urgently requested 100 copies of the small white booklet titled "Narcotics Anonymous, as well as a copy of the NA bylaws and meeting topic suggestions. Their group met Friday nights at the Holy Spirit Hospital's detox unit. This letter—factual and heartfelt—captured the growing hunger for literature and guidance in newly forming communities. As the year waned, new meetings took root in Levittown at Saint Michael's Church, started by John H. and Rich M., and in northeast Philadelphia with the Primary Purpose Group. The latter introduced a unique format-Saturday step and tradition meetings that omitted speakers and replaced "alcohol" with "drugs/addicts" in the classic AA Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions. Beginning at 7 P.M., these meetings accommodated social plans after the session and eventually

relocated to the Maternity of the Blessed Virgin Mary (BVM) Church in 1981, highlighting the evolving diversity of NA meeting types and schedules.



MEETING LIST

NORTHEAST GROUP
Byberry State Hospital, Kennedy Hall
Southampton Rd. & Roosevelt Blvd.
Philadelphia, Pa.
Sunday 8:30 p.m.

OAKLANE GROUP
St. Mark's Lutheran Church
Broad & Chelten St.
Philadelphia, Pa.
Monday 8:30 p.m.

LANSDALE GROUP
Episcopal Church
4th & Broad St.
Lansdale, Pa.
Monday 8:30 p.m.

LOGAN GROUP
Mohlenberg Lutheran Church
13th & Ruscomb St.
Philadelphia, Pa.
Tuesday 8:30 p.m.

NORRISTOWN GROUP
St. Augustine Church
1208 Green & Basin St.
Norristown, Pa.
Tuesday 8:30 p.m.

13TH & RUSCOMB OLIVIA & HALL
Mulhenberg Lutheran Church
13th & Ruscomb St.
Philadelphia, Pa.
Friday 8:30 p.m.

DOYLESTOWN GROUP
Doylestown Presbyterian Church
Andrews Hall Room 106
Church & Mechanic St.
Doylestown, Pa.
Tuesday 8:00 p.m.

MT. PENN GROUP
25th & Fabert Sts.
Mt. Penn, Pa.
Monday 7:30 p.m.

SOUTHAMPTON GROUP
Today Clinic on County Line
¼ mile west of 2nd Street Pike
Southampton, Pa.
Wednesday 8:30 p.m.

COLLEGEVILLE GROUP
St. James Episcopal Church
Rt. 422 & Evansburg Rd.
Evansburg, Pa.
Thursday 8:30 p.m.

[redacted]
Friday 8:30 p.m.

Skelmore + Large St.
7:30 Saturday
Resurrection Church

Throughout 1975, the tapestry of Narcotics Anonymous meetings in Pennsylvania and its environs was woven tighter, reflecting both the growing awareness of addiction recovery needs and the passionate commitment of members who transformed modest spaces—from hospital rooms to pizza parlors-into sanctuaries of hope and healing.

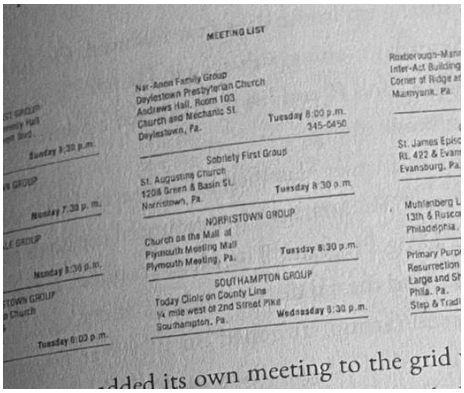
1976 - NA’s Flourishing Footprint

The landscape of Narcotics Anonymous in 1976 was still rugged, still forming—what one might call a frontier of recovery. Groups were growing, spreading across Pennsylvania, Delaware, and New Jersey, held together not by a centralized body or blueprint, but by the determination of a few committed addicts willing to bring the message wherever space could be found.

The year began with quiet momentum with new meetings popping up in different areas. On January 4, the Frankford & Allegheny Group launched a Sunday night meeting at the Cornerstone Community Church in Philadelphia. On January 5, Harrisburg saw the birth of a Monday night closed beginner’s meeting at the United Methodist Church on Derry Street. The structure was notable—newcomers upstairs in one meeting, more seasoned addicts downstairs in another. Recovery was happening on all levels.

By January 7, in Dunmore, Pennsylvania, the Freedom Group opened its doors in the basement of another United Methodist Church, offering two weekly meetings on Wednesdays and Fridays at 7:30 P.M. These meetings provided essential grounding in a region that previously had little direct access to NA fellowship.

The January 1976 meeting list, though still sparse, hinted at the breadth of commitment. Meetings were scattered from Mount Penn to Lansdale, Doylestown to Collegeville. The Sobriety First Group continued at Green & Basin in Norristown. The Northeast Group met in the old wards of Byberry State Hospital. Saturday nights belonged to the Primary Purpose Group at Large and Shelmire, a now-legendary anchor for East Coast NA.

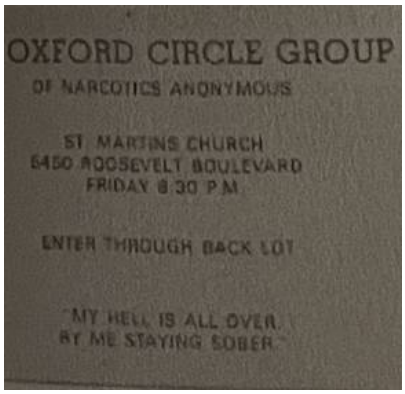


In March, Scranton added its own meeting to the grid when Stan B. started a Friday night group at Immaculate Conception Church. But not all expansion was without conflict.

Around the same time, members of Intergroup visited a meeting in South Philadelphia where AA and NA literature were being used interchangeably. Members approached the group gently but firmly, hoping to steer them toward NA's traditions. After repeated visits and repeated drift, Intergroup made the hard decision to remove the South Philly group from the meeting list. It was a painful reminder that NA's identity, still young, needed careful tending.

By summer, the pace quickened. On June 3, the West Chester Group began a Wednesday night meeting at the Open Door Crisis Center. John F. remembered attending regularly with Ray. Only days later, the Norristown Group expanded again, this time launching a Sunday night meeting at the YMCA on East Airy Street. June 15 marked another northern addition as Vince M. and "Scoop" founded a Sunday afternoon meeting in the Wyoming Borough Building.

On July 2, the Boulevard Group relocated its Friday night meeting to Saint Martin's Church at Roosevelt Boulevard and Oxford Avenue. It became the Oxford Circle Group. Tom C. represented them at Intergroup, though he also continued to represent his old group. When challenged, he answered simply: "You tell us we can't, but we're doing it anyway." It was a practical resistance rooted in scarcity and love.



More meetings sprang up in the days that followed. On July 3, Ray D. and Kathy D. began a Saturday evening gathering in Danville at the Grove Presbyterian Church. On July 4, Bob P. and his wife opened a Sunday night meeting at First Presbyterian in Bloomsburg.

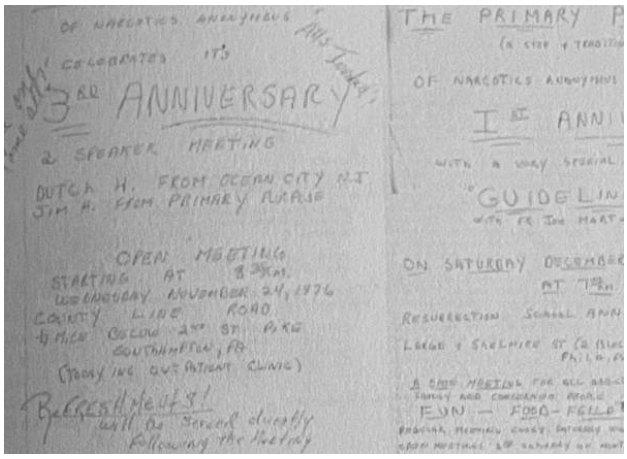
That same weekend, a quiet classified ad appeared in the News Journal in Wilmington, Delaware: “We can help.” It announced the birth of TRIAD—the Trinity Alcohol and Drug Program. The phone number listed then still rings today at their office behind the red door on Adams Street.

The Serenity Special Group launched on July 7 at Eugenia Hospital in Lafayette Hill. By the end of August, Newcastle, Delaware, added a Tuesday night meeting at Americus House.

On September 2, Mifflinburg entered the map with a new Thursday night meeting at the United Church of Christ—later confirmed in a Daily Item article published that November.

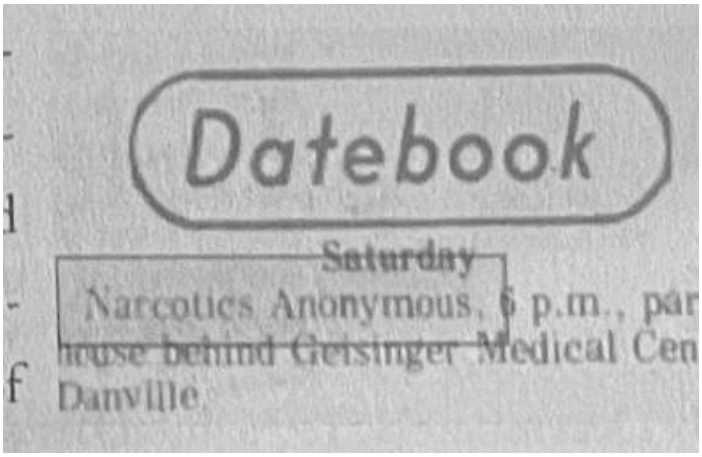
October saw creative new efforts. Some addicts at Carrier Clinic in Belle Mead, New Jersey, started holding NA meetings in the Varnes TV Lounge. Though run by a counselor and somewhat blended with therapy, they opened each meeting with the White Book, holding fast to at least one NA tradition.

In Williamsport, the 801 Clubhouse began hosting Tuesday and Friday meetings. It was an ambitious attempt at starting a full clubhouse for the NA fellowship. Though the effort ultimately folded, it left a legacy. Over 30 members who attended that year remained clean. One of them, Denny S., got his start when Guido A. insisted he take on coffee service—not just to show up, but to haul the pot home and back. The lesson: responsibility is the first step toward belonging.

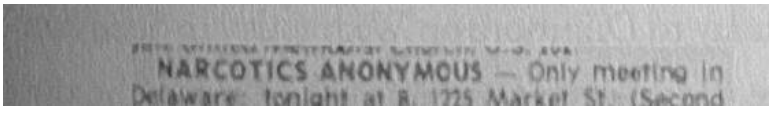


The Southampton Group marked its third anniversary on November 24 with speakers Dutch H. from Ocean City and Jim H. from the Primary Purpose Group. Then, on December 18, that same Primary Purpose Group celebrated its first anniversary with fellowship, food, and a special showing of Guidelines with Father Martin. That same day, an elusive 2:00 P.M. group met at 301 Cherry Street in Pottstown, however, little else is known about it.

The year closed with another announcement in the Daily Item, highlighting a Saturday night NA meeting in a house behind the Geisinger Center in Danville. That gathering, like so many others, stood as proof of what was now possible.



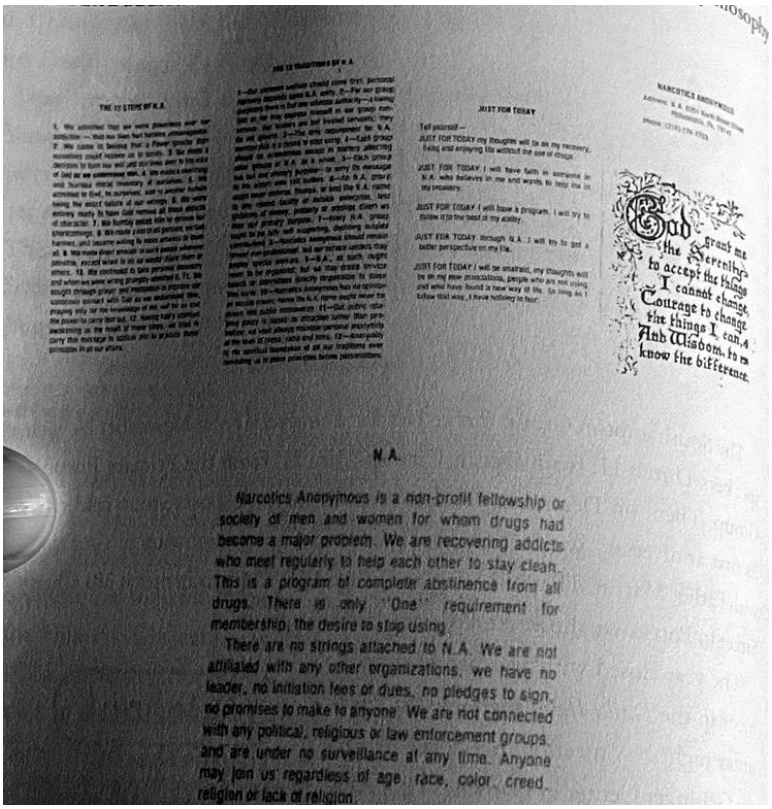
In late December, an NA meeting was announced in the Wilmington, Delaware News Journal, as the only NA meeting in Delaware.



By late 1976, a meeting list circulated that included not only the standard locations and times, but also key NA texts: “The 12 Steps of NA,” “The 12 Traditions of NA,” “Just for Today,” the “Serenity Prayer,” and what would become known as “What is the NA Program.” Notably, these early materials used

the word “recovering” rather than “recovered,”

reflecting an evolving philosophy around addiction and identity.



THE 12 STEPS OF N.A.

JUST FOR TODAY

God grant me the Serenity to accept the things I cannot change, Courage to change the things I can, And Wisdom, to me know the difference.

N.A.

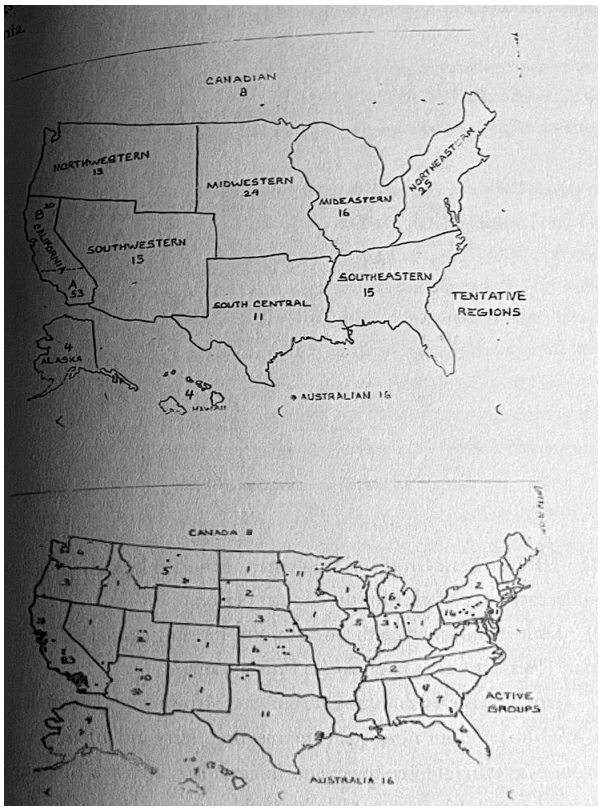
Narcotics Anonymous is a non-profit fellowship or society of men and women for whom drugs had become a major problem. We are recovering addicts who meet regularly to help each other to stay clean. This is a program of complete abstinence from all drugs. There is only One requirement for membership, the desire to stop using.

There are no strings attached to N.A. We are not affiliated with any other organizations, we have no leader, no initiation fees or dues, no pledges to sign, no promises to make to anyone. We are not connected with any political, religious or law enforcement groups, and are under no surveillance at any time. Anyone may join us regardless of age, race, color, creed, religion or lack of religion.

By December 31, 1976, members could find a Narcotics Anonymous meeting every day of the week. But to do so might mean driving hours—perhaps from Harrisburg on Monday to Dunmore on Wednesday to Scranton on Friday. Still, they made the drive. Because one meeting could mean the difference between relapse and recovery, between silence and solidarity. The program wasn’t yet big. But it was bold. And growing. And quietly, steadily, changing lives.

The First World Service Conference (WSC) was held in Ventura, California on November 12 to 14, 1976. Included in the minutes were two maps of the US and Canada. One map showed the active regions and the other map showed the active groups. The Northeastern Region had 25 active groups, Pennsylvania-16, New Jersey-1, New York-2, Maryland-2, Massachusetts-1, Connecticut-3. The 16 NA

meetings in Pennsylvania were the second most meetings in the world besides California.

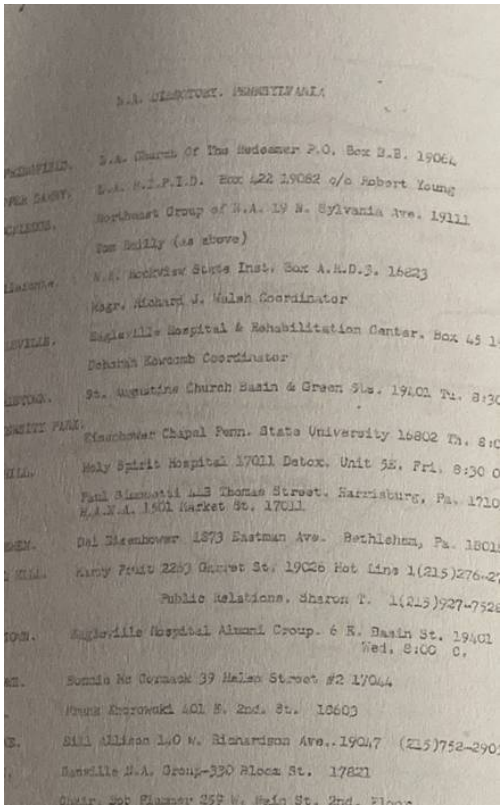


In 1976 the first World Directory of NA meetings was prepared. Meetings listed in the directory showed Norristown, Upper Darby, and Springfield all continued. The State College meeting may have moved to University Park, also continued.

The directory listed a few of the meetings that were occurring outside of the Philadelphia area, Rockview Penitentiary in Bellefonte, Holy Spirit Hospital in Camp Hill, Lewistown, Berwick, and Danville. It’s not certain why

so many of the existing NA groups in northcentral Pennsylvania were excluded from this directory.

1) The Northeast Group of NA existed at another location so the address in this directory was probably for the contact person.



N.A. DIRECTORY. PENNSYLVANIA

N.A. Church Of The Redeemer P.O. Box N.E. 19064

N.A. H.I.P.I.D. Box 422 19082 c/o Robert Young

Northeast Group of N.A. 19 N. Sylvania Ave. 19111

Tom Reilly (as above)

N.A. Activities State Inst. Box A.H.D.3. 16823

Mngr. Richard J. Walsh Coordinator

Eagleville Hospital & Rehabilitation Center. Box 45 1

Deborah Kowcomb Coordinator

St. Augustine Church Basin & Green Sts. 19401 Tu. 8:3

Eisenhower Chapel Penn. State University 16802 Th. 8:

Holy Spirit Hospital 17011 Detox. Unit 5E. Fri. 8:30

Paul Simonetti 443 Thomas Street. Harrisburg, Pa. 1710

N.A.N.A. 1601 Market St. 17011

Del Eisenhower 1873 Eastman Ave. Bethlehem, Pa. 1801

Kathy Pruitt 2283 Garnet St. 19026 Hot Line 1(215)276-2

Public Relations. Sharon T. 1(215)927-752

Eagleville Hospital Alumni Group. 6 E. Basin St. 19401
Wed. 8:00 P.

Bonnie Mc Cormack 39 Helen Street #2 17044

Frank Krzywicki 401 E. 2nd. St. 18603

Bill Allison 140 N. Richardson Ave.. 19047 (215)752-290

Danville N.A. Group-330 Block St. 17821

Chair. Bob Plummer 252 W. Main St. 2nd. Floor

2)Little is known when the institutional meeting started at Rockview Penitentiary (Pleasant Gap) in Bellefonte, Pennsylvania.

3) Jerry T. registered a meeting at Penn State University's Eisenhower Chapel with WSO in 1972 but never held the meeting. Jerry did attempt an Addicts Anonymous meeting at Eisenhower Hall but it didn't catch on. The State College meeting did start in 1977-1978. Most likely this entry was just a contact address.

1977 - A Tapestry of Growth

As 1977 dawned, new seeds were being planted. On February 1st, a closed Tuesday meeting began at a halfway house located at 818 N. 20th Street in Harrisburg, established by the HANA 818 Group. Only days later, another meeting

started on February 7th at the Holy Spirit Hospital's Detox Unit 5E in Camp Hill. Alice C., who was involved at the time, recalled how NA members-both men and women-supported these early hospital meetings, often held in hospital cafeterias.

Momentum gathered. On March Ist, a Tuesday night meeting opened at the Franklin Commerce Building on South Franklin Street in Wilkes-Barre. A week later, on March 7th, Williamsport welcomed a new Monday night meeting at Annunciation Church.

On the 1977 NA Meeting List, The Wilmington NA Group's Tuesday night meeting was finally listed at the 1212 Corporation AA Clubhouse. John F., one of its earliest participants, remembered how it came about: "Two nice gentlemen wanted to find a place for the kids to talk about dope... and get the kids who identified themselves as addicts out of the hair of AA members who didn't want them around."

They borrowed a room at the local clubhouse where AA meetings were held, grabbed a copy of the White Book, and started what they called an NA meeting. "If I went to it today," John admitted, "I would not recognize it as an NA meeting. It didn't follow the traditions and eventually folded. But we managed, and we did quite well. We got a handle on the steps."

The very next day, Carlisle added a Wednesday night group at the Church of the Brethren. July 7th brought Norristown's Friday at Eight Group into existence at Norristown State Hospital's Building #1.

August 1st was a pivotal day. In Wilmington, when John F., Ray P., Maggie P., and Ray formed the Delaware Step Group meeting Tuesday nights at TRIAD on North Adams Street. John F. and John D. recalled that the group placed intense focus on the Twelve Steps, even revising AA's 12 & 12 by hand-scratching out "alcohol" and replacing it with "drugs." With limited literature from World Services, members photocopied what they could, often favoring IP #1 for its comprehensive readings.

On August 16th, the Insight Group began meeting Tuesday nights at the Old Airport Building in Chambersburg. In September, Penn State's Eisenhower Chapel was the home for a Thursday night meeting that later relocated to St.

Andrew's Episcopal Church in State College.

On September 28th, Stroudsburg saw the birth of a Wednesday night group at the Open Forum on Main Street. Just over two months later, The Pocono Record published an article recognizing this as the only NA meeting in Monroe, Carbon, and Pike Counties.

Citing Richard Gale, director of the Tri-County Detox Center, the article noted that the group drew between four and eight attendees, aged 19 to 28.

Recovering addicts often served as guest speakers, providing structure and inspiration.

The year closed with signs of deeper commitment. In December 1977, two addicts in Wilkes-Barre started a literature study group at a Boy Scout building in Exeter—marking a shift toward deeper exploration of NA's core principles.

1978 - Building a Fellowship from the Ground Up

The new year brought new frontiers. On February 4th, NA found a foothold Indian Hill Lodge in Beach Lake, where ex-patients formed a Saturday night group. Though the meeting was closed, it was fully independent from the facility, bound instead by the principles of NA fellowship.

On March 4th, an open meeting was held at Clearbrook Lodge in Shickshinny. Harvey D. remembered walking in and being struck by the unfamiliar slogans: "Think, Think, Think" and "First Things First." Yet, despite initial confusion, he connected with the speakers and felt an absence of judgment—a quiet but profound resonance. March Gth brought the formation of the Acceptance Group, which held Monday meetings at St. Peter's Evangelical Lutheran Church in Wilkes-Barre. On May 10th, the Double Bubble Group was launched at the House of Prayer Church in Aliquippa. At its inception, this was the only NA meeting within 275 miles—there were no meetings yet in Ohio or West Virginia. Just four years later, that lone group would blossom into over 100 meetings across western Pennsylvania, proving that "miracles do happen "

Two Monday night meetings launched on June Sth. One was held in West Chester at the First Presbyterian Church. The other opened in Newark, New Jersey, at Mount Carmel Guild Narcotic & Rehab Center. AJ H. remembered that Newark meeting well. Started by an AA member sympathetic to addicts, it struggled with mixed messages. Some members still drank or used marijuana, and AJ found himself repeatedly advocating for full abstinence, as outlined in the NA White Book. Eventually, the meeting faded. "I had chased everyone away," he reflected, underscoring the painful growing pains of defining NA's identity.

The next day, June Gth, two Tuesday night groups were formed. One-One Day at a Time-met off Route 11 in Danville. The other, started by a doctor and the Grateful Addicts Group, convened at the VA Medical Center in East Orange, New Jersey. That doctor, though a member of another fellowship, was a genuine addict and became instrumental in holding the group together.

In Philadelphia's historic Center City, around July brought the launch of a new Wednesday night group at 4th and Pine Streets. Jet and Herb had formed it after attending meetings in Northeast Philly and realizing a new presence was needed closer to downtown. That meeting, in a modest room off the main hall of the Presbyterian church, would become the first NA home group for George W. Step meetings were held using the AA step book. The group had its own vibe—open and a little offbeat. One evening, a crew of long-haired men in army jackets arrived, buzzing about conventions and literature. It felt, one member later said, like a secret underground society. John Sw. recalled, "it was a kind of a place where everybody gravitated to from all over. Like people would come from Norristown, Northeast Philly, because it was a big happening, because after we'd had a meeting, we would all go to South Street."

July 5th saw the Wilmington Group relocate and open a new Wednesday meeting at North Market Street.

On the same evening, Doylestown's County Line Group launched its own meeting at the Aldie Counseling Center.

Also on August 1st, the Noon Step Group began at the YMCA on Airy Street in Norristown. Mr. X remembered it as a gathering place for Eagleville alumni. Sunday meetings, often held at noon or 2:00 P.M., brought together a dedicated group that studied steps together, guided by Bill B. and others. Eventually, the

group was forced to leave the YMCA, amid rumors of drug activity and change to the facility's programming.

August brought more new beginnings with a Thursday meeting launched August 3rd at Christ Church in West Chester. On August 7th, the Women and Addiction Group began meeting Monday nights at the Mid-Montgomery Clinic in Norristown. And on August 1st—again that same pivotal day-George R and Tracy founded the Bristol Group at the Bristol-Bensalem Drop-in Center. The group initially met above Richmond Furniture and later moved around the corner. George remembered copying literature at the library, clinging to the few documents that existed. "IP #1 had all the readings," he said. "That's the one I would copy."

On September 6th, Norristown's Independence House at Building #1 began hosting a Wednesday night meeting.

By the end of 1978, a new texture had formed in the NA landscape of Pennsylvania and surrounding states. In each town and city, groups were forming-some small and fragile, others quickly multiplying. They gathered in churches, hospitals, VA centers, halfway houses, and drop-in clinics. They revised literature, shared what little they had, and learned through trial and error what it meant to build a fellowship.

1979 - Pennsylvania and New Jersey

As 1979 began, Narcotics Anonymous in Pennsylvania was quietly gaining traction. On January 2, a Tuesday night meeting opened at St. Joseph Hospital in Lancaster. A few weeks later, the York Daily Record noted that NA had secured a Wednesday evening time slot at 130 South Beaver Street in York. Although these may have seemed like isolated flickers, they were early signals of an awakening--one community at a time.

In late March, the Day-by-Day Group launched its Tuesday 8:30 P.M. meeting in the basement of Saint John's United Church of Christ at 6th and Walnut in Allentown. They added a Wednesday meeting by May 27, and a Saturday meeting in November 1981 signaling growing

demand. Meanwhile, June 1 brought dual launches: one in Hazleton, in the offices of Alcohol and Drug Services of Lower Luzerne County, and another in Mansfield, where Don L. started a Friday night meeting at Saint James Episcopal Church Hall on Route 6.

June 2, 1979, saw Wayne P. open a Saturday morning meeting in Darby at the Young People's AA Clubhouse. "That meeting I started in Darby—like, we used the Big Book," Wayne remembered. The club attracted a cross-addicted younger crowd, and NA's identity in such spaces was still in flux.

By July 3, George R. relocated a Bristol-area Tuesday night meeting from the Bensalem Drop-in Center to a youth development facility on Mill Street. Phil S. recounted how he and Kenny followed their sponsor, Dan-a former Jesuit priest-to that meeting. "It was on Tuesday nights in Bristol, on Mill Street," he said. "Most of the young people at that meeting were in Today, Inc.'s outpatient program."

Listings continued to appear in local papers throughout the summer. In late July, The Daily Item printed notice of an open NA meeting at Grove Presbyterian Church in Danville. October 6 saw the debut of the Always Addicts Group in Princeton, New Jersey, sparked by two Carrier Clinic alumni, Julian L. and Dave M. Initially registered as a special-interest AA meeting, their name provoked pushback from the local AA service structure. They appealed to the NA WSO, where—after initial hesitation over the "AA" initials-Jimmy K. gave a definitive answer: "Call it whatever you want."

By the holidays, the HANA group in Harrisburg held a Christmas party at the United Methodist Church on Derry Street, drawing together members from what was still a fragile but forming fellowship. Yet the momentum was now unstoppable.

1980 - Foundations and Firestarters

As the 1970s ended, Narcotics Anonymous in the northeastern United States was still fragile-more dream than infrastructure, more instinct than institution. Yet 1980 became the year where isolated sparks became steady flames.

Across Pennsylvania, New Jersey, and parts of the Mid-Atlantic, small groups recovering addicts began holding meetings with little more than hope, borrowed literature, and each other. Around the same time, the Greater Philadelphia Area issued a meeting lis using a Norristown P.0. box and hotline number: (215) 276-2703.

On January 5, 1980, Rich M. and Jane G. founded the Friendship Group at 315 Mill Street. After an incident with an unlocked door and scattered client files, they moved to Grace Episcopal Church in Hulmeville. Al R. described it this way: "We didn't know anything about steps or traditions. What we did know was fellowship. We hung together and did everything."

The following day, January 6, 1980, three more meetings were launched: the Hulmeville Steppers at Grace Episcopal, a Friday night Big Book Study Group at Allentown's Drug & Alcohol Building, and the County Line Group at the Aldie Foundation in Doylestown. Paul Z., newly out of treatment at Today Inc., attended that first Aldie meeting, chaired by a man named Dutch. A parallel Sunday night meeting started that same day at Our Lady of Mt. Carmel in

Doylestown. By mid-January, a Monday night meeting had opened at the United Trinity Methodist Church in Pennsville, New Jersey.


New anti-drug group sponsored by church

Gloria Dei Lutheran Church, 570 Welsh road, Huntingdon Valley, is sponsoring a new chapter of Narcotics Anonymous on Tuesday evenings at 8 P.M. at the Youth Center.

The mutual support group was established in response to parents and others who wanted to know how to help the children cope with drug-related problems. For information,

In March 1980, The Philadelphia Bulletin reported the launch of a new Tuesday night NA meeting at Gloria Dei Lutheran Church in Huntingdon Valley—part of a broader community effort to address youth drug issues.

Spring 1980 saw daily noon meetings begin in Williamsport, initially in a jewelry store's second-floor space, then at the Bethune-Douglass Center. On March 2, a Sunday noon H&I meeting opened at Fox Chase's Bridge Therapeutic Center. The next day, March 3, Paul Z. and Stash began a short-lived Wednesday night group at Our Lady of Mount Carmel. "We used the Little White Book." Paul recalled. "But back then, people still smoked at meetings. Someone burned the new carpet, and we got kicked out." New meetings began appearing rapidly. On June 3, 1980, a Tuesday 7:30 P.M. meeting started at Trinity Episcopal Church in Williamsport. Two days later, a meeting opened at the 310 Club in Butler.

In July 1980, expansion accelerated. The We Had to Hear It Group launched in Neptune, New Jersey. Midnight Madness, at Pebble Hill Church in Doylestown became the first midnight meeting on the East Coast, offering a Friday night Option for young and restless addicts. In Harrisburg, HANA added a Sunday morning meeting at Gaudenzia House—a program not yet fully drug-free. There was a 90-day clean time stipulation to attend. Alice C., a graduate of Gaudenzia, remembered, "Some staff still drank at our graduation. We just got up and left."

Jim F. recalled that the Gaudenzia House would actually teach people how to drink.

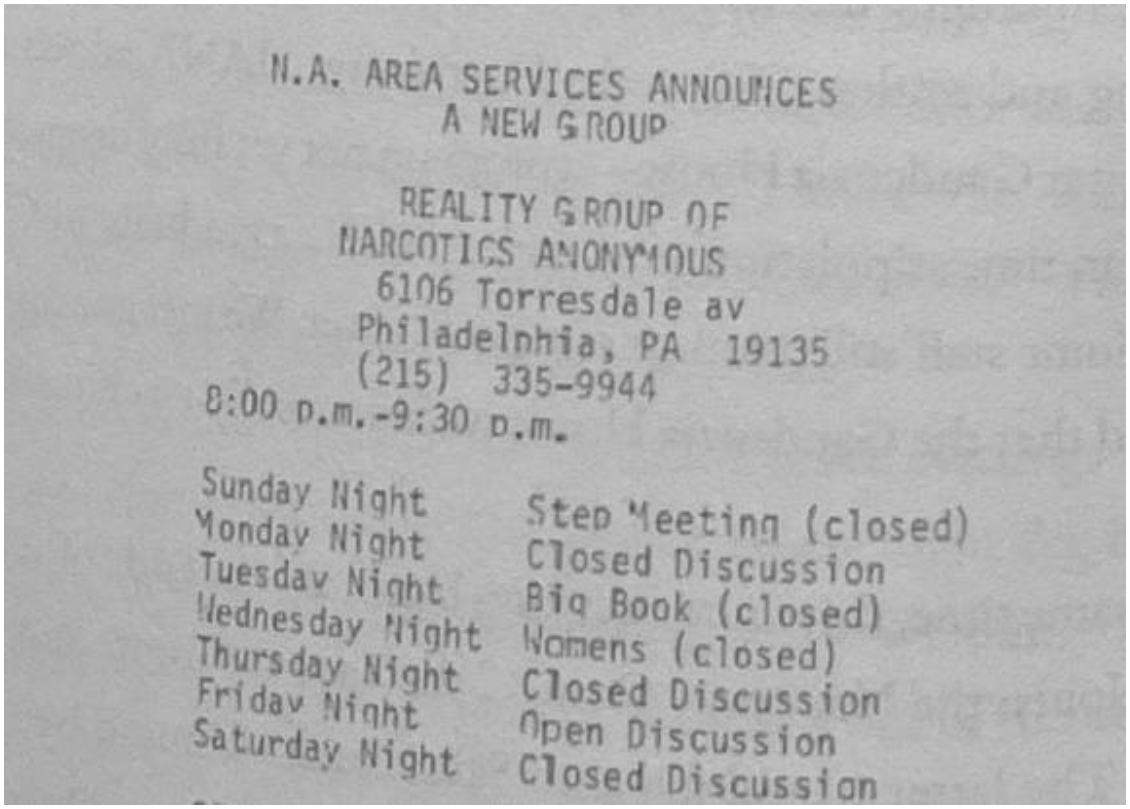
Around the same time, three new meetings began at Our Lady of Assumption Hall in Philadelphia: the NA Hope Group," the Tacony Group, and the Young Men's Group. The latter would move to Saint Luke's Church by early 1981.

Meanwhile, NA's reach spread to Washington, D.C., Baltimore, Maryland, and

towns in Virginia, with members from Philly offering guidance through workshops at the VA hospital. "We invited them to join the Mid-Atlantic Region," John F. recounted.

August brought more growth. On August 7, the Denial & Acceptance Group opened in Allentown. On August 23, Joe F. helped launch the Freedom Group in Kensington.

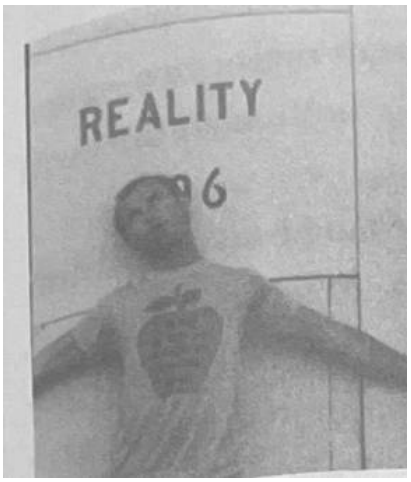
Some of the earliest gatherings were chaotic and short-lived, meeting in churches, clinics, and even above jewelry stores. But others—like the Reality Group in Philadelphia—would go on to shape the entire character of NA culture on the East Coast. As one member remembered, "... then it became an official NA meeting, after the AA guys bailed out, they didn't want anything to do with it. So, none of the AA guys stayed. They went back to AA." From campus basements to midnight meetings, from youth-driven social circles to makeshift clubhouses, the heart of Narcotics Anonymous began to beat stronger, louder, and with more Conviction, September 1 marked a landmark shift. Ray N., a member of the Stepping Stones AA group in Northeast Philadelphia, founded the Reality Group clubhouse at 6106 Torresdale Avenue. Originally an AA group with a heavy young-addict presence, it quickly became an unofficial NA hub. "We actually took it over and created an NA group," said Joe F. "It was like the first NA clubhouse in Philly." With its storefront layout, rotating locations, and nightly 8:00 P.M. meetings, the Reality Group attracted people from across the East Coast.



N.A. AREA SERVICES ANNOUNCES
A NEW GROUP

REALITY GROUP OF
NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS
6106 Torresdale av
Philadelphia, PA 19135
(215) 335-9944
8:00 p.m.-9:30 p.m.

Sunday Night	Step Meeting (closed)
Monday Night	Closed Discussion
Tuesday Night	Big Book (closed)
Wednesday Night	Womens (closed)
Thursday Night	Closed Discussion
Friday Night	Open Discussion
Saturday Night	Closed Discussion



Henry D. painted a vivid portrait of the early Reality meeting culture: "We had an old metal desk... praying hands with a gavel. rows of chairs we grabbed from trash picking.. pass around a book that had everybody's name...

people would sign Mickey Mouse and Minnie Mouse." In mid-1982, the Reality Group was evicted from its long-time home on Torresdale so they briefly tried meeting at a former pharmacy. Eventually, by December 1982 (approximate), the group relocated to the Lower Kensington Environmental Center at 2205 Bridge Street, reflecting the ongoing search for safe, sustainable spaces for addicts to meet and heal. Upstairs there was an inpatient rehab where and H&I meeting was held and downstairs there was an outpatient rehab and they allowed us to have NA meetings. More meetings appeared that month: in Atlantic City, Trenton, and Cherry Hill; at the Solly Avenue Recreation Center and Welsh Road Outpatient Center in Philadelphia; and in Bloomsburg, Mechanicsburg, and Williamsport. On September 15, the YMCA in Williamsport added a Monday night meeting.

Finally, on December 5, 1980, the W.A.I.T. Group—short for Where Am I Today-launched at 37th & Chestnut in Philadelphia, bridging the gap between university students and local recovery seekers. "It actually started as a white meeting," Craig L. reflected, "but it was on the periphery of the Black community. So it became a bridge."

In just two years, the scattered, fragile NA presence in Pennsylvania and surrounding areas had become a living network. From hospital basements and treatment centers to storefront clubhouses and midnight vigils, the language of recovery had found its voice—and its people were just getting started.

1981 - Multiplying the Message

The year 1981 marked a turning point in the spread and identity of Narcotics Anonymous across Pennsylvania, New Jersey, and Delaware. What had once been a scattering of fledgling groups evolved into a vigorous web of meetings

spanning prisons, hospitals, community centers, churches, and campuses. This was a year defined by rapid expansion and courageous experimentation—a time when addicts were not just finding recovery but building the structure that would support it.

With little literature, few resources, and only word-of-mouth to connect them members planted meetings wherever there was a need-sometimes welcomed sometimes evicted, but always resilient. These early efforts were not always polished or permanent, but they reflected a fierce commitment to make NA accessible to anyone, anywhere.

On January 2, the Sobriety & Beyond Group inaugurated a 7:30 P.M. Friday meeting at the Flynn House in Jersey City, New Jersey. Just a day later, two institutional meetings took root in Doylestown: a Saturday 7:00 P.M. gathering at the Bucks County Women's Prison and a simultaneous Men's Stag meeting at Bucks County Rehab.

By January 5, NA reached Saint Joseph's Hospital in Lancaster, where a Monday night meeting opened its doors.

These early meetings reflected both a strategic and compassionate effort to reach the institutionalized addict, meeting them where they were. Also, in January the Young Men's Group held a Sunday meeting at a storefront at Cumberland and Kensington for about six months.

February brought an extraordinary wave of new groups and formats. On the 5th alone, five new meetings were launched, including the Glad to Be Alive Group at Salem United Church of Christ in Doylestown and the Buxmont Step Group in Warminster. The same date also saw the birth of the Last Chance Group on the 4th Floor of Saint Mary's Hospital in Philadelphia, and a Step meeting at the Horsham Clinic. In Harrisburg, the "HANA 818" meeting relocated to the ASI building on February 10, indicating a need for more stable institutional partnership. Just two days later, an innovative daytime meeting started above the methadone clinic at ACT in Philadelphia, driven by Harvey D. and a counselor named Patty. Harvey D. recalled, "Patty was a therapist at ACT. Ray N. said to

me at the Reality Group that they need a meeting there. I said, 'How am I going to start a meeting at Broad and Erie at night?' Ray said, 'Talk to Patty and have a daytime meeting.' And she said absolutely." March saw the resurrection and relocation of groups such as the Primary Purpose Group, which moved to Maternity BVM Church. Eagleville Hospital became a Sunday night home for the New Way Group after the YMCA evicted them. Dwayne S. recalled the transition: "They kicked us out... Ed F. made the suggestion that we bring them up to Eagleville in the dining room." A Saturday, 11:00 am meeting started at Aldersgate in Willow Grove.

Meanwhile, Al R. pioneered a student-focused NA presence at Bucks County Community College, though his midday meetings struggled with attendance. He remembered, "It didn't last long … 90% of the time it was me sitting there with literature and then eventually no one showed up."

Women through Sobriety, the Living Room Group in Reading, and new meetings in Vineland, New Jersey, and New Cumberland, Pennsylvania, all began during this fertile period.

April brought the dawn of the Haven of Serenity Group in Sellersville and the Higher Power Group in Allentown. Jill F. shared her experience in treatment at the Strecker Institute, emphasizing how NA integration into clinical settings shaped her early recovery: "While I was still in Strecker, one of the conditions of being discharged was that you had to have resources... Either H&I or whoever brought Narcotics Anonymous meetings into the treatment facility."

On April 5, 1981, "Clean Sheet" Issue #2 announced a new Narcotics Anonymous group, the Reality Group at 6106 Torresdale Avenue in Philadelphia. By April 29th this group offered a full week of closed meetings, including step studies, women's nights, and open discussions on Fridays. It was a robust schedule that reflected the maturing infrastructure in the area.

The momentum of the spring didn't slow. The Abington Group started May 1, followed by a lively NA dance at the Bethune-Douglas Community Center in Williamsport on May 2. By May 5, the York Group had launched Tuesday

and Thursday meetings at First Presbyterian Church, expanding by year's end to Monday and Saturday nights. June saw new meetings like the Christmas Group in Wilmington and the Easy Does It Group in West Chester. Pat P., one of its founders, detailed the group's careful planning and early trials: "We wanted to belong to the area right away ... Within one or two months, the other four guys relapsed. I was the only one that lasted. So, I had to do everything for a while... secretary, treasurer, GSR. Monsignor Kelly would only deal with me." In Media, the Easy Does It Group, co-founded by Bill O. and Clay, was influenced by Frank from Delaware who brought announcements from across the NA fellowship. Meetings at Carrier Clinic in New Jersey provided a rare source of NA literature in the area. July saw the flowering of the Light Group located at 1443 East Cumberland and Kensington Avenue in Philadelphia. One member recalls a meeting on Kens-ington Avenue, a storefront, with no chairs. They went around and stole car seats from abandoned cars. The group relocated to 1502 Frankford, around May, New Horizons at PATH was born from inspiration at the East Coast Convention in Trenton. Mike P. and Mike L. sought to ensure adherence to NA's traditions, asking a PATH counselor, "We want to start a meeting here?"

The Glad to Be Alive Group moved to a new location in Bristol. Meanwhile, Lansdale's Monday meeting expanded to Thursdays, and a speaker meeting began at PADRAD in Pottstown.

August brought the Surrender Group to Saint Thomas Church and the Berks Youth Counseling Center meeting. In Philadelphia, the Community College started a Tuesday noon meeting. The "Back to Basics" Beginners Group launched in Hulmeville.

In September and October, groups like Great to Be Alive, Ellisburg Freedom, and God as I Understand Him took root, with spiritual emphasis reflected in their names and locations—churches, institutes, and correctional facilities alike.

In September 1981, three determined NA members brought the message of recovery to the Pocono Mountains, founding the Mount Pocono Group. They Opened a new meeting at Saint Mary's Roman Catholic Church on Fairview

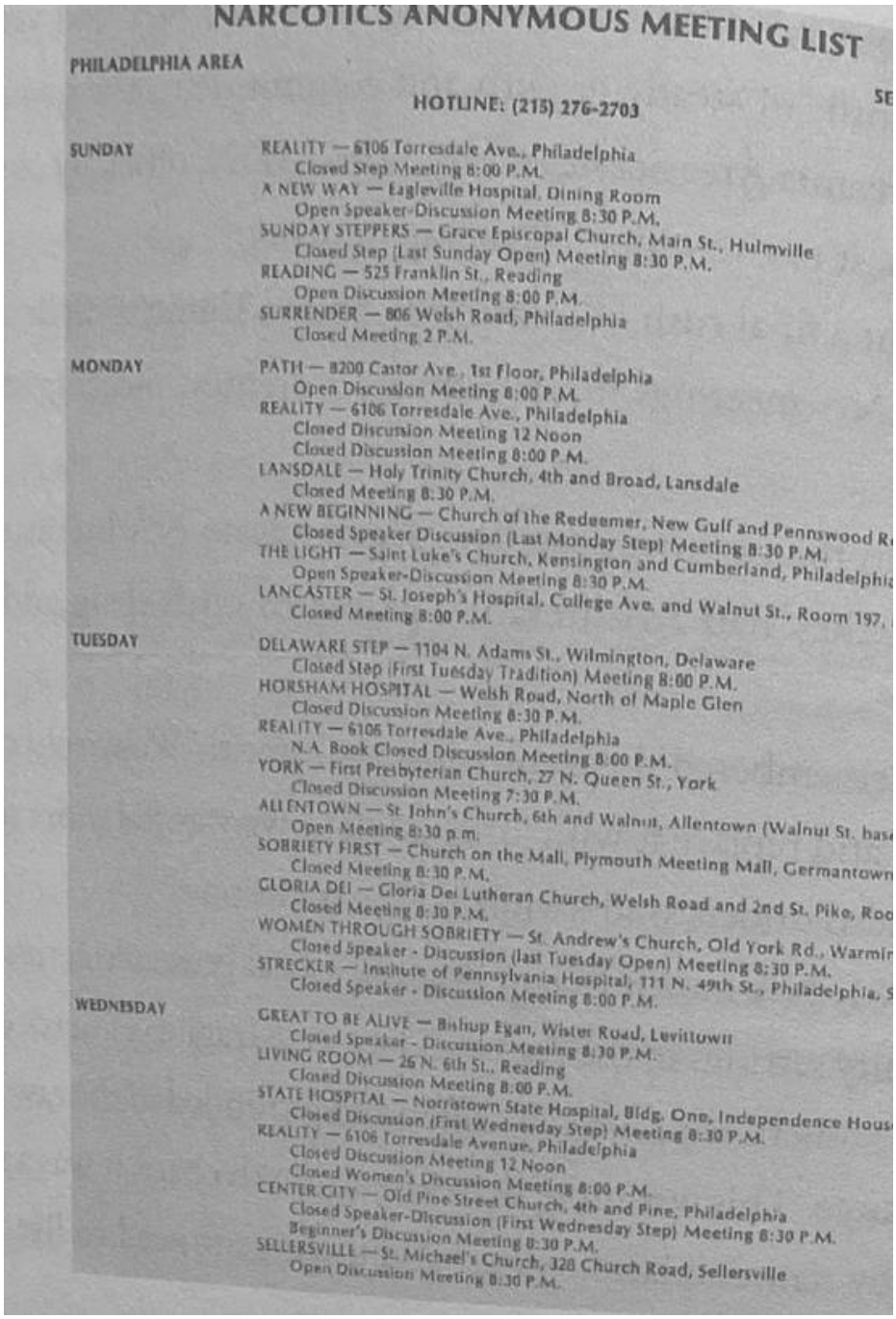
Avenue-a modest but powerful start in a region where NA had yet to take root. After three months of steady growth and commitment, the group joined the Northern Pennsylvania Area Service Committee (ASC), officially connecting their mountain outpost to the wider fellowship network.

November brought a final rush of group formations: Came to Believe Group in Philadelphia, HANA meetings in Harrisburg, a Trenton meeting started by Scott G.

Jim D. reflected on the resource scarcity: "There was no NA literature at the Trenton meeting.. they had AA literature geared towards drug addicts and Hazelden literature,"

Bill O. similarly remembered the improvisational spirit: "We would cross out the word 'alcoholic' and replace it with 'drug addict.' We wanted more literature to be available, but also understood it violated the traditions."

By the end of 1981, NA meetings had become a vital presence across institutional and community settings in the region. They were fragile yet fierce outposts of recovery—led by addicts, supported by allies, and grounded in the raw need for connection and change. This was more than just a growth chart; it was a spiritual migration, carried by names, places, voices, and the urgent need to live another day, clean.



NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS MEETING LIST

PHILADELPHIA AREA

HOTLINE: (215) 276-2703

SUNDAY

REALITY — 6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Closed Step Meeting 8:00 P.M.
A NEW WAY — Eagleville Hospital, Dining Room
Open Speaker-Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
SUNDAY STEPPERS — Grace Episcopal Church, Main St., Hulmville
Closed Step (Last Sunday Open) Meeting 8:30 P.M.
READING — 525 Franklin St., Reading
Open Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
SURRENDER — 806 Welsh Road, Philadelphia
Closed Meeting 2 P.M.

MONDAY

PATH — 8200 Castor Ave., 1st Floor, Philadelphia
Open Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
REALITY — 6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 12 Noon
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
LANSDALE — Holy Trinity Church, 4th and Broad, Lansdale
Closed Meeting 8:30 P.M.
A NEW BEGINNING — Church of the Redeemer, New Gulf and Pennswood R
Closed Speaker Discussion (Last Monday Step) Meeting 8:30 P.M.
THE LIGHT — Saint Luke's Church, Kensington and Cumberland, Philadelphi
Open Speaker-Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
LANCASTER — St. Joseph's Hospital, College Ave. and Walnut St., Room 197,
Closed Meeting 8:00 P.M.

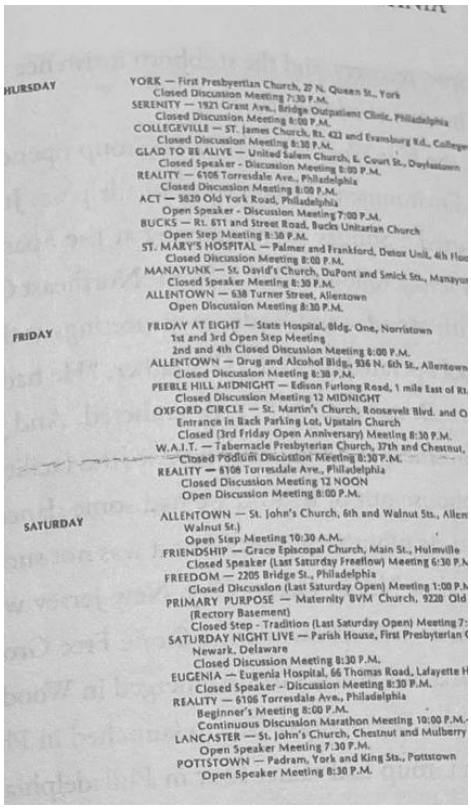
TUESDAY

DELAWARE STEP — 1104 N. Adams St., Wilmington, Delaware
Closed Step (First Tuesday Tradition) Meeting 8:00 P.M.
HORSHAM HOSPITAL — Welsh Road, North of Maple Glen
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
REALITY — 6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
N.A. Book Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
YORK — First Presbyterian Church, 27 N. Queen St., York
Closed Discussion Meeting 7:30 P.M.
ALLENTOWN — St. John's Church, 6th and Walnut, Allentown (Walnut St. bas
Open Meeting 8:30 p.m.
SOBRIETY FIRST — Church on the Mall, Plymouth Meeting Mall, Germantown
Closed Meeting 8:30 P.M.
GLORIA DEI — Gloria Dei Lutheran Church, Welsh Road and 2nd St. Pike, Roo
Closed Meeting 8:30 P.M.
WOMEN THROUGH SOBRIETY — St. Andrew's Church, Old York Rd., Warmi
Closed Speaker - Discussion (last Tuesday Open) Meeting 8:30 P.M.
STRECKER — Institute of Pennsylvania Hospital, 111 N. 49th St., Philadelphia, S
Closed Speaker - Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.

WEDNESDAY

GREAT TO BE ALIVE — Bishop Egan, Wister Road, Levittown
Closed Speaker - Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
LIVING ROOM — 26 N. 6th St., Reading
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
STATE HOSPITAL — Norristown State Hospital, Bldg. One, Independence Hous
Closed Discussion (First Wednesday Step) Meeting 8:30 P.M.
REALITY — 6106 Torresdale Avenue, Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 12 Noon
Closed Women's Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
CENTER CITY — Old Pine Street Church, 4th and Pine, Philadelphia
Closed Speaker-Discussion (First Wednesday Step) Meeting 8:30 P.M.
Beginner's Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
SELLERSVILLE — St. Michael's Church, 328 Church Road, Sellersville
Open Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.

1982 - A Year of Emergence and Endurance



HURSDAY

YORK — First Presbyterian Church, 29 N. Queen St., York
Closed Discussion Meeting 7:30 P.M.
SERENITY — 1921 Grant Ave., Bridge Outpatient Clinic, Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
COLLEGEVILLE — ST. James Church, Rt. 422 and Evansburg Rd., College
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
GLAD TO BE ALIVE — United Salem Church, E. Court St., Doylestown
Closed Speaker - Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
REALITY — 6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
ACT — 3820 Old York Road, Philadelphia
Open Speaker - Discussion Meeting 7:00 P.M.
BUCKS — Rt. 611 and Street Road, Bucks Unitarian Church
Open Step Meeting 8:30 P.M.
ST. MARY'S HOSPITAL — Palmer and Frankford, Detox Unit, 4th Flo
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
MANAYUNK — St. David's Church, DuPont and Smick Sts., Manayu
Closed Speaker Meeting 8:30 P.M.
ALLENTOWN — 638 Turner Street, Allentown
Open Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.

FRIDAY

FRIDAY AT EIGHT — State Hospital, Bldg. One, Norristown
1st and 3rd Open Step Meeting
2nd and 4th Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
ALLENTOWN — Drug and Alcohol Bldg., 936 N. 6th St., Allentown
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
PEEBLE HILL MIDNIGHT — Edison Furlong Road, 1 mile East of Rt.
Closed Discussion Meeting 12 MIDNIGHT
OXFORD CIRCLE — St. Martin's Church, Roosevelt Blvd. and O
Entrance in Back Parking Lot, Upstairs Church
Closed (3rd Friday Open Anniversary) Meeting 8:30 P.M.
W.A.I.T. — Tabernacle Presbyterian Church, 37th and Chestnut,
Closed Podium Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
REALITY — 6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 12 NOON
Open Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.

SATURDAY

ALLENTOWN — St. John's Church, 6th and Walnut Sts., Allen
Walnut St.)
Open Step Meeting 10:30 A.M.
FRIENDSHIP — Grace Episcopal Church, Main St., Hulmville
Closed Speaker (Last Saturday Freeflow) Meeting 6:30 P.
FREEDOM — 2205 Bridge St., Philadelphia
Closed Discussion (Last Saturday Open) Meeting 1:00 P.
PRIMARY PURPOSE — Maternity BVM Church, 9220 Old
(Rectory Basement)
Closed Step - Tradition (Last Saturday Open) Meeting 7:
SATURDAY NIGHT LIVE — Parish House, First Presbyterian
Newark, Delaware
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
EUGENIA — Eugenia Hospital, 66 Thomas Road, Lafayette H
Closed Speaker - Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
REALITY — 6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Beginner's Meeting 8:00 P.M.
Continuous Discussion Marathon Meeting 10:00 P.M.
LANCASTER — St. John's Church, Chestnut and Mulberry
Open Speaker Meeting 7:30 P.M.
POTTSTOWN — Padram, York and King Sts., Pottstown
Open Speaker Meeting 8:30 P.M.

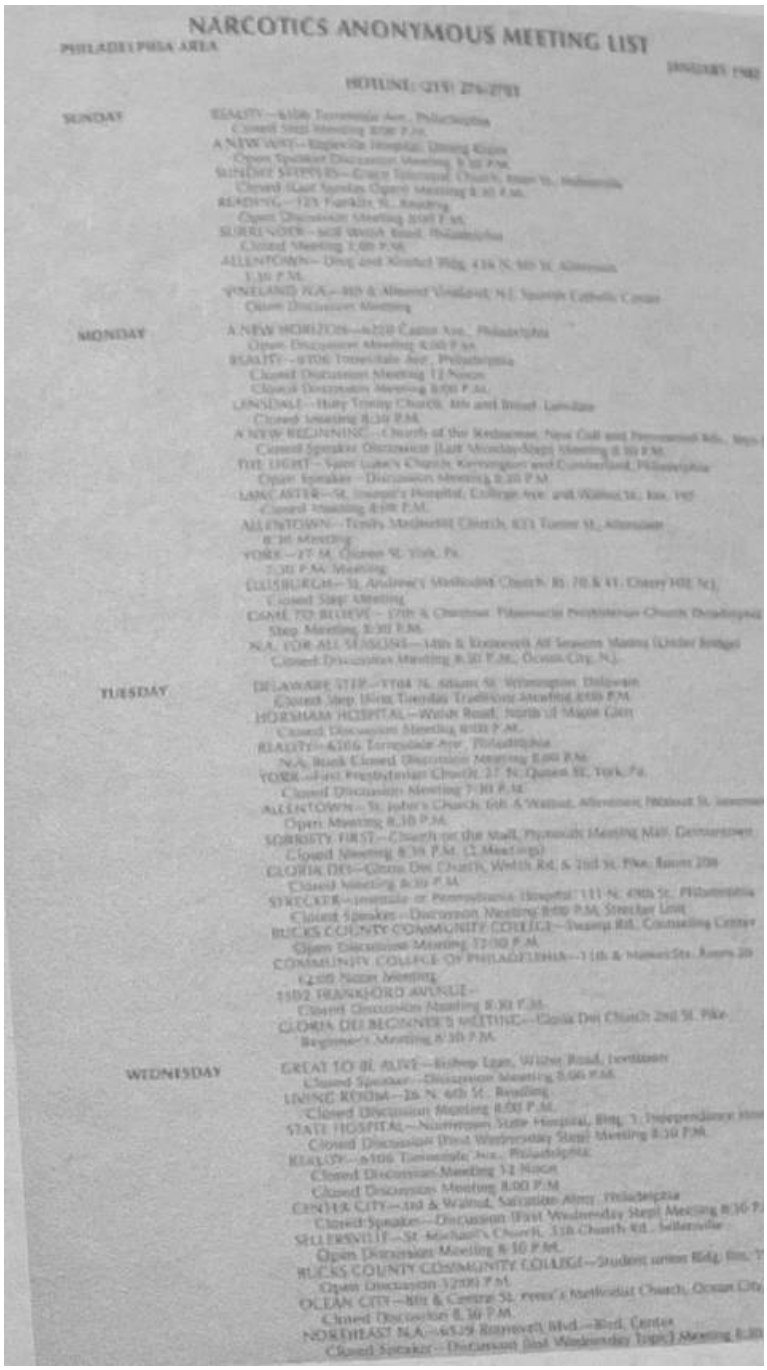
As Narcotics Anonymous entered 1982, its grassroots fellowship erupted into full bloom across the Mid-Atlantic region. Dozens of new groups emerged in basements, churches, hospitals, schools, and even private homes—each one anchored by recovering addicts who believed in the message and carried it forward with urgency. This was a year marked not just by growth, but by tenacity: early leadership struggles, relocations, and even resistance from established institutions tested the young fellowship's resilience. Yet by year's end, what had begun as scattered sparks had ignited a steady flame, lighting the way for the countless members still to come.

From city neighborhoods and suburban churches to hospitals, dental offices, schools, and wilderness retreats, NA meetings began to blossom across Pennsylvania, New Jersey, Delaware, and into Maryland. Behind each new address was a

story-of courage, relapse, recovery, and the stubborn insistence that no addict need ever die from the horrors of addiction.

On New Year's Day, the If It Works Don't Fix It Group opened its doors at the Lower Kensington Environmental Center in Philadelphia. Just days later, the Vineland Group started a Sunday night meeting at the Spanish Catholic Center in Vineland, New Jersey, followed closely by the Northeast Group, which launched on January 4 with Monday and Wednesday meetings at the Boulevard Center, in the dental school operated by Kathy G.'s father. "He had a big dental facility at Harbison and the Boulevard," Jill F. remembered. And John Sw. recalled, "they went out of business and then they gave it [the facility] to us. We were trying to make a clubhouse out of it. And we had some dances there and stuff like that. It lasted about six months or a year, but it was not successful."

January also saw the arrival of NA in Ocean City, New Jersey with the NA for All Seasons and Ocean City Groups, while the Stone Free Group opened in Newark, Delaware. The Grateful Heads Group emerged in Woodbury, New Jersey; the New Horizons (Great Beginnings) Group launched in Phillipsburg. By mid-month, the Life wish Group had taken root in Philadelphia. Meetings sprouted not only in cities but also inside hospitals and churches where addicts found a way to serve.



NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS MEETING LIST

PHILADELPHIA AREA

HOTLINE: (215) 276-2781

SUNDAY

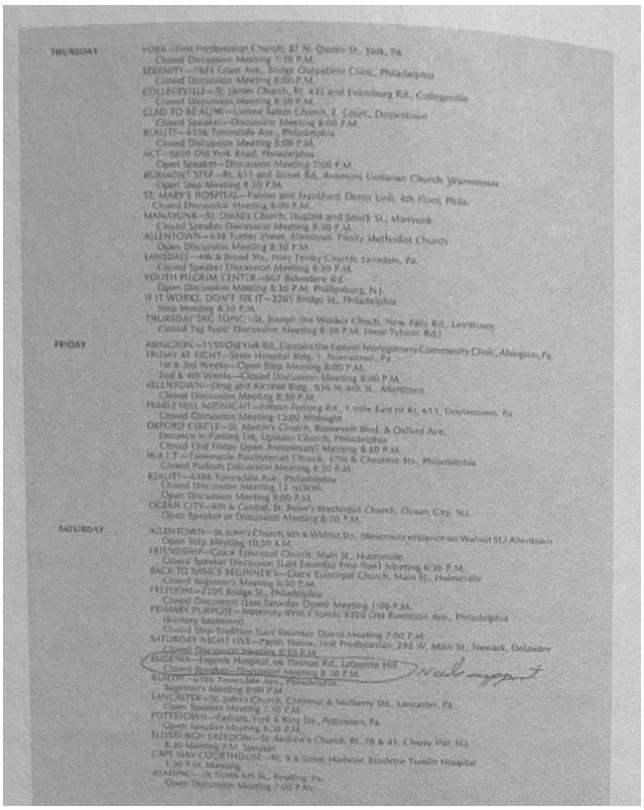
MONDAY

TUESDAY

WEDNESDAY

Jeanne M., Trish, and Gerry O. played a vital role in spreading the message to South Jersey, launching the Ellisburg Circle Group in Ellisburg. Ray T. helped

start another meeting there as well as the Miracles Happen Group in Westville.



THURSDAY

YORK—First Presbyterian Church, 27 N. Queen St., York, Pa.
Closed Discussion Meeting 7:30 P.M.
SERENITY—1941 Grant Ave., Bridge Outpatient Clinic, Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
COLLEGEVILLE—St. James Church, Rt. 422 and Evansburg Rd., Collegeville
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
GLAD TO BE ALIVE—United Salem Church, E. Court, Doylestown
Closed Speaker—Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
REALITY—6156 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
ACT—5828 Old York Road, Philadelphia
Open Speaker—Discussion Meeting 7:00 P.M.
BUXMONT STEP—Rt. 611 and Street Rd., Buxmont Unitarian Church, Warminster
Open Step Meeting 8:30 P.M.
ST. MARY'S HOSPITAL—Palmer and Frankford, Detox Unit, 4th Floor, Phila.
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
MANAYUNK—St. David's Church, Dupont and Smick St., Manyunk
Closed Speaker Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
ALLENTOWN—634 Turner Street, Allentown Trinity Methodist Church
Open Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
LANSDALE—4th & Broad Sts., Holy Trinity Church, Lansdale, Pa.
Closed Speaker Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
YOUTH PILGRIM CENTER—667 Belvedere Rd.
Open Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M. Phillipsburg, N.J.
IF IT WORKS, DON'T FIX IT—2205 Bridge St., Philadelphia
Step Meeting 8:30 P.M.
THURSDAY TAG TOPIC—St. Joseph the Worker Church, New Falls Rd., Levittown
Closed Tag Topic Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M. (near Tyburn Rd.)

FRIDAY

ABINGTON—1150 Old York Rd., Upstairs the Eastern Montgomery Community Clinic, Abington, Pa.
FRIDAY AT EIGHT—State Hospital Bldg. 1, Norristown, Pa.
1st & 3rd Weeks—Open Step Meeting 8:00 P.M.
2nd & 4th Weeks—Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
ALLENTOWN—Drug and Alcohol Bldg., 536 N. 6th St., Allentown
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
PEBBLE HILL MIDNIGHT—Hilton-Fetling Rd., 1 mile East of Rt. 611, Doylestown, Pa.
Closed Discussion Meeting 12:00 Midnight
OXFORD CIRCLE—St. Martin's Church, Roosevelt Blvd. & Oxford Ave.
Entrance in Parking Lot, Upstairs Church, Philadelphia
Closed (3rd Friday Open Anniversary) Meeting 8:30 P.M.
W.A.I.T.—Tabernacle Presbyterian Church, 17th & Chestnut Sts., Philadelphia
Closed Podium Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
REALITY—6406 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 12 NOON
Open Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
OCEAN CITY—4th & Central, St. Peter's Methodist Church, Ocean City, N.J.
Open Speaker or Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.

SATURDAY

ALLENTOWN—St. John's Church, 5th & Walnut Sts. (Basement entrance on Walnut St.) Allentown
Open Step Meeting 10:30 A.M.
FRIENDSHIP—Grace Episcopal Church, Main St., Hulmeville
Closed Speaker Discussion (Last Saturday Free-Box) Meeting 6:30 P.M.
BACK TO BASICS BEGINNER'S—Grace Episcopal Church, Main St., Hulmeville
Closed Beginner's Meeting 6:30 P.M.
FREEDOM—2205 Bridge St., Philadelphia
Closed Discussion (Last Saturday Open) Meeting 1:00 P.M.
PRIMARY PURPOSE—Maternity BVM Church, 9220 Old Bustleton Ave., Philadelphia
(Rectory Basement)
Closed Step Tradition (Last Saturday Open) Meeting 7:00 P.M.
SATURDAY NIGHT FIVE—Parish House, First Presbyterian, 192 W. Main St., Newark, Delaware
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
EUGENIA—Eugenia Hospital, 66 Thomas Rd., Lafayette Hill
Closed Speaker—Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
REALITY—6156 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Beginner's Meeting 8:00 P.M.
LANCASTER—St. John's Church, Chestnut & Mulberry Sts., Lancaster, Pa.
Open Speaker Meeting 7:30 P.M.
POTTSTOWN—Fellows, York & King Sts., Pottstown, Pa.
Open Speaker Meeting 8:30 P.M.
ELLISBURGH FREEDOM—St. Andrew's Church, Rt. 70 & 41, Cherry Hill, N.J.
8:30 Meeting P.M. Speaker
CAPE MAY COURTHOUSE—Rt. 9 & Sixth Harbour, Burdette Tomlin Hospital
1:00 P.M. Meeting
READING—26 North 6th St., Reading, Pa.
Open Discussion Meeting 7:00 P.M.

Meanwhile, Harry P. and Dutch H. brought NA to Cape May Courthouse with a Saturday meeting at Burdette Tomlin Hospital.

On February 20, 1982, the Primary Purpose Group of NA celebrated its first anniversary-not its original formation, but its rebirth after regrouping. Held in the basement of Maternity BVM Church at 9220 Old Bustleton Avenue in Northeast Philadelphia, the event marked more than a passage of time. It was a celebration of renewal, of survival, and of recommitment.

By March, the meeting explosion reached new velocity. Fairless Hills welcomed the New Way Group on Tuesdays, and a daytime meeting opened at the Student Education Center in Philadelphia. Levittown added the Tag Topic Group, while Cornwell Heights reportedly birthed a Friday meeting. Newtown's First Presbyterian Church held Sunday gatherings, and Wilmington, Delaware, saw the launch of the Talking Heads Group.

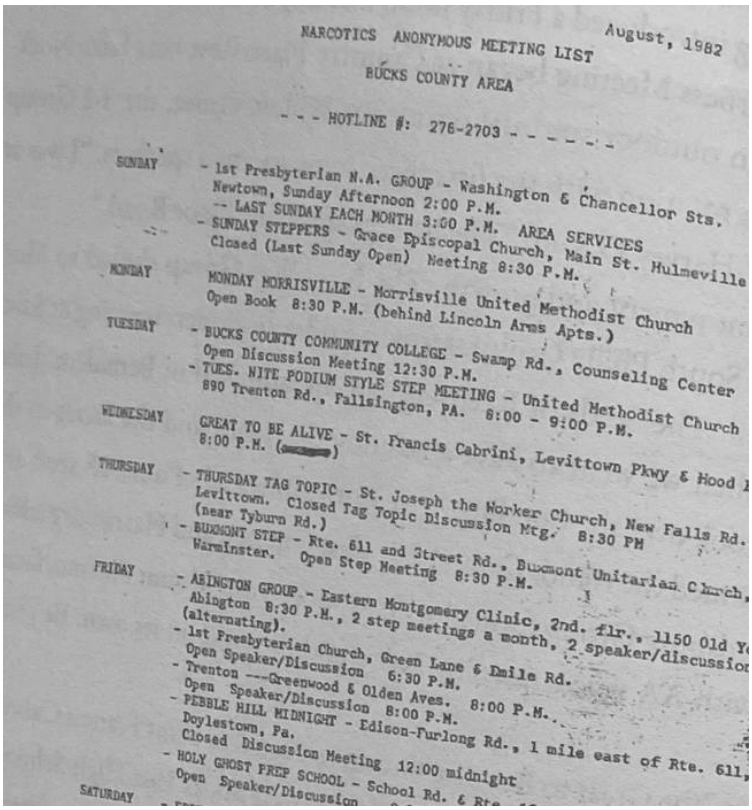
In April, Reading introduced a Friday noon meeting at the North Sixth Club. The Lenape Wilderness Meeting began at Country Place Rest near Lake Nockamixon, offering an outdoor spiritual refuge. In Willow Grove, the 3-2 Group began its five-week rotation with the first three steps and two speakers. "I was at the first meeting," Harvey D. said. "The little hospital by Tabor Road." May brought movement and growth. The New Way Group shifted to Morrisville, while the South Philly Group started a Friday beginners meeting at Saint Rita's Bingo Hall. The Seeds of Recovery Group launched in Bensalem. John Sw. said, "And then we went to have a meeting one night and the locals in the neighborhood took over the building... we just grabbed all of our NA stuff and left." June continued the trend: Camp Hill, West Chester, and Harrisburg added meetings. Stroudsburg Group formed with support from Mount Pocono, facing early friction with AA voices insisting NA couldn't stand on its own. But they persisted.

In Levittown, the Great to Be Alive Group relocated to Saint Francis Cabrini. A Monday 8:00 P.M., a gathering opened at Central Bucks East High School; a Saturday noon Survival Group met at Steve A.'s house. NA was finding form in any space that could hold a circle of chairs and a sense of hope.

July welcomed a new men's and women's meeting at the Church on the Mall in Plymouth Meeting. August saw the Surrender Group move to the Boulevard Center. September was a time of relocations.

Meanwhile, Levittown, Bensalem, and Laurel, Maryland, each saw new meetings. The Lenape Wilderness Group hosted a beachside meeting and picnic in Allentown, showing how recovery could be both joyful and spiritual.

In August, the Bucks County Area published their meeting list.



NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS MEETING LIST August, 1982

BUCKS COUNTY AREA

- - - HOTLINE #: 276-2703 - - - - - -

SUNDAY
- 1st Presbyterian N.A. GROUP - Washington & Chancellor Sts. Newtown, Sunday Afternoon 2:00 P.M. -- LAST SUNDAY EACH MONTH 3:00 P.M. AREA SERVICES
- SUNDAY STEPPERS - Grace Episcopal Church, Main St. Hulmeville Closed (Last Sunday Open) Meeting 8:30 P.M.

MONDAY
MONDAY MORRISVILLE - Morrisville United Methodist Church Open Book 8:30 P.M. (behind Lincoln Arms Apts.)

TUESDAY
- BUCKS COUNTY COMMUNITY COLLEGE - Swamp Rd., Counseling Center Open Discussion Meeting 12:30 P.M.
- TUES. NITE PODIUM STYLE STEP MEETING - United Methodist Church 890 Trenton Rd., Fallsington, PA. 8:00 - 9:00 P.M.

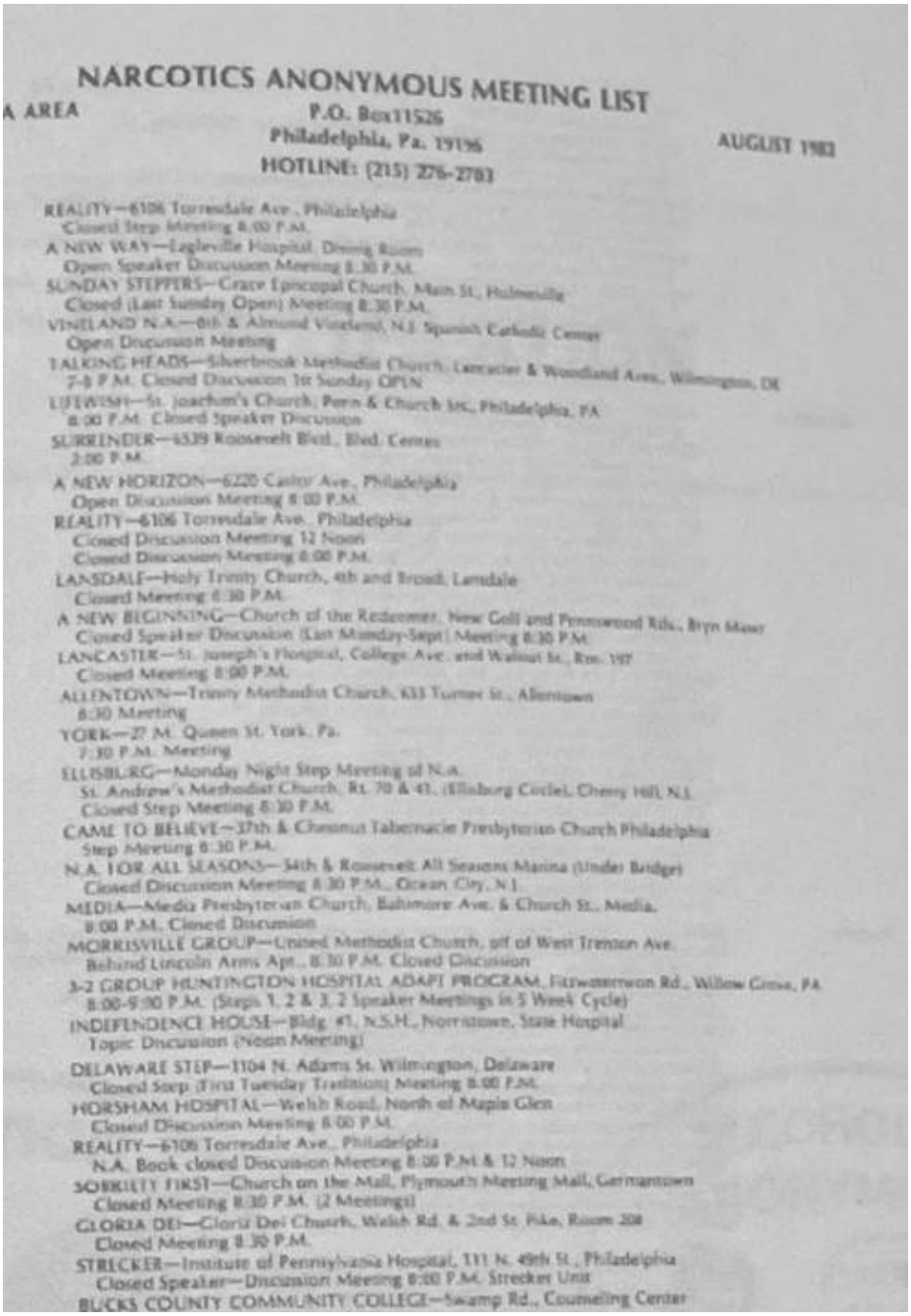
WEDNESDAY
GREAT TO BE ALIVE - St. Francis Cabrini, Levittown Pkwy & Hood 8:00 P.M. ([redacted])

THURSDAY
- THURSDAY TAG TOPIC - St. Joseph the Worker Church, New Falls Rd. Levittown. Closed Tag Topic Discussion Mtg. 8:30 PM (near Tyburn Rd.)
- BUXMONT STEP - Rte. 611 and Street Rd., Buxmont Unitarian Church, Warminster. Open Step Meeting 8:30 P.M.

FRIDAY
- ABINGTON GROUP - Eastern Montgomery Clinic, 2nd. flr., 1150 Old Y Abington 8:30 P.M., 2 step meetings a month, 2 speaker/discussio (alternating).
- 1st Presbyterian Church, Green Lane & Emile Rd. Open Speaker/Discussion 6:30 P.M.
- Trenton ---Greenwood & Olden Aves. 8:00 P.M.. Open Speaker/Discussion 8:00 P.M.
- PEBBLE HILL MIDNIGHT - Edison-Furlong Rd., 1 mile east of Rte. 611, Doylestown, Pa. Closed Discussion Meeting 12:00 midnight
- HOLY GHOST PREP SCHOOL - School Rd. & Rte. Open Speaker/Discussion

SATURDAY

In October, the Somerton Group started in Philadelphia. Williamsport's More Than Clean Group began weekday morning 12 & 12 meetings. Tannersville's Grace United Church hosted a new meeting through Stroudsburg's influence, though leadership challenges soon surfaced, prompting business meetings and leadership changes. In November, the Kresgeville Step Meeting opened in a rural Lutheran Church, By the close of 1982, NA in the region had passed a point of no return. It was no longer a few voices in the dark, no longer fragile or unsure. Through each speaker meeting, each pamphlet shared, and each folding chair unfolded in trust, the NA fellowship was taking form. It was wide, imperfect, uneven, and sometimes chaotic. But it was alive—with gratitude, with truth, and with addicts who were learning to live clean, together.



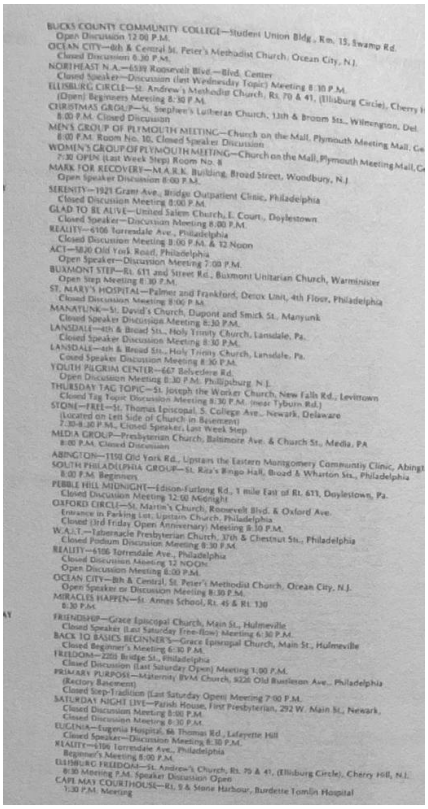
NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS MEETING LIST

A AREA

P.O. Box11526
Philadelphia, Pa. 19196
HOTLINE: (215) 276-2783

AUGUST 1982

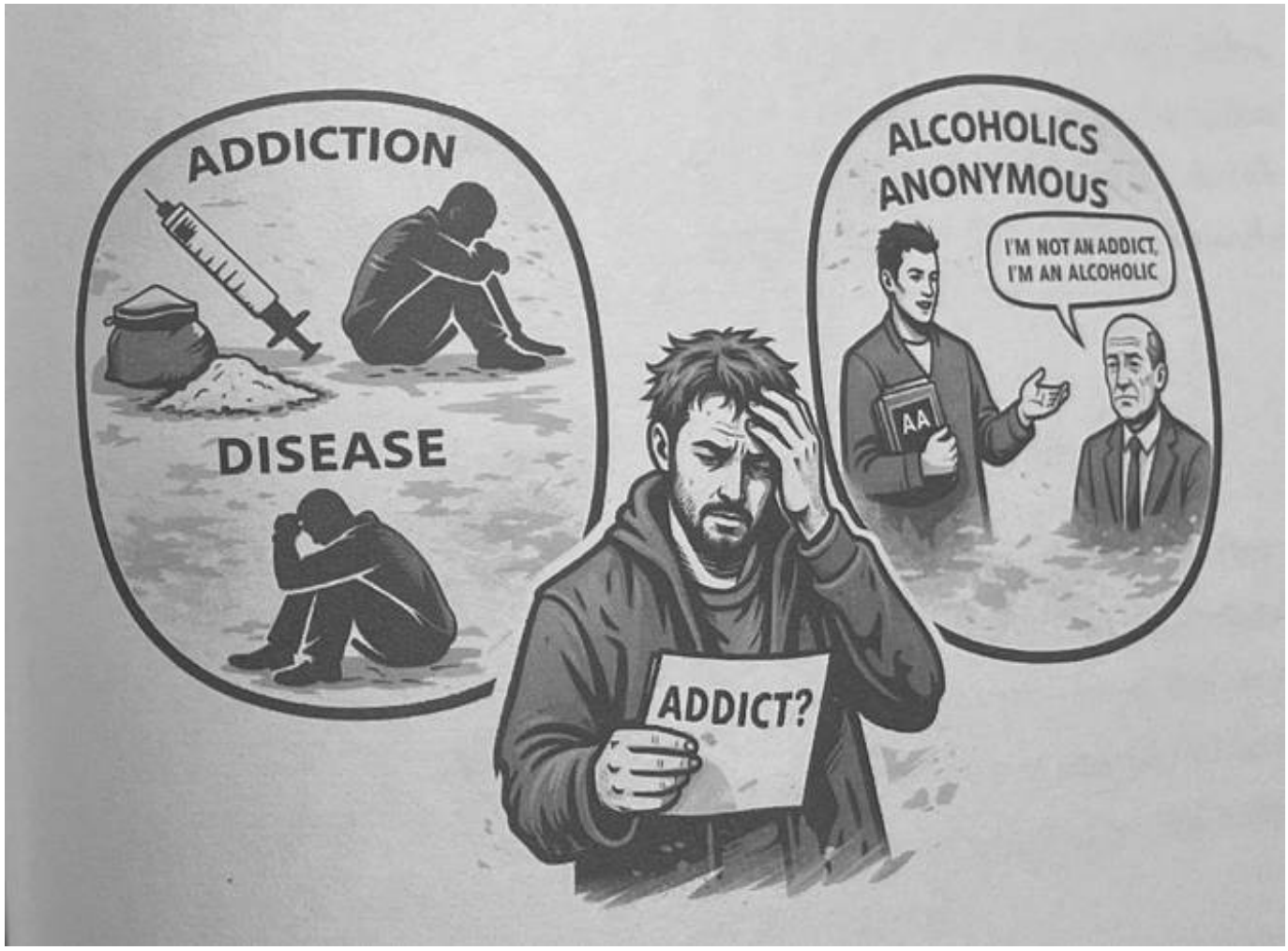
REALITY—6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Closed Step Meeting 8:00 P.M.
A NEW WAY—Eagleville Hospital, Dining Room
Open Speaker Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
SUNDAY STEPPERS—Grace Episcopal Church, Main St., Hulmeville
Closed (Last Sunday Open) Meeting 8:30 P.M.
VINELAND N.A.—6th & Almond Vineland, N.J. Spanish Catholic Center
Open Discussion Meeting
TALKING HEADS—Silverbrook Methodist Church, Lancaster & Woodland Aves., Wilmington, DE
7-8 P.M. Closed Discussion 1st Sunday OPEN
LIFEWISH—St. Joachim's Church, Penn & Church Sts., Philadelphia, PA
8:00 P.M. Closed Speaker Discussion
SURRENDER—4539 Roosevelt Blvd., Bled. Center
2:00 P.M.
A NEW HORIZON—6220 Castor Ave., Philadelphia
Open Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
REALITY—6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 12 Noon
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
LANSDALE—Holy Trinity Church, 4th and Broad, Lansdale
Closed Meeting 8:30 P.M.
A NEW BEGINNING—Church of the Redeemer, New Gulf and Pennswood Rds., Bryn Mawr
Closed Speaker Discussion (Last Monday-Sept) Meeting 8:30 P.M.
LANCASTER—St. Joseph's Hospital, College Ave. and Walnut St., Rm. 197
Closed Meeting 8:00 P.M.
ALLENTOWN—Trinity Methodist Church, 633 Turner St., Allentown
8:30 Meeting
YORK—27 M. Queen St. York, Pa.
7:30 P.M. Meeting
ELLISBURG—Monday Night Step Meeting of N.A.
St. Andrew's Methodist Church, Rt. 70 & 41, (Ellisburg Circle), Cherry Hill, N.J.
Closed Step Meeting 8:30 P.M.
CAME TO BELIEVE—37th & Chestnut Tabernacle Presbyterian Church Philadelphia
Step Meeting 8:30 P.M.
N.A. FOR ALL SEASONS—34th & Roosevelt All Seasons Marina (Under Bridge)
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M., Ocean City, N.J.
MEDIA—Media Presbyterian Church, Baltimore Ave. & Church St., Media,
8:00 P.M. Closed Discussion
MORRISVILLE GROUP—United Methodist Church, off of West Trenton Ave.
Behind Lincoln Arms Apt., 8:30 P.M. Closed Discussion
3-2 GROUP HUNTINGTON HOSPITAL ADAPT PROGRAM, Fitzwatertown Rd., Willow Grove, PA
8:00-9:00 P.M. (Steps 1, 2 & 3, 2 Speaker Meetings in 5 Week Cycle)
INDEPENDENCE HOUSE—Bldg. #1, N.S.H., Norristown, State Hospital
Topic Discussion (Noon Meeting)
DELAWARE STEP—1104 N. Adams St. Wilmington, Delaware
Closed Step (First Tuesday Tradition) Meeting 8:00 P.M.
HORSHAM HOSPITAL—Welsh Road, North of Maple Glen
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
REALITY—6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
N.A. Book closed Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M. & 12 Noon
SOBRIETY FIRST—Church on the Mall, Plymouth Meeting Mall, Germantown
Closed Meeting 8:30 P.M. (2 Meetings)
GLORIA DEI—Gloria Dei Church, Welsh Rd. & 2nd St. Pike, Room 208
Closed Meeting 8:30 P.M.
STRECKER—Institute of Pennsylvania Hospital, 111 N. 49th St., Philadelphia
Closed Speaker—Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M. Strecker Unit
BUCKS COUNTY COMMUNITY COLLEGE—Swamp Rd., Counseling Center



BUCKS COUNTY COMMUNITY COLLEGE—Student Union Bldg., Rm. 13, Swamp Rd.
Open Discussion 12:00 P.M.
OCEAN CITY—8th & Central St. Peter's Methodist Church, Ocean City, N.J.
Closed Discussion 8:30 P.M.
NORTHEAST N.A.—6539 Roosevelt Blvd.—Bled. Center
Closed Speaker—Discussion (last Wednesday Topic) Meeting 8:30 P.M.
ELLISBURG CIRCLE—St. Andrew's Methodist Church, Rt. 70 & 41, (Ellisburg Circle), Cherry
(Open) Beginners Meeting 8:30 P.M.
CHRISTMAS GROUP—St. Stephen's Lutheran Church, 13th & Broom Sts., Wilmington, Del.
8:00 P.M. Closed Discussion
MEN'S GROUP OF PLYMOUTH MEETING—Church on the Mall, Plymouth Meeting Mall, Ge
8:00 P.M. Room No. 10, Closed Speaker Discussion
WOMEN'S GROUP OF PLYMOUTH MEETING—Church on the Mall, Plymouth Meeting Mall, G
7:30 OPEN (Last Week Step) Room No. 8
MARK FOR RECOVERY—M.A.R.K. Building, Broad Street, Woodbury, N.J.
Open Speaker Discussion 8:00 P.M.
SERENITY—1921 Grant Ave., Bridge Outpatient Clinic, Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
GLAD TO BE ALIVE—United Salem Church, E. Court., Doylestown
Closed Speaker—Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
REALITY—6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M. & 12 Noon
ACT—5820 Old York Road, Philadelphia
Open Speaker—Discussion Meeting 7:00 P.M.
BUXMONT STEP—Rt. 611 and Street Rd., Buxmont Unitarian Church, Warminster
Open Step Meeting 8:30 P.M.
ST. MARY'S HOSPITAL—Palmer and Frankford, Detox Unit, 4th Floor, Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
MANAYUNK—St. David's Church, Dupont and Smick St., Manyunk
Closed Speaker Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
LANSDALE—4th & Broad Sts., Holy Trinity Church, Lansdale, Pa.
Closed Speaker Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
LANSDALE—4th & Broad Sts., Holy Trinity Church, Lansdale, Pa.
Closed Speaker Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
YOUTH PILGRIM CENTER—667 Belvedere Rd.
Open Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M. Philipsburg, N.J.
THURSDAY TAG TOPIC—St. Joseph the Worker Church, New Falls Rd., Levittown
Closed Tag Topic Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M. (near Tyburn Rd.)
STONE—FREE—St. Thomas Episcopal, S. College Ave., Newark, Delaware
(Located on Left Side of Church in Basement)
7:30-8:30 P.M., Closed Speaker, Last Week Step
MEDIA GROUP—Presbyterian Church, Baltimore Ave. & Church St., Media, PA
8:00 P.M. Closed Discussion
ABINGTON—1150 Old York Rd., Upstairs the Eastern Montgomery Community Clinic, Abingt
SOUTH PHILADELPHIA GROUP—St. Rita's Bingo Hall, Broad & Wharton Sts., Philadelphia
8:00 P.M. Beginners
PEBBLE HILL MIDNIGHT—Edison-Furlong Rd., 1 mile East of Rt. 611, Doylestown, Pa.
Closed Discussion Meeting 12:00 Midnight
OXFORD CIRCLE—St. Martin's Church, Roosevelt Blvd. & Oxford Ave.
Entrance in Parking Lot, Upstairs Church, Philadelphia
Closed (3rd Friday Open Anniversary) Meeting 8:30 P.M.
W.A.I.T.—Tabernacle Presbyterian Church, 3705 & Chestnut Sts., Philadelphia
Closed Podium Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
REALITY—6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Closed Discussion Meeting 12 NOON
Open Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
OCEAN CITY—8th & Central, St. Peter's Methodist Church, Ocean City, N.J.
Open Speaker or Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
MIRACLES HAPPEN—St. Annes School, Rt. 45 & Rt. 130
8:30 P.M.
FRIENDSHIP—Grace Episcopal Church, Main St., Hulmeville
Closed Speaker (Last Saturday Free-flow) Meeting 6:30 P.M.
BACK TO BASICS BEGINNER'S—Grace Episcopal Church, Main St., Hulmeville
Closed Beginner's Meeting 6:30 P.M.
FREEDOM—2201 Bridge St., Philadelphia
Closed Discussion (Last Saturday Open) Meeting 1:00 P.M.
PRIMARY PURPOSE—Maternity BVM Church, 8226 Old Bustleton Ave., Philadelphia
(Rectory Basement)
Closed Step-Tradition (Last Saturday Open) Meeting 7:00 P.M.
SATURDAY NIGHT LIVE—Parish House, First Presbyterian, 292 W. Main St., Newark,
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:00 P.M.
Closed Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
EUGENIA—Eugenia Hospital, 66 Thomas Rd., Lafayette Hill
Closed Speaker—Discussion Meeting 8:30 P.M.
REALITY—6106 Torresdale Ave., Philadelphia
Beginner's Meeting 8:00 P.M.
ELLISBURG FREEDOM—St. Andrew's Church, Rt. 70 & 41, (Ellisburg Circle), Cherry Hill, N.J.
8:30 Meeting P.M. Speaker Discussion Open
CAPE MAY COURTHOUSE—Rt. 9 & Stone Harbour, Burdette Tomlin Hospital
1:30 P.M. Meeting

Before continuing with these events, it helps to step back for a moment. Many of the changes taking place during this time did not happen all at once. They grew out of earlier efforts-small meetings, shared experience, and addicts learning how to help one another. In those early days, something simple but powerful began to take hold: addicts seeing themselves in each other and finding hope in those connections. Looking back at this foundation helps explain how the fellowship began to grow and why what came next mattered so much. It begins with identification.

IDENTIFICATION



In the late 1960s and early 1970s, NA emerged as a raw, unstructured space for those struggling with addiction. In contrast to AA, which had a more formalized structure, NA meetings were informal and intensely personal. They were spaces of emotional honesty, often featuring raw, unfiltered shares of addiction's harsh realities-incarceration, withdrawal, homelessness, and the fragile glimmer of hope. For many early members, NA was the first place where they could openly acknowledge their identity as addicts, finding solace in the shared vulnerability of their peers. The fellowship lacked formal structures like step work, sponsors, or even clear language, yet it provided a sense of belonging and the vital opportunity to simply "get better" together. Early NA was about emotional connection rather than rituals, with members sharing in a way that was sometimes chaotic but always deeply genuine.

NA's early years were marked by a strong sense of fellowship, where addicts helped each other with little more than their shared experience and a commitment to staying clean. The absence of a rigid structure was at times chaotic but undeniably impactful, providing hope and connection for those in desperate need of both.

1969 to 1972 - Raw, Unstructured, Deeply Personal

Narcotics Anonymous meetings were unlike anything seen today. They were long, organic gatherings chaired by whomever felt moved to lead, often reading from heavily redacted AA literature. The concept of "recovery" had not yet solidified. Roy P. captured this cultural lexicon when he reflected, "We never used terms like recovery' back then. It was like you were getting yourself straightened Out.' Recovery was something that came after."

There were no sponsors, step work, or strict behavioral expectations. Still, the honesty and emotional exposure in these rooms forged unshakable bonds. Members sat shoulder to shoulder, sharing coffee, tears, and unfiltered truths.

For many early members, they could share as drug addicts without shame or censorship. Maureen remembered being advised at an early Northeast Club meeting to identify as an alcoholic. She shrugged it off: "All I knew was I felt their kindness there... I just wanted to be a member." Ray D. recalled his first experience

of being able to introduce himself honestly as an addict: "I was addicted to alcohol. I was addicted to drugs. I couldn't hide that truth from myself. Hearing others share their stories, I felt at home for the first time in my life."

Dutch H. emphasized the grounding effect of naming one's addiction. Dutch put it plainly: "I had an identity. It may not have been the prettiest. But at least] knew what I was and what I was doing." The fellowship provided not just relief. but a way to survive: "You can't get high as long as you're within arm's reach of another addict,"

Craig L. noticed NA's unique lens: it wasn't about the drug-it was about addiction itself. "NA was founded by addicts, and its philosophy was focused on addiction—not just the substance," he said. "The hugs mattered. The philosophy mattered."

Early NA meetings were dialogic and immediate. Crosstalk was not only permitted—it was encouraged. Chairpersons might answer directly to a newcomer's cry for help. John S. would later criticize this as excessive or chaotic, but for many it was lifesaving.

Roy P. explained the format's necessity: "Some of us were too scared to raise our hands. But just maybe, it might give you enough of an edge to blurt that thing out. Man, I feel like getting loaded tonight.'" Reggie, who first attended at seventeen, echoed this view. "Back then, we actually had cross-talk at meetings. If you said something reckless, people would call you out: 'What are you, crazy?'" Many early members attended both AA and NA meetings, navigating cultural friction between the two. AA often demanded adherence to its language—an erasure of drug identity that felt deeply alienating. Bill remembered being warned not to "dilute the message" by sharing about drugs in AA: "Imagine there's a guy coming in, a pure alcoholic.. he hears you talking about shooting dope, and he's. going to leave." Others, like Neil M., straddled both worlds by mentally substituting terms: "I simply replaced alcohol with drugs," said Neil. John S. noted the gradual linguistic shift within NA: "People moved from saying ' addict and alcoholic' to just ' addict," and from 'clean and sober' to 'clean. '"

Maria described AA as a "land of shoulds," contrasting it with NA's radical honesty: "We just talked about today—what was happening, how we felt-in the most direct and honest way possible." Racial representation in early NA was sparse and complicated. Dwayne S. felt both a responsibility and an ambivalence as one of the few Black members: "When Black people showed up, I felt personally responsible for trying to keep them there. At the same time, I enjoyed being 'the only Black guy.' It came with a certain prestige. His ability to adapt came from growing up in predominantly white spaces. "When I walked into the rooms of NA, it felt normal," he said. "But [could see why others struggled." Some early members thrived in NA's loose, emotional format; others found it chaotic and unstructured. Bob admitted preferring AA for its discipline. "I saw NA as more free-flowing... even as NA evolved, I never stopped introducing myself as both an alcoholic and a drug addict." Even so, there was a growing awareness that NA could be something more. Despite his criticism, Bob and others were deeply involved, sometimes attending multiple meetings per day. "It wasn't about thinking 'NA, NA, NA' —it was just what we did."

For many, NA wasn't about steps or literature—not at first. It was about a feeling. A room. A person who told your story. Dennis D. said it best: "The NA meeting gave me something more: a vision. I saw men—and a few women-living in the community with a couple of years clean. I believed in it completely."

Ray T. remembered that spark: "That's the part I couldn't get away from and that I want to say, haunted me. But it saved me." Debbie K. reflected on seeing her peers die and choosing NA in desperation: "I felt hope and some sense of belonging."

Brian T., who went to his first meeting with his brother Ray, had never felt such resonance: "It's the first time I went to a place and I heard somebody talk, not as an authority, but as somebody who was having problems like me."

Many of those early members remember the meetings with both reverence and realism. Carl W. recalled the blunt honesty: "Back then, if you spoke out of turn in a meeting, people would tell you to shut up... Somebody said something the Other day that I hadn't heard in years: 'For the first 90 days, you have nothing to Say."

In hindsight, even without structure, sponsors, or step work, something vital happened in those smoky, noisy, unpredictable rooms. People stayed clean. They found each other. And most importantly, they found hope.

1973 to 1976 - Improvised but Impactful

By the mid-1970s, NA gatherings were still informal but had begun to take on more consistency. Meetings took place in clubhouses where AA meetings were held, counselors' homes, and borrowed spaces. Sometimes, no one even arrived to unlock the door—but the commitment to recovery never wavered. The rooms echoed with stories of shattered lives. Yet, they were also filled with the fierce determination to survive and to heal.

The membership skewed young, often composed of addicts in their early twenties who bonded through what many called "white-knuckling" recovery. But through the struggle came deep camaraderie. Members showed up for each other-not just in meetings, but in life.

Jim F. remembered meeting Dutchy and Eileen at 10th and the Boulevard. "It was a good feeling to meet people because when I would go to my AA meetings they used to always tell us, if your primary problems are drugs, we suggest you attend Narcotics Anonymous."

For those who felt out of place in AA, NA offered a haven. Pat P. recalled the early makeshift meetings: "We were just doing the best we could, calling ourselves NA even though we weren't connected to any area or service structure." Despite being relegated to the smallest rooms, these addicts formed strong bonds. As Pat remembered, "Afterward, we'd all come together for a cookout."

Noel F. noted the power of fellowship in those early years: "It felt like we were white-knuckling it together. It wasn't easy, but I felt comfortable with them. I felt like they truly understood what I was going through."

The identity of an "addict" took time to solidify. Ken E. remembered being told that language mattered: "If my way of sharing might discourage a newcomer, then it's better for me to keep my mouth shut." Denny S. recalled the array of labels used early on-dually addicted, poly addicted, cross addicted-and the

confusion it caused: "My niece said, 'Daddy, what's that?' I said, 'I guess they're addicted to crosses." The fellowship was learning how to be truly inclusive. Patty M., choosing to do "90 in 90" through AA instead of NA, experienced second-class treatment at some meetings: "We had to sit in the back, and we weren't allowed to speak." John F., likely the first openly gay member in his area, was embraced despite his differences: "People saw past everything else and simply saw me as an addict. That was enough." John F. shared how NA was seen as a junior division compared to AA-until he found his truth there. "There was no NA literature. Very few meetings. But we were being kept clean and sober by each other, not by AA." Even without literature or structure, the power of NA lay in identification. Patty M. and Mr. X both described finding hope in hearing others share honestly. "That gave me inspiration and kept me coming back," Patty said. Mr. X echoed, "I believed it could work for me, too."

John S. remembered how important it was to be among young people also trying to recover: "I felt as though we were embarking on an adventure together." For many, recovery wasn't just survival-it was a reclamation of lost time and the discovery of real friendship.

Despite setbacks-like showing up for a meeting and finding the door locked-NA continued to evolve. "NA today is just as effective," Mr. X said. "There are more meetings, more people being helped." Through those uncertain years, the message remained the same: no addict need ever die from the horrors of addiction—not when there's a room full of people waiting to welcome them home.

NA had begun to carve out a distinct identity, separate from AA, though still informal and evolving. It became a lifeline for those who felt alienated from AA's alcohol-focused structure, particularly for younger members and those for whom addiction wasn't just about alcohol. NA's culture was characterized by a survival mentality, where bonds were forged in shared struggle and raw honesty. Members identified not just through sobriety but through the universal experience of addiction, regardless of the substances involved. Though often lacking literature or formal guidance.

1977 to 1980 - Diverging Roads: NA and AA Part Ways

By the late 1970s, the cultural divide between Narcotics Anonymous and Alcoholics Anonymous had become increasingly distinct. While AA remained deeply rooted in its alcohol-centered origins-often structured, older, and resistant to change—NA was beginning to take shape as something younger, looser, and more inclusive. Many" began to realize NA was a fellowship with its own identity, message, and culture.

In AA, drug addicts often felt like second-class citizens. Harry P. recalled the sting of rejection when he introduced himself as a drug addict and alcoholic in an AA meeting after rehab. "I was told I wasn't wanted there," he said. For Harry, and many like him, NA became a necessary refuge-even if it was still raw and evolving. "NA was fine to get started if you had a problem with AA.. It was like the minor leagues and the major leagues to me "

NA, at that time, was not yet structured. Many members had never heard of the Twelve Steps, sponsorship, or even common slogans. The White Book was just starting to circulate, and the Basic Text was still a future dream. For newcomers like Cindy R., the experience was bewildering. "It was like drinking from a fire hose," she said. "I had never read any literature. I didn't know what they meant by sponsorship or any of the slogans." Yet, beneath the lack of formality, something real was taking shape.

Despite its chaos-or perhaps because of it-NA created a powerful sense of belonging for those who had always felt on the margins. For many, it was the first place they were ever truly welcomed. Members described the culture as "hip, slick, and cool"-emotionally open and relational rather than hierarchical or rules-based, Mary Mc. described her turning point at the Collegeville meeting. ""I remember hearing people tell their story... and I thought, 'Just maybe.'" What struck her most was the desperation in the room. "We were young, but we'd been there. We'd been through hell. It really felt like life or death."

Denny S. echoed that simplicity. "Someone told me, 'If you don't use, you won't get high. And if you don't get high, your life will change.' That stuck with me forever."

For Joe F., the bond was instant. "NA grabbed me. I felt more at home there than anywhere else." Pete B. was initially offended by being asked to call himself an addict-he'd just made peace with being an alcoholic. But that discomfort gave way to something unexpected. "I was feeling hope. And it was a strange feeling-I hadn't felt that in years. " Even those who felt unsure, like Charlie F., were drawn to the self-sustaining fellowship. "It was nice to see people who weren't in treatment still banding together and providing support. It gave me hope that I could make my life different." Though many NA members were in their twenties, their life experiences ran deep-marked by prison, violence, overdoses, and loss. The age proximity made identification easier, even as the stories reflected hard-lived lives. Kurt E. compared NA and AA as being like family. "We were the nuclear family," he said, "and AA was like cousins and grandfathers... but we had our own thing."

Still, not everyone fits in right away. Dave S. was just 16 when he arrived and found himself in a room full of older heroin addicts. "It was just hard for me because I was a kid, and there were no kids around yet." George R., at 17, remembered older members telling him he was lucky to have avoided decades of pain. "I hallucinated 24/7 for my first 40 days clean. I know exactly what you're talking about." George W.

recalled feeling comfortable enough in NA to be himself in a way he couldn't in AA. "They were more my age group..... It just felt different."

Others found comfort in hearing stories that matched their lives—not tales of lost pensions and failed marriages, but references to music, street life, and shared trauma. "They weren't talking about their memories from World War II," Phil S. said. "They were talking about the same things I was going through."

For women, early NA could be isolating. Cindy R. often found herself the Only female in the room, surrounded by men much older than her. "It's kind of hard not to notice when you're the only female in the room," she said. AA's older crowd often felt foreign to her—those members had families, jobs, cars. She didn't. "That was quite a gap. So, I had to really lean in and listen to speakers to identify."

Mary Mc. remembered being rejected for sponsorship in AA because she was a drug addict. "In NA, people went a little bit farther to help you." Her relationships with women in active addiction had been toxic, marked by betrayal and mistrust. But in recovery, that began to change. "I found the group of women got clean with.. We weren't sleeping around."

As NA's identity formed, so did its language. Early members introduced themselves in a range of ways-dually addicted, cross-addicted, poly-addicted. Many carried both AA and NA labels until NA's message of identification through the term "addict" began to unify them.

AJ H. remembered being afraid he wouldn't belong. "I thought they were going to say an addict is someone who shoots dope, carries a gun, and has been to jail. And I hadn't done those things. But they said, Most of us don't think twice about this—we just know.' And I thought, 'Shit-I'm one of these people. '"

Alice C. didn't relate to alcoholism at all. "I said I was an addict, and an older lady in AA told me the drug addict meeting was down the street. But NA focused on addiction, and that's what resonated with me. "

Tom C. pointed to one key difference: "In AA, you had to tell your story through a bottle. In NA, we could talk about our drug addiction." The message, Jeff S. said, was clear: total abstinence from any mood-altering substance. The fellowship met in jails, church basements, hospital wings, and halfway houses. Wherever there was space—and a shared desire to live clean—NA would gather. Jeff S. remembered how people would offer couches to those coming off heroin. "No strings attached. Just, You're welcome. You need to be here. We'll help you if you want help." Another addict., a violent outlaw biker, was moved by the suffering he heard in NA rooms. "I understood the language of desperation. We were the last house on the block. It was jails, institutions, or death. " Some described the fellowship as magical. Paula B. said, "It was like Camelot .. Everybody came together at this magical time." By 1980, a shift had occurred. Members began to clearly separate themselves from AA-not out of resentment, but out of recognition that each fellowship had a distinct purpose. As Al R. put it, "We were pretty much violating AA traditions by being in their meetings. We were diluting their message."

For many, the contrast became stark. NA was not about alcohol-it was about addiction in all its forms. It wasn't just about abstinence-it was about healing, connection, and a shared experience. It wasn't founded on ritual-it was built on raw honesty and peer identification. And slowly, meeting by meeting, voice by voice, the Narcotics Anonymous fellowship found its own rhythm, language, and heartbeat. They were no longer guests at someone else's table. They were building their own house-one story at a time. By the end of 1980, what had once been scattered attempts had matured into a living fellowship: young, under-resourced, and flawed-but deeply committed to the message that no addict need ever die from the horrors of addiction. This was the year NA in the region moved from the margins toward momentum.

1981 to 1982 - Contrast with AA: Language

AA's archaic language and structure often felt alienating, especially to younger people or those whose struggles centered around drugs. Members frequently reported feeling judged or silenced in AA when talking about drugs. NA offered a more comfortable, relatable, and emotionally safe space.

In the early years, the message wasn't as nurturing as it is today. Instead, there was a strict "work the steps or die" mentality. This "tough love" approach helped some stay clean when softer tactics might not have worked. Over time, NA has softened its tone, with some members expressing concern over losing that edge.

Al R. reflected, "I think that our message has gotten kind of watered down over time. Maybe rightfully so. On some levels, because, you don't hear work the steps or die motherfucker' anymore. You don't hear, 'sit down and take the cotton out of your mouth and out of your ears and put it in your mouth.'"

Jeanne M. found solace in the fact that even Doctor Bob, one of AA's founders, had struggled with pain medication addiction. However, outside of her NA home group, she felt monitored in what she could say. But when she finally found NA, she immediately felt at home. She said, "We didn't have a Basic Text yet, so we took the Big Book and we crossed out 'alcohol' and put 'addict' in the book to give us comfort. Doctor Bob was addicted to pain meds. I got solace with that.

So, hey, basically he needed us. I had an NA home group and that was thee place I could really talk about drugs. I wasn't allowed to talk about drugs ina other place."

Jill F. noted that while AA was more established and structured, NA felt mo relatable, especially because it allowed open discussions about drug addiction.

said, "The people in AA were a lot of old timers because the program was around for longer. If you wanted to be around people that had time, you hung around the more established program. They gave off that vibe, they had a book, and wer more organized. I thought that NA was cooler and they were more like me. In NA, you could talk about whatever you want. Nobody made you feel weird for talking about the fact that you wanted to get high and if you wanted to drink. never wanted to fucking drink. I wasn't a drinker. I was a drug addict."

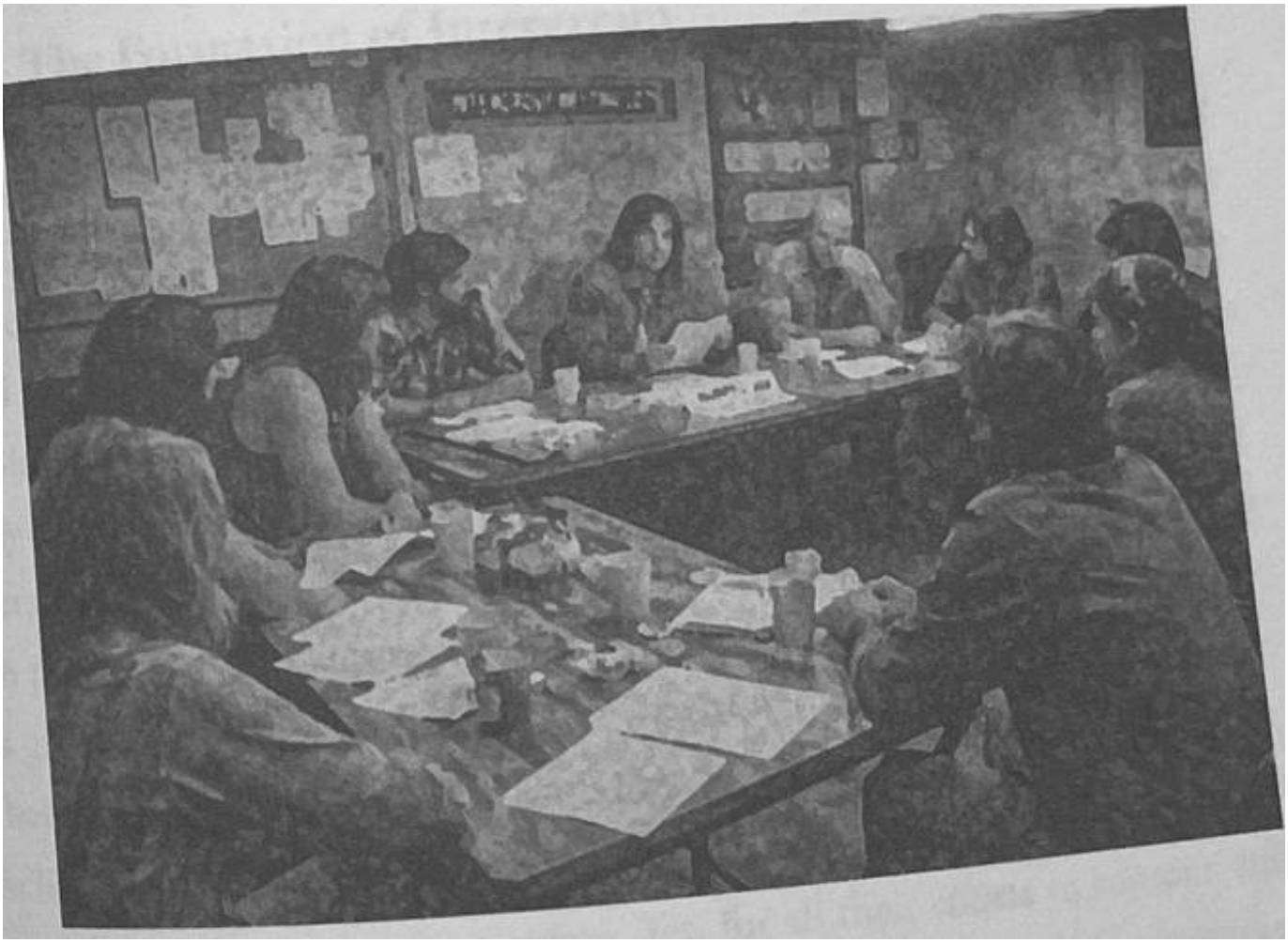
Jim D. struggled to relate to the language of AA's Big Book. Jim said, "What I considered archaic language. It was pretty refreshing when I went to that NA meeting in Morrisville in the summer of 82, where they had an approval form of the Basic Text. When they read things like 'Who is an Addict?' I'm like, I'm not an alcoholic with an alcohol problem. I'm not an alcoholic with a drug problem. I'm a freaking addict!" Many members were desperate to fit in and be accepted, often shaped by guilt and shame from their past behaviors. Even small acts of kindness-being invited to hang out after a meeting, being encouraged to share—had lasting emotional impact. Gary F. felt he had let others down because of past lies. He was trying to fit in because he admired what others in the program had and genuinely wanted to stop using. Gary said, "I wanted what people had. I was trying to fit in after going in and out. I lied because I wanted to fit in, and I loved what this was doing. I didn't want to get high anymore. But this guy John D. said Hey come on and you'll hang out with me after the meeting.' I couldn't believe it because I thought I let him down cause I lied." Margie C. wrestled with doubts about whether she was a "real" addict, especially if she didn't use in extreme ways. She said, "I was confused at first because they said it was all about drugs, but the majority of the people that were there at that time were people that shot dope. I never shot dope. I snorted dope."

For those who felt alienated in other settings, NA became a sanctuary. Members repeatedly described it as magical, comforting, and transformative. The one thing Henry D did understand was simple: keep coming back and stay clean, because this thing won't work unless you stay clean. Henry said, "In the beginning days was # 1 getting a home group, #2 was getting a sponsor, and #3 was, obviously, abstinence from all drugs. Considering what our literature was saying at the time about alcohol and tuberculosis and diabetes, eventually we took it out. We abstain from all drugs. And that includes alcohol!" Mike B. felt unable to share openly about his specific struggles, like the desire to use dope, in those early recovery settings. Naturally, he was drawn to NA because it addressed his experience more directly. Mike said, "I had no idea about recovery, AA or NA. I remembered the differences of the way I felt I couldn't share it. What I wanted to share. I couldn't speak about, you know wanting to use dope and so I gravitated obviously towards NA." Jack C. said, "The first word We' —that's when I knew I was in the right place."

The Power of Saying "I'm an Addict"

Early Narcotics Anonymous in Pennsylvania and surrounding areas offered something radical: a place where addicts could openly identify as addicts without shame. Unlike AA, where drug stories were often silenced or reshaped around alcohol, NA embraced addiction in all its forms. Members found relief in hearing their own experiences spoken back to them—whether about prison, withdrawal, or the daily fight not to use. This raw honesty created powerful identification: people who had long felt invisible finally felt seen. The simple act Of saying "I'm an addict" gave them both an identity and a community. Even without structure, literature, or sponsors, NA's early fellowship thrived on that identification, forging bonds strong enough to keep many alive and clean when nothing else could. Members felt seen, heard, and validated in NA-creating a deep emotional connection.

INTERGROUP



In the shadow of the early 1970s, as recovery communities across the country began quietly taking root, a small but determined circle of recovering addicts in the Philadelphia area recognized a growing need. Meetings were scattered and disconnected, often functioning like isolated islands rather than parts of a broader whole. What they sought was something cohesive—an organized way to manage institutional commitments, share literature, and give members a regular opportunity to gather and support one another. The solution they turned to wasn't created from scratch; instead, they borrowed from the structure of Alcoholics Anonymous, observing its Intergroup model and adapting it to fit the budding Narcotics Anonymous fellowship in their region. Thus, in the early part of 1973, they formed a service body of their own, calling it Intergroup, a term they borrowed directly from AA, as "Area Service" and "Regional Service" were not yet part of the NA lexicon.

1973 - The Formation of Intergroup

At first, meetings were held in homes and apartments, drawing in anywhere from 12 to 15 people-names like Ray T., Brian T., Roy P., Chappie, and others who would become familiar voices in the early chapters of local NA history. They moved forward with no clear blueprint. Policy was nonexistent. They were improvising constantly-winging it, as some later described. Their gatherings, fueled by coffee, donuts, and a fierce sense of purpose, slowly evolved from informal conversations to structured service meetings. They agreed to meet monthly and began producing simple but vital tools: printed meeting lists, speaker schedules, and a growing collection of homemade literature.

Their reach expanded quickly, with interest spilling over into nearby communities like Norristown and Pottstown. Individuals such as Rich Mc. and others stepped forward, eager to participate. Yet, for all their efforts to connect with NA's roots on the West Coast, communication with California was sporadic and often discouraging. Letters were sent, but replies either never came or arrived months later, often without much direction. Many of the learning experiences the California fellowship went through, the Philadelphia meetings also went through

in due course, using the same literature, Steps, and Traditions as their base. Roy P. recalled:

For a whole year, we kept writing letters to California through the Intergroup, but we never got a response. We kept writing and writ.

ing, but nothing. People would ask me, "Is there really anything out there?" And I'd think, "Well, I met three people in NA back in 1969," but here we were in 1973, still without contact. As far as I knew, those three might have been the only ones—but I didn't care. We kept going.

And Dave F. added, And let me just say that we didn't know if there was any NA anywhere else in the world. We had heard that there were meetings Out in California.

Even without precedent, the group sought to ground every action in principle. They filtered every decision through that lens, determined to preserve NA's spiritual foundation even in the absence of policy or precedent. This deep respect for the Traditions became a defining feature of their early development. They would pull out the 12 Traditions, think it through, talk it through, then vote on it with consensus. They never violated the Traditions. They would try to filter everything through the Traditions. Even though they didn't know anything, they tried to say, how does this affect the Traditions? They would have to sit down over coffee and say, is this something that we should do and bring out the Traditions. That was like their Bible to go to. Ray T. remembered:

We're struggling to get a meeting. We keep a meeting open and we're talking to the council of these churches, so we're like, I'm not messing that up for anything, right. And then we go to the traditions.

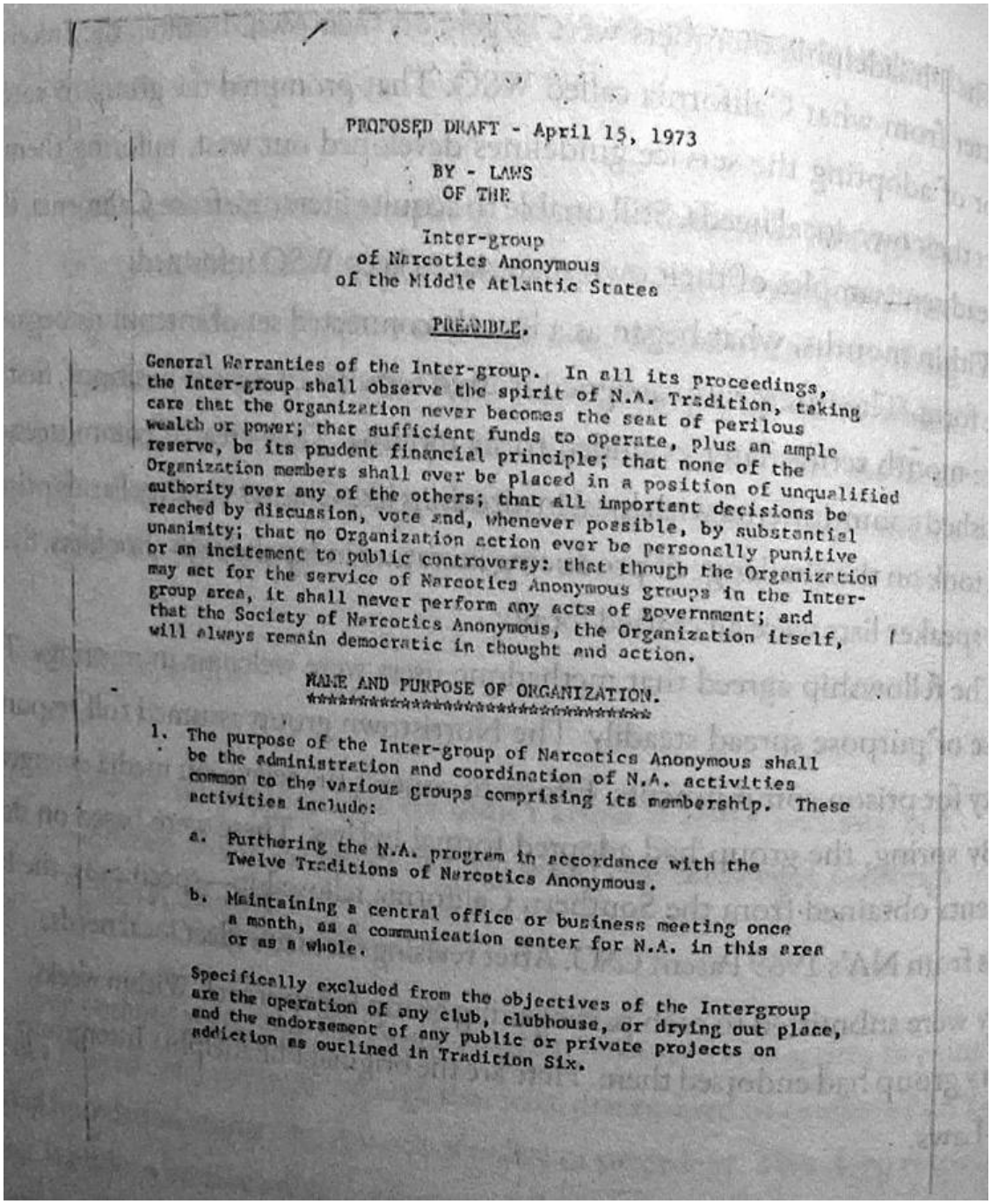
The Philadelphia members were largely on their own. In time, they received a letter from what California called WSO. That prompted the group to vote in favor of adopting the service guidelines developed out west, tailoring them to meet their own local needs. Still unable to acquire literature from California, they instead sent samples of their own material to keep WSO informed.

Within months, what began as a loosely connected set of intentions began to take form. The Intergroup assigned trusted servants to formal positions, first on three-month terms, later extended to six months. They created committees, established commitments with local institutions like Chester County Farms prison, and took on the challenge of producing literature independently. Booklets, flyers, and speaker lists were all crafted locally.

The fellowship agreed that methadone users were welcome in meetings. The sense of purpose spread steadily. The Norristown group assumed full responsibility for prison commitments. Efforts to contact the television media emerged.

By spring, the group had adopted formal bylaws. These were based on documents obtained from the Southern California fellowship—specifically, the bylaws from NA's 1969 Parent GSO. After revising them to reflect local needs, they were submitted to each participating group for approval. Within weeks, every group had endorsed them. Here are the original Philadelphia Intergroup By-Laws.

Intergroup by-laws — April 15, 1973



PROPOSED DRAFT - April 15, 1973

BY - LAWS
OF THE

Inter-group
of Narcotics Anonymous
of the Middle Atlantic States

PREAMBLE.

General Warranties of the Inter-group. In all its proceedings, the Inter-group shall observe the spirit of N.A. Tradition, taking care that the Organization never becomes the seat of perilous wealth or power; that sufficient funds to operate, plus an ample reserve, be its prudent financial principle; that none of the Organization members shall ever be placed in a position of unqualified authority over any of the others; that all important decisions be reached by discussion, vote and, whenever possible, by substantial unanimity; that no Organization action ever be personally punitive or an incitement to public controversy: that though the Organization may act for the service of Narcotics Anonymous groups in the Inter-group area, it shall never perform any acts of government; and that the Society of Narcotics Anonymous, the Organization itself, will always remain democratic in thought and action.

NAME AND PURPOSE OF ORGANIZATION.
****

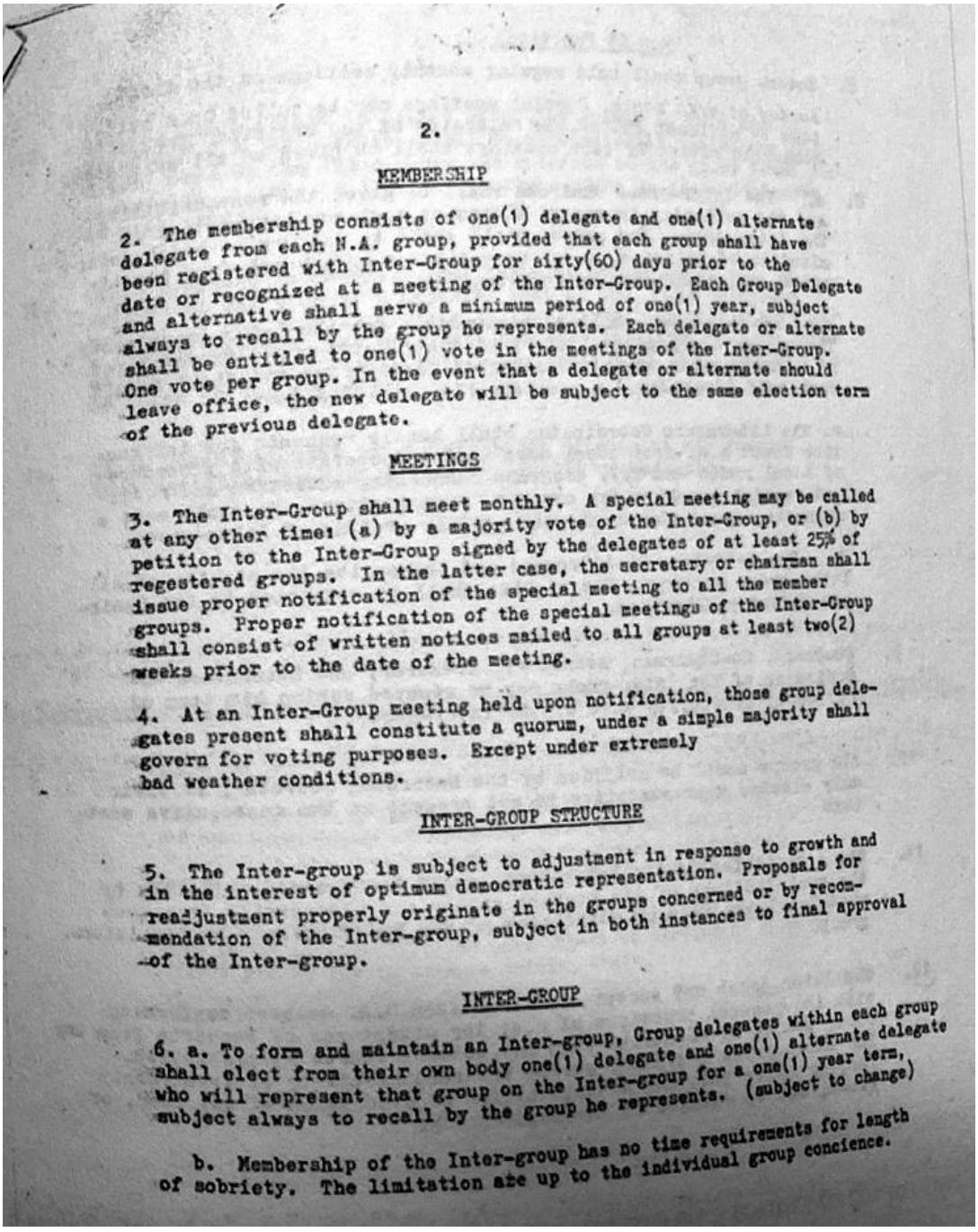
1. The purpose of the Inter-group of Narcotics Anonymous shall be the administration and coordination of N.A. activities common to the various groups comprising its membership. These activities include:

   a. Furthering the N.A. program in accordance with the Twelve Traditions of Narcotics Anonymous.

   b. Maintaining a central office or business meeting once a month, as a communication center for N.A. in this area or as a whole.

Specifically excluded from the objectives of the Intergroup are the operation of any club, clubhouse, or drying out place, and the endorsement of any public or private projects on addiction as outlined in Tradition Six.

Intergroup by-laws — membership and meetings



2.

MEMBERSHIP

2. The membership consists of one(1) delegate and one(1) alternate delegate from each N.A. group, provided that each group shall have been registered with Inter-Group for sixty(60) days prior to the date or recognized at a meeting of the Inter-Group. Each Group Delegate and alternative shall serve a minimum period of one(1) year, subject always to recall by the group he represents. Each delegate or alternate shall be entitled to one(1) vote in the meetings of the Inter-Group. One vote per group. In the event that a delegate or alternate should leave office, the new delegate will be subject to the same election term of the previous delegate.

MEETINGS

3. The Inter-Group shall meet monthly. A special meeting may be called at any other time: (a) by a majority vote of the Inter-Group, or (b) by petition to the Inter-Group signed by the delegates of at least 25% of regestered groups. In the latter case, the secretary or chairman shall issue proper notification of the special meeting to all the member groups. Proper notification of the special meetings of the Inter-Group shall consist of written notices mailed to all groups at least two(2) weeks prior to the date of the meeting.

4. At an Inter-Group meeting held upon notification, those group delegates present shall constitute a quorum, under a simple majority shall govern for voting purposes. Except under extremely bad weather conditions.

INTER-GROUP STRUCTURE

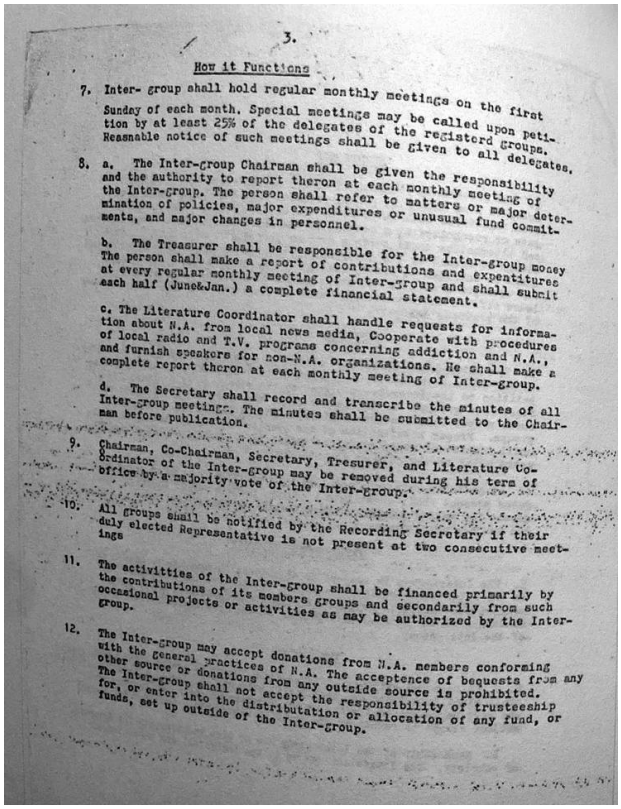
5. The Inter-group is subject to adjustment in response to growth and in the interest of optimum democratic representation. Proposals for readjustment properly originate in the groups concerned or by recommendation of the Inter-group, subject in both instances to final approval of the Inter-group.

INTER-GROUP

6. a. To form and maintain an Inter-group, Group delegates within each group shall elect from their own body one(1) delegate and one(1) alternate delegate who will represent that group on the Inter-group for a one(1) year term, subject always to recall by the group he represents. (subject to change)

b. Membership of the Inter-group has no time requirements for length of sobriety. The limitation are up to the individual group concience.

Intergroup by-laws — how it functions



3.

How it Functions

7. Inter- group shall hold regular monthly meetings on the first Sunday of each month. Special meetings may be called upon petition by at least 25% of the delegates of the registerd groups. Reasnable notice of such meetings shall be given to all delegates.

8. a. The Inter-group Chairman shall be given the responsibility and the authority to report theron at each monthly meeting of the Inter-group. The person shall refer to matters or major determination of policies, major expenditures or unusual fund commitments, and major changes in personnel.

b. The Treasurer shall be responsible for the Inter-group money The person shall make a report of contributions and expentitures at every regular monthly meeting of Inter-group and shall submit each half (June&Jan.) a complete financial statement.

c. The Literature Coordinator shall handle requests for information about N.A. from local news media, Cooperate with procedures of local radio and T.V. programs concerning addiction and N.A., and furnish speakers for non-N.A. organizations. He shall make a complete report theron at each monthly meeting of Inter-group.

d. The Secretary shall record and transcribe the minutes of all Inter-group meetings. The minutes shall be submitted to the Chairman before publication.

9. Chairman, Co-Chairman, Secretary, Tresurer, and Literature Coordinator of the Inter-group may be removed during his term of office by a majority vote of the Inter-group.

10. All groups shall be notified by the Recording Secretary if their duly elected Representative is not present at two consecutive meetings

11. The activitties of the Inter-group shall be financed primarily by the contributions of its members groups and secondarily from such occasional projects or activities as may be authorized by the Inter-group.

12. The Inter-group may accept donations from N.A. members conforming with the general practices of N.A. The acceptence of bequests from any other source or donations from any outside source is prohibited. The Inter-group shall not accept the responsibility of trusteeship for, or enter into the distributation or allocation of any fund, or funds, set up outside of the Inter-group.

Intergroup by-laws (continued)

12. Matters which relate to policy affecting groups in the area, or affecting N.A. as a whole, shall be automatically tabled for (30) thirty days by the Inter-Group and referred to the group level for discussion, consideration, and recommendation to the delegates in each group.

13. These By-Laws, representing our table of organization, may be amended at any time by a majority vote of the group delegates present at any regular meeting of the Inter-Group providing that a copy of the proposed amendment has been submitted to each group at least (30) thirty days before the meeting at which action is to be taken on the amendment.

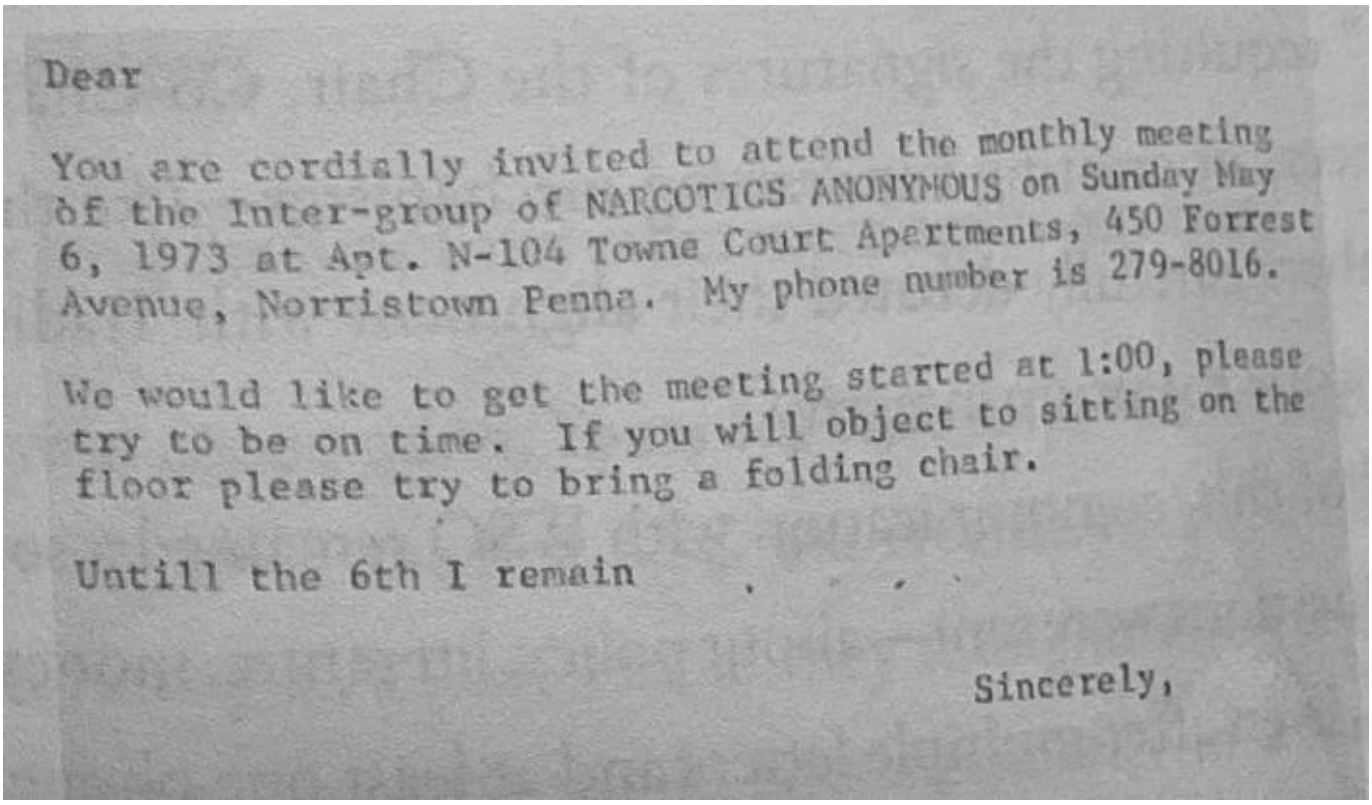
14. It is hereby brought to the attention of whom it may concern, that Narcotics Anonymous is a non-profit organization.

The Secretary sent four copies of the By-laws to each group with an invitation.

Dear You are cordially invited to attend the monthly meeting of the Inter-group of NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS on Sunday May 6, 1973 at Apt. N-104 Towne Court Apartments, 450 Forrest Avenue, Norristown Penna. My phone number is 279-8016.

We would like to get the meeting started at 1:00, please try to be on time. If you will object to sitting on the floor please try to bring a folding chair.

Until the 6th I remain Sincerely, Charlie F.



Dear

You are cordially invited to attend the monthly meeting of the Inter-group of NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS on Sunday May 6, 1973 at Apt. N-104 Towne Court Apartments, 450 Forrest Avenue, Norristown Penna. My phone number is 279-8016.

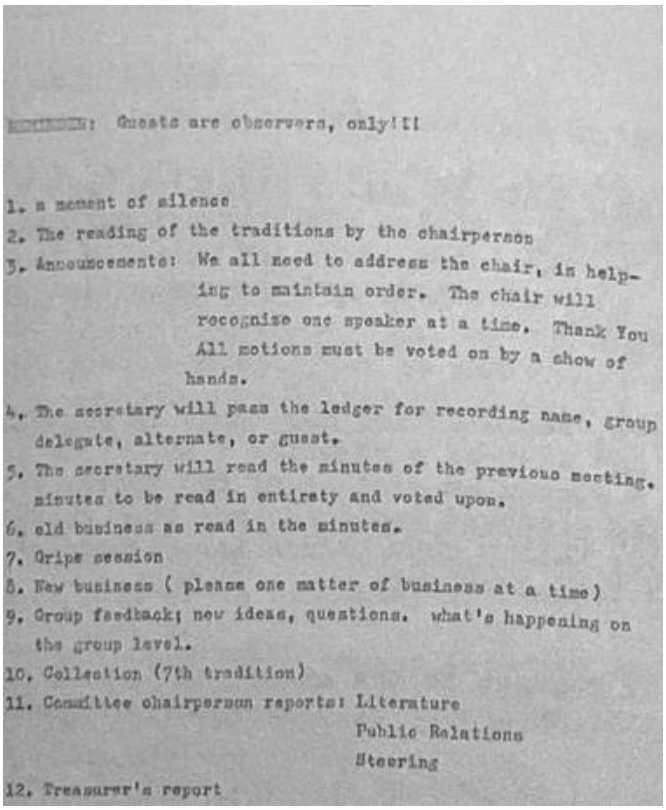
We would like to get the meeting started at 1:00, please try to be on time. If you will object to sitting on the floor please try to bring a folding chair.

Untill the 6th I remain

Sincerely,

Ralph S. distributed copies of the Intergroup meeting format to the groups.

The Intergroup also began to formalize its financial and operational structure, Each group contributed small monthly donations to help with growing phone expenses. A checking account was established under the name "Inner Group



[redacted]: Guests are observers, only!!!

1. a moment of silence
2. The reading of the traditions by the chairperson
3. Announcements: We all need to address the chair, in helping to maintain order. The chair will recognise one speaker at a time. Thank You All motions must be voted on by a show of hands.
4. The secretary will pass the ledger for recording name, group delegate, alternate, or guest.
5. The secretary will read the minutes of the previous meeting. minutes to be read in entirety and voted upon.
6. old business as read in the minutes.
7. Gripe session
8. New business (please one matter of business at a time)
9. Group feedback; new ideas, questions. what's happening on the group level.
10. Collection (7th tradition)
11. Committee chairperson reports: Literature
    Public Relations
    Steering
12. Treasurer's report

Association," requiring the signatures of the Chair, Co-Chair, and Treasurer. In the process of creating fundraising mechanisms-like the sale of 50/50 tickets—members carefully debated their alignment with Traditions, adjusting language and scope to ensure integrity.

Through all of this, communication with WSO remained a source of tension and mystery. Questions were sent—about policy, literature, money—but answers rarely followed. Even after multiple letters and at least one phone call, no clarity came. Still, the Philadelphia Intergroup persevered, continuing to operate as if the responsibility was theirs alone.

Dear Friends, We are sending this letter in reference to a phone call made in May concerning communication problems between us and GSO. We talked to Debbie D. about these problems. She said to write a letter with all our questions and problems and said we would definitely get an answer this time.

1. We were wondering why in the last 6 months we have written many times asking various questions and never received any answers.

2. We have started a NA Intergroup and would like to know the difference between our Intergroup and GSO if any.

3. We were wondering if literature that we make out here should be sent to you for approval before we distribute it. Our Intergroup is making up a stamp reading NA Intergroup approved but we would like to know where we stand on this problem.

4. We would like to know how close the NA Big Book is and if you have any other literature other than the NA pamphlet, please let us know if there is anything we can do to help.

5. We talked to Debbie D. about the fact that some groups had sent money to GSO quite a while ago for NA Books and never received them. Debbie said if we wrote and told her the amount of money sent and the group she would send the books to us.

Springfield NA $10.00 about 9 months ago.

Lewisburg NA $10.00 (please send these books to Ray T. house with reply to letter).

6. Please send the list of any other meetings in our area.

Thanks for your cooperation, Yours & Fellowship, NA Intergroup Brian T. On October 23, 1973, the first ASC was created in the San Fernando Valley at a meeting in Jimmy K.'s home, or so they thought. Greg P. drafted a full set of service guidelines, which he would later summarize in a formal letter dated December 12, 1973. At the time, NA had only two defined areas: Northern and Southern California. Groups in Pennsylvania, though organizing through Philadelphia's Intergroup, remained distant from these emerging structures. What emerged over the course of that pivotal year was not simply a service body-it was a foundation. One built on relationships, consensus, and above all, commitment to the spiritual principles that had drawn them to recovery in the first place. Though they were largely self-taught, the structure they created would have a lasting influence, extending far beyond Philadelphia to surrounding counties, across state lines, and eventually, along the entire Eastern Seaboard.

Their legacy is found not just in by-laws and booklets, but in the spirit they carried into every room, every institution, and every coffee-stained meeting format. They weren't just organizing recovery-they were anchoring it.

1974 - A Structure Begins to Take Shape

By the start of 1974, the Intergroup of NA in Pennsylvania had begun to mature from a loose gathering of groups into a service body with structure, direction, and a growing sense of shared purpose. Seven groups met in Collegeville in early January, and among the usual group reports and updates, Ray T. stepped forward to examine potential improvements to the Hotline—an early signal that communication and access to help were front and center on the collective mind.

Intergroup revised the By-Laws:

1. Each group will carry two votes: 1 delegate and 1-alternate

2. One guest may be brought from each group by the representative if they feel that he or she might be a future delegate of Intergroup

3. The guest will not be a voting member

4. The term of office was changed from 6 months to 1 year

5. The succession law was taken out. A person may serve as many times as he or she is elected.

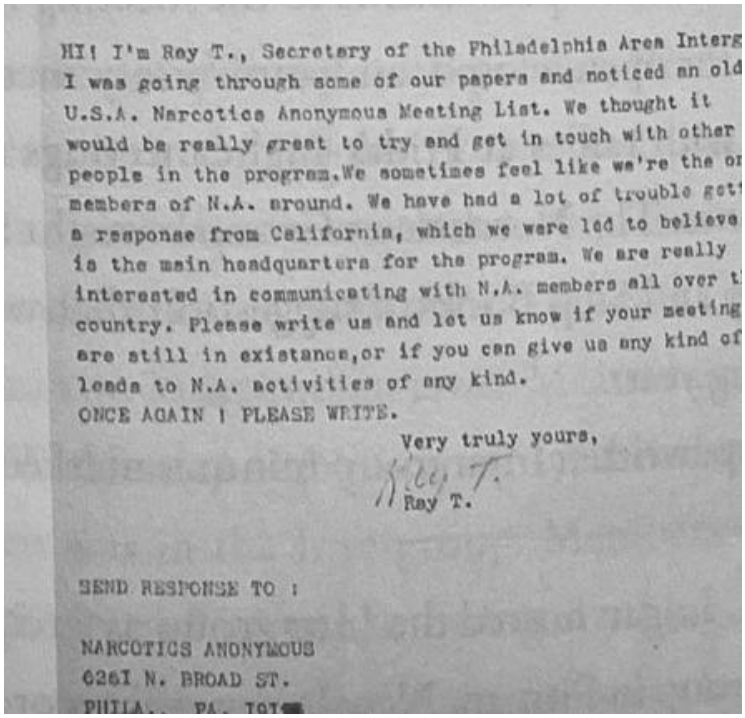
6. Office holder must be a delegate.

Momentum built steadily as February brought the group to Pottstown. Discussions surfaced about whether Intergroup should coordinate speaking engagements or leave such tasks to the discretion of individual groups. Tensions and concerns emerged around group participation, especially among those who had not attended recent meetings. Delegates were asked to go back to their respective groups and vote on a significant procedural issue: whether both a delegate and an alternate could cast votes in Intergroup matters or whether one vote per group would better reflect group conscience. The options underscored a deeper conversation about leadership and service-was a delegate merely a representative or a servant of the group's will?

When the members gathered again at 13th & Ruscomb the following month, the results of that vote were brought to the table. With some groups supporting the change and others opposing it, the result was an even tie. The issue was postponed, allowing time for further consideration. Still, progress continued. The Intergroup established two new working committees: one to guide 12-step work and another—the Steering Committee—to oversee recreational and social events, recognizing that fellowship outside of formal meetings was equally vital.

As spring arrived, delegates returned to Collegeville. The matter of group voting was finally settled: going forward, each group would cast a single vote, regardless of whether both the delegate and alternate were present. The Pottstown group had begun engaging local unions and detox centers in outreach efforts, and Intergroup voted to list the NA phone number in the local telephone book, absorbing the modest fee to ensure accessibility. The Literature Committee was formally tasked with establishing procedures for providing literature to new groups, signaling the start of a more formalized distribution process.

May ushered in a period of outreach and financial awareness. Ray T., in a pivotal move, began corresponding with NA contacts across the country, sending letters and initiating dialogue beyond Pennsylvania's borders. One of the earliest connections was with a lone member in New York—a symbolic step that would lead to more expansive regional communication.



HI! I'm Ray T., Secretary of the Philadelphia Area Interg
I was going through some of our papers and noticed an old
U.S.A. Narcotics Anonymous Meeting List. We thought it
would be really great to try and get in touch with other
people in the program.We sometimes feel like we're the on
members of N.A. around. We have had a lot of trouble gett
a response from California, which we were led to believe
is the main headquarters for the program. We are really
interested in communicating with N.A. members all over t
country. Please write us and let us know if your meeting
are still in existance,or if you can give us any kind of
leads to N.A. activities of any kind.
ONCE AGAIN ! PLEASE WRITE.

Very truly yours,

Ray T.

SEND RESPONSE TO :

NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS
6261 N. BROAD ST.
PHILA., PA. 191

Meanwhile, the 12-Step Committee was dissolved, with the understanding that groups would assume responsibility for their own outreach reports. Carl W. took on the responsibility of delivering NA books to Norristown to foster

engagement, and despite a billing error from Bell Telephone that raised the phone listing cost to $4.56, resulting in a total bill of $42, Intergroup remained committed to keeping the line active. Calls from the answering service were being successfully routed, and volunteers were stepping up to handle 12-step calls.

The June gathering at Collegeville continued these trends. Ray T.'s correspondence yielded a reply from California, including a letter and phone call from the NA community there. Sandra C. in New York shared recollections of short-lived efforts to establish meetings in her area. These interactions emphasized the hunger for connection and structure beyond Pennsylvania. A request for support in Coatesville was voiced, though no one was yet available to initiate a meeting there. To foster unity, a picnic was planned at a Bucks County swimming pool. The event, announced by Ray T. at a Philadelphia meeting, was to include catered food, a Yes album as a door prize, and tickets priced at $7.50 for adults and $4.00 for children under five. The event would also feature a 50/50 drawing, with proceeds earmarked to fund the next year's Steering Committee.

By mid-July, the Intergroup returned to Philadelphia. Approval of the by-laws was now unanimous among all participating groups, including Pottstown, Logan, Norristown, Collegeville, Boulevard, Byberry, and Southampton. Ray T . 's outreach had yielded responses from meetings in Denver and State College-both active—as well as two mail returns. Brian T. itemized long-distance 12-step call costs, and further improvements to the meeting lists were discussed, including designations for open, closed, and anniversary meetings. Fundraising practices were refined, with raffles at Friday night meetings adjusted to ensure clarity about their purpose. The Norristown Group brought forward a proposal to purchase Day by Day and Step Books, a suggestion that would remain unresolved until the following year. In August, the first typewritten Intergroup minutes marked a quiet milestone in professionalism. The following month, Logan hosted the Intergroup as a request from Sharon H. for a starter kit for a group in Pitman, New Jersey, was recorded—but no trace of the group would surface thereafter. When the delegates returned to Collegeville in October, attention turned to leadership and procedural integrity. Ray urged early training of new officers and

clarified that only delegates or alternates should serve in such roles. Poor attendance among alternates was noted, and the group agreed to formalize delegate responsibilities. Guests would continue to be welcomed at meetings, but without voting or speaking rights. The process for recognizing new meetings was updated—requiring representatives to first attend Intergroup before receiving support. Free literature would now only be distributed to those physically present. Bill B. questioned the propriety of writing a magazine article about NA, concerned about anonymity, and a committee was formed to review the article. By November 1974, the WSO had already earned a reputation for being nomadic. It had been relocated several times—first from Crenshaw Boulevard, then to 1246 Highland Avenue, and subsequently to a room above a bail bondsman's office and even a suicide prevention center. Each move reflected both the grassroots nature of the organization and the challenges of sustaining centralized services without a stable infrastructure.

By late 1974, Philadelphia's Intergroup received a long-overdue letter from WSO-possibly authored by Jimmy K. himself—acknowledging past communication breakdowns and recommending materials published by Hazelden. The letter also included a request for assistance in developing an NA presence in Rochester, New York, where a Friday night meeting had already begun in the basement of a Universalist Church on South Clinton Avenue as early as August In November, with nine of eleven groups present, Jim F. reminded attendees that all major changes required a 30-day notice, and that the book modifications discussed the month before were therefore premature. Each group was issued twelve books, and the Public Relations (PR) and Literature Committees were formally split into two independent arms. Meanwhile, Harry P. of Malvern sought support for a Wednesday night meeting at Christina House.

In late 1974, Eileen was in the Intergroup. Members once started fighting between the two of them and started throwing anything, including books and chairs. She was in the middle and got a chair thrown at her because she tried to try to stop the fight. That kind of stuff doesn't really go on any more but that was pretty common back then. There was a lot of fighting and yelling, and there were a lot of control issues. And people took control of, or hostage of, our integration.

As the year closed in December, the tone at the final Intergroup meeting reflected both progress and introspection. Ray and Tony R. raised the need to reexamine meetings through the lens of the Traditions, and the suggestion was warmly received. Jerry encouraged members to take personal responsibility for the quality of their meetings. Jim D. cautioned against expanding too quickly, favoring quality over quantity, while Jim S. promoted cross-fellowship involvement. John C. emphasized the significance of a strong home group.

Feedback on all these matters was to be taken back to the groups.

To bring the fellowship together in celebration, a New Year's Eve dance was Organized at 13th & Ruscomb, with tickets set at $5.00 and festivities planned from eight in the evening until one in the morning-capping off a pivotal year of development, debate, and dedication within Pennsylvania's Narcotics Anonymous Intergroup.

1975 - A Fellowship Taking Root

As 1975 dawned, the spirit of NA in the Philadelphia region pulsed with urgency and conviction. The fellowship was young but rapidly growing, and with that growth came questions-some administrative, others philosophical-that would define the culture and character of NA in the years to follow.

At the year's outset, the Intergroup found itself grappling with ethical nuances that would become emblematic of early NA's tension between practicality and principle. A spirited conversation unfolded over whether 50/50 raffle tickets-used to raise modest funds-ought to be sold only within the fellowship or extended to outsiders. The matter was put to careful thought, and consensus emerged: NA would keep its fundraising efforts within the fellowship. This commitment to internal integrity, though modest in scope, marked a deeper commitment to maintaining NA's identity on its own terms. Simultaneously, a deeper sense of self-definition was underway. Jerry S. and Maria R., active and creative members, began work on a poster bearing the phrase "I Am Responsible", part of a broader push to instill ownership and identity within the recovering community. Even small administrative details mattered. Jerry carefully corrected the address printed on meeting lists—a simple gesture

reflecting the seriousness with which members handled the communication of essential information. By early February, with representation from fourteen meetings, the Intergroup's agenda began to expand. Conversations turned to literature approval, the shaping of fundraising practices, and even the possibility of NA establishing its own clubhouse-a suggestion ultimately dismissed as beyond the fellowship's scope. Meanwhile, the ethical question surrounding raffles deepened. External opinions were sought from New York and California, New York's firm opposition, grounded in their own experience, carried significant weight. Eventually, unanimity was achieved: NA would discontinue the use of raffles for general fundraising, though they would remain permitted for social events, preserving a sense of celebration without compromising principles. As winter turned to spring, the group returned to the unresolved issue of raffles. More input arrived—this time, from AA sources suggesting that such decisions belonged to the discretion of individual groups. With that, the Intergroup agreed to pause all 50/50 activities until clarity could be reached. In the same spirit of respect for autonomy, it was affirmed that policies regarding open or closed meetings should likewise be left to each group's judgment.

That April, as the number of represented meetings rose to sixteen, the fellowship grew more confident in its ability to generate its own materials. Still, NA's independence was not yet complete. Concerns emerged over the rising frequency of AA speakers at NA meetings. Frank P., with firm conviction, encouraged members to speak from their own experience and reaffirmed the value of NA's distinct voice. He also compiled and distributed a list of 28 detox centers to assist members and newcomers alike—a quiet act of service that would echo for years to come.

As May arrived, attention turned to logistics. A proposal surfaced to install a dedicated NA phone line, a simple but vital step toward professionalizing communication. The group chose to pursue a business line, funding it through the treasury. A follow-up meeting was scheduled at the local YMCA to ensure proper implementation. The steps may have been small, but they pointed toward a larger aspiration: a fellowship that was responsive, accessible, and unified.

By early summer, structural questions again took center stage. Discussion emerged about the nature and purpose of meetings. Jim H. reminded the group that NA's focus must remain sobriety, not therapy. Meetings, he emphasized were sacred spaces for shared experience, not clinical analysis. Ray T. further encouraged a revival of the 12-Step program in its original spirit, highlighting the importance of direct, personal outreach over passive reliance on answering services. A physical log of incoming calls was established, and with it, a culture of accountability. Meanwhile, the Southampton group quietly split in two, reflecting both growth and a healthy divergence of paths.

Midway through July, a new set of questions arose-some philosophical, others organizational. A group known as Addicts Anonymous appeared in the region, prompting curiosity about whether their mission aligned with NA's. Harry P. was tasked with making contact and exploring possible connections. Meanwhile, the business phone line was confirmed, and Jerry volunteered to handle literature requests via mail. Oaklane began holding a Tradition meeting in the final week of each month, and a Friday night bulletin was introduced.

By August, access logistics arose for a Navy Yard meeting, where entry might soon require special passes. Still, inclusion remained a priority-women would not be excluded.

September's gathering revealed continued silence from California, prompting Brian T. to consider calling the NA co-founder directly. Meanwhile, the Southampton group voiced discomfort with what they saw as a growing reliance On rehabs as an easy solution. Within NA, recovery had to be hard-won. Language was debated again: Mary proposed replacing the term "recovered" with "recovering," a subtle shift acknowledging that the process of healing was never truly complete. In October and November of 1975, another significant move took place. The NA WSO was once again relocated-this time back to Jimmy K.'s home. However, this return was not without consequence. Signs of administrative collapse became evident: boxes of unprocessed literature orders piled up, opened envelopes with missing checks were discovered, and important historical records had been lost. Even more troubling was the erosion of confidence among some members of the fellowship, as the chaos began to strain the growing trust that had

been carefully built over the years. Jimmy, committed to ensuring that literature remained accessible to members, operated the office not only from his house but also from his truck, where he stored literature for quick distribution. In October's Intergroup it was agreed that Intergroup positions would not he held for consecutive terms, and that new delegates would be introduced in December, taking office in January. A new Nar-Anon meeting was also launched, offering support to families impacted by addiction. In November, further word arrived from California-another vague and unsteady letter, clouded by their ongoing move back to Sun Valley. A letter from Sylvia, however, brought sharp clarity. With thirteen years of sobriety behind her, she wrote decisively against the use of money raffles, stating she had never known them to have a place in recovery fellowship. The debate ended. Raffles would not return.

As the year ended, December's meeting in Collegeville brought calm and reflection. Another uncertain letter from California was received, and with it, the decision to suspend further correspondence until firmer ground could be found. On a more symbolic note, the group agreed to refer to its leader as chairperson rather than chairman, embracing a more inclusive language. Vincetta and Bill B. also reached out to the local congregation, continuing the slow but steady work of community engagement.

The year ended with NA in Philadelphia standing stronger, more united, and more clearly defined than ever before. Through countless debates and decisions, a fellowship was forging its identity-not by imitation, but by thoughtful discernment and shared responsibility. These were the roots of something lasting.

1976 - Branches and Roots

As winter 1975 settled into 1976, the Intergroup meeting gathered at 13th & Ruscomb with representatives from several established groups—South Philly, Logan, Southampton, Oaklane, Lansdale, Doylestown, Norristown, and Northeast. A few groups, including Mount Penn, Manayunk, Levittown, and Collegeville, were notably absent, though the energy in the room was far from diminished

Elections that day brought new leadership: Terri B. was chosen as Chairperson, with Tom R. as Secretary and Ken S. as Co-Secretary. Harry P. assumed the role of Treasurer, Bill A. led Literature Committee, Frank P. stepped in for PR and Brian T. took the helm of Steering. These appointments, more than mere formalities, represented a generational shift in service, one that emphasized shared commitment and continuity. A by-laws amendment followed, clarifying that any replacements for outgoing delegates or alternates would fulfill the remainder of their predecessors' terms—a small structural adjustment that reinforced stability.

The expansion of NA groups was happening at a steady clip, but some questioned whether it was too much, too fast. Groups newly welcomed into Intergroup were not always following through with participation. Voices urged caution, warning that rapid growth without depth could weaken unity. In response, a suggestion emerged to include Nar-Anon meetings on the official NA meeting list, a gesture of solidarity and family support. Doylestown would host these parallel meetings.

In addition to service roles and structure, the conversation turned toward prisons. Terri B. raised the issue of prison commitments—a need often quietly acknowledged but rarely addressed. Though traditionally handled at the group level, there was early discussion of forming a central committee. Meanwhile, the Literature Committee pushed forward with a project close to its heart: a version of the Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions tailored for NA's voice and needs.

Work was slow but steady, and each meeting brought it closer to completion. A month later, the Intergroup reconvened in Collegeville. Some familiar names were absent—Levittown had quietly folded, and 13th & Ruscomb, the host just weeks before, did not attend. Yet representation remained strong across South Philly, Logan, Southampton, Oaklane, Lansdale, Doylestown, Norristown, and Northeast, now joined by Mount Penn, Manayunk, and Collegeville. The Secretary seat required reassignment after Tom R. was no longer able to serve. Pat P. was elected in his place. Meanwhile, Bill A. noted that two trusted members were en route to California, hoping to reestablish more consistent communication with NA's West Coast leadership. Local challenges remained, though. The Tuesday night meeting at 13th & Ruscomb was floundering, in part because of delegates struggling to uphold their commitments. The meeting

would not last the year. Bill A. voiced what many were beginning to feel: the fellowship's rapid expansion risked outpacing its roots. Reinforcing group commitment was no longer just an ideal-it was a necessity. By March, the Intergroup had returned to 13th & Ruscomb. While some groups like Logan and South Philly had now dropped off, others remained consistent-Southampton, Oaklane, Lansdale, Doylestown, Northeast, Mount Penn, Manayunk, and Collegeville. Norristown had undergone a symbolic transformation, adopting a new name: "Sobriety First." A new group, "Primary Purpose," also entered the fold. Leadership elections continued, placing Harry P. as PR Chair and Neil M. on Steering. Small but meaningful administrative decisions followed: the group agreed to stop using its previous stamp, and Bill A. was entrusted to bring a set of minutes with him to California—a signal of the East's willingness to collaborate across the country.

In a letter dated March 6, 1976, Jimmy wrote to Sylvia, emphasizing the importance of centralized communication: "No NA mail should go anywhere but Box 622… this was the cause of much confusion before." Order was beginning to replace chaos.

April brought a new wave of growth. Wyoming and Dunmore groups were officially welcomed into Intergroup, swelling the roster to include nearly a dozen meetings.

June found the fellowship gathered at St. James Episcopal Church in Collegeville, a space that offered both sanctuary and seriousness. Groups from across the region continued to attend, from Southampton and Lansdale to Sobriety First, Wyoming, and Dunmore. In that same meeting, Dunmore, Wyoming, and Taylor-Gibson were officially assigned to the Northeastern Region. The Intergroup also made a difficult but necessary decision: if any group continued to disregard the traditions, they would be removed from the meeting list. The moment marked a shift toward accountability. Discussions also resumed around practical tools for unity-sobriety chips were considered for distribution when funds allowed. And in a move signaling a shift in tone, the once-controversial 50/50 raffles were reapproved-this time to fund meeting list printing, left to each group's discretion.

By the end of 1976, Philadelphia's Intergroup had established itself as a central force in shaping NA's direction. What started as scattered meetings with borrowed AA materials developed into a coordinated effort to print, distribute, and safeguard NA's own literature. Debates over language, format, and governance reflected a fellowship steadily moving toward maturity and autonomy, while starter kits, booklets, and slogans carried its message beyond city limits. Through these efforts, Pennsylvania NA laid down practical structures and practices that not only sustained local groups but also contributed to the foundation of a wider, distinctly NA identity.

During the year 1976, The N.A. Tree was presented to the fellowship service committees.

Planting the Tree

By mid-1975, Narcotics Anonymous stood on the threshold of transformation. Its grassroots fellowship had begun to evolve beyond local meetings and scattered literature into something more unified—a structure capable of supporting a growing international community of addicts seeking recovery. This shift was catalyzed in part by two key contributors: Jimmy K. and Greg P.

In June 1975, Jimmy and Greg finalized and published The N.A. Tree, a foundational service manual that outlined the structure, purpose, and spiritual integrity of NA's service bodies. It was a bold and visionary document, giving form to the budding NA service structure and offering a blueprint for the Organization's future. Though quietly introduced, The N.A. Tree would become central to NA literature by early 1976, when it was formally adopted.

On the east coast, in 1976, the Narcotics Anonymous fellowship in the Philadelphia area also was ready for transformation. What had begun just a few years prior as a cluster of struggling groups-held together by shared pain, recovery ,

and spiritual urgency—had grown exponentially. The enthusiasm that drove this growth was undeniable, yet it brought new challenges. The once intimate network of meetings was now sprawling, with administrative needs outpacing available resources, and with no central guidance to knit the pieces together. More critically, the Philadelphia fellowship felt disconnected from what many considered NA's birthplace-California. The West Coast had seen the first stirrings of NA in the 1950s, and over the years, its members had begun to develop literature, organize service bodies, and define practices that were slowly becoming the foundation of the fellowship. But by 1976, communication between the coasts had faltered. Letters often went unanswered. Guidance was limited. The East Coast was growing, but growing in the dark. Local members had begun writing their own literature and organizing independently through what they called the Intergroup, an early service body composed of elected representatives from different meetings. But uncertainty loomed. Were their efforts aligned with NA as a whole? Did their innovations need authorization from California? And most pressingly, were they truly part of something bigger-or were they alone?

These weren't just administrative concerns. They were spiritual questions. And in that uncertainty, the Philadelphia Intergroup decided it was time to seek clarity-not through letters, but through personal contact.

That spring, two trusted members, Bill A. and Kathy H., stepped forward. Bill had been maintaining a steady if unreciprocated correspondence with California, and Kathy brought the time, willingness, and conviction needed for such a task. Without any official sanction beyond the faith of their peers, they boarded a plane and flew west—carrying not only a notebook of questions but the collective hope of the East Coast fellowship.

Their arrival in California marked more than just a geographical crossing. It was a meeting of worlds. There, they were welcomed by Jimmy K., one of the founding figures of Narcotics Anonymous and a deeply respected voice in its spiritual and organizational development. Bill and Kathy were immersed in the life of the California fellowship. Jimmy opened his home to them, personally escorted them to meetings across Los Angeles, and shared stories, wisdom, and, most importantly, an inclusive vision.

It was a moment of recognition two growing branches of the same tree, finally acknowledging each other. Though Bill missed the San Luis Obispo gathering of experienced California members, he collected a treasure trove of experience, guidance, and documents. Upon returning to Philadelphia, he delivered a detailed and enthusiastic report to the Intergroup. Even more significantly, he brought back something tangible: The N.A. Tree. The N.A. Tree was unlike anything the East Coast had seen before. It was a manifesto of structure, clarity, and spiritual unity. In its pages, it laid out a model for organizing Narcotics Anonymous at every level—from individual groups to regions and beyond. It didn't impose; it suggested. But those suggestions were grounded in experience, fellowship, and service. To many in Philadelphia, The N.A. Tree arrived like a bolt of revelation. The Intergroup was already straining. Meetings were overcrowded and often chaotic. Group delegates—who had little clarity on their roles—struggled to navigate decisions. There was no consistent language for service positions. No framework for accountability. The Tree offered answers.

As Dave F. later reflected, "Now we're getting word that there is a California Fellowship of NA, and they were the 'Central Office.' They were the 'Home Office.' And that's when they had published The N.A. Tree, which was the news."

Momentum carried into May, as the Intergroup met again at 13th & Ruscomb. Harry P. introduced The N.A. Tree, a proposed framework for better organization. His call for structure was received warmly, and the decision was made to hold a separate meeting to explore its implementation. The sense was clear: NA was outgrowing its ad-hoc roots, and something more durable was required.

Inspired by The N.A. Tree, a formal Tree Committee was established. On June 6, 1976, the Intergroup held a pivotal presentation to introduce the document.

Members listened attentively as the committee walked through its key principles.

Among them: the restructuring of the service body from an Intergroup to an ASC, clearer role definitions, and a regional structure that could handle growth more effectively.

The fellowship voted to study the proposal more deeply. Jim H. was elected as committee chair, and in a powerful symbolic act of alignment, a list of all local group secretaries was sent to California.

The N.A. Tree was no longer just a concept. It was becoming a living blueprint for the East Coast.

On July 11, 1976, the new ASC met at a modest twin home located at 1716 Loney Street, a house in a quiet Philadelphia neighborhood. Groups from Logan, Manayunk, Southampton, Primary Purpose, Doylestown, and Mount Penn were present, alongside representatives from the Northeastern Region.

Brian T. was elected Chairperson of the restructuring committee, with Stan B., Ron B., and Rich filling co-leadership and secretary roles. The energy in the room was transformative. Decisions were made quickly. One of the first was to discontinue the toll-free phone line, considered an expense that could no longer be justified. An acknowledgment that communication systems would need to be reimagined in light of a growing, more complex fellowship.

Most critically, the Tree Committee delivered a sweeping report containing 43 structural recommendations inspired by the California model. A trio of trusted servants-Jim H., Ron B., and Bill A.—volunteered to attend meetings across the region to help clarify the committee's work. Another meeting at Loney Street was scheduled on July 25 to determine group alignments, make necessary elections, and address the fate of the treasury. Among the most significant changes were:

The dissolution of the Intergroup. In its place, the formation of three ASCs, divided by geography:

Philadelphia & Bucks County Montgomery County & Mount Penn Scranton/Northeastern Region New service roles at the group level:

The Secretary, not Chair, would now be the principal servant-leader of each meeting-responsible for setup, literature, coffee, and overall meeting management.

The Treasurer would manage all finances and logistics.

Each group would elect a GSR and Alternate GSR, both with clean time requirements and strict attendance expectations.

The establishment of monthly ASC meetings and quarterly Regional Service Committee (RSC) gatherings, to handle coordination, institutional outreach, literature production, and events.

Introduction of a General Service Delegate (GSD) to represent the region at the WSC, with a clearly defined two-year term, election process, and service requirements.

The Philadelphia region was becoming more than a collection of meetings. It was becoming a regional body, with functional unity and spiritual alignment. But the transformation wasn't without struggle. Not everyone welcomed California's influence. For some, it felt like an imposition—an outside body telling them how to do what they had built on their own. The cultural differences between East and West were real. Dave F. vividly remembered the divide: "This is really where you start to see a dichotomy between old-timers and the new California style. Some people just didn't take to it. I remember that Jim H. did his presentation. Then we opened it up, and I was the first one on my feet. I said, 'Fuck* California!' That was my response." Yet over time, even skeptics came to see the wisdom in the structure. It wasn't about control-it was about unity. The Tree was not about doing it "California's way." It was about doing it together. It offered not a rigid hierarchy, but a framework for cooperation-one rooted in service, humility, and the Twelve Traditions.

On July 11, the Northern Area Service held a meeting at Divine Providence Hospital in Williamsport, reflecting increasing coordination in central and northern Pennsylvania.

On July 25, 1976, the Philadelphia Intergroup convened for the last time. The era of improvisation had ended. From that point forward, each ASC would meet monthly. The RSC would gather quarterly, starting in January 1977. The

meeting list would be updated one last time, and new corrections would be processed only annually. Guidelines were drafted, bylaws amended, and service positions filled. A new language of leadership took hold—one that emphasized spiritual responsibility over authority, and group conscience over personal opinion. The closing statement from the Tree Committee captured the essence of what was unfolding:

The purpose is to promote greater unity in NA, and this must start with a greater awareness of responsibility—beginning with the members and working upward.

In August, the Philadelphia-Bucks ASC held its first official meeting, also at Loney Street. The structure became more defined: Brian T. remained Chairperson, with Mickey as Co-Chair and Ron B. continuing as Secretary. Rich took on Treasurer duties, while Jim H. led PR and Bill A. oversaw the Literature Committee. A new mailing address was established at Loney Street, and a rubber stamp bearing the address was approved for literature. It was also decided that one individual could hold multiple service positions, so long as they did not conflict. A new answering service was adopted, funded by raffles at the area level-a compromise that balanced principle with sustainability.

By early September, members traveled to Williamsport, gathering at the 801 Club for a regional Intergroup meeting. Stan B., hailing from West Pittston, arrived with something that would shift the course of NA's development in the region: a copy of The N.A. Tree. For many attendees, it was the first real introduction to the fellowship's evolving national service structure. Though still early in its dissemination, the Tree offered a compelling vision-an interconnected, accountable, and principled system that could guide NA through the next phase of its existence.

In just a few months, the Philadelphia fellowship had gone from questioning Its identity to stepping confidently into a connected future. Through service, structure, and spiritual purpose, it had begun to find its place-not just a new structure-but a deeper sense of belonging.

Eventually, even language began to change. Minutes from a July 1976 meet. ing in Philadelphia were labeled "NA Area Service Committee" -marking a shift from Intergroup toward alignment with the Tree structure. That transition wasn't quick or easy. Members like Jim H. and Ron B. met in a duplex on Loney Street to hash out 43 specific changes suggested by California. "That was when we stopped copying AA," Jim H. explained. They even pushed to drop the label "Intergroup Approved."

The fellowship had spent the year defining, refining, and-most importantly-growing. From minute stamps to public radio spots, from folding groups to new regional delegates, every motion and decision represented a step away from improvisation and toward intention. What had begun as a fragile thread of meetings across Pennsylvania was now becoming something broader, deeper, and more enduring: a living tree, roots planted, branches spreading.

BEING OF SERVICE



Before service had titles or guidelines in Narcotics Anonymous, it was simply what members did. It wasn't a role-it was a lifeline. A couch was a detox bed. A pot of coffee was a symbol of welcome. Cleaning ashtrays or making a late-night drive to pick up someone slipping back into addiction was just part of life. Members gave what they could, how they could, because they understood that recovery wasn't something one did alone.

Dutch - I can tell you this: the first ten people ever to achieve sobriety on the East Coast were recorded on tape. Those tapes were placed in a safety deposit box, and the person responsible swore they would never be released. Furthermore, the first ten GSRs in the Philly region are still clean. So, that tells you something about service.

One Addict Helping Another

Noel F. recalled her couch being constantly occupied by addicts trying to get clean. "Father Frank's first day was on my couch," she said. "That was just routine." In a time when rehabs were scarce or inaccessible, couches like Noel's were the closest thing to treatment centers.

Jeff S. remembered a man who had relapsed in Philadelphia and called home for help. "They didn't hesitate," Jeff said, describing how two friends immediately made the drive to retrieve him. "That's what really intrigued me—how addicts sincerely wanted to carry the message." Many who relocated from places like Philadelphia to Williamsport continued that tradition, putting newcomers on their couches.

Service extended to the little things. Sharon B. remembered volunteering to clean ashtrays at meetings. "I figured I could do that without burning the place down," she joked. She also spoke at high schools for public outreach. Others Opened meetings where none had ever been, often showing up alone to dark basements or half-lit classrooms, clinging to hope that someone else would come.

The spirit of service was everywhere. People carpooled to meetings across counties-drives to Pottstown or down the shore to see Barbara Blaze were common. "We just felt like we were on a mission," Alice C. said. "When they told us we weren't welcome at AA, we started our own meetings." Even when only two or three people showed up, they kept the lights on and the doors open. As NA began to grow, this spontaneous service culture began to evolve, Members were learning that love and willingness weren't always enough. Structure—though controversial-began to emerge. The introduction of The N.A. Tree created roles and service bodies. While some saw this as a natural step forward, others feared it might sanitize the deeply personal nature of early service. Dwayne S. remembered rotating through multiple service roles at the Church on the Mall and later in Eagleville. "During a year, you could be the treasurer, the secretary, the literature person. That's just how it worked." There was no emphasis on the home group. "We went wherever there was a meeting and got involved."

The deeper question-where were their priorities?-became part of a larger cultural tension. Denny S. remembered people saying their one vote didn't matter. But a few believed otherwise: that talents shouldn't be wasted for lack of resources. "Do you support your GSR?" became a vital question of financial and spiritual accountability.

For Bob P., the lack of early structure had its own kind of freedom. "There was no policy. We told our story and we left," he said of early Hospitals & Institutions (H&I) meetings. But he also saw the cracks in such informality. "They were just as confused and flaky as we were," John F. added, "but over time, we became a little more grounded."

Despite occasional disorganization, service efforts began to multiply. Institutions were visited. Literature was printed and distributed. Hotlines were run out of people's homes. Every meeting list folded, envelope stuffed, or commitment kept added to a snowball of progress. Mary Mc. recalled one prison trip where the facility went into lockdown. "We all had to go against the wall. It was crazy, she laughed. "But that was just service back then."

As NA matured, so did its challenges. Some pioneers noticed a drop in urgency.

More members, yes-but fewer cleaning ashtrays, fewer rushing to newcomers’

aid. Jeff described an impromptu H&I meeting where Steve T. asked if he'd share at a rehab the next week. "I work here," Jeff said. "All the more reason," Steve replied.

Service, though, still inspired connection. George R. remembered people traveling from Boston and West Virginia to see how Philly was doing it. "We started to grow a little bit," he said. Al R. noted how connections from Washington DC to Connecticut became common. "We'd drive to Baltimore on a Saturday. It wasn't out of the ordinary."

AJ described running a meeting by himself for five and a half months—then driving almost an hour to attend others. "That's how I found more people." he said. "We had meeting lists, but they were junk-typed, copied, handwritten notes. We needed to look more mature if we were going to be taken seriously."

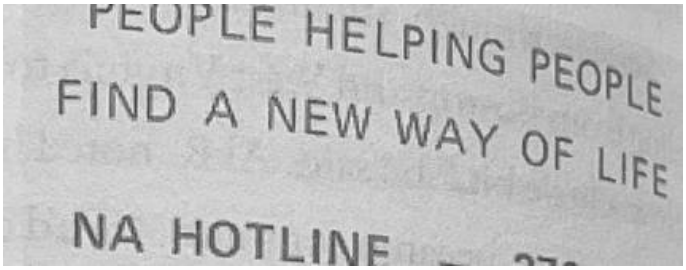
Even sponsorship and step work took time to develop. Dutch H. remembered early step meetings devolving into shouting matches. "The guy who yelled the loudest was right," he said. Most members had AA sponsors, and often worked steps as groups, not one-on-one.

Yet progress happened. Noel recalled working the steps with someone from Chit Chat Farms. "People say we didn't do steps—but we did. Sponsorship was mixed too, not gendered like today. We learned from each other."

What started as people "hanging onto each other for dear life," as Al R. put it, became a global structure rooted in unity and shared purpose. Jim D. captured the spirit that still anchors NA: "You got to work the steps, and you got to do Service."

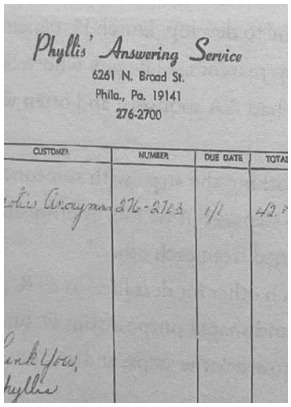
Regional coordination was also expanding. An "N.A. NEWs" issue from Northeastern Pennsylvania, dated April-May 1981 (Volume I, Issue III), announced the next Regional Literature Committee meeting for May 31 in Williamsport. Mailing addresses for various service committees across the state were included, further strengthening a web of contact and communication.

The Hotlines



In the earliest days of NA in Philadelphia, long before mobile phones, digital infrastructure, or social media, a grassroots need emerged: communication. The fledgling groups realized that to truly offer help, they needed to be reachable—at all hours, in all circumstances.

As a group they decided to have a hotline. They got the money together, whether it was with the 50-50s or whatever, to get an answering service. Thus, was born Philadelphia's first NA hotline.



The first Hotline was started at Phyllis's answering service located at 6261 North Broad Street and Medary Ave., near Park Ave. in Philadelphia. The phone number was (215) 276-2703. All the calls went into the answering service 24/7. The service had a list of members who they could contact about the calls. The first people on the list were Brian T. and Ray T. They would get 12-step calls in the middle of the night. The calls would always be answered.

This wasn't a polished operation with call centers or scripts. It was a phone call routed straight into the home of Ray T., a member whose relative stability made him the obvious choice. He had what many in the program then did not—a steady job, a home, a car, and a supportive family.

Brian T. had a beeper, adding a layer of responsiveness to a system that, while analog, was deeply committed. When that phone rang, someone picked it up—not a professional, but a recovering addict who understood the desperation on the other end.

The very first 12-step call from that hotline came for Ronnie M. They found him at Mount Sinai Hospital, at 5th and Reed in South Philadelphia, crawling under a table, seemingly lost to the world. But when he heard that the people who had come for him were addicts-like him-he stopped, sat upright at the table, and gave them his full attention. Just like that, the message connected. Roy P. recalls going into the ward there. The system evolved. Calls were routed by region—Philly calls to Philly members, Norristown calls to Norristown members. Whoever picked up was expected to act. The service may have become more efficient, but the principle remained unchanged: addicts helping addicts, one call at a time. Dutch was living at a home at the intersection of Frankford Avenue and Belgrade Street, amidst pots, pans, and well-worn decks of cards, that the voice of NA in Philadelphia found its home. The kitchen became a headquarters of sorts. Addicts who were unemployed or considered unemployable found purpose manning the line and playing spades and pinochle between calls.

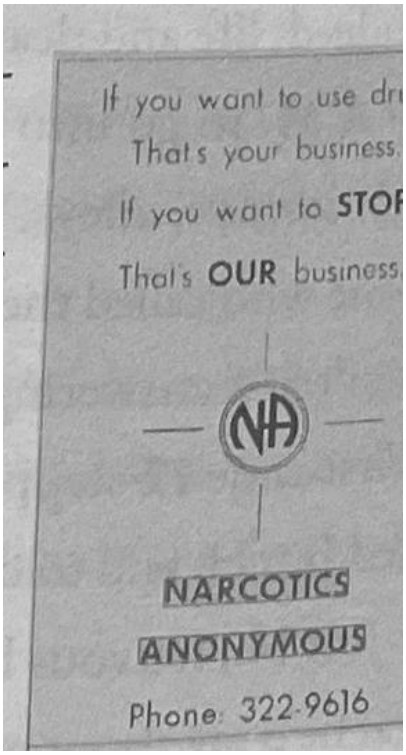
Stories from those days abound. Dutch remembers one in particular—Jimmy C. He could light up a room, command a meeting, make everyone laugh until it hurt. But he used the fast drug, the kind that made your brain race and your body follow. One day, the hotline rang-it was the police. Jimmy had recently jumped out a three-story window, his leg was in a cast, and he got picked up by the cops. They found the NA hotline number in his pocket. When the NA members got to the precinct, it was too late. "You're too late," the officer said. "We just cut him down." Jimmy had hung himself ten minutes before they arrived. "Learned from an early time in my recovery," Dutch reflected, "that this is life and death."

Indeed, life and death were not hyperbole. Many members regularly got up at 2:00 A.M. to go into dangerous neighborhoods, answering cries for help from street corners, alleys, and stairwells. Maureen recalled how they'd descend on anyone who called the line wanting to stop using. "They loved it," she said. They weren't just answering phones-they were offering lifelines.

First-time 12-steppers were thrown straight into action. One Saturday, Mike S.

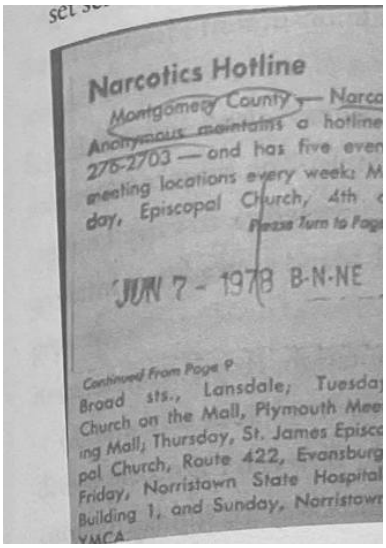
called Jim H. and told him to drive to Penndel in Bucks County to pick someone up. Jim H., nervous but willing, brought along the AA Big Book and rehearsed what he'd say about recovery. But when the guy got in the car—high on speed—he

talked nonstop from pick-up to drop-off. Jim H. never got a word in. Still, he did what was asked. He showed up. That was enough. Jim F. recalls a buddy of his, a guy named Frank P. called the hotline. They wanted to make sure that there wasn't something there that they didn't know about. They were told Narcotics Anonymous was at 10th and the Boulevard. Maureen described how they would eagerly respond to calls from struggling addicts. "We would love it if we got a call. We'd descend on that poor person." she said, laughing, but entirely serious about their passion for 12-stepping. A public service announcement (PSA) was developed and broadcast widely: If you do drugs, that's your business. If you want to quit, that's our business. NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS 24-hour HOTLINE (215) 276-2703. We are not interested in what or how much you used, who your connections were, or what you've done. We only care about what you want to do about your problem—and how we can help. Momentum continued to build. On June 7, 1978, Montgomery County newspapers announced NA's hotline number-276-2703-and listed five weekly meetings, from Lansdale to Norristown. That hotline became much more than a number. It was a lifeline, a bridge, a voice in the dark. It connected people not just to meetings, but to possibility—to hope.



In March 1973, an NA hotline was posted in the “Spotlight” section of the Williamsport Area Community College (WACC). In 1975, the county jail warden in Middleburg called the NA hotline in Sunbury to request a 12-step call on a young inmate who according to the warden, “I don’t think he belongs here.” Two recovering addicts answered to the request, which amazed them because it was rare for a prison warden to contact NA for help with an inmate.

In late 1977 NA in the Scranton/Wilkes-Barre area announced a 24-hour telephone answering service, (717) 344-9527, manned by group members on a set schedule.


Narcotics Hotline

Montgomery County — Narco

Anonymous maintains a hotline

276-2703 — and has five even

meeting locations every week: M

day, Episcopal Church, 4th

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JUN 7 - 1978 B-N-NE

Continued From Page 9

Broad sts., Lansdale; Tuesda

Church on the Mall, Plymouth Mee

ing Mall; Thursday, St. James Episc

pal Church, Route 422, Evansburg

Friday, Norristown State Hospital

Building 1, and Sunday, Norristow

YMCA

Momentum continued to build. On Narcotics Hotline June 7, 1978, Montgomery County newspaper announced NA's hotline number-276-2703-and listed five weekly meetings, from Lansdale to Norristown.

On December 10, 1978, after years of ef- JUN 7 - 1978 B-N-NE fort and research, Williamsport launched its ong-awaited hotline. It marked the culmination of years of phone service discussion, first proposed in 1977. The service finally came to life-fully member-operated, fully NA.

Henry D. recalled how quickly he became involved: "I remember standing outside Reality Group when a girl ranted about the helpline being terrible. I called it—and she was right. I told my sponsor, and he said, 'Well, maybe you should get involved,' Four months later, I was the helpline chair." With only nine months clean, he took charge of the helpline: "All I knew how to do was pick up the phone, call people from around the area, find people's numbers. So, I took it upon myself. No one told me. I just took charge."

Behind The Walls

Between 1970 and 1982, a quiet revolution unfolded behind locked doors, clinic walls, and prison gates across Pennsylvania and surrounding regions. This chapter traces the birth and rapid expansion of Narcotics Anonymous' H&I service-from the experimental early days at White Deer Run and Today, Inc., through the first known jail and hospital meetings, to the emergence of a broad and enduring institutional outreach network.

Driven by raw willingness, personal transformation, and spiritual urgency, NA members began carrying their message into psychiatric hospitals, youth facilities ,

detox units, and penitentiaries. What began as informal conversations and renegade commitments matured into a cornerstone tradition of NA service.

Locations like Muncy State Prison, Horsham Hospital, Rockview Penitentiary, Clearbrook Lodge, and the Coatesville Veterans Administration Hospital became unlikely but crucial homes for recovery.

This period captures a time when structure lagged behind spirit-but it didn't matter. The meetings were small. The tools were simple. The volunteers were untrained. But the message was clear: we recover, and we return to carry hope. This is the story of how NA stepped across thresholds-and how addicts inside began to walk out changed.

At Byberry State Hospital, known for its grim reputation, Roy P. contacted "Byberry Bob," a man long associated with the facility. Roy's idea was simple: start a Narcotics Anonymous meeting. Bob panicked. "You can't do that over here!" he exclaimed. But despite the initial fear, NA found a way in. Sunday night meetings were born, attended by a mix of patients-some addicts, others not. In those early days, what mattered most was simply finding a space.

On November 22, 1970, a story broke in the Philadelphia Inquirer that would echo through the recovery world. Father Daniel Egan, known nationally as "The Junkie Priest," was in town. Egan, a Catholic priest with a gift for storytelling and a steel resolve, had written a bestselling memoir chronicling his years running Village Haven, a New York rehabilitation center for women. That fall, he had come to Philadelphia to testify in favor of a proposed teen rehab center known as The Bridge.

At the zoning hearing, Egan's wit was on full display. "It'll be easier to get into Heaven," he quipped, "than it will be to get into The Bridge." His presence made an impact. When The Bridge finally opened in 1971, on Pine Road in the Fox Chase section of Philadelphia, it became one of the few residential programs in the area focused specifically on teenagers. Among its earliest residents was Tom C., court-mandated into treatment. It was there that Tom first encountered the Twelve Steps and met figures who would later shape the regional NA story: Kenny E., Frank P., Jimmy F. Though not an NA-run facility, The Bridge played a crucial role in what would come. It bridged

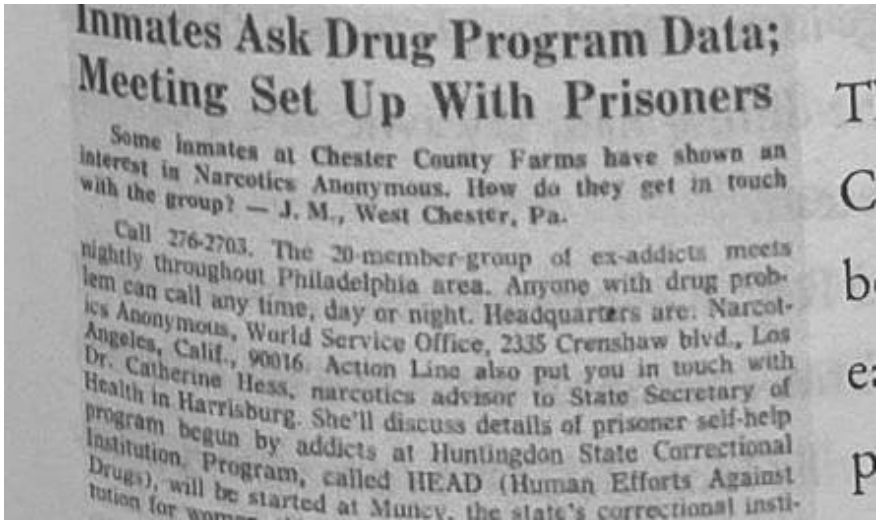
more than services-it bridged generations, linking young addicts to the first flickers of a growing recovery movement. On March 1, 1971, another experiment took root, this time in Langhorne, Bucks County. Today, Inc. opened its doors with a focused mission: help adolescents facing addiction by embracing a therapeutic community model. Dutch S. and Ardell S., both of whom had recently left Eagleville, joined the staff. There they met Kathy H., whose mother, an AA member, became a quiet but meaningful bridge between fellowships. The connections formed at Today, Inc. would go on to ripple through the region, helping to lay the groundwork for an NA presence that reflected youth culture, lived experience, and a fierce commitment to recovery.

Meanwhile, outreach efforts expanded. Members from Intergroup visited detox units and hospitals, building bridges to institutions that would later become major partners in carrying the message. The first detox commitment in Pottstown was initiated, and discussions were held with Pennsylvania General Hospital.

Chester County Farms

In early 1973, as NA slowly gained ground in Pennsylvania's towns and cities, a few brave members began extending the message into places where hope was in shorter supply. In March of that year, the NA group in Norristown spearheaded a bold effort: taking the program behind bars. This marked not only the first H&I commitment in Pennsylvania, but also the first NA prison meeting on the East Coast.

January 9, 1973 - Philadelphia Inquirer:



Inmates Ask Drug Program Data; Meeting Set Up With Prisoners

Some inmates at Chester County Farms have shown an interest in Narcotics Anonymous. How do they get in touch with the group? — J. M., West Chester, Pa.

Call 276-2703. The 20-member-group of ex-addicts meets nightly throughout Philadelphia area. Anyone with drug problem can call any time, day or night. Headquarters are: Narcotics Anonymous, World Service Office, 2335 Crenshaw blvd., Los Angeles, Calif., 90016. Action Line also put you in touch with Dr. Catherine Hess, narcotics advisor to State Secretary of Health in Harrisburg. She'll discuss details of prisoner self-help program begun by addicts at Huntingdon State Correctional Institution. Program, called HEAD (Human Efforts Against Drugs), will be started at Muncy, the state's correctional institution for

The commitment was launched at Chester County Farms Prison, with NA members showing up on the last Saturday of each month. There was no formal approval process at the outset. Members simply walked in and carried the message. Among the original participants were Roy, who played a central organizing role, Brian,

and Jimmy B. They were joined, crucially, by Joe M., a prison guard who may have helped smooth the path with facility staff—an invaluable ally in an otherwise resistant system.

For a few months, the meetings ran smoothly. The facility's hands-off attitude allowed NA to plant its message with a sense of freedom and immediacy that felt radical for its time. But this early momentum would be tested. On one occasion, Roy picked up a man for a 12-step call who had taken drugs before arriving. During the prison meeting, the man became visibly unstable—dancing, singing, and causing a disturbance. The event prompted an immediate lockdown: the sergeant and correctional officers ejected the group, halting their access.

The suspension wasn't permanent, but when NA was eventually allowed back in, the tone had shifted. The facility now imposed clean-time requirements for volunteers, an effort to prevent further incidents and ensure more reliable representation. The shift revealed a hard truth: many recovering addicts lacked the social or emotional maturity to navigate the rigid institutional environment of a prison commitment. What had begun as a hopeful experiment now required more discipline, patience, and structure.

Still, NA's spirit of service endured—even when met with skepticism. At one point, members jokingly suggested to the warden that they should be rewarded for their service with cookies and milk. The warden, unimpressed, asked them not to return. The comment may have been tongue-in-cheek, but it underscored the often-tense dynamic between recovering addicts eager to serve and institutions unsure how to receive them.

While incarcerated at Chester County Farms, Dwayne S. encountered Narcotics Anonymous for the first time. What we now recognize as an H&I panel—a discussion group bringing the NA message into institutions—visited the prison one Saturday morning. On his way to the dining hall, Dwayne unexpectedly found himself sitting in on the meeting instead.

Three men—Dutch H., Brian T., and Ray T.—introduced themselves as members of Narcotics Anonymous. That brief encounter planted a seed. About six months later, after transferring to Eagleville Hospital, Dwayne crossed paths with the same trio again—this time through NA meetings held in the canteen. Their presence and persistence helped guide him further into the program.

Despite the setbacks, the Chester County Farms commitment set a precedent. It introduced the East Coast to a vital thread of NA's identity: carrying the message to those still locked up, physically or otherwise. The lesson was clear—if recovery could make it through prison gates, there was no place too dark for the light of NA to enter.

Locked Detox Wards

Inside institutions where hope often struggled to survive, the NA message began to seep through cracks in the walls. The language of recovery started to appear-sometimes formally, sometimes not. There were locked detox wards for the guys coming back from Vietnam at Walson Army Hospital out at Fort Dix, Saint Luke's Hospital, and the Veterans Administration Hospital in West Philly. They were tough meetings because those guys were dishonorably discharged. Public opinion was treating them like they were pieces of crap. Here these NA guys are coming in like, "Hey guys, there's a way." You could cut the hostility with a knife. A lot of guys were afraid to go into these wards, but did it anyway.

In the uncertain twilight between 1973 and 1974, two young men began a meeting where few others would dare. At Saint Luke's Hospital, located at 8th and Girard in North Philadelphia, Ralph and Roy opened a NA meeting inside the heroin detox unit—a space known unofficially as the Joey Bishop Lounge.

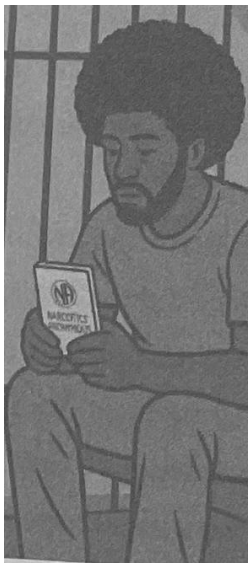
It wasn't an easy room to walk into, and even fewer chose to return. "A lot of guys were scared to go in there," Roy would recall. "It was all Black. The guys who were in there, these were heavy-duty drug addicts.. your average guy was in his late 40s or 50s and had been shooting drugs since before we were born." Ralph and Roy were in their twenties. The men they were trying to reach had already lived decades in the grip of addiction-some were teamsters, longshoremen, not street thugs, but weathered survivors. "They were just there to get their jones down. This was a way to mainstream them back into society... so they wouldn't have to steal and whatnot."

Many newcomers balked at going in. They weren't dope shooters, hadn't lived the same kind of street history, and didn't know what to expect. But Ralph, a

towering presence at 6'5", stood by Roy's side and went in anyway. Their work in that lounge was quiet, gritty, and often unrewarded. But it mattered. This was what carrying the message looked like when there was no road map, only the desire to show up and serve.

Hope Behind Bars

By the spring of 1975, the impulse to carry the message into locked facilities was gathering steam.



At the Northumberland County Jail in Sunbury, Pennsylvania, an institutional meeting was started in mid-March. The jail sat near the banks of the Susquehanna River. Within those walls, NA began reaching out to incarcerated men and women.

Patty M., one of the first volunteers, remembered those days well. "I felt so much gratitude that I had to express it," she said. "And I felt that was the way.

We brought literature in. Sometimes it was a topic meeting, sometimes it was just to get the women talking. Not just let them sit there and listen to us." John S. recalled helping with a Prison Committee and an Intergroup across the Sunbury-Lewisburg-Williamsport region. One debate stood out-whether to fund a trip to Hershey Park or purchase literature for incarcerated addicts. "One member blasted the trip idea," John recalled. And the Intergroup canceled the Outing so we could buy literature. John S. listed a dozen jails and hospitals where he helped carry the message. On June 5, 1976, a new milestone was set. Inside the towering walls of Rockview Penitentiary in Bellefonte, a Saturday afternoon meeting began. It was a difficult and sometimes daunting endeavor, but the meeting endured. One Saturday at a time, the message continued. From Rockview State Penitentiary to Allenwood Federal Prison to numerous county prisons, recovering addicts from northcentral Pennsylvania brought hope into locked spaces.

On February 2, 1978, Muncy State Correctional Institution-one of Pennsylvania's most secure facilities for women—welcomed its first dedicated NA meeting. Held every first and third Thursday, the 8:00 P.M. closed meeting quickly became home for Patty M. "My home group became the Muncy prison group," she said. "And I went to that meeting for about five years."

Other meetings began to quietly emerge. At Chase Penitentiary in Dallas, Pennsylvania, Vince M. and John S. helped start an H&I group around June 1978. Then came September. That month, Broad Meadows Prison in Thornton (later known as DELCO or the George W. Hill Correctional Facility) saw the launch of Friday night meetings for both men and women. Ray T. carried the commitment almost entirely on his own, bringing NA into a place many had forgotten.

On Saturday, September 2, Bucks County Prison for Men in Doylestown welcomed its first 7:00 P.M. meeting. On September 8, White Hill in Camp Hill joined the growing list with a Friday night commitment.

Members were actively taking NA into institutions—Broad Meadows (Men's Unit), Eagleville Hospital, Bucks County Prison—though some efforts, like the women's meeting at Broad Meadows, were faltering because of lack of support.

One of the earliest signs of this expansion came on December 6, 1979. In Harrisburg, at Forest State Correctional Institution—located at 286 Woodland Drive—NA planted its flag. A Thursday night meeting was launched behind prison walls. Though simple in form, it represented a shift: the Harrisburg area was stepping into institutional service with conviction.

The energy carried into the new decade. In September 1980, three new meetings were established in just over a week, all centered in the Harrisburg and Carlisle locales. On Tuesday, September 16, a women's meeting began at Dauphin County Prison, located at 501 Mall Road. The next evening, a men's meeting followed at the same facility. And just seven days later, on September 24, a Thursday night 8:00 P.M. meeting opened at Cumberland County Prison On Claremont Road in Carlisle. These weren't symbolic efforts-they were sustained, grassroots commitments. And together, they marked the emergence of a small but determined H&I movement in Central Pennsylvania.

The Montgomery County Correctional Facility, located in Eagleville, PA, al. lowed addicts to hold meetings in June 1981. In Philadelphia, meanwhile, an. other institutional frontier was opening-or perhaps reopening. Holmesburg Prison, located at 8215 Torresdale Avenue, became a new home for NA H&I work around October. For over a decade, until the prison's closure in 1995. Holmesburg remained a vital NA outpost. Tom C. recalled accompanying a friend who was helping organize the first rounds of meetings there. Joe F. remembered it as part of a much broader push: "We had a commitment down at the Navy Brig. We had some detoxes at Saint Mary's and The Bridge. I remember going into Holmesburg."

Sometime in 1982 two more correctional facilities let NA hold meetings: State Correctional Institution at Graterford, and Norristown Prison, on Erie Street.

Hospitals and Institutions Expands

These committees were often referred to as "Prisons and Institutions" or just the "Prison Committee". It wasn't until much later that the term "Hospitals and Institutions" was formalized, These early institutional meetings were often humble affairs—held in makeshift rooms, filled with uncertainty. Attendance was sometimes sparse, resistance frequent. But the message was consistent: we showed up. NA members carried the White Book, told their stories, and offered presence. As an example, a new institutional meeting began on November 4th at the Today, Inc. inpatient clinic in Langhorne. Before literature was abundant, before H&I guidelines were formalized, this was how the message spread-hand to hand, behind locked doors, one human heart to another. On April 6, 1975, an institutional meeting began at Horsham Hospital, a Psychiatric and detox facility located at 722 East Butler Pike. The NA message had now found its way not just into jails, but into the heart of the medical treatment community. In October 1976, the opening of Indian Hill Lodge marked another key moment. Perched along the Delaware River in Beach Lake, Wayne County, the

Lodge became more than a treatment center—it became a junction. Recovering addicts gathered there, weaving connections between professional care and spiritual recovery, often across fellowships. NA meetings were not held here until years later. In September 1977, Don Landgraff was appointed director of Endless Mountains Treatment Center. Landgraff had previously been a key figure at White Deer Run, along with Dick Flanagan, where many had begun their recovery journeys. His move to lead the new center marked a fresh chapter in rural addiction treatment. Endless Mountains became a refuge, shaped by Landgraff's vision, for those ready to begin again. At the request of Don Landgraff, on a wintery night in December 1979, two members of NA from the Wilkes-Barre area traveled to the Endless Mountain Treatment Center to share their experience, strength, and hope to residents there.

On September 6, 1978, Eagleville Hospital opened an 8:00 P.M. H&I meeting—an event that Roy P. once called "the place where it started."

By the close of the 1970s, the slow-burning momentum of H&I work ignited into a broader movement, What had once been a handful of scattered efforts-rooted in instinct, gratitude, and personal willingness—began to coalesce into a recognizable structure. More NA members were carrying the message into correctional facilities, detox units, psychiatric hospitals, youth institutions, and halfway houses. It wasn't always organized. It wasn't always polished. But it was real, and it was spreading.

On February 21, a new H&I meeting was launched at Eugenia Hospital, a psychiatric facility at 66 Thomas Road in Lafayette Hill, Pennsylvania. Debbie O., a speaker at Eugenia Hospital, recalled a moment of accidental elevation.

"Sharon B. was a patient. She picked me as her sponsor because I was the leader of the meeting. She thought I was the president of NA." It was a telling anecdote-funny, but meaningful. NA had no leaders, no presidents, no executives.

What it had were addicts willing to show up. That was enough. At the September 1981 Philadelphia ASC meeting the Manayunk Group took On the task to start hosting an H&I meeting at Fairmount Institute on Friday nights. The meeting was later listed in the 1984 meeting directory as the "Carry The Message." group.

By the fall of 1981, the geographic footprint of H&I had stretched even farther. Across the river and into New Jersey, the message was carried to Princeton. At the Princeton House—a 21-day residential treatment center affiliated with Princeton Hospital—a new NA meeting began. The institution leaned heavily toward Alcoholics Anonymous, offering AA outings and in-house meetings. But Narcotics Anonymous was beginning to make its voice heard.

Jim D. remembered being a patient there at the time. “They gave me a meeting directory—it probably had only 10 or 12 NA meetings in all of New Jersey,” he recalled. “They didn’t really have pamphlets. Just some Little White Books. That was it.” But sometimes, that was enough. The book got into someone’s hand. The message landed in someone’s heart.

On February 4, another meeting opened—this time at the Loysville Youth Development Center, a juvenile facility tucked into the rural hills at 10 Opportunity Drive. The name itself—Opportunity Drive—felt symbolic of the program’s purpose. Here, too, the message was beginning to reach younger addicts caught in the criminal justice system. The next month the Woodside Center on Mall Road in Harrisburg. Each meeting added a new node to the growing network of institutional NA outreach.

By mid-1982, the NA H&I landscape was dense, complex, and—most importantly—alive. New meetings sprang up across multiple counties and even into neighboring states. The reach was astonishing. Meetings had started at Delaware Valley Detox, 280 Jacksonville Road, Warminster; Warminster Hospital, 225 Newtown Road; Delaware State Hospital, 1901 N. DuPont Highway, New Castle, Delaware; and Eastern State Hospital, 707 Neshaminy Mall, Bensalem.

Each new commitment had a story behind it. Sometimes, it began with awkward questions. Kurt E. recalled a pivotal moment at a regional learning day: “Someone asked what Montgomery County was doing at Graterford. The answer? Nothing. Not me, but Bobby B. and Joe R. made the contacts, went up there, and did a presentation. I don’t know exactly what they did, but they got things moving. That’s how NA started at Graterford.” It wasn’t always strategic. It was organic. Addicts saw a need, made a phone call, found a staff ally, pushed through red tape—and showed up.

In Bucks County, a more coordinated effort was underway. On September 2, 1982, a new cycle of H&I meetings began at Saint Joseph the Worker Church in Levittown. The meetings were scheduled twice a month-on the first and third Thursdays at 6:00 P.M. The structure, simple as it was, offered something vital: consistency. Addicts inside could count on someone coming back, Then, in November, one final milestone closed the year. On Sunday, November 7, 1982, a new institutional meeting began at the VA Medical Center in Coatesville, Pennsylvania. Held at 8:00 P.M., the meeting carried historical weight. Bill O. remembered hearing something from the hospital's director: "He told me he believed it was the first NA meeting in a federal facility on the East Coast." Pat P., who started the commitment, worked at the VA at the time. He explained how his professional and recovery lives overlapped: "We used to send patients who completed treatment to Vitae House. We had a federal contract with them, and part of my job was to check on our veterans, follow up, and see how they were doing."

NA's institutional reach had now spread across Pennsylvania, New Jersey, and Delaware. It was no longer a footnote to the program. H&I had become a cornerstone of NA's service identity. Philadelphia's H&I work was expanding across detox units, brigs, county jails, and youth programs—creating a constellation of service commitments that mirrored the very geography of addiction and institutionalization.

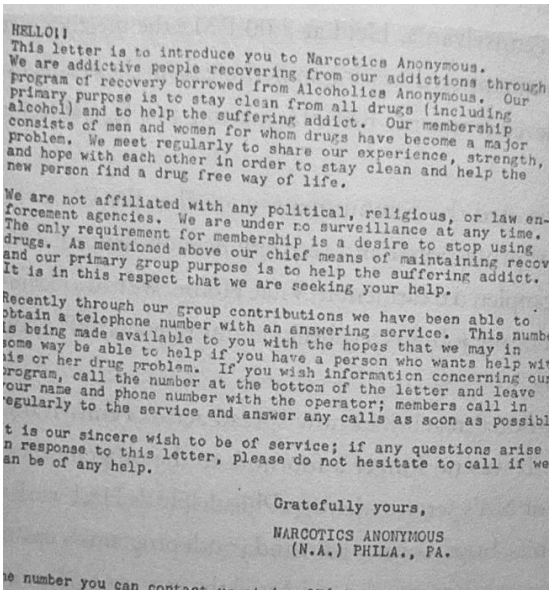
These weren't grand gestures. They were acts of steady devotion. One meeting at a time. One pamphlet at a time. One addict at a time.

Public Outreach

The small but growing NA fellowship in the Philadelphia area had begun turning outward-speaking directly to the public in ways that were both bold and cautious, experimental and deeply rooted in tradition. NA's core principle of anonymity demanded sensitivity in every public encounter, and the members who stepped forward did so with a protective reverence for the Traditions.

Matthew Hickey's research documented how schools in Chester and Philadelphia counties invited former addicts (two from the Gaudenzia House and two from Eagleville) to speak with students during the 1969–70 school year.

In Philadelphia, a typewritten letter simply titled "HELLO" introduced NA to schools and professionals. "We're under no surveillance at any time," it read, reflecting the stigma addicts still faced. "Our chief means of maintaining recovery is to help the suffering addict."



HELLO!!

This letter is to introduce you to Narcotics Anonymous. We are addictive people recovering from our addictions through program of recovery borrowed from Alcoholics Anonymous. Our primary purpose is to stay clean from all drugs (including alcohol) and to help the suffering addict. Our membership consists of men and women for whom drugs have become a major problem. We meet regularly to share our experience, strength, and hope with each other in order to stay clean and help the new person find a drug free way of life.

We are not affiliated with any political, religious, or law enforcement agencies. We are under no surveillance at any time. The only requirement for membership is a desire to stop using drugs. As mentioned above our chief means of maintaining recov and our primary group purpose is to help the suffering addict. It is in this respect that we are seeking your help.

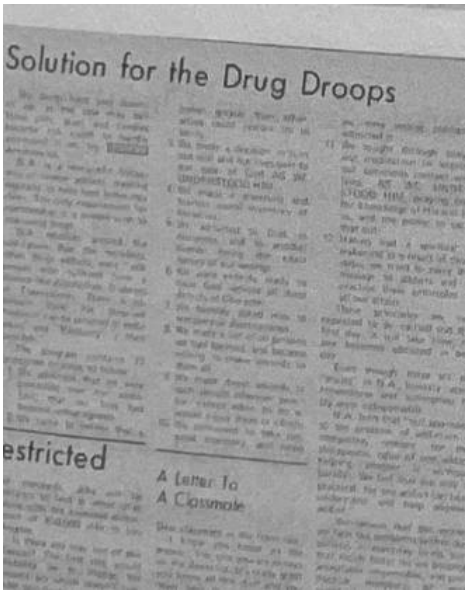
Recently through our group contributions we have been able to obtain a telephone number with an answering service. This numb is being made available to you with the hopes that we may in some way be able to help if you have a person who wants help wi his or her drug problem. If you wish information concerning ou program, call the number at the bottom of the letter and leave your name and phone number with the operator; members call in regularly to the service and answer any calls as soon as possibl

It is our sincere wish to be of service; if any questions arise in response to this letter, please do not hesitate to call if we can be of any help.

Gratefully yours,

NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS
(N.A.) PHILA., PA.

e number you can contact



Solution for the Drug Droops

estricted

A Letter To
A Classmate



In 1974 Bob McK. and Jim D. explored the possibility of expanding public awareness through radio airtime. Jim also reached out to local television stations, hoping to have the NA Hotline number flashed again during public broadcasts.



Addicts Celebrate Freedom With Tales of Old Madness

Addicts Celebrate Freedom With Tales of Old Madness

By JACK BOOTH
Of The Bulletin Staff

AT THE HEIGHT of his drug addiction, Bob held a fleeting job as the driver of a "Mr. Softee" ice cream truck.

For four days, he drove the truck while going without food or sleep and staying constantly high on methadrine.

"I had these big ideas, like being the guy who's giving out drugs instead of ice cream," he recalled. "That lasted four days, and at the end I brought the truck back on fire. No ice cream left. Just $17 in the till."

There should have been $200, but I gave ice cream away to practically every kid I passed. I was even pull-

ing over to people who weren't there."

The anecdote's gallows humor drew sustained laughter at a recent meeting of Narcotics Anonymous in the Muhlenberg Memorial Lutheran Church, 13th and Ruscomb sts. in North Philadelphia.

But the 30 or so addicts in the audience were laughing uneasily. All of them, in their own ways, had sunk to the same depths, and they sensed what was about to follow.

"I just went berserk when I brought the truck back on fire," the 22-year-old Bob continued. "I parked it and I ran over to this kid's house and shot up some meth."

"I had convulsions and when I came to I heard voices saying, 'He's dead; get him out of here.' I looked up, and I didn't recog nize anyone

dead, get him out of here.' I looked up, and I didn't recognize anyone. There were people I had been around all the time, and I didn't recognize anyone.

"For the first time, it occurred to me that the whole thing wasn't a game. Not that I was going to stop anything about the next day I was going again. But I knew it wasn't a game anymore."

Bob gave his account of a celebration of his "first anniversary" of being free of drugs. Two others celebrated their first year of being "clean."

The three young people, despite hostility to their new status as "reformed" addicts, are part of the first

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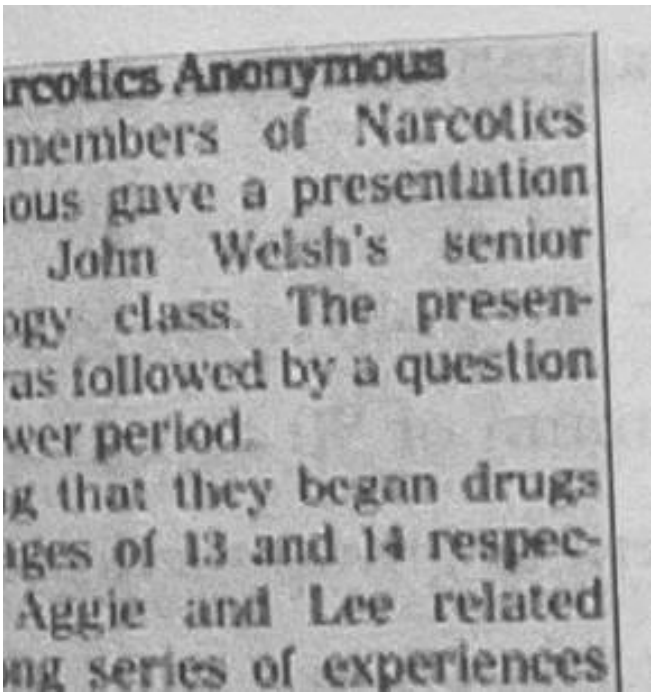
Addicts Celebrate New Freedom

In July 1975, Jack Booth of the Philadelphia Bulletin attended a meeting at 13th & Ruscomb, a location known for its strong adherence to NA's principles. When Booth asked to take a photo, members flatly refused any full-face images or last names. As a compromise, Booth climbed into the loft above the meeting space, where members bowed their heads in unison, preserving anonymity while still allowing a visual essence of the meeting to be captured. The resulting article, titled "Addicts Celebrate Freedom with Tales of Old Madness," appeared in the Sunday Bulletin on July 27, 1975, declaring that this was the first sizable group of recovering addicts to stick with NA in Philadelphia. It noted that although the program had begun there four years earlier, real growth didn't occur until the previous year. At the time, nearly a dozen groups were meeting regularly, with close to 100 members and a hotline.

NA members carried their message beyond Philadelphia. On August 8, 1975, Ray T. and Sharon appeared on WWDB 96.5 FM, joining talk radio host Frank Ford at 2:00 P.M., to field live questions from callers. In a conversation that would later be remembered as the fellowship's "first tangible PR effort," Ray and Sharon emphasized NA's all-or-nothing approach to abstinence: no drugs, no alcohol—because alcohol was considered a drug. When a caller pressed Ray about willpower and whether he could still drink, Ray calmly explained, "It's not willpower ... the people, the meetings, and the program—that's what keeps me sober."

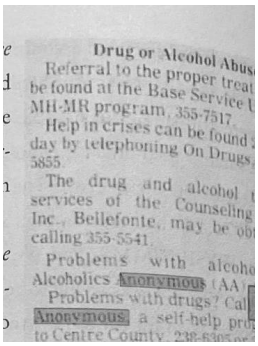
On August 19, 1975, Ray D. and Kathy S. spoke at a public "Speakers Night" in Hazleton, Pennsylvania. Held at 240 West Broad Street and announced in the Hazleton Standard, the event served as both outreach and awareness. The

two members shared personal accounts of how addiction had made their lives unmanageable, echoing NA's First Step to a new audience. There were also small but notable triumphs that year. Brian succeeded in having NA's name aired on local radio. PR flourished under Sharon B's efforts, securing a feature on Channel 6 and mentions on WYSP. In July 1976, PR had taken a bold step forward, coordinating efforts with local media: WYSP, WMMR, and WCAU. The WIBG radio spot would soon be broadcast. Also, PR was trying to get on Joe Spivack's talk shows. Noel was making a poster flash for KYW-TV. And WFIL's "Call for Action" would list a new meeting in Eagleville and the hotline number. The fellowship was not just growing-it was announcing itself to the public. Over the next few years, NA's voice grew clearer, louder, and more regional in scope. The media began taking notice in towns across the mid-Atlantic.


rcotics Anonymous
members of Narcotics
ous gave a presentation
John Welsh's senior
gy class. The presen-
as followed by a question
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g that they began drugs
ges of 13 and 14 respec-
Aggie and Lee related
ng series of experiences

On February 10, 1977, the Aegis, a local Harford County, Maryland, paper, reported on a presentation given to a senior psychology class by two NA members, Aggie and Lee. They spoke of early drug use, the progression of addiction, and the role of family in their eventual discovery of NA. “We’ve found meaning in life,” they said. Meetings were held every Monday at 8:30 P.M., at the Presbyterian Church on Old Fallston Road in Fallston.

A week later, the Pottsville Republican published an article titled "Narcotics Anonymous: Aid for Addicts" (February 17, 1977), drawing directly from NA literature: "We are people in the grip of a continuous and progressive illness whose ends are always the same-jails, institutions, and death." The Pottsville group met Wednesdays at 10 A.M. in the Masonic Building and had begun meeting around September 1974.



Drug or Alcohol Abus

Referral to the proper treat
be found at the Base Service U
MH-MR program, 355-7517.

Help in crises can be found
day by telephoning On Drugs
5855.

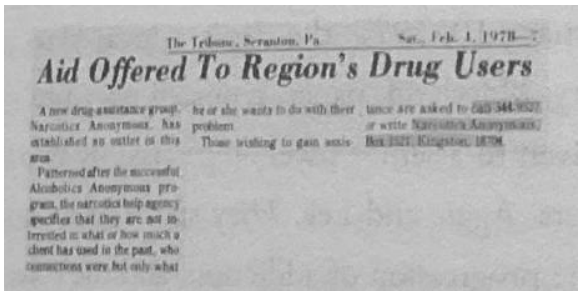
The drug and alcohol
services of the Counseling
Inc., Bellefonte, may be ob
calling 355-5541.

Problems with alcoho
Alcoholics Anonymous (AA

Problems with drugs? Cal
Anonymous, a self-help pro
to Centre County.

On November 21, 1977 the Centre Daily Times published an article titled “Drug or Alcohol Abuse” informing the public “Problem with drugs? Call Narcotics Anonymous, a self-help program new to Centre County.”

By February 1, 1978, Scranton’s The Tribune declared, “Aid Offered to Region’s Drug Users,” introducing NA to northeastern Pennsylvania. The article provided contact information for those seeking help—Box 1521, Kingston, Pennsylvania—and stressed the program’s focus on what the addict wanted to do now, not what they had done in the past.



The Tribune, Scranton, Pa. Sat., Feb. 4, 1978—7

Aid Offered To Region's Drug Users

A new drug-assistance group, Narcotics Anonymous, has established an outlet in this area.

Patterned after the successful Alcoholics Anonymous program, the narcotics help agency specifies that they are not interested in what or how much a client has used in the past, who connections were but only what he or she wants to do with their problem.

Those wishing to gain assis- tance are asked to [illegible] or write Narcotics Anonymous, Box 1521, Kingston, 18704.

The Scranton-Wilkes-Barre area’s 24-hour phone line—(717) 344-9527—was staffed by volunteers with a minimum of 90 days clean time, a commitment to group service, and the willingness to do 12-step work. A Steering Committee meeting on January 16, 1978, at the home of Vince M. and Kathy W. in Kingston, laid plans for further media outreach—including a special television feature.

The program reached an important media milestone on March 12, 1978, with a televised panel titled “Town Meeting on the Air” on WNEP-TV Channel 16. Orchestrated by Stan B. through the Outreach Program of the Northern PA ASC, the event brought NA into living rooms across the Scranton-Wilkes-Barre region. Four members, sitting with their backs to the camera, spoke openly about recovery, answering live questions from callers. It was a landmark moment. “This is a great step for NA in our area,” the “N.A. NEWS” newsletter later reported. “Special thanks to Channel 16’s staff for giving us this great chance to reach the addict who still suffers.”

By July 7, meetings had spread into Danville and Bloomsburg, with eight AA and NA meetings offered weekly between Montour and Columbia Counties.

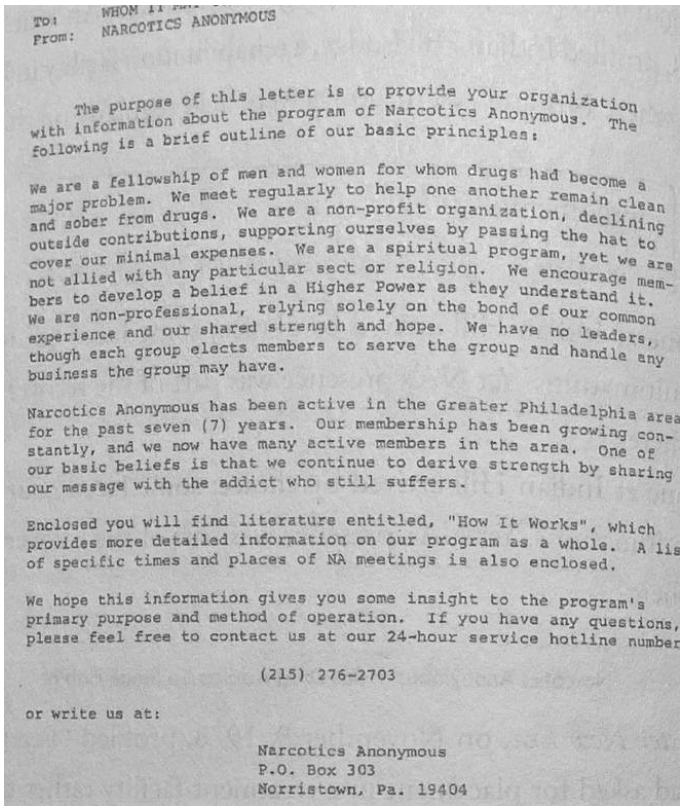
NA also began intersecting with emerging rehab centers. An article from Oc-rober 24, 1978, profiled Indian Hill Lodge, a rehabilitation facility in Beach Lake, Pennsylvania, where NA and AA meetings were held regularly on the grounds.

Indian Hill Lodge Not a Cure-All; But a Place to Begin Pulling Things Together Not everyone at Indian Hill arrived by choice; some faced court mandates, others family ultimatums. Yet NA's presence was part of the recovery ecosystem taking shape there. Not everyone at Indian Hill arrived by choice; some faced court mandates, others family ultimatums. Yet NA's presence was part of the recovery ecosystem taking shape there.

Narcotics Anonymous' Helps Drug Addicts To Break Habits The Lancaster New Era, on November 9, 1978, profiled "Peter," a former addict who had asked for placement in a treatment facility rather than face jail after overdosing.

After finding AA inadequate for his needs, Peter co-founded an NA fellowship in the Greater Pittsburgh area. "There are now more than 200 members," he said. Yet challenges remained: few treatment centers knew about NA, and fewer still trusted it.

By the summer of 1979, Narcotics Anonymous in the Philadelphia area had moved beyond its fragile early years and was now entering a phase of deepening structure and outreach. One of the clearest signs of this maturity was a formal letter issued by the fellowship that July. Addressed "To Whom It May Concern," the document provided a calm, composed overview of NA's principles and practices.



To: WHOM IT
From: NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS

The purpose of this letter is to provide your organization with information about the program of Narcotics Anonymous. The following is a brief outline of our basic principles:

We are a fellowship of men and women for whom drugs had become a major problem. We meet regularly to help one another remain clean and sober from drugs. We are a non-profit organization, declining outside contributions, supporting ourselves by passing the hat to cover our minimal expenses. We are a spiritual program, yet we are not allied with any particular sect or religion. We encourage members to develop a belief in a Higher Power as they understand it. We are non-professional, relying solely on the bond of our common experience and our shared strength and hope. We have no leaders, though each group elects members to serve the group and handle any business the group may have.

Narcotics Anonymous has been active in the Greater Philadelphia area for the past seven (7) years. Our membership has been growing constantly, and we now have many active members in the area. One of our basic beliefs is that we continue to derive strength by sharing our message with the addict who still suffers.

Enclosed you will find literature entitled, "How It Works", which provides more detailed information on our program as a whole. A lis of specific times and places of NA meetings is also enclosed.

We hope this information gives you some insight to the program's primary purpose and method of operation. If you have any questions, please feel free to contact us at our 24-hour service hotline number

(215) 276-2703

or write us at:

Narcotics Anonymous
P.O. Box 303
Norristown, Pa. 19404

The letter outlined what was becoming a well-honed identity: a fellowship of recovering addicts, spiritual but not religious, self-supporting, and firmly grounded in anonymity, mutual aid, and experience-based guidance. "We meet regularly to help one another remain clean," it read, affirming a philosophy rooted not in outside expertise, but in shared suffering and collective strength. The letter also made it clear: NA had been active in Greater Philadelphia for seven years by this time, and the local fellowship had grown steadily. It enclosed literature, including "How It Works," and a meeting directory. A 24-hour hotline-(215) 276-2703—was available for addicts or professionals seeking more information. The return address, P.O. Box 303 in Norristown, anchored the letter in a city that had been part of the movement since the early 1970s.

This gesture-public, principled, and informative-marked a transition point: from underground meetings in church basements and hospitals to a community ready to articulate its presence to the wider world.

In August 1980, NA's Bucks County Public Information (PI) Committe mailed a letter to local contacts:

We charge no dues or fees; we are fully self-supportive through Our Own contributions. We operate a 24-hour HOTLINE service ... We sincerely hope you will consider us when referring to drug addicts who want to stay free of the habit.

A month later, NA's presence reached a new cultural milestone: Game 6 of the World Series, October 21, 1980, at Veterans Stadium in Philadelphia. NA managed to get a PSA displayed on the massive scoreboard during the seventh or eighth inning. The message read: "If you want to do drugs, that's your business. If you want to stop, that's ours." As George R. recalled, it was seen on national television-proof that NA's message could coexist with America's pastime.

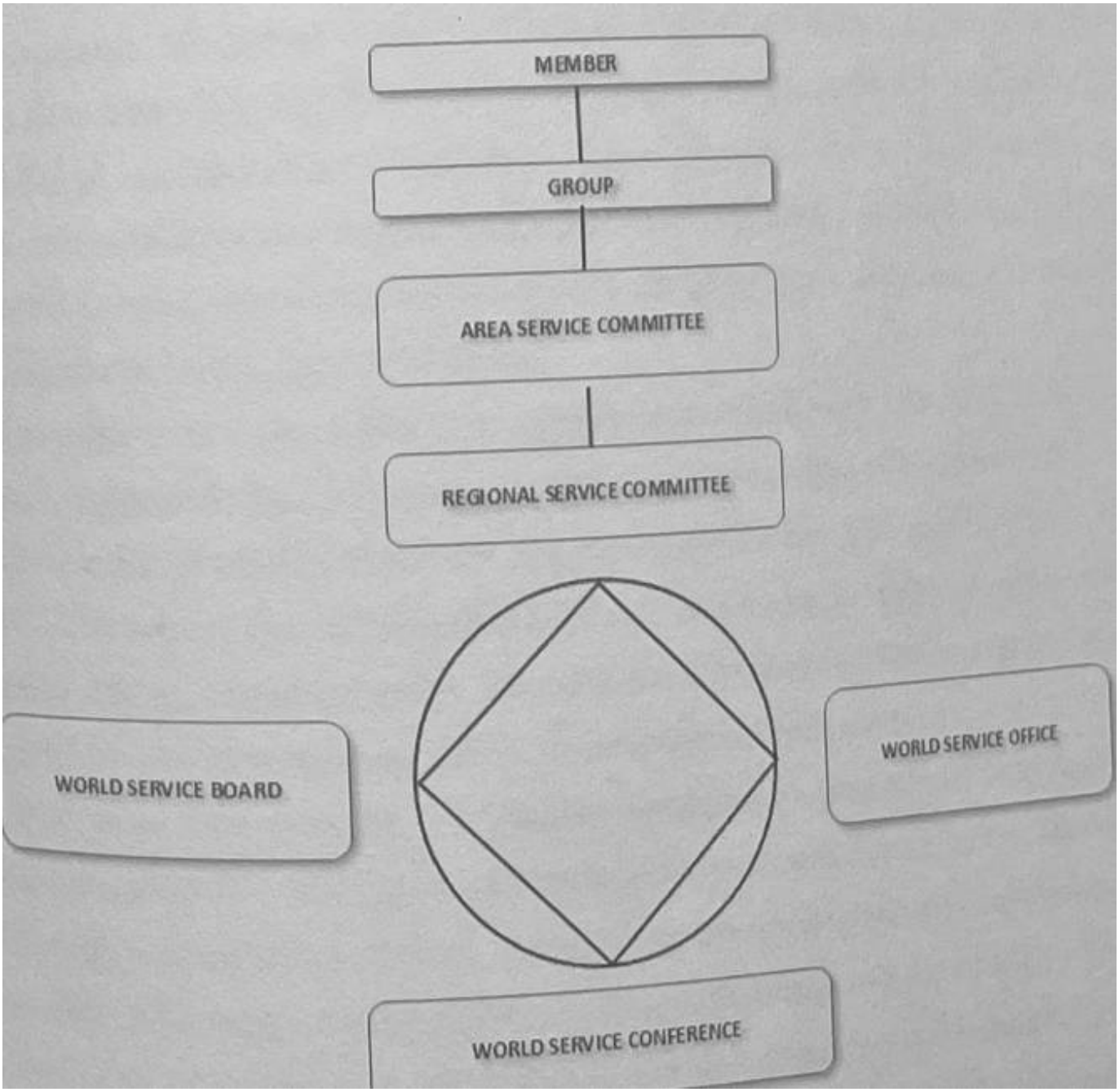
On December 8, 1980, Pete B. followed up with a letter requesting that local media outlets run NA's PSA and consider hosting NA members on local talk shows.

On December 14, 1980, Norristown's ASC met again at the YMCA. The big news was a media opportunity: Channel 48 had invited NA members to speak on television, with faces obscured to preserve anonymity. George R. and Cindy were chosen to represent the fellowship, with George K. and Jane as alternates. On December 29, NA members George and Cindy R. appeared on a UHF Channel 48 show hosted by Marty Jacobs. Though a substitute host was brought in at the last minute, the silhouetted interview aired as planned. As Cindy R. recalled, "We were just outlines. They asked about the disease and recovery. I remember being blacked out."

After being voted in as PR chairperson in 1980, George R. began coordinating meetings, deliberately scheduling them on off-nights to draw in more newcomers. With little experience and almost no guidance, teams were assigned to handle outreach to newspapers, schools, radio, and television. Eventually, George sourced a piece of guidance literature from Atlanta-after six months of operating without One.

Through newspapers, radio, TV, and hotlines, NA's identity was maturing. The voices that once spoke only inside dimly lit rooms were now being broadcast to entire regions-carefully, courageously, and always with the message intact: One addict helping another, so that no one needs to die from addiction.

THE SERVICE STRUCTURE



1976 - Building the Service Framework

The Southern California RSC, long celebrated as the first, was reportedly formed on April 17, 1977. However, Pennsylvania's regional structure had begun in July 1976 and was fully functioning by January 1977, making it, in fact, the world's first operational RSC. The summer of 1976 marked a significant milestone in the formation of Narcotics Anonymous service structures throughout Pennsylvania. On August 1, 1976, the Philadelphia-Bucks ASC held its inaugural official meeting at 1716 Loney Street in Philadelphia. This location would serve as the committee's permanent mailing address, and soon after, a rubber stamp was ordered to mark literature accordingly. The fledgling committee elected its first officers: Brian T. as Chairperson, Mickey as both Co-Chair and Steering Committee representative, Ron B. as Secretary and PR, Rich as Treasurer, Jim H. as PR Committee Chair, and Bill A. as Literature Committee Chair. Practical decisions grounded this structure—officers could hold more than one position, provided no conflict of interest existed, and costs for the newly adopted answering service would be supplemented through 50/50 raffles.

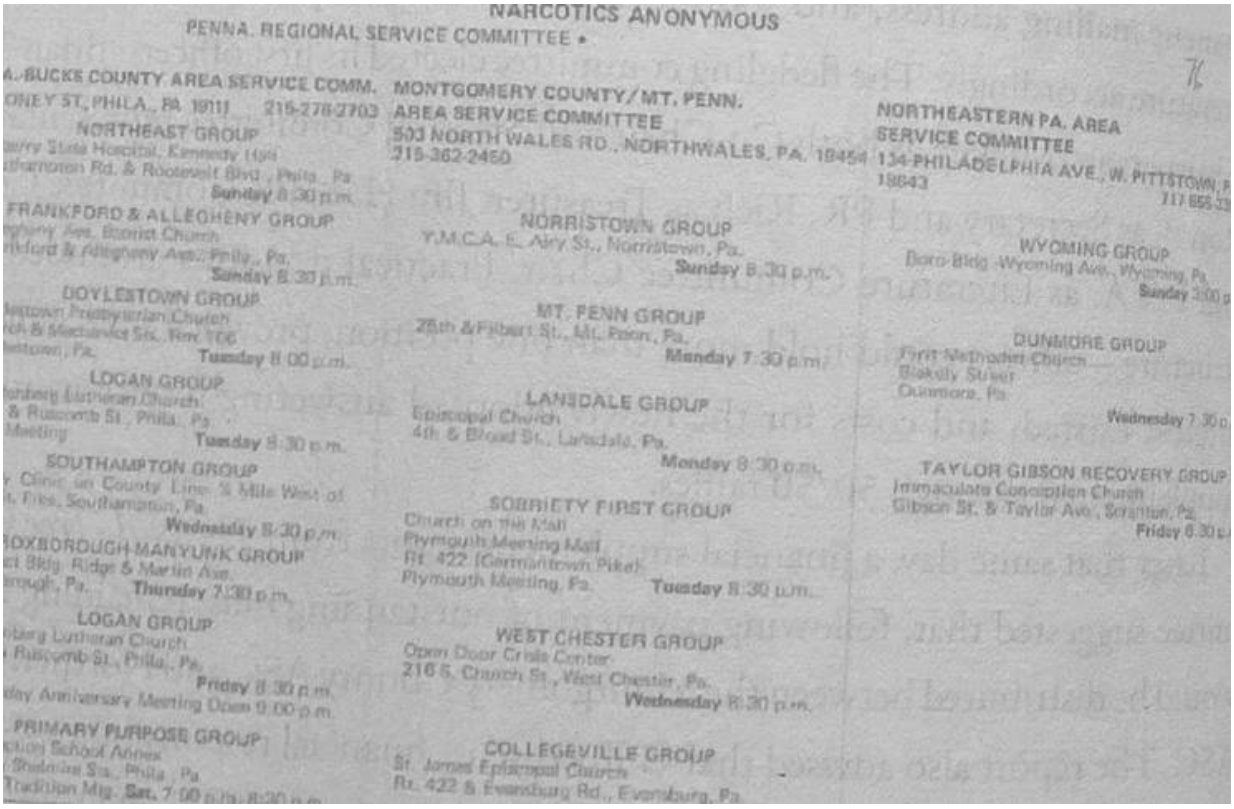
Later that same day, a financial supplement report from The N.A. Tree Committee suggested that, following payment of outstanding bills, remaining funds would be distributed between the Montgomery County ASC and Northern Area ASC. The report also advised that GSRs discuss financial responsibilities—such as phone lines, committee expenses, and donations to the RSC-at group meetings, to encourage more consistent contributions from members.

That same date, August 1, 1976, also witnessed the first official meeting of the Pennsylvania RSC, with participants from Doylestown, West Chester, Plymouth Meeting, Collegeville, Mount Penn, Roxborough-Manayunk, Southampton, Lansdale, Northeastern Pennsylvania, Logan, Byberry, and the Primary Purpose group. The tone of the meeting revealed both excitement and concern. During an open gripe session, Ron B. criticized the fellowship's handling of a support request from the Byberry group, noting that when he brought the matter up at a prior meeting, he was met with laughter-a breach of NA's unity principles. The

RSC agreed that its PR Chair would write a letter of apology to Byberry. Another discussion focused on how to respond to non-addicts attending NA meetings;

the consensus was that each group should decide through its own conscience.

From a small office at 6261 North Broad Street in Philadelphia, the Pennsylvania RSC was beginning to coordinate a sprawling and rapidly diversifying network of groups. At the time, the Philadelphia-Bucks County ASC listed seven active groups: from the Sunday night Northeast Group to the Saturday Primary Purpose Group. Just northwest, six meetings comprised the Montgomery County/Mount Penn Area, including the well-established Norristown and Lansdale groups. Farther north, the Northeastern Area had three groups in Wyoming, Dunmore, and Taylor-Gibson.


NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS

PENNA. REGIONAL SERVICE COMMITTEE

A.-BUCKS COUNTY AREA SERVICE COMM.
ONEY ST., PHILA., PA. 19111 215-276-2703

NORTHEAST GROUP
Sunday 8:30 p.m.

FRANKFORD & ALLEGHENY GROUP
Sunday 8:30 p.m.

DOYLESTOWN GROUP
Tuesday 8:00 p.m.

LOGAN GROUP
Tuesday 8:30 p.m.

SOUTHAMPTON GROUP
Wednesday 8:30 p.m.

OXBOROUGH-MANYUNK GROUP
Thursday 7:30 p.m.

LOGAN GROUP
Friday 8:30 p.m.

PRIMARY PURPOSE GROUP
Sat. 7:00 p.m.

MONTGOMERY COUNTY/MT. PENN.
AREA SERVICE COMMITTEE
503 NORTH WALES RD., NORTHWALES, PA. 19454
215-362-2450

NORRISTOWN GROUP
Y.M.C.A., E. Airy St., Norristown, Pa.
Sunday 8:30 p.m.

MT. FENN GROUP
Monday 7:30 p.m.

LANSDALE GROUP
Monday 8:30 p.m.

SOBRIETY FIRST GROUP
Tuesday 8:30 p.m.

WEST CHESTER GROUP
Wednesday 8:30 p.m.

COLLEGEVILLE GROUP

NORTHEASTERN PA. AREA
SERVICE COMMITTEE
134 PHILADELPHIA AVE., W. PITTSTOWN, P
18643

WYOMING GROUP
Sunday

DUNMORE GROUP
Wednesday 7:30

TAYLOR GIBSON RECOVERY GROUP
Friday 8:30

In Newark, on September 30, 1976, the Friday Night NA group formally adopted by-laws addressing behavioral expectations: no drugs or paraphernalia allowed, newcomers could attend one meeting while still using but must be clean thereafter, and violence was strictly prohibited. The group also clearly defined officer roles and responsibilities, specified sobriety requirements, and emphasized that leaders were trusted servants-not authorities. The Northern PA ASC began meeting regularly in Williamsport starting February 27, 1977, with GSRs from eight groups—including Sunbury, Danville, Dunmore, Harrisburg, and Wyoming. This meeting marked a shift from earlier "

Intergroup" models toward The N.A. Tree-inspired structure. Bob P. was elected Chairperson, and discussions centered on logistical matters: the production of 2,000 meeting lists, increasing Allentown participation, and coordination with Philadelphia groups. A new policy permitted alternates to serve in officer roles, maximizing participation amidst limited manpower.

1977 - Pennsylvania Leads the Way

From March through July 1977, Northern Pennsylvania's service body rotated meeting locations-Dunmore, Williamsport, Danville—reflecting its vast geographic reach. Ray D. was elected Chair in April, succeeding Bob P. During this period, concerns were raised about the burdens placed on a few members repeatedly holding group-level commitments because of rigid sobriety requirements. Suggestions included easing those limits through group conscience. Members also noted difficulty understanding NA's 12 Traditions, sparking early plans to dissect them for deeper study.

In parallel, service was expanding in the southern part of the state. On July 8, 1977, a Hotline Committee meeting took place at Trish R.'s house in New Jersey. Jeanne M. recalled the early struggles: volunteers carried beepers, fielded calls not just from addicts but also family members, and clashed over the role of technology in recovery outreach. The effort was unsustainable, yet it revealed a deep commitment to connect the suffering with solutions.

A major gathering occurred on July 24, 1977, as the PA RSC met in conjunction with the 3rd Annual Round-Up and Picnic in the Park at Milton State Park. Ray D. chaired a session attended by 43 members, covering both local reports and broader concerns. There was consensus that complacency had begun creeping into service, with a recurring struggle to fill roles and maintain commitment. Nevertheless, the event offered hope, fellowship, and a $96.39 donation to the WSO.

Dwayne S., a literature person from the region, recalled his first service commitment in 1977. Equipped with a phone and a bank account, he was able to place orders directly with California. Literature shipments came to his home, and he worked closely with Jimmy K.-NA's founding figure. But California's

temporary literature shortage spurred local groups to write and share their own material-until they were told this was unauthorized, igniting a short-lived feud

1978 - From Fragile Roots to Firm Foundations

By early 1978, coordination had matured. On February 26, the ASC met in Danville, followed by a significant event in March: Greg P., then Chairman of NA's Board of Trustees, stopped in Pennsylvania en route to a Washington, DC presentation. His message was clear-NA needed to remain autonomous, unaffiliated with outside organizations.

The Third WSC, recognized today as the first in its modern form, was held April 1-2, 1978 at Los Angeles Valley College. For the first time, WSC was a standalone event, drawing representatives from Southern and Northern California, Pennsylvania, Texas, Minnesota, Colorado, Georgia, and even British Columbia. Thirty trusted servants gathered to set foundational processes in motion. Committees for Policy, Literature, Institutions, and PR were formed. Ray D. delivered reports from both North and South Pennsylvania. The spirit of World Service had begun to take shape.

The Fourth Biannual PA RSC and picnic, held May 7, 1978 at Luzerne County Community College in Nanticoke, drew 42 members and reflected the rising maturity of the Northern fellowship. Ray D., serving as Literature Committee chair and WSC delegate, proposed initiatives that would later shape NA's publishing future: a "Big Book," a 12 & 12 tailored to NA, and a two-tier system distinguishing between "NA Approved" and "NA Accepted" literature. A Pennsylvania Literature Committee was formally established with representatives from across the state.

A report clarified California's position on acceptable NA meetings: they must be open to the public, unaffiliated with institutional rules, staff-led meetings were invalid, and the 12 Traditions must be upheld. There was robust discussion about whether California had the right to threaten lawsuits against institutions misusing the NA name. Pennsylvania twelve members asserted their right to question WSO policies and insisted that input should flow in both directions.

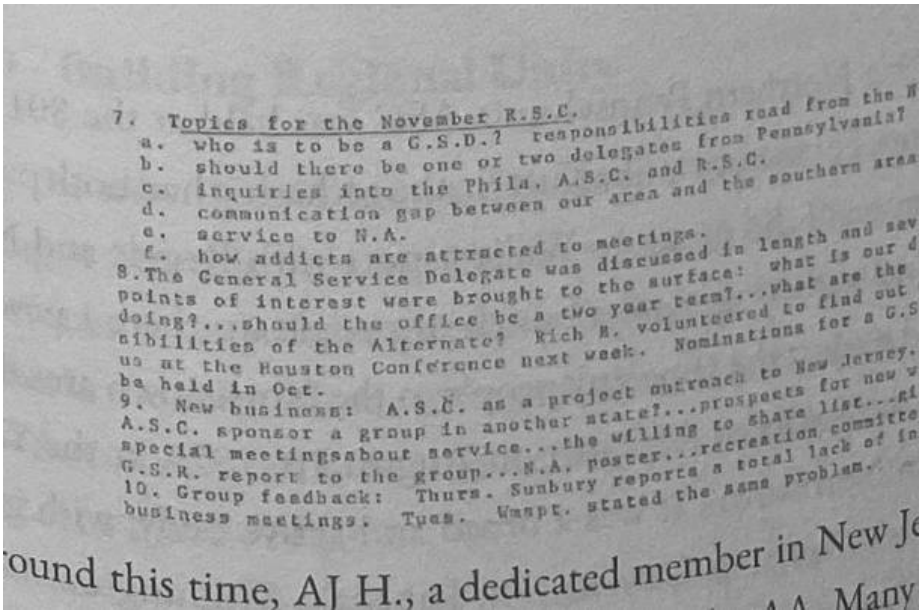
Shortly after, on June 28, Gerry G., chair of the Pennsylvania RSC, sent minutes and a letter of inquiry to the WSO. His concerns? The feasibility of lawsuits against institutions using the NA name improperly. The Pennsylvania fellowship wanted to understand NA's legal policy: Did the fellowship have the resources to pursue lawsuits? Were all peaceful options being exhausted first? Were the traditions being upheld? Jimmy K. responded on July 16, 1978 with reassurance. A note preserved in the WSO archives reads: "Everything is OK now. Jimmy K, WSO Inc." The fellowship was navigating the legal and spiritual tensions of growth with measured care.

More correspondence followed. On August 29, 1978, Mr. and Mrs. Greg Pierce sent a letter to Ray T. in Landenberg, Pennsylvania, affirming interregional connections that continued to strengthen.

Other developments included the start of a Nar-Anon meeting in Harrisburg, the creation of a Willing to Share List to support smaller groups, and a proposed newsletter exchange with NA in Atlanta, Georgia. However, the "N.A. News" came under scrutiny for including content deemed outside NA's focus, such as AA material and institutional events.

The September 17, 1978 RSC meeting, held at Holy Spirit Hospital in Camp Hill, saw attendance from 14 of 19 groups. Some groups, like Sunday Chambers-burg and Wednesday Carlisle, had folded. They were unsure of the existence of a Sunday Bloomsburg group. A sense of regional fragility lingered. Some of the topics included:

Around this time, AJ H., a dedicated member in New Jersey, recounted the carly isolation of NA in a region dominated by AA. Many local AA members dismissed NA, claiming it had "folded." But AJ's direct call to the NA office confirmed firmed


7. Topics for the November R.S.C.
a. who is to be a G.S.D.? responsibilities read from the N
b. should there be one or two delegates from Pennsylvania?
c. inquiries into the Phila. A.S.C. and R.S.C.
d. communication gap between our area and the southern area
e. service to N.A.
f. how addicts are attracted to meetings.
8. The General Service Delegate was discussed in length and sev
points of interest were brought to the surface: what is our d
doing?...should the office be a two year term?...what are the
sibilities of the Alternate? Rich R. volunteered to find out
us at the Houston Conference next week. Nominations for a G.S
be held in Oct.
9. New business: A.S.C. as a project outreach to New Jersey.
A.S.C. sponsor a group in another state?...prospects for new w
special meetingsabout service...the willing to share list...si
G.S.R. report to the group...N.A. poster...recreation committe
10. Group feedback: Thurs. Sunbury reports a total lack of in
business meetings. Tues. Wmspt. stated the same problem.
ound this time, AJ H., a dedicated member in New J
Many

otherwise—and reinvigorated their commitment to grow NA's presence in New Jersey.

As the crisp November air settled over Montgomery County on Sunday, November 5, 1978, the Fifth Biannual RSC convened at Saint James Episcopal Church, a landmark nestled in the heart of Collegeville, Pennsylvania. The Northern ASC continued regular meetings held October 22 and November 5 rotated between Dunmore and Danville.

Meanwhile, in November 1978, The Voice of NA, Volume I, Issue 2, announced the release of the World Directory. The momentum was unmistakable. But practical issues persisted.

From rough-hewn meeting formats and heated debates about phone answering to the establishment of literature committees, newsletters, and region-wide assemblies, the years from 1976 to 1978 saw the Pennsylvania NA fellowship move from its formative phase to a robust, evolving structure. Though financial, logistical, and cultural hurdles remained, these years laid the groundwork for the cohesive service structure that would eventually link the region more firmly to the global NA community.

1979 - A Spirit of Fellowship in the North and South

The 7th Biannual RSC meeting of NA in Pennsylvania was held May 6, 1979 at the Trinity Presbyterian Church, Bloomsburg, Pennsylvania. The time was from 1:00 PM to 6:00 PM. There was fellowship, refreshments, and business discussions.

On July 21, 1979, a Northern Pennsylvania ASC was held at the 801 Clubhouse in Williamsport. For members like Kurt E., the gathering had both practical and spiritual resonance: "I did go up to Williamsport with Reggie and Neil to some kind of regional gathering. And a bunch of people up there I never saw before. They treated me just the same way people in the Norristown area did."

Just weeks later, the Southern ASC met on August 10, 1979, at the YMCA on 41 Airy Street in Norristown. It was a broad and active body, with groups represented from Delaware Step, Doylestown, Lansdale, Wilmington, Oxford Circle, Collegeville, and several others—including newer efforts like "Primary

Purpose" and "Serenity Special." Though some groups had recently folded or restarted, the sense of unity was palpable. The meeting launched the first N.A. Newsletter, a tool for connecting scattered members. By December 16, 1979, Northern Pennsylvania's ASC in Danville had matured. Fourteen members were present, with GSRs from Williamsport, Dunmore, Exeter, Wilkes-Barre, Mansfield, and Danville. It was agreed that ASC meetings would occur bi-monthly. Vince M. shared news from the newsletter The Voice of NA, promoted glow-in-the-dark key tags for one and two years clean, and made available starter kits, tapes, The N.A. Tree, World Directories, new pins, and even bumper stickers through the Steering Committee. As the 1970s ended, Narcotics Anonymous was no longer a fledgling movement in Pennsylvania—it had begun taking root, branching out, and defining its identity through service. The years 1979 and 1980 were marked by the emergence of structured ASCs, Intergroup collaboration, and grassroots decision-making that balanced passionate commitment with spiritual principle.

As John F. recalled, these early service gatherings were passionate and at times chaotic: "Area service was wild and woolly, but I've got to say-it kind of preserved our spiritual values... We used to meet at this long, narrow table... Everybody showed up... Passions would flare, tempers would rise. And one time.. one guy stands up, grabs another by the shirt, and decks him. But as he's punching the guy out, he's yelling, 'It's a fucking spiritual program, man!'"

Despite occasional fireworks, service remained rooted in unity and purpose.

1980 - Building Regional Unity

As the new decade began, February 17, 1980, brought another service meeting in Danville. Just months later, May 11 saw Intergroup distribute H&I commitments to facilities including Eagleville, Today Inc., Friendship House, and Bucks County Prison. Alongside that, NA members produced wall hangings—Serenity Prayer, Who Is an Addict, and the 12 Steps—available for 50c each Or $22 for a bundle of 50.

By May 2-4, 1980, the 5th WSC had reconvened in Van Nuys. Representation had grown to include West Pennsylvania, East Ohio, and New Jersey. Bob P.,

reporting for Western Pennsylvania and Eastern Ohio, described a flourishing but fractured situation in his region: Philadelphia alone had over 60 meetings, but lacked any formal service structure. Eastern Pennsylvania was writing its own literature, but the greatest obstacle was communication—or the lack thereof. Meeting lists were distributed to WSC attendees to help bridge these gaps.

Bob P. introduced his alternate, Jim from Youngstown, Ohio. That year, Bob was elected Chair of PI at WSO, stepping deeper into service on a global level.

By December 7, 1980, New Jersey held its first ASC meeting in Edison, with plans to meet monthly in Toms River. As AJ recalled: “By then, we had about six active groups north of Pennsville. That first area service meeting, I think, was at Seton Hall in Orange … We didn’t have GSRs. We had secretaries, treasurers, and coffee makers. The whole state was supposed to be a single service area—except for the far southern meetings.”

1981 - The Rise of Regional Structure

As 1981 dawned, the Philadelphia fellowship of Narcotics Anonymous was in motion, gathering strength from spontaneous efforts in community service, literature development, and group formation.

This era marked a turning point. What had begun as scattered groups and spiritual experiments was becoming an organized network. Passionate debate, makeshift cookouts, glow-in-the-dark key tags, and impromptu literature efforts all fed into a larger movement. Area service brought structure. The East Coast Convention brought vision. And slowly, a new chapter of Narcotics Anonymous was being written—not just by those who attended meetings, but by those who built the rooms and showed others how to fill them.

The year began with the Philadelphia ASC at the YMCA in Norristown on January 11. That same week, NA reached Timber Mountain in Lititz, Pennsylvania, and on January 18, members gathered again at the Norristown YMCA to align local practices with the NA Service Manual.

By February, momentum required more structure. At the ASC on February 8, members agreed to seek a new location for the ASC, since the Norristown YMCA was no longer available. PR efforts expanded, with literature sent to 20

high schools and posters going up across Philadelphia. It was decided that all starter kits would now include a copy of the unapproved Steps. The first RSC of the year, held February 21 in Harrisburg, offered more than spaghetti. It was a crossroads: regional identities began to emerge and strengthen. ust weeks later, at the March 7 RSC in Philadelphia, various regions reported their growth: five new meetings in Philadelphia, ten in Greater Virginia, and three in Harrisburg. Central Pennsylvania was preparing a proposal to host WCNA-12, which they hoped to present at the second East Coast Convention of NA (EC. CNA) and later in Miami.

On March 8 in Plymouth Meeting, Area Service took on a full docket. Pete had speaking engagements with schools but resigned from PR, and Terica stepped into the role. John shared the region's support for Harrisburg's convention bid, and in a critical decision, members agreed that no major NA events should occur within 100 miles of each other during the World Convention bidding process.

Leadership was shifting. Guido stepped down as RSR, and George R. was elected in his place. Jane was elected Alternate Area Service Rep, and questions arose around the formal recognition of new groups. Ultimately, it was decided that any group following the Traditions and the Service Manual would be listed.

By April 12, Service was still in Plymouth Meeting. Questions emerged about listing other Twelve Step groups on NA meeting lists, and members agreed to bring the matter to the WSC. Institutional work continued, and a key Regional Meeting took place April 18 in Baltimore.

George reported, "The WSO promised faster literature. Posters should show Only the NA symbol, not our name. The phrase ' an honest desire' stays." Plans were made to send ten members to Florida for the convention bid.

In the spring of 1981, Jimmy K. resigned from the Board of Trustees: "Due to continuing interference with my personal life and the continuing creation of disunity within the fellowship by some demagogue members of the service units who seem to fear that which they seek the most, I hereby resign."

His departure marked a somber but necessary passing of the torch from the program's founder to a broader, more democratic service structure.

Regional cooperation was tangible at the May 24 meeting in Harrisburg George R. remembered, "The guys from Wilkes-Barre wanted us to volunteer.

each area brought what was going on and shared it."

June brought logistical struggles. The hotline was shut off until the Freedom Group and John lent money to cover the bill. Terica was mailing out to TV anc radio outlets. Institutional commitments were divided among host groups, and ECCNA registrations climbed to 230, with expectations of 400.

The Mid-Eastern Region to Mid-Atlantic Region

In early May, George represented the "Mid-Eastern Region" (a term coined for lack of a better name) at the WSC in Los Angeles. The name "Mid-Eastern" would soon give way to something more enduring: the Mid-Atlantic Region. George R. stated "Right before I went out to the conference, we were arguing Over it. John F. wanted to call it the New Hope region. We were dead set and no fucking way is it going to be called the New Hope Region because we felt that he wanted to call it that because the New Hope in Pennsylvania was a gay area. And so anyway, we wound up going out to the WSC without a name for our region " The region boasted five hotlines and around 100 meetings.

George R. recalled: "I wasn't going as a representative; I was going just to attend the World Conference... I realized we didn't have any representation... Larry N. said he'd be alternate only if I was the representative. It was very difficult going out there. Jimmy yelled at me."

By July, the need for regional unity became undeniable. On July 10, the proposed RSC of the "North Eastern - Mid Atlantic Region" prepared to meet. A week later, they gathered at Trinity Church in Wilmington. Five areas were represented: DC Metro, New Jersey, Baltimore, Harrisburg/Williamsport, and Philadelphia. Reports detailed hotline activity, literature needs, and institutional efforts. John F. led the meeting and promised elections at the next session in October. A motion passed: the region would now be called the Mid-Atlantic Region. They would soon submit a bid to host the World Convention in Hershey, Pennsylvania.

Meanwhile in Delaware, grassroots service thrived amid scarcity. Meetings at TRIAD in Wilmington were sparse but dedicated. Pat P. recalled, "There weren't that many people... maybe 6 to 10." Bill O. added, "We didn't have a key. We had to go up the fire escape and climb in a window." Pamphlets under review for the 1983 WSC were copied locally by Nick and Kathy D. Despite being unofficial, they filled an urgent need. In August, the ASC established a two-year clean time requirement for service. Dress codes at institutions were questioned, and NA appeared on TV again. Institutional commitments expanded. September marked a new address for the ASC: the First Unitarian Church on Chestnut Street in Philadelphia. Controversies arose. Could strict alcoholics speak at NA meetings? Was it acceptable to read from the Grey Book? Could using addicts attend? Each issue was left to the group's discretion, guided by the Traditions.

October 11 marked the first ASC at the First Unitarian Church. Elections were held, with John F. of Wilmington becoming Chair. The administrative team now reflected an organized body with clearly defined roles across the tri-state area.

Pat P. remembered a quiet but meaningful moment from October at the ASC meeting held at TRIAD in Wilmington, Delaware, offering Wild Bill a ride home after others wouldn't. "I was just so intrigued by this guy. Six years later, I asked him to sponsor me."

The December Philadelphia ASC brought the year full circle. A structure had emerged from chaos. A region had taken form. Literature, policy, fellowship, and identity were all being shaped in real time by a few dozen addicts who believed that the NA message could and must grow.

What had begun in basements and borrowed rooms was now linked by hotlines, conventions, pamphlets, and faith. The Mid-Atlantic Region stood, not in polished perfection, but in raw willingness—a new voice rising for the addict who still suffers.

1982 - The Expansion and Structuring of NA

The year 1982 opened with determined momentum, as the spirit of service and structural growth flourished across the Northeastern and Mid-Atlantic

Narcotics Anonymous fellowship. The past decade had seen the fellowship in Pennsylvania grow from a handful of fragile groups into the largest regional body in NA, encompassing more than 80 active meetings. With the growth came the growing pains—questions of finance, representation, and organizational clarity—but also the flowering of a spirited culture of events, newsletters, and inter-area connection that made recovery feel both possible and alive. Recovering addicts were not just finding personal recovery but were building the infrastructure for a sustainable, responsive service system. The work was done meeting by meeting, city by city, and region by region.

On January 3, 1982, the Little Apple ASC convened for its first meeting at St. John's United Church of Christ at 6th and Walnut Street in Allentown, Pennsylvania. Only a week later, on January 10, the Philadelphia ASC met at 21st and Chestnut Streets, continuing its consistent and vital monthly work.

Just two weeks into the new year, a significant milestone in regional unity and expansion unfolded. On January 23, the Mid-Atlantic RSC gathered in Passaic, New Jersey, amidst a fierce snowstorm that did little to deter the devoted members who made the treacherous journey from all corners of the region. It was a testament to the resolve of the fellowship. This meeting officially recognized three new areas: New York City, Allentown, and Tidewater/Virginia Beach. John F. was elected Regional Service Representative (RSR)-Alternate, Steve H. of New Jersey was elected Treasurer, and Betsy F. was also voted into office. The region now spanned eight areas with impressive reports of nearly 200 meetings. New York City, 9 meetings; Tidewater/Virginia Beach, 6 meetings; Allentown, 8 meetings, a hotline, and active poster distribution; Baltimore, expanding institutional meetings; Philadelphia, 80 meetings, with 15 new groups joining in December; New Jersey, estimated 30 meetings and growing; Washington, D.C., 33 meetings; and Baltimore (again reported), 12 meetings.

Dutch remembered this era vividly: "We were the very first region outside of what was called the whole Mid-Atlantic, which was east of the Mississippi, to have a voice. We did it because we wanted Philadelphia to have a voice … Southern California had all the juice."

John F. contextualized it further: "At the beginning, at the end of the '70s two area service committees from Harrisburg and Philadelphia formed the Mid-Atlantic

region... Eventually, we stretched as far north as Boston and south to Virginia Beach, and inland to Washington." By February, the service wheels were spinning even faster. The Little Apple Area met again on February 12 at Trinity Youth Center in Allentown. The next day, February 13, the Mid-Atlantic Region and Literature Conference convened in College Park, Maryland. Hosted by the Washington D.C. The event drew 150 addicts, highlighting the strength of recovery in the Black community there. With the addition of Connecticut and Delaware, the region now included 10 areas, representing 20s groups, 287 weekly meetings, and 32 H&I commitments. The voice of 1,435 recovering addicts was being heard. On February 14, multiple area meetings took place, including Philadelphia's (again at 21st & Chestnut), South-Central Pennsylvania's in Harrisburg, and a newsletter was issued to celebrate the progress. South-Central Pennsylvania listed officers like Frank M. (H&I), John R. (Literature), Brad S. (Newsletter), John F.

(Social), and Cindy P. (ASC Minutes), supported by local contact numbers in Harrisburg, Reading, Lancaster, and Lebanon.

March 6 saw another Mid-Atlantic Regional Meeting in Hulmeville, Pennsylvania. Two more areas, Connecticut and Harrisburg, were welcomed. Now boasting 12 areas, the region chose to delay voting on revisions to the Service Manual to allow groups time for review. Support for the Big Book was unanimous.

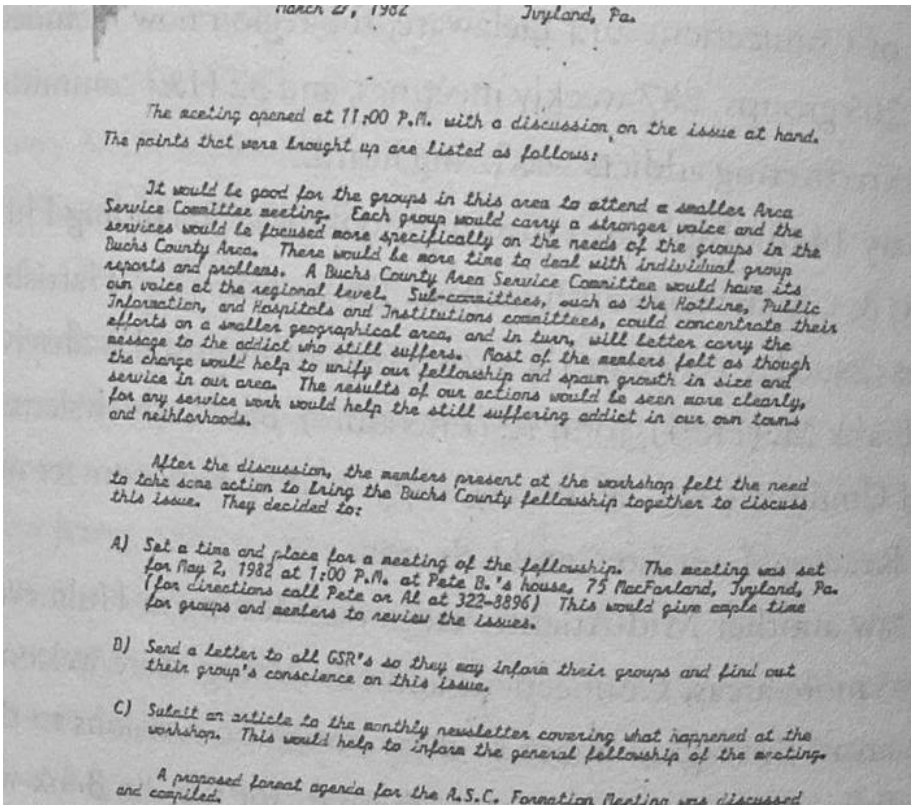
At the same time, nominations for the World Board of Trustees were sought from the Philadelphia areas. Among those nominated were George R., Joe C., and Ray T.-members whose leadership and service had helped anchor the area's identity and continuity.

Throughout March, service committees continued their work. On March 14, area meetings took place in Philadelphia, Delaware State (Delaware County), and South-Central Pennsylvania. The Delaware Area meeting at TRIAD in Wilmington, included groups such as Talking Heads, Media, Delaware Step, and more.

Ray P. served as Area Service Representative (ASR), George W. as Alternate, and Maggie as Secretary.

One workshop stood out: a serious discussion about whether Bucks County should form its own ASC. The vision of an autonomous Bucks County service

area was becoming more than an idea—it was beginning to root itself in the soil of fellowship. The idea was to allow groups in Bucks County to form their own ASC, ensuring their voices could be more directly heard, and services more localized. On March 27, while attendance was modest, the conversation was bold. Ten Bucks County members attended, joined by Philadelphia-area members and even two guests from Atlanta.



March 27, 1982 Ivyland, Pa.

The meeting opened at 11:00 P.M. with a discussion on the issue at hand. The points that were brought up are listed as follows:

It would be good for the groups in this area to attend a smaller Area Service Committee meeting. Each group would carry a stronger voice and the services would be focused more specifically on the needs of the groups in the Bucks County Area. There would be more time to deal with individual group reports and problems. A Bucks County Area Service Committee would have its own voice at the regional level. Sub-committees, such as the Hotline, Public Information, and Hospitals and Institutions committees, could concentrate their efforts on a smaller geographical area, and in turn, will better carry the message to the addict who still suffers. Most of the members felt as though the change would help to unify our fellowship and spawn growth in size and service in our area. The results of our actions would be seen more clearly, for any service work would help the still suffering addict in our own towns and neighborhoods.

After the discussion, the members present at the workshop felt the need to take some action to bring the Bucks County fellowship together to discuss this issue. They decided to:

A) Set a time and place for a meeting of the fellowship. The meeting was set for May 2, 1982 at 1:00 P.M. at Pete B.'s house, 75 MacFarland, Ivyland, Pa. (for directions call Pete or Al at 322-8896) This would give ample time for groups and members to review the issues.

B) Send a letter to all GSR's so they may inform their groups and find out their group's conscience on this issue.

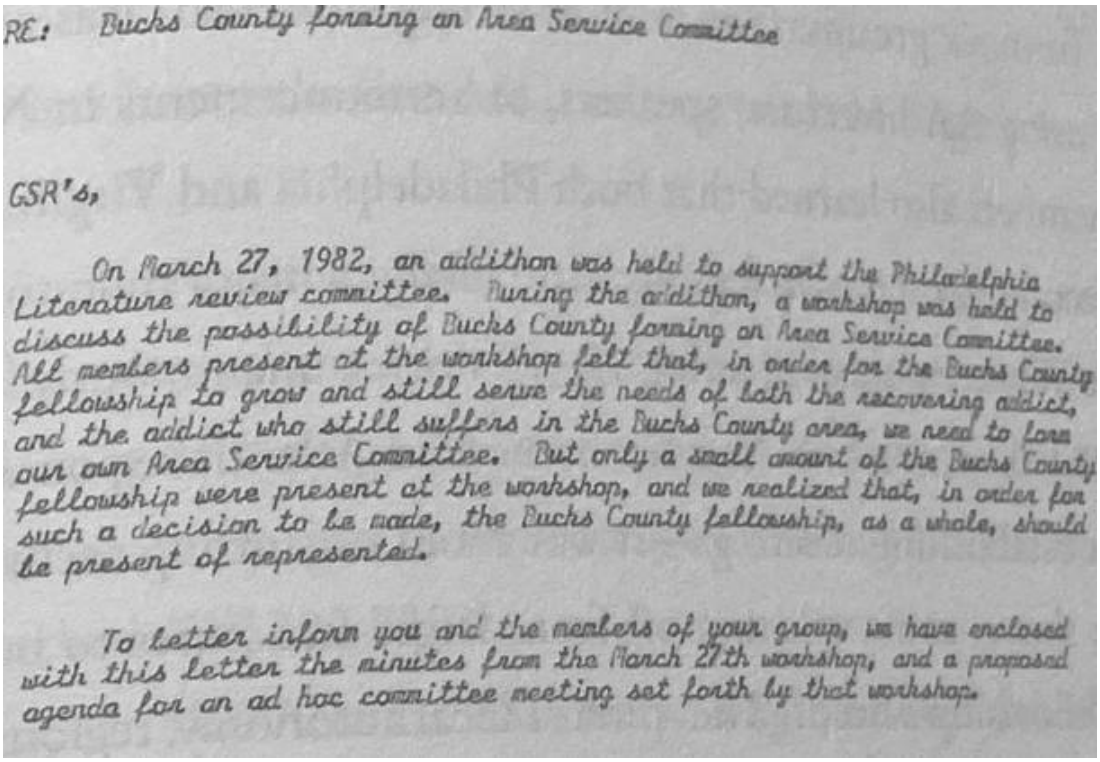
C) Solicit an article to the monthly newsletter covering what happened at the workshop. This would help to inform the general fellowship of the meeting.

A proposed format agenda for the A.S.C. Formation Meeting was discussed and compiled.

The proposal outlined an agenda for a May 2 meeting in Ivyland, including detailed procedures for officer elections, subcommittee formation, and foundational decisions about eligibility and responsibilities.

The March 27th letter from “Concerned Members of Bucks County NA” stressed gratitude for Philadelphia’s support but emphasized the need for a separate service structure to match the area’s explosive growth. “To many members what we are proposing may seem both radical and scary,” the letter read, “but we must not sell ourselves short.”

GSR's,



RE: Bucks County forming an Area Service Committee

GSR's,

On March 27, 1982, an addithon was held to support the Philadelphia Literature review committee. During the addithon, a workshop was held to discuss the possibility of Bucks County forming an Area Service Committee. All members present at the workshop felt that, in order for the Bucks County fellowship to grow and still serve the needs of both the recovering addict, and the addict who still suffers in the Bucks County area, we need to form our own Area Service Committee. But only a small amount of the Bucks County fellowship were present at the workshop, and we realized that, in order for such a decision to be made, the Bucks County fellowship, as a whole, should be present of represented.

To better inform you and the members of your group, we have enclosed with this letter the minutes from the March 27th workshop, and a proposed agenda for an ad hoc committee meeting set forth by that workshop.

April and May brought more milestones. On April 4, South-Central Pennsylvania met again in Lancaster. Philadelphia met on April 11. The first Bucks County ASC meeting took place on May 2, in the grassy corral outside the farmhouse at 75 McFarland Avenue in Ivyland. Eleven groups attended. Key items included H&I outreach to Bucks County Rehab, discussions on fundraising in line with Traditions, and the structuring of voting protocols. The group agreed that GSRs would bring group conscience to the ASC, and that Only GSRs would vote. Jane G. served as the first Bucks County Chair, and Pete B. as Vice-Chair. The farmhouse in Ivyland would remain a central hub of recovery, fellowship, and service.

On May 9, a Philadelphia ASC was held at 22nd & Chestnut, with donations from groups like Oxford Circle, Serenity Group, Great to Be Alive, Pebble Hill, and Lansdale. Dutch met with Bill O., Maggie, and John F. to discuss starting a new area combining Delaware, Chester County, and Delaware County. The seed of a new region was forming.

Meanwhile, South-Central Pennsylvania gathered in Reading on the same day, with six groups participating.

On June S, the Mid-Atlantic Region met again, this time in Tidewater, Virginia. The following areas were recognized and accepted: Richmond (3 groups); Peninsula Area (5 groups, 150 members); Bucks Area (13 groups); Tidewater Southside (7 meetings, 2 new in Norfolk); Washington, D.C. (35 meetings, 5 institutions); Baltimore (15-16 meetings, 2,000 members); Little Apple (2 new meetings); and Connecticut (11 meetings, not yet an area, but given a vote).

Also on June 13, South-Central Pennsylvania met in Harrisburg, with representation from six groups. One item of strong consensus was a shared opinion against using AA literature, speakers, or announcements in NA meetings. That day, members also learned that both Philadelphia and Virginia were in the process of becoming their own regions. And finally, a major milestone: the WSC approved the White Book, containing 12-15 stories, unanimously.

By July 1982, the vision of NA service in the Mid-Atlantic region was no longer merely about establishing meetings-it was about organizing them. New ASCs began taking shape, some splitting off from larger structures to better address the growing fellowship's needs. The spirit of local autonomy, regional unity, and grassroots action flourished as NA members across the Eastern Seaboard came together in living rooms, basements, farmhouses, and churches to give shape to what would become an enduring service legacy.

On July 11, 1982, the Bucks County ASC met at its now-familiar gathering place, the farmhouse at 75 MacFarland Avenue in Ivyland. Only six groups were represented—a modest showing, but a significant one. At this meeting, Bucks County was formally accepted into the Mid-Atlantic Region. Among the items of business were efforts to bolster the Regional Literature Committee's newsletter. Pete B. and an Allentown addict offered to coordinate input.

Envelopes labeled "Newsletter Input" would be distributed to groups, with hopes for submissions by August 31.

Mike L. raised a concern that the hotline desperately needed women's phone numbers, especially in Levittown. There was a need for new meeting lists, and the Literature Committee noted a discrepancy in the "Who-What-How-Why" pamphlet, which lacked a "Why" section. Pete committed to checking its presence in the White Book. Mike F. proposed making literature more available to H&I committees—a motion tabled until the next meeting pending group input.

Elsewhere, the South-Central Pennsylvania ASC met on the same day in Lebanon. And by late July, Bucks reconvened again in Ivyland. Meanwhile, further north, structural change was underway. The Northern Pennsylvania ASC officially split. The newly formed North-Central Pennsylvania ASC (NCPASC) included towns like Lewisburg, Danville, Sunbury, and Bloomsburg. The

Scranton-Wilkes Barre ASC covered its namesake cities. Simultaneously, Mount Pocono groups joined the Allentown Area for stability. In Southern New Jersey, the first ASC meeting was held August 1st in Ocean City, chaired by Ray T. On August 15, three notable ASC meetings took place: South-Central Pennsylvania met in Lancaster; the newly formed NCPASC held its first formal meeting, electing officers and forming Literature, H&I, PI, and newsletter committees. They also hosted monthly dances and managed five institutional meetings. A hotline was launched: 717-322-7289. That same day, the Mid-Atlantic RSC met in Virginia Beach. John F. recalled: "We stayed in people's houses, and one night we went skinny dipping in the Atlantic Ocean. George R. took Al R. to that meeting." By August 29, the Bucks County ASC met again in Ivyland, with ten groups represented. The H&I subcommittee reported that Penndel Mental Health and Pottstown Rehab were requesting meetings. The PI subcommittee divided its responsibilities into four categories: TV, form letters, posters/stickers, and a speaking engagement system. The area now boasted 14 meetings, and ideas like wallet-sized cards with the Serenity Prayer and phone list discussions were on the table. A Literature Review Committee was formally created.

The expansion of NA brought with it questions of financial accountability and tradition. On September 3, 1982, Chuck S., Chairman of the Board of Trustees, read aloud a letter from Bobby B. of Philadelphia (dated July 14) concerning fundraising monies. The Board issued an official response on August 7. While the details of the correspondence aren't recorded, its inclusion reflects the growing pains of a fellowship learning to balance spirit-led action with structural integrity.

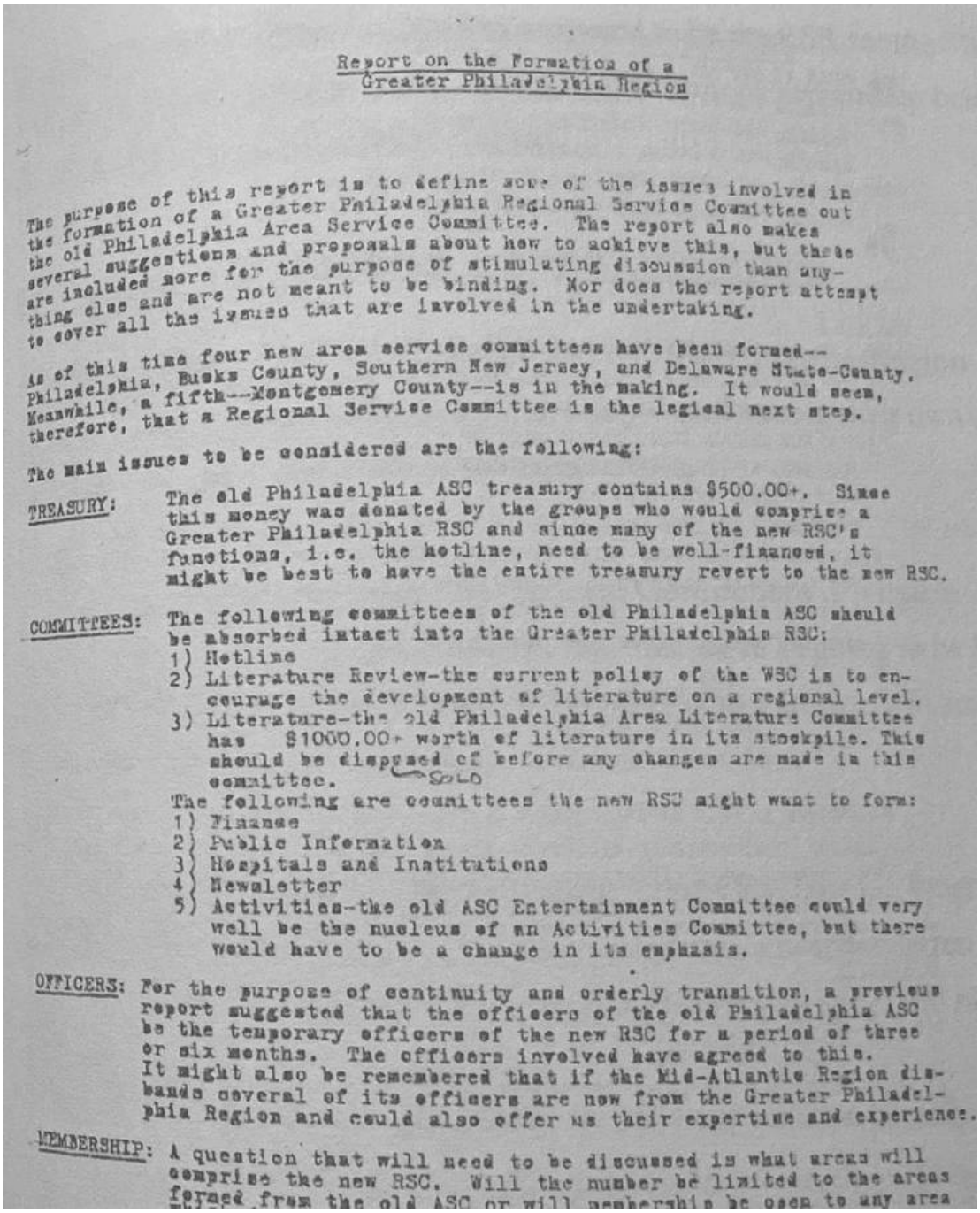
The Birth of the Greater Philadelphia Region

September 5 saw seismic changes. The Philadelphia ASC split into three separate areas: Philadelphia, Delaware State/Delaware County, and Southern New Jersey. Each new area held their own service meetings.

A week later, on September 11, the Mid-Atlantic Region convened in Allentown. The meeting included food, a California-style meeting, and a dance.

George R. remembered: "I called them luncheons. I had no idea it was actually a regional meeting... it was more of an exchange of information." Area reports were robust: Bucks County (joining the Greater Philadelphia Region): 16 meetings; South-Central Pennsylvania: 19 meetings and 7 institutional; North Central Pennsylvania: 11 meetings and 5 institutional; Little Apple: 13 meetings; Connecticut: 13 meetings and 2 institutional; and Baltimore, Richmond, Tidewater, and Peninsula areas all reported plans to withdraw. Bill presented the first draft of a regional newsletter; Frank distributed the 3rd draft of the H&I Handbook.

On September 19, a pre-regional meeting was held at 22nd & Chestnut. A Comprehensive report proposed the formation of the Greater Philadelphia Region. By this time, five new areas were in place: Philadelphia, Bucks County, South Jersey, Delaware State-County, and the budding Montgomery County.



Report on the Formation of a
Greater Philadelphia Region

The purpose of this report is to define some of the issues involved in the formation of a Greater Philadelphia Regional Service Committee out the old Philadelphia Area Service Committee. The report also makes several suggestions and proposals about how to achieve this, but these are included more for the purpose of stimulating discussion than anything else and are not meant to be binding. Nor does the report attempt to cover all the issues that are involved in the undertaking.

As of this time four new area service committees have been formed--Philadelphia, Bucks County, Southern New Jersey, and Delaware State-County. Meanwhile, a fifth--Montgomery County--is in the making. It would seem, therefore, that a Regional Service Committee is the logical next step.

The main issues to be considered are the following:

TREASURY: The old Philadelphia ASC treasury contains $500.00+. Since this money was donated by the groups who would comprise a Greater Philadelphia RSC and since many of the new RSC's functions, i.e. the hotline, need to be well-financed, it might be best to have the entire treasury revert to the new RSC.

COMMITTEES: The following committees of the old Philadelphia ASC should be absorbed intact into the Greater Philadelphia RSC:

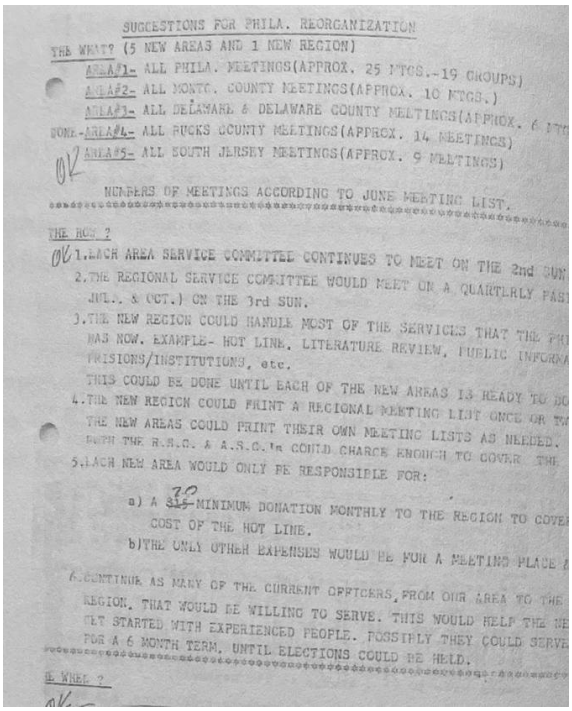
1) Hotline
2) Literature Review-the current policy of the WSC is to encourage the development of literature on a regional level.
3) Literature-the old Philadelphia Area Literature Committee has $1000.00+ worth of literature in its stockpile. This should be disposed of before any changes are made in this committee. SOLD

The following are committees the new RSC might want to form:

1) Finance
2) Public Information
3) Hospitals and Institutions
4) Newsletter
5) Activities-the old ASC Entertainment Committee could very well be the nucleus of an Activities Committee, but there would have to be a change in its emphasis.

OFFICERS: For the purpose of continuity and orderly transition, a previous report suggested that the officers of the old Philadelphia ASC be the temporary officers of the new RSC for a period of three or six months. The officers involved have agreed to this. It might also be remembered that if the Mid-Atlantic Region disbands several of its officers are now from the Greater Philadelphia Region and could also offer us their expertise and experience.

MEMBERSHIP: A question that will need to be discussed is what areas will comprise the new RSC. Will the number be limited to the areas formed from the old ASC or will membership be open to any area



SUGGESTIONS FOR PHILA. REORGANIZATION

THE WHAT? (5 NEW AREAS AND 1 NEW REGION)

AREA#1- ALL PHILA. MEETINGS(APPROX. 25 MTGS.-19 GROUPS)
AREA#2- ALL MONTG. COUNTY MEETINGS(APPROX. 10 MTGS.)
AREA#3- ALL DELAWARE & DELAWARE COUNTY MEETINGS(APPROX. 6 MTG
DONE-AREA#4- ALL BUCKS COUNTY MEETINGS(APPROX. 14 MEETINGS)
AREA#5- ALL SOUTH JERSEY MEETINGS(APPROX. 9 MEETINGS)

NUMBERS OF MEETINGS ACCORDING TO JUNE MEETING LIST.

THE HOW ?

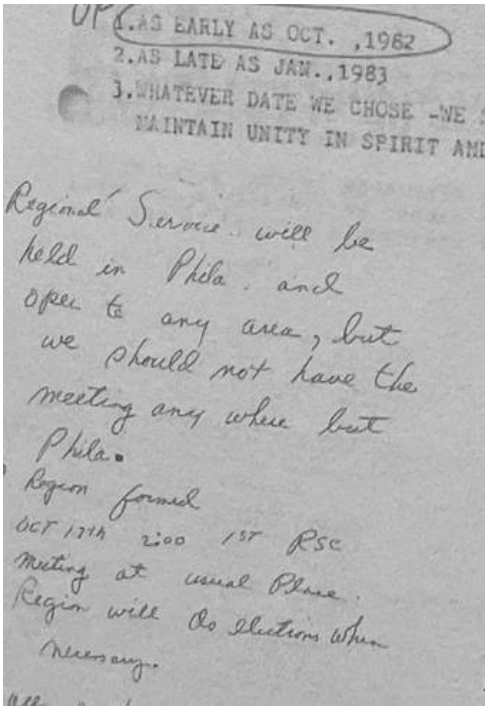
1.EACH AREA SERVICE COMMITTEE CONTINUES TO MEET ON THE 2nd SUN
2.THE REGIONAL SERVICE COMMITTEE WOULD MEET ON A QUARTERLY BAS
JUL., & OCT.) ON THE 3rd SUN.
3.THE NEW REGION COULD HANDLE MOST OF THE SERVICES THAT THE PH
HAS NOW. EXAMPLE- HOT LINE, LITERATURE REVIEW, PUBLIC INFORMA
VISIONS/INSTITUTIONS, etc.
THIS COULD BE DONE UNTIL EACH OF THE NEW AREAS IS READY TO DO
4.THE NEW REGION COULD PRINT A REGIONAL MEETING LIST ONCE OR TW
THE NEW AREAS COULD PRINT THEIR OWN MEETING LISTS AS NEEDED.
BOTH THE R.S.C. & A.S.C.'s COULD CHARGE ENOUGH TO COVER THE
5.EACH NEW AREA WOULD ONLY BE RESPONSIBLE FOR:

a) A ~~$15~~ 70 MINIMUM DONATION MONTHLY TO THE REGION TO COVE
COST OF THE HOT LINE.
b)THE ONLY OTHER EXPENSES WOULD BE FOR A MEETING PLACE

6.CONTINUE AS MANY OF THE CURRENT OFFICERS, FROM OUR AREA TO THE
REGION, THAT WOULD BE WILLING TO SERVE. THIS WOULD HELP THE NE
GET STARTED WITH EXPERIENCED PEOPLE. POSSIBLY THEY COULD SERVE
FOR A 6 MONTH TERM, UNTIL ELECTIONS COULD BE HELD.

THE WHEN ?

The report called for the transfer of all treasury funds and assets from the old ASC to the new regional body. It recommended carrying over existing officers to ensure a smooth transition and proposed that the new RSC manage services like the hotline, literature review, and PI until each area could take on those roles.



1.AS EARLY AS OCT. ,1982
2.AS LATE AS JAN.,1983
3.WHATEVER DATE WE CHOSE -WE
MAINTAIN UNITY IN SPIRIT AN

Regional Service will be held in Phila. and open to any area, but we should not have the meeting any where but Phila.
Region formed
OCT 17th 2:00 1ST RSC meeting at usual Place. Region will do elections when necessary.

The watershed moment came October 17, when the first Greater Philadelphia RSC meeting convened at the First Unitarian Church in Philadelphia. John F. recalled: “They elected me the first chair, and we didn’t know any better then they also

elected me the RSR-Alternate. So, I'm supposed to be the RSR for the Mid-Atlantic, but we don't belong to the Mid-Atlantic anymore, so I end up being the RSR for the Greater Philadelphia Region."

The Last Time in One Place

The following week, on October 24, the Mid-Atlantic Region met in Allentown. Area reports highlighted that many were forming their own regional structures. George R. reflected on the camaraderie:

Those people over there, they're from Connecticut... Virginia..

Philly... And this is probably the last time we're all going to be in One place because after today, these other places are going to start their own regional meetings.

On November 28, the NENJASC met in Jersey City. Jane G., longtime secretary of the Mid-Atlantic Region, formally resigned in a heartfelt letter: "You have taught me a great deal and helped me to grow. Thank you again and may God be with you."

December 4, the Mid-Atlantic RSC met in Milford, Connecticut. Membership reports included: South-Central Pennsylvania: 25 meetings, 11 institutional; Connecticut: 14 regular and 2 institutional; Little Apple: 15 meetings; Northeast New Jersey: 17 meetings (up from 9); and Massachusetts: 14 meetings (13 Massachusetts, 1 New Hampshire). Bucks County was formally removed from the region, having joined the new Greater Philadelphia Region. New York also withdrew.

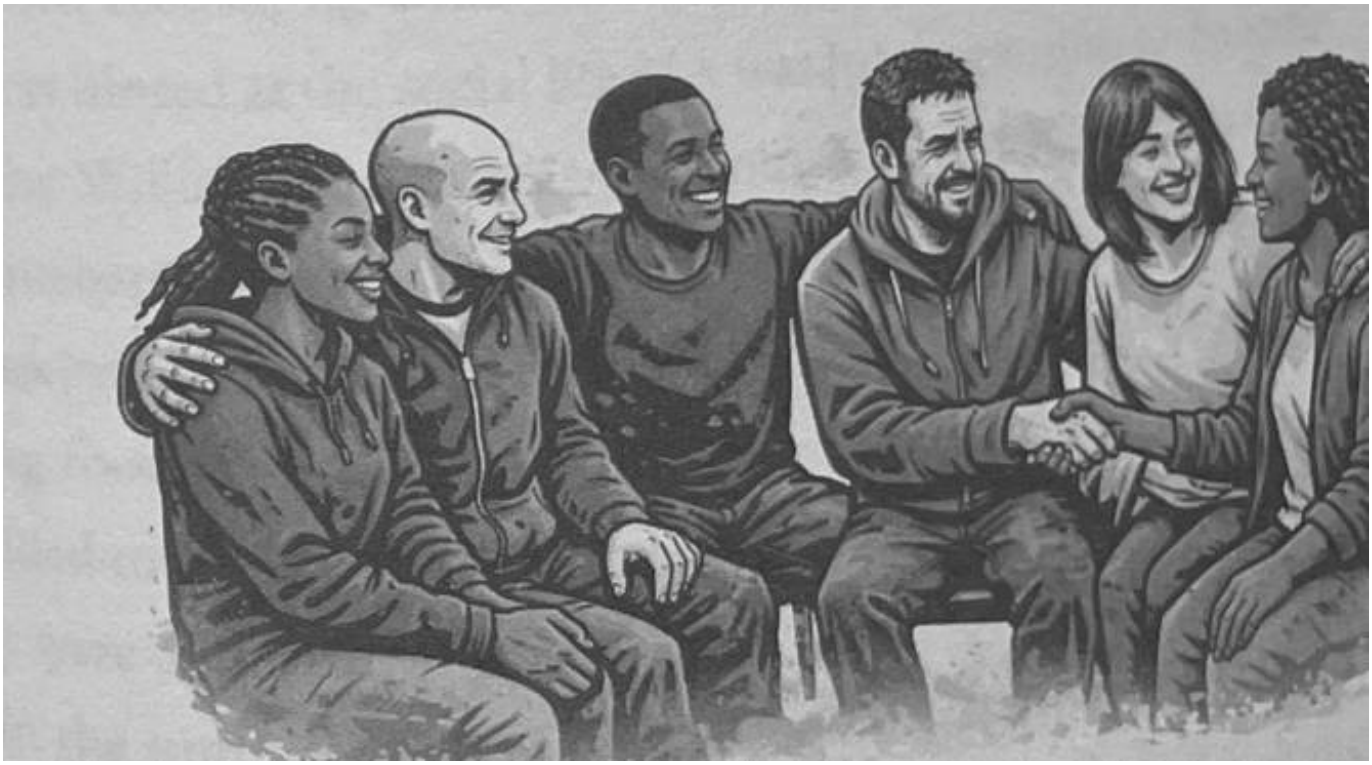
On December 26, the Bucks County ASC met in Ivyland. Eight groups attended. Paul Z. was elected as the new ASR. Outreach efforts to groups not in attendance were initiated. A service workshop followed the next day.

This period in 1982 was a vivid portrait of NA's growth through action. The fellowship didn't wait for perfect structures to begin serving. Instead, they responded to need with courage, flexibility, and principle. Meetings in basements, backyards, and church halls became the laboratories of service, and the voices of

recovering addicts began to echo from Ivyland to College Park, from Wilmington to New York. The message was clear: "We do recover" — and we organize to make sure others can too.

By year's end, the spirit of service had outpaced its structures. The old had given way to the new, not with rupture but with reverence. The Philadelphia ASC, once a single entity overseeing an immense swath of NA meetings, had successfully transformed into a constellation of five autonomous areas, joined under the freshly formed Greater Philadelphia Region. What began as informal gatherings in kitchens and churches had matured into a movement of governance, fellowship, and principle-driven action.

FELLOWSHIP

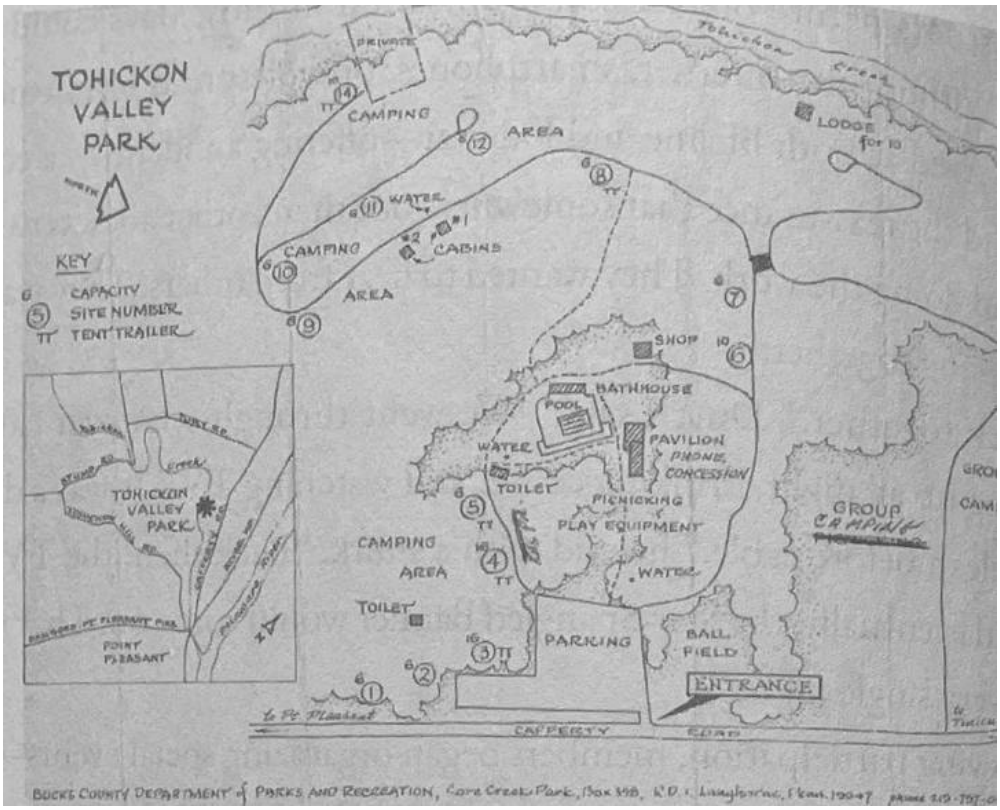


The grassroots nature of NA communication in those days could not be overstated. Without the Internet, smartphones, or widespread infrastructure, a newsletter served as both lifeline and lodestar-offering an identity, a common language, and the reassurance that somewhere out there, other addicts were staying clean and doing the work. They wanted to hear from others. They wanted to build something together. "We stuck together," Dutch said. "We went through whatever came our way—staying up all night, drinking coffee, and watching Tv." It was a different era. "I got clean before cable," he said with a smirk. "Back then, the TV played all night, and eventually, the Star-Spangled Banner would come on. That was our routine-every single night." With growing participation, members began organizing social events—camping trips, dances, and shared experiences that helped build the spiritual glue between recovering addicts. The sober dances held at the 4021 Club, and its success hinted at the social life NA was just beginning to discover.

The Williamsport retreat/campout was held Labor Day weekend across the Susquehanna River from White Deer, Pennsylvania, in 1973. Part of the area was a junkyard but not where they were camping. They joked about having caterers bring food into the junkyard for the campout. During this time Intergroup decided to remove the Williamsport and Lewisburg groups from the meeting list that were doing urine testing.

In the summer of 1974, something quiet but powerful took root in the heart of Philadelphia's recovering community: "N.A. News," Volume 1, Number I.

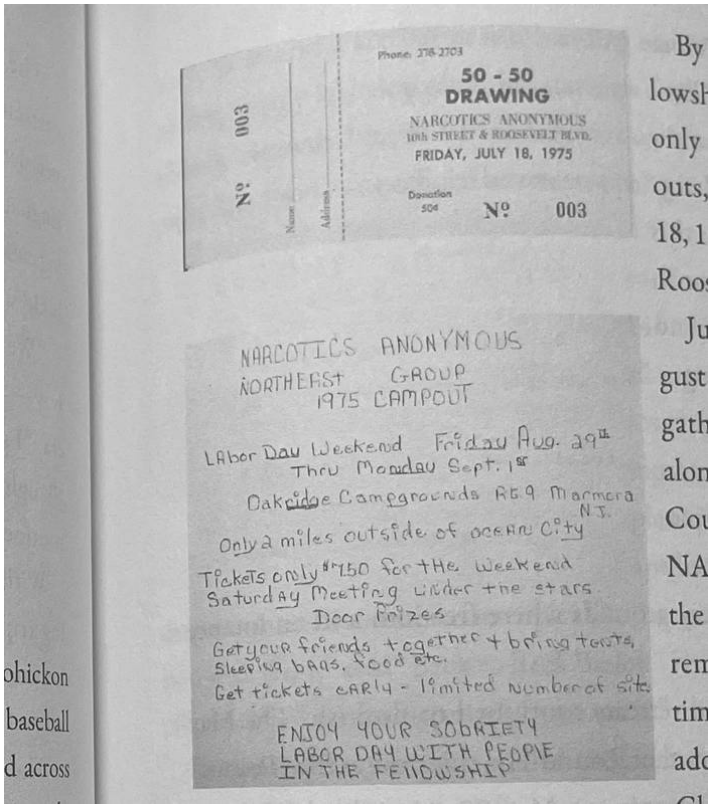
The modest, typewritten newsletter opened with a humble declaration: "This newsletter is a beginning for us to share with you." It wasn't just a collection of announcements or reflections-it was a call to action. Issued from the Literature and PR Committees at 6261 North Broad Street, this small publication invited Input, shared experience, and built a fragile but deliberate thread of unity across a still-young and scattered Narcotics Anonymous fellowship.



The Second Annual Intergroup Round-Up took place on July 21 at Tohickon Valley Park in Bucks County. Families brought their children. There were baseball games, swimming, a volleyball tournament, and a catered dinner shared across long picnic tables. According to “N.A. News,” published the following month: “Well over 50 sober people sat in enthusiastic talk … the most outstanding feelings from the entire picnic were people laughing, talking, and enjoying themselves in sobriety. Being sober and being able to do all the fun things they’ve always wanted to do—together.”

The Malvern Retreat House hosted annual recovery-focused retreats at Saint Joseph’s in the Hills in Malvern, Pennsylvania. During August 16–18 of 1974, one such retreat attracted and photographed nine addicts sitting around a table; Dave F., Larry, Jim B., Bob M., Jerry S., Joe M., Johnny C., Ralph S., and Jim H. They called themselves the 8/3 - Men of Malvern. The 8/3 was in reference to the retreat being held in the 3rd week of the 8th month. Another photograph taken at an undetermined date showed ten addicts standing outside the retreat including Bob M., Jerry S., Dutch H., Jimmy B., John C. amongst the others.

By the following year, a spirit of fellowship continued to swell—seen not only in meetings but in dances, cookouts, fundraisers, and campouts. July 18, 1975, saw a 50/50 drawing at 10th & Roosevelt Boulevard.

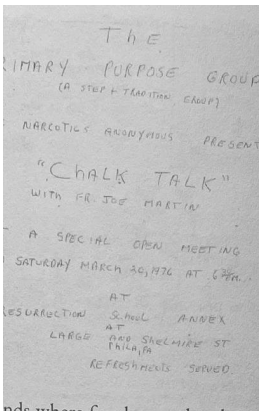


Just two weeks after that, from August 29 to September 1, 1975, members gathered at Oakridge Campgrounds along Route 9 in Marmora, Cape May County, New Jersey, for a memorable NA/Al-Anon Round-Up. Organized by the Northeast Group, this campout was remembered fondly: “just a real nice time” spent “fellowshipping with other addicts and not being all drugged up.”

Clean fun, in nature, with community—this was the kind of experience early NA offered in place of what drugs once promised.

In the fall, the momentum continued. On September 19, another 50/50 drawing brought members back to 10th & Roosevelt, a familiar location for outreach and fundraising.

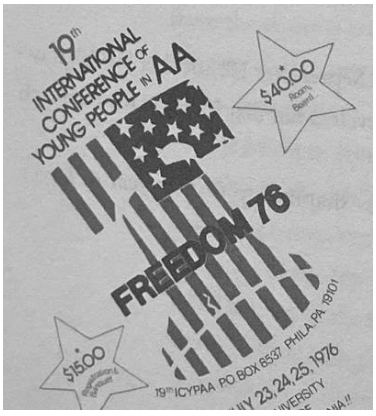
But it wasn’t all about events—1976 was shaping up to be a year of larger visibility and deeper coordination.



On March 20, 1976, the Primary Purpose Group presented “Chalk Talk” with Father Joe M., hosted at the Resurrection School Annex on Large and Shelmire Streets. Events like this bridged the spiritual and the communal, grounding recovery in both message and shared experience. That same spring, a bicentennial spirit swept the country, and NA was no exception. Dwayne, an early member, remembered a large picnic in Valley Forge Park—symbolically powerful, linking recovery to the very grounds where freedom and endurance were once tested.

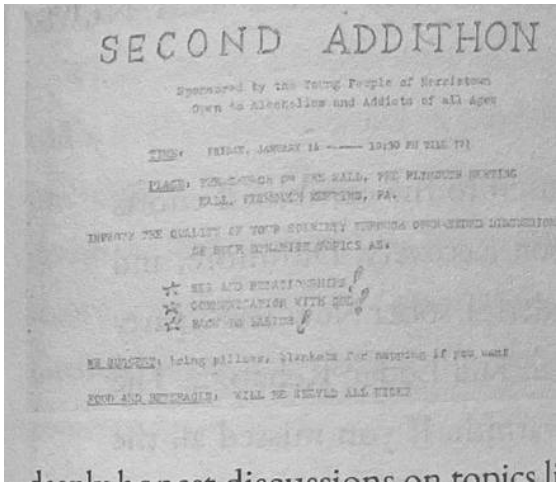
Fellowship through campouts and retreats continued to flourish. The May 1976 Intergroup minutes described another Round-Up, this time at the “Peanut” Public Camp in Collegeville, Pennsylvania, on May 23. Most likely this was referring to SGF (Samuel G. Friedman) summer camp located near the creek.

Perhaps most notable was NA’s intersection with the broader recovery world at the 19th International Conference of Young People in Alcoholics Anonymous (ICYPAA), held July 23–25, 1976, at the University of Pennsylvania. Nearly 1,000 young people gathered in Philadelphia—the largest such AA conference at that time. Attendees, mostly in their 20s, brought fresh energy, along with shifting identities: many introduced themselves as “alcoholic/addict,” a linguistic and cultural bridge that underscored the presence of dual-recovery members in both fellowships.



Two Sunbury-area NA members attended the conference, and its impact was immediate. Inspired by ICYPAA’s energy, they traveled on to Harrison, New

York, to attend a similar event, handing out NA White Books and IPs to attendees-only later learning that state law forbade public assembly of identified addicts. Nonetheless, NA's message was on the move, carried by foot, car, and paper handouts-unofficial but unstoppable.


SECOND ADDITHON

Sponsored by the Young People of Norristown
Open to Alcoholics and Addicts of all Ages

bring pillows, blankets for napping if you want

deeply honest discussions on topics li

The rhythm of recovery was not SECOND ADDITHON confined to daylight. On January 14-15, 1977, the second Addithon-an all-night marathon of meetings and fellowship—was held at Plymouth Meeting Mall. Sponsored by the Young People of Norristown, it was open to addicts and alcoholics of all ages and featured deeply honest discussions on topics like "Sex and Relationships," "Communication with God," and "Back to Back Basics." Flyers encouraged attendees to "bring pillows, blankets for napping if you want."

Attendees like John S. recalled the drive from Sunbury to Plymouth Meeting-a 2½/ hour trek rewarded by warm coffee, generous hospitality, and rich recovery. Dave F., in charge of coffee, remembered using double the recommended grounds to make strong Colombian Bokar, a fitting symbol for a fellowship that ran on heart and caffeine.

On Memorial Day 1977, John S., Jay M., and Danny D. of the Sunbury group drove nearly 200 miles to Lenox Hill in New York City, intent on visiting and distributing NA pamphlets to a Pills Anonymous meeting. That organization canceled their meeting because of the holiday, but the spirit behind the effort-carrying the message across distance and disappointment—spoke volumes about the fellowship's dedication.

More Addithons followed. On September 3-4, 1977, another was held at the Plymouth Meeting Mall. On September 30, Williamsport's 801 Clubhouse hosted its own marathon meeting. Irene J., an AA member from Scranton, drove Several young addicts in her Cadillac—a memory that remained emblematic of how recovery sometimes reached across program lines to bring newcomers to safe spaces.

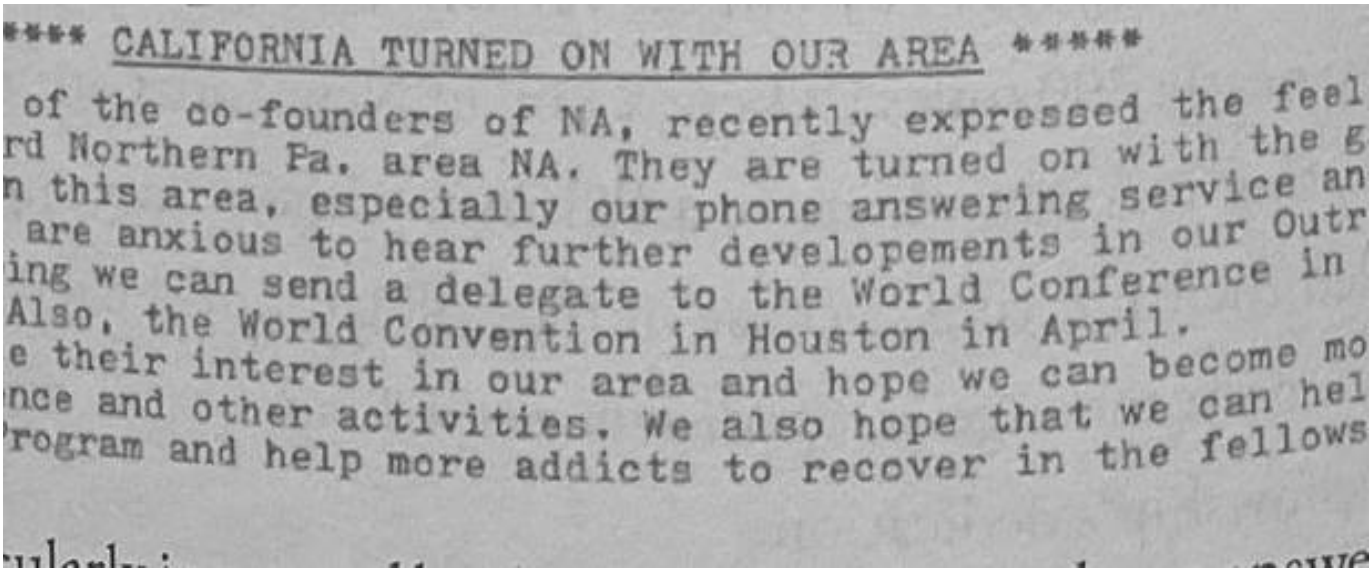
As 1977 ended, the Primary Purpose Group marked its second anniversary, December 17 with a showing of Father Martin's film "Guidelines". Events these brought stability and depth, reinforcing the message of recovery thro accessible media and consistent gatherings. Rich W. wrote the article "My First Sober New Years" to the "N.A. NFy January 1978:

I extend my gratitude and appreciation to the combined efforts of the members of the Taylor Gibson Recovery, Dunmore, and Wyoming groups of NA for the wonderful, sober New Year's party and midnight meeting held at Indian Hill Lodge Rehab. . The evening was full of laughter and warmth. If you missed all the hugging and kissing that went on at midnight, it's because you weren't there.

The following year, the North-Central Pennsylvania area of NA began its own version of "NA NEWS." In February 1978, an issue titled "Cal Turned On With Our Area" included a remarkable note: Jimmy K., NA's co-founders, had expressed deep appreciation for the growth occur Pennsylvania.

to further the Program and help more addicts to recover in the fellowship.

He was particularly impressed by the region's 24-hour phone answering and outreach efforts. This encouragement from NA's birthplace helped g East Coast fellowship momentum.



**** CALIFORNIA TURNED ON WITH OUR AREA *****

of the co-founders of NA, recently expressed the feel
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Also, the World Convention in Houston in April.
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Then came a milestone. September 21–24, 1978, WCNA-8—themed “Carry The Message”—was held in Houston, Texas. It was the first World Convention outside California. Three members of the Scranton-Dunmore fellowship in Pennsylvania made the drive, returning home energized. Their excitement sparked a new wave of local commitment.

The Primary Purpose Group celebrated its third anniversary on December 23, 1978, again showing Father Martin's Chalk Talk at the Resurrection School Annex. One day earlier, HANA held a Christmas party at the United Methodist Church on Derry Street. These events, spiritual and festive alike, closed out a year of continued expansion and emotional connection. What threads all these moments together—from campfires in Cape May to hot coffee in Plymouth Meeting, from folded newsletters in Philadelphia to canceled meetings in New York-is the desire for unity through shared effort. In all these details, a clearer picture of NA's early identity emerges-not just as a program of recovery, but as a living community, creatively adapting, deeply committed, and unafraid to try new things. Whether through all-night addithons, young people's conferences, or backyard picnics in Valley Forge, the message was the same: we do not have to do this alone.

The Role of Attraction, Not Promotion

During the spring of 1979, NA members also found connection and clarity in unlikely spaces. The Downingtown Young People's Conference—though an Alcoholics Anonymous event-was a gathering place for many young addicts. George W. recalled the weekends at Downingtown as transformative:

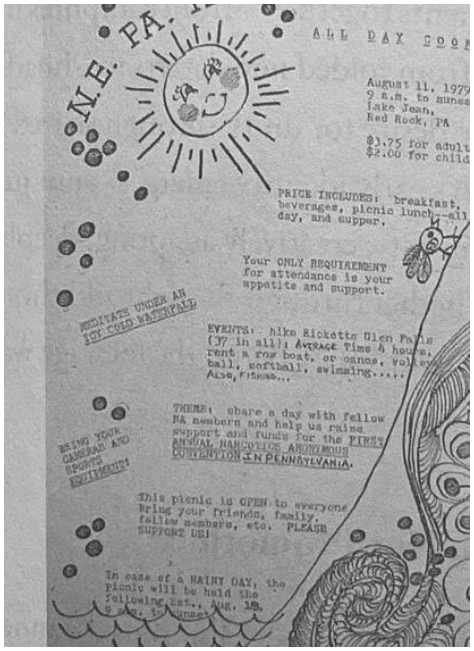
It was called "Time for Change." We had cabins with wooden floors and bunk beds. I remember praying on those bare floors, thinking maybe next time God won't mind if I use a pad. But what really stuck with me was how I felt-like part of the human race for the first time. That conference changed me.

Ken E. remembered attending: "They were AA conferences, but a lot of us addicts went. It was a spiritual connection."

Jim F. remembers one time Narcotics Anonymous had a 10 year get together with Jim H., Barber B., Dutch, and a lot of people from NA from that time frame.

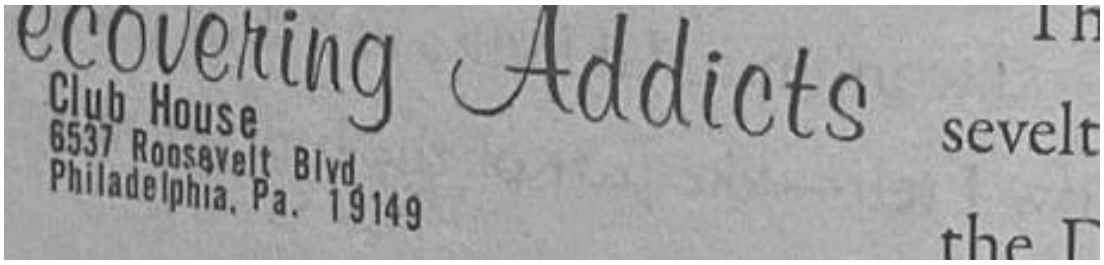
On August 11, 1979, the Northeast Pennsylvania Steering Committee held a full-day cookout at Lake Jean in Red Rock, Pennsylvania. For $3.75 (or $2

for children), members enjoyed breakfast, lunch, supper, and a range of activities—hiking, softball, canoeing—all tied to the theme: “Share a day with fellow NA members and help raise support and funds for the first annual NA Convention in Pennsylvania.”



The following year, in August 1980, four recovering addicts came together with a dream: to create a space of belonging and recovery that extended beyond meeting times. They called themselves “The Recovering Addicts,” and their goal was to start a clubhouse—not officially a part of NA, but centered around NA’s spirit and practices.

They found a location at 6537 Roosevelt Boulevard in Philadelphia, next to the Dental School. Soon, they had incorporated, drafted a charter, and begun hosting fundraisers to support the venture. These weren’t just casual affairs. Dances, spaghetti dinners, sunrise breakfasts following all-night meetings, 50/50 drawings, and addithons became regular fixtures. Within four months, the group had raised $650—a substantial achievement given the era and circumstances.



More importantly, the clubhouse efforts knit together addicts across city and county lines. Bucks County and Philadelphia members joined forces, drawn not only by a shared goal but by the fun and fellowship such events brought. The

clubhouse gave recovering addicts "something to do"—a crucial element in a life no longer centered around using. George R. remembered, "We did dances in the fire hall in Yardley, and raised money to donate to John and Debbie who started the clubhouse. We were all so young. We had a connection with the guys in the Northeast, they were just a few years older." Still, obstacles remained. They had trouble maintaining the Roosevelt Boule-yard location and would soon face the challenge of finding another suitable home. But what they had already achieved-structure, unity, and vision—spoke volumes. The articles of incorporation painted a picture of a structured, service-minded community. Membership was open to recovering addicts with 90 days of clean time, though guests with less were welcome under supervision. Voting members paid modest dues—$3 for the first month, $5 monthly thereafter. An executive board oversaw club activities, comprising a chairperson, vice-chairperson, secretary, and two treasurers, all of whom were expected to have significant clean time and good standing. The organizational expectations were high, but so was the commitment to inclusion: no restrictions based on area, age, race, religion, or lack thereof.

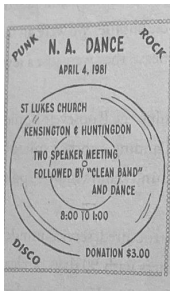
By early 1981, the Recovering Addicts' clubhouse had become a cultural hub. A Valentine's Day dance was held there on February 14, continuing the tradition of events that blended fellowship and festivity. The last record of the clubhouse existence was in 1983.

Meanwhile, the Williamsport area was maintaining its own rhythm. On May 10, 1980, a dance was held there—a small but celebratory affair. The Plymouth Meeting Mall, already the site of memorable addithons earlier in the decade, hosted another major overnight gathering on December 5-6, 1980, with 123 attendees. The calendar was filled with expressions of joy and recovery.

Another milestone arrived: "Clean Sheet," the first Philadelphia NA newsletter produced by the local Literature Committee, was published on February 28, 1981. It was delayed because of intense work on the Narcotics Anonymous Book, but the issue also turned its gaze to the future. It announced registration progress for the 2nd East Coast Convention of NA, set for June at Trenton State College, with early signs pointing to a turnout of over 300.

Outreach in Every Direction

Spring bloomed with action. On April 4, a spirited dance at St. Luke’s Church in Kensington featured two speaker meetings followed by music from the “Clean Band,” covering punk, rock, and disco until 1:00 A.M. For a $3 donation, attendees got both recovery and revelry.

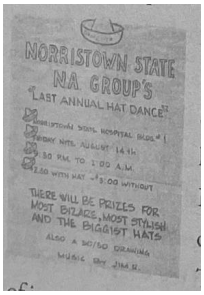


On April 24, Saint John’s UCC in Allentown hosted an Addithon at 6th and Walnut. The following month, on May 31, a Memorial Day picnic was held at the Easter Seals Pavilion grounds—another instance of service, sunshine, and togetherness.

The June 1 issue of “N.A. NEWS” (Vol 1, Issue IV) further reinforced this network. It listed contact information for WSO in California, regional P.O. Boxes in Kingston and New Cumberland, and even the upcoming East Coast Convention’s mailing hub in Doylestown. A directory was forming. A movement was being mapped.

Summer 1981 belonged to the Reality Group. On July 24, August 15, and October 6 it hosted an overnight Addithons at its Torresdale Avenue home. On August 22 the group hosted a picnic at Six Penny Lake in French Creek State Park. The group sponsored disco, punk, and rock dances at Beth Ameth on Bustleton and Unruh, September 26, on Halloween night, October 31, and December 26.

As the days shortened and leaves began to fall, the calendar filled with spirited activity. August 14 the Norristown State NA Group hosted its “Last Annual Hat Dance,” a late-night event at Norristown State Hospital’s Building #1. Entry cost $2.50 with a hat and $3.00 without—an example of the humor and heart that often softened recovery’s edges. The event ran from 9:30 P.M. to 1:00 A.M., echoing a kind of joy reclaimed from the chaos of addiction. A tradition with roots going back a few years.



Later that year, from September 4-7, WCNA-10 was held in Wichita, Kansas, under the theme, "The Ties That Bind Us." It was becoming increasingly clear that NA was evolving rapidly—and not always comfortably. One powerful story recalled how Allentown members had previously driven week after week to help stabilize a struggling meeting in Doylestown. Now, the tables had turned, and it was Allentown that needed support. The call was clear: recovery depended on mutual service, and the road went both ways. By November 1981, "Clean Sheet" Issue #3 was in circulation. It contained several noteworthy developments. First, a Regional Literature Committee had been formed, and one of its first goals was to create a Mid-Atlantic regional directory of groups, times, and contact persons. Second, Allentown was working hard to establish itself as its own service area. Later, the Mid-Atlantic RSC met in Williamsport, and on December 5, regional elections were held: Anne from Williamsport was elected Chairperson, Rich M. took on the Literature Committee.

The "Clean Sheet" also reported progress on the clubhouse effort. A constitution had been approved, funds were sufficient, and the search for a permanent location in Bucks County was underway. The goal was now real and urgent: a safe, consistent space for addicts to gather, grow, and serve.

November 20-21, 1981, the Allentown fellowship held a 24-hour Addithon beginning at 8:00 P.M. Friday night and running through Saturday evening. It drew over 200 attendees from as far as Pittsburgh and Georgia. Speakers included Debbie S. from Philadelphia, Tom N. from Atlanta, John N. from Sellersville, Cathy S. from Harrisburg. Guido A. from Williamsport, and Brenda N. from Sellersville.

One addict captured the spirit of the time: "We had over 200 people there Back then when they said people drove 200 miles to support another group, we did.

If you needed help in Virginia Beach, I'd go. Norfolk, Pittsburgh, West Virginia, Massachusetts-it didn't matter. We traveled to support one another. That was the exciting thing about our history-our growth, and the people who touched Our lives."

This era didn't just see meetings expand. It witnessed a cultural emergence: a sense of place, a rhythm of celebration, a shared identity forming in newsletters,

dances, and road trips. It was, in every sense, a clubhouse without walls—whet recovery lived in action, service, and deep connection.

On February 20, 1982, the Primary Purpose Group of NA celebrated its fifth anniversary-not its original formation, but its rebirth after regrouping. Held in the basement of Maternity BVM Church at 9220 Old Bustleton Avenue in Northeast Philadelphia, the event marked more than a passage of time. It was, celebration of renewal, of survival, and of recommitment.

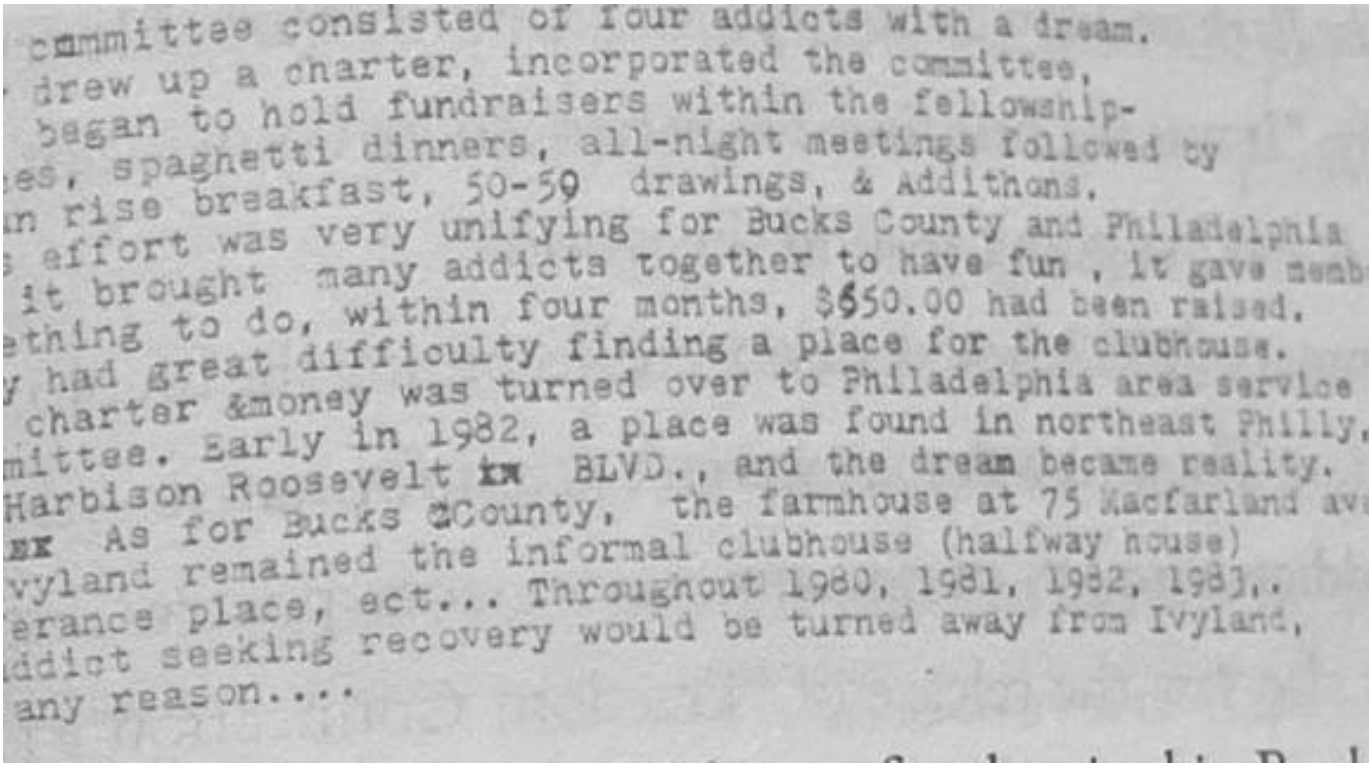
Just over a week later, the fourth issue of the "Clean Sheet" newsletter was published on March 1, 1982 by the Philadelphia Literature Review Committe. The publication now had a $50 monthly budget-an acknowledgment of its importance. The committee met weekly at 75 MacFarland Avenue in Ivyland, a site that had become an unofficial hub for meetings, halfway house activities, and service coordination. This issue voiced a quiet urgency. Of the 80 groups in the area, only 21 had contributed financially that month. The need for a formal Finance Committee was discussed, and Dutch H. was elected as its first chair. A revision of the NA Service Manual was underway, and a workshop was scheduled to go deeper into those updates.

Perhaps most significantly, the "Clean Sheet" put out a call for history. Members with personal stories or access to old meeting minutes were urged to contribute to the NA history project by contacting the Ivyland address or calling (215) 322-1552. There was also increasing recognition that the area's size had become unwieldy. The rapid growth pointed toward the need to decentralize into smaller, more manageable areas. Allentown had already made that leap—and was thriving.

On the 20th, the First Annual Spring Stomp was held at Trinity Episcopal Church in Wilmington, Delaware, showing NA's growing cross-state influence. A week later, on March 27, an Addithon was organized to support the "Clean Sheet."

Even as the Roosevelt Boulevard clubhouse effort faced ongoing challenges, the farmhouse at 75 MacFarland Avenue in Ivyland served as a de facto clubhouse, halfway house, and conference center for the Philadelphia area. Throughout 1980, 1981, and 1982, Ivyland remained a refuge for countless addicts seeking

ort. As one shared memory affirmed, "No addict seeking recovery was ever ed away from Ivyland—for any reason."


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charter &money was turned over to Philadelphia area service
mittee. Early in 1982, a place was found in northeast Philly,
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Earlier that year, the remaining clubhouse funds raised in Bucks County had en turned over to the Philadelphia ASC—a gesture of trust and unity, signal-the community's faith that the dream would continue, even if the location

Gatherings, Dances, Newsletters, and Workshops

On April 17 1982, two major events took place. One was a dance at he North Sixth Club in Reading, and the other a Philadelphia gathering titled Beyond Your Wildest Dreams," held at the intersection of Bustleton and Unruh. These events, echoing past traditions of social recovery, offered joyful spaces for clean fun and community. Then, from September 2-5, 1982, WCNA-12 was held at the Hyatt Regency in Milwaukee, Wisconsin, under the theme:

To help the addict who still suffers, to celebrate the NA way of life, and to attract anyone interested in recovery to the NA fellowship.

The fifth issue of the "Clean Sheet," released April 1, responded to a letter from WCNA-12, clarifying that conventions are celebrations, not official functions of NA as a whole, and must still follow NA's Twelve Traditions. These discussions reflected a maturing service structure, careful to uphold spiritual principles even as the fellowship grew more public-facing.

May brought more gatherings and milestones. On May 21-22, an Addithon was held in Allentown at Saint John's UCC. The following night, the Glad to Be Alive Group hosted a dance in Doylestown, while the New Jersey fellowship held a Picnic in the Park on May 23 at Cape May County Park. Henry D. recalled that picnic vividly: "It was the first time I experienced NA outside of the Philadelphia area. To me, it was like going around the world."

By the summer of 1982, newsletters were becoming the lifeblood of Intergroup communication. These newsletters weren't just informative-they were creative, connecting addicts through stories, announcements, poetry, and perspective.

September also saw the release of "Freedom Connection #1," a new publication aimed at strengthening unity across areas and regions. Pete B., one of its co-editors, described how it was born during an impromptu workshop. "We wanted to demonstrate the actual process of producing a newsletter," he explained, signaling the movement's hands-on, teach-and-serve ethic.

August 28 saw Lancaster's 12-hour picnic with live music and raffles. Labor Day, September 6, was marked with a picnic at Tyler State Park.

New Jersey's "Recover and Discover" published Issue #1 in August, with a second to follow in September and a third in October. October was especially eventful. On October 1, "Recover and Discover" Issue #3 came out, followed by a whimsical and theatrical fundraiser— The Theatre of the Absurd—held at Holy Ghost Prep in Bensalem on October 8. As Al R. recalled, "New York would have these fundraisers... a bunch of us from Bucks County would caravan up."

That same month, Doylestown hosted a costume dance at Salem United Church (October 15) and an Addithon at Pebble Hill Church (October 21). Meanwhile, New Jersey hosted its "Powerless in the Pines" picnic and campout at Stokes State Forest on October 22, followed by a Halloween dance in Princeton October 29) and another in South Orange on November 1.

These were remarkable developments for a fellowship barely two decades old-still maturing, still scrappy, and still largely volunteer-run. But the desire to grow was unmistakable, and the infrastructure-newsletters, hotlines, car caravans, literature tables-was rising to meet it.

1982 was not just another year-it was a year of convergence. The NA community in and around Philadelphia matured in both form and function.

Newsletters blossomed, service committees formed, regions flirted with division and reorganization, and events brought together members from across counties It was a year where the dream of a clubhouse lived not just in a single building, but in Ivyland and in dances, in literature workshops and picnic blankets spread across parks in New Jersey and Pennsylvania. The infrastructure was strengthening, but so too was the spiritual fabric—the understanding that this was a program of connection. That "you could be the missing link in the service structure," as "Freedom Connection" reminded its readers.

And so, from Ivyland to Allentown, Doylestown to Cape May, Norristown to Princeton, the message was clear: NA was no longer a whisper in the dark. It was a chorus—diverse, vibrant, and unwavering in its purpose. The fellowship wasn't just growing. It was learning how to stay connected as it grew.

CUSTOMS



The Embrace of Recovery

Long before slogans like "Hugs, Not Drugs" adorned T-shirts and banners in Narcotics Anonymous, a quiet cultural revolution was already underway in the meeting rooms of Philadelphia, Norristown, and their surrounding communities. It wasn't declared, designed, or debated-it emerged, heartfelt and spontaneous, from a need far deeper than ritual: the need to belong. On the East Coast of the United States in the early 1970s, particularly in and around therapeutic communities like Eagleville Hospital, White Deer Run, The Bridge, and Today, Inc., something unique was happening. Among those who walked out of treatment centers and into the nascent meetings of NA, a new form of greeting took hold-one that reflected the raw vulnerability and radical love of early recovery. They began to hug.

This simple act of physical closeness—uncommon in the more formal handshakes of Alcoholics Anonymous-quickly became an expression of shared struggle and communal healing. What had begun as an emotional gesture in group therapy settings migrated into the daily practice of Narcotics Anonymous meetings. For many, it wasn't just about warmth-it was survival.

Roy remembered: "The people who had come out of the Eagleville program, they would hug. 'Show me some love'. We didn't think much of it down in Noel said: "One of the biggest things for me back then was we hugged. I've heard some people say we didn't hug, and I don't know where they were from, but we hugged."

Kathy H. recalled: "I think it largely depended on where you went to your meeting. There were some huggers, and they were like, Don't hug me people' and you could figure out where. I think it had to do with the people who would be there repeatedly, like the NA meeting at the Today they would hug, all the time."

As George R. put it plainly, "We always hugged-from day one."

There was an immediacy to it. The East Coast groups, especially those with strong ties to places like Eagleville, weren't just experimenting with a new custom.

They were forging an identity distinct from other fellowships. And the idea

stuck. Hugging became more than just a gesture; it became NA's unspoken code.

"We were hugging everybody-counselors, therapists, patients," Dave F. recalled "When we got out of the facility, we continued the hugs."

Not everyone took to it right away. In the more traditional and male-dominated spaces of Philadelphia, some were hesitant. Harvey D. shared his early discomfort: "I'd come into a meeting, put out my hand and say, Hey, Harvey D., what's your name?" And the guy would wrap his arms around me. But I'm a man. We're men. Let's get to know each other a little bit and I'll give you plenty of hugs." Still, over time, even skeptics softened to the embrace.

It wasn't just men redefining the rules of interaction. Women, too, were reckoning with the meanings and boundaries of touch in a space where physical intimacy could be both healing and triggering. Jeanne M. offered a piercing reminder; "Most of us have been raped and beat up... and we don't want you touching us. It causes trauma, dissociation." In such spaces, the question of consent was ever-present, and some found alternatives-hugging shoulder to shoulder, leaning in without contact, or simply standing in quiet solidarity.

Eileen said: "I was like, 'Don't freaking touch me'. I wasn't into hugging people that I didn't know. And it kind of freaks me out. " And yet, for most, the hug was sacred. "In NA, it was always a hugs circle," said Philly Phil, "shoulder to shoulder. In fact, we used to say handshakes are for Strangers." This cultural practice didn't stop at greetings. It became ritualized in the very structure of meetings. Members formed large closing circles, wrapping arms around each other, heads sometimes resting on shoulders, tears often falling in silence. It was here, in these intimate, final moments of a meeting, that many first felt they belonged. John F. remembered one such moment vividly being greeted by a pretty friendly guy. "He said, 'Give me a hug, brother,' and literally lifted me off my feet. I was dangling, and all I could say was, I think I'm going to bite your neck.' He put me down very gently and said, 'Whatever keeps you clean, man.' At that moment, I knew I was a member of Narcotics Anonymous. "

The contrast with other fellowships was stark. "There wasn't that much hugging going on in AA," said Pete B., "but in NA meetings, everybody hugged. That was a huge difference." Even as NA spread across the country, the East Coast retained its hugging culture with pride. The West Coast would eventually adopt it-but later, and with less intensity. According to Dwayne S., "The majority of people were shaking hands, and people around Norristown were hugging instead. That became the difference between AA and NA. We hugged instead of shaking hands." Stories of these early years abound, filled with names and faces etched into the collective memory: Jumping Jim, who embodied the emotional rawness of early recovery; Steve H., who brought hugging from White Deer Run to new areas; John D., who helped create early T-shirts with bold slogans that declared the difference loud and proud. For some, the hug remained symbolic—a stand against isolation, a declaration of unity. For others, it was a deeply emotional act. "I'm a hugger," said Gary F. simply. "It's just... I feel like hugs, like from the heart."

And yet, even within the circle, individuality persisted. Patty M. acknowledged that while hugging could sometimes feel unsafe, at other times it felt like a gift: "an inclusion... like you were being included somehow."

For many, that inclusion was what made all the difference. It wasn't about protocol—it was about recognition. "When I noticed the difference," said Jack C., "in NA we locked arm in arm. In AA we held hands. And I remember thinking, 'Wow. I'm part of something now.'"

In a 1994 interview with Bob Stone he said, "But hugging was not a custom of the Fellowship on the west coast at the time.

That was something that they learned from the folks in the east."

So it was that the NA hug-tender, spontaneous, and disarming-grew to define a fellowship. It became the physical expression of the program's spiritual message: that no one needs ever be alone again. And in a world that had too often greeted addicts with suspicion, shame, or scorn, the embrace of a fellow member meant everything.

As the saying goes in East Coast NA, "Handshakes are for strangers. In NA we hug"

The Closing Prayers

In the earliest days of Narcotics Anonymous, meeting formats were often borrowed directly from Alcoholics Anonymous. This included the practice of opening meetings with the Serenity Prayer and closing gatherings with the Lord’s Prayer-recited in a circle, with members either holding hands or resting arms around each other's shoulders. This ritual of closing meetings, deeply embedded in AA tradition, carried over naturally into the fledgling NA fellowship and became a familiar part of early meeting culture.

For many, this custom offered a comforting sense of structure and spiritual grounding. Members like Mary Mc. remembered standing arm in arm in circles and reciting the prayer, a reflection of unity and hope. Others, like Pat P., found great meaning in these words and favored the Lord's Prayer over other options. It was simply what they knew—what they had always done.

Yet as Narcotics Anonymous grew and welcomed members from an increasingly broad range of spiritual, cultural, and religious backgrounds, this once-universal prayer began to stir quiet discomfort. Some members expressed that it felt too religious, too tied to a specific doctrine. Margie C., a Muslim member, recalled wrestling with how to engage in a ritual that didn't speak to her faith. Others, like Mike B., observed how the growing diversity of members—across race, culture, and belief-necessitated a reevaluation of the group's language and practices. The shift wasn't immediate, nor was it without resistance. Longtime members like Alice C. and Denny S. remembered the slow change-first to the Serenity Prayer, and eventually, in some places, to NA's own Third Step Prayer. Each step marked an evolution in how the fellowship defined itself, gradually moving from borrowed traditions toward its own voice and spiritual identity. As Al R. reflected, the move away from "Our Father" felt like a sign that NA was learning to stand on its own two feet. Even among those who recognized the shift, opinions varied. George Rex-pressed some confusion over the transition, wondering why one prayer was deemed "too religious" while another still invoked spiritual themes. But others,

like Charlie F. and John S., noted the emergence of new traditions, like closing with the Serenity Prayer while standing together, shoulder to shoulder—a continuation of the unity the Lord's Prayer once symbolized, but in a language more accessible to all. For some, the change was geographic as well as generational. Aj H. recalled the contrast between areas like Central North Jersey, where some clung to the old ways, and others—closer to New York—where members pushed to close with more neutral prayers. Joe F. noted that in Philadelphia, both prayers might have been used, depending on the group and its members, reflecting a time of transition and negotiation.

Other voices captured the gradual but clear movement toward inclusivity. Tom C. remembered the familiar ritual of gathering in a circle, hands on shoulders, even as the prayer at the center began to shift. Pete B. saw the embrace of new closing practices as one of the defining differences between AA and NA, while Jim D. was emphatic: "You don't say 'Our Father' in NA. That's what they do in AA."

Over time, the Serenity Prayer gained dominance, its simple request for serenity, courage, and wisdom resonating with many across spiritual lines. The Third Step Prayer, drawn from NA's own literature, also grew in use-particularly as members began to prioritize language that reflected NA's own principles and collective voice. For many groups, the words became less important than the act: standing in a circle, joined in recovery, closing in unity.

In this evolution, NA demonstrated not just a change in ritual, but a deepening commitment to inclusion, autonomy, and authenticity. From a borrowed tradition to a chosen one, the prayer at the end of the meeting became a mirror of the fellowship itself: ever growing, ever adapting, always striving to ensure that every addict, regardless of background, could feel they belonged.

LITERATURE



In the early 1970s, NA in Pennsylvania was little more than a scattered collection of meetings bound together by shared desperation and a flimsy pamphlet called the White Book. This foundational text, though revered, reflected an early and somewhat fragmented view of addiction. The "How It Works" section listed substances individually-pills, alcohol, heroin—without yet recognizing addiction as a singular, overarching disease. Members were told to avoid all mind-altering chemicals, but the literature didn't yet frame addiction as the common thread. The absence of this understanding meant recovery was often approached substance-by-substance rather than holistically. Yet in the face of these limitations, something powerful began to take root. The voice of a fledgling fellowship began to stir—not from the established centers of the West Coast, but from basements, church halls, and treatment centers across Pennsylvania. What they lacked in materials, they made up for in drive, improvisation, and a fierce determination to recover and be heard.

"It was difficult to get anything from NA back then," Kathy H. remembered. "AA always had books and pamphlets at the ready, but NA felt like a poverty-stricken fellowship. We had almost nothing in writing."

With no real infrastructure, Pennsylvania members leaned heavily on AA literature. The Twelve and Twelve, the Big Book-these became makeshift tools of recovery. Names were crossed out, "alcohol" was replaced with "drugs," and members read aloud while tripping over language that didn't quite fit. Some questioned the use of another fellowship's materials, but for most, it was a simple choice between finding a way to recover or being lost.

Roy P. recalled early ambitions: "For a while, we considered writing our own version of the Twelve and Twelve, but that never materialized."

Instead, they carried White Books in their pockets, dog-eared and worn—symbols of survival more than doctrine. "We called it hip pocket recovery," said Pat P., "We slipped the Little White Book into our back pockets and took it everywhere." Noel F. noted that while meeting formats varied, that book remained the foundation: "From day one, our meetings followed a structure based on reading from it."

When new material emerged-like NA's IPs-they were eagerly adopted.

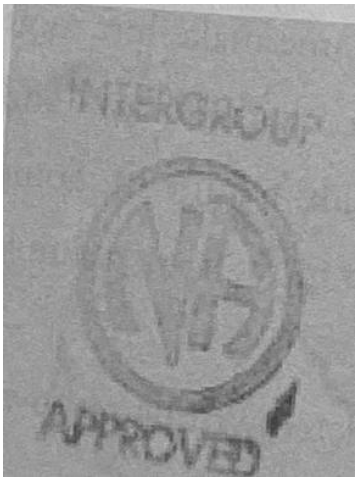
Others turned to outside resources, such as Hazelden's Day by Day meditation

hook or Father Martin's films like Chalk Talk and Guidelines. In Sunbury, meetings even showed LSD-25, an anti-LSD film, as part of their efforts to educate and inspire, although films such as this one were looked at as questionable by attendees because it didn't offer an NA message.

Support from local treatment centers like Eagleville and White Deer Run helped push NA into the public eye, distributing literature and encouraging recovering addicts to start meetings. But real momentum came from the members themselves. Attending AA meetings, borrowing their materials, rewriting steps, and slowly carving out a space of their own, Pennsylvania's NA members began creating a distinctly NA culture. Bob P. recalls "The literature we used to use until stuff was being printed was the book called Young, Sober and Free by Shelly Marshall. She was out of the Spokane, Washington, area. We had our 3rd anniversary in Beaver County and we had her speak. I don't remember anybody ever telling us not to not use it. I even told Jimmy I was using it."

Stamped and Approved

At a time when meetings were found through whispers and word-of-mouth, the Philadelphia Intergroup became central to literature production and distribution.



The yellow meeting cards they printed evolved into tri-fold lists complete with Steps, Traditions, and a short ex- APPROVED planation of NA-simple tools designed for newcomers and the curious alike.

At the outset, the group began to take on structure. Flyers were revised to reflect language that emphasized "recovering" rather than "recovered," while the presence of AA literature would be left to individual group conscience. The first meeting lists and phone lists were created—many of them typed, copied, and stamped "Intergroup Approved"—flooded the fellowship. Ray T. drafted an NA Explanation Sheet, while others brought forward Fourth Step inventory guides and literature sheets for review. Slogans like "If you want to

use drugs, that's your business. If you want to stop, that's ours," became calling cards of identity and intent. As literature projects advanced, members such as Ralph S began writing interpretive materials, including a thoughtful paper on the First Tradition, "Personal Recovery Depends on NA Unity." There was even talk of creating a NA-style 12 Steps and 12 Traditions book, echoing AA's. Intergroup members began reading these materials to individual groups, seeking feedback and approval-the first signs of a democratic literature development process that would one day define NA worldwide. The Intergroup meetings became hotbeds for new literature ideas. Joe O. brought in "Moral Inventories." Ursula circulated "15 Points to Consider." As the movement spread, new groups were seeded with starter kits—binders containing the White Book, IPs, meeting formats, and homemade Fourth Step guides. Debates raged over whether meeting lists should include the word "Honest" or whether "Recovered" should become "Recovering." Tapes about NA sponsorship and alternate Twelve Step versions were reviewed. Philadelphia even sent materials to upstate Pennsylvania and other regions.

Books like Day By Day were approved for sale. Bill A authored the "20 Questions." Some members argued that changes to NA literature should be sent to California for approval, but consensus held firm—they had no right to tamper with the Steps and Traditions, but they did have the right to build supportive materials.

John F. recalled their loose connection to Sun Valley-at first, just a phone number used to order fragments of literature. Then came meeting minutes, and then, a new directive: stop using AA literature. "It created a crisis," he said. "But we felt exempt. We'd rewritten the Twelve and Twelve to fit our needs. They asked us to write a step each and compile them into our own booklet. That never happened—except in my home group."

The Intergroup Literature Committee was finding its stride. They began stamping books for accountability, clearing past dues by distributing 20 books per group, and managed to reduce costs on bulk purchases, paying $122 per 1,000 books—a savings of 53. Each group received 30 meeting lists to bolster local visibility. NA Upstate placed a bulk order of 1, 000 books, and a payment deadline

was set. Half of the proceeds from literature sales were allocated to the Literature Committee, and a new Preamble Package was in the works to support emerging groups.

The Intergroup Secretary responded to the California letter with local literature, and fifteen copies of the newly printed Intergroup by-laws were distributed-one per group-for review and proposed amendments. Literature requests continued, including one from a woman at Eagleville, while Linda was asked to explore options for sobriety chips, and Maria R. began designing a poster to promote NA's message.

A growing sense of autonomy among groups was evident. The shift toward self-sufficiency became more visible when groups were encouraged to buy literature rather than simply receive it, echoing the Seventh Tradition's emphasis on self-support.

Dave F. proposed that the body pay closer attention to the growth of NA nationwide, prompting further updates to the starter kits now offered to new groups. Each included NA books, the Preamble, meeting lists, by-laws, letters of introduction, and Fourth Step inventory sheets. Literature distribution was now firmly regulated-books would not be provided unless officially stamped.

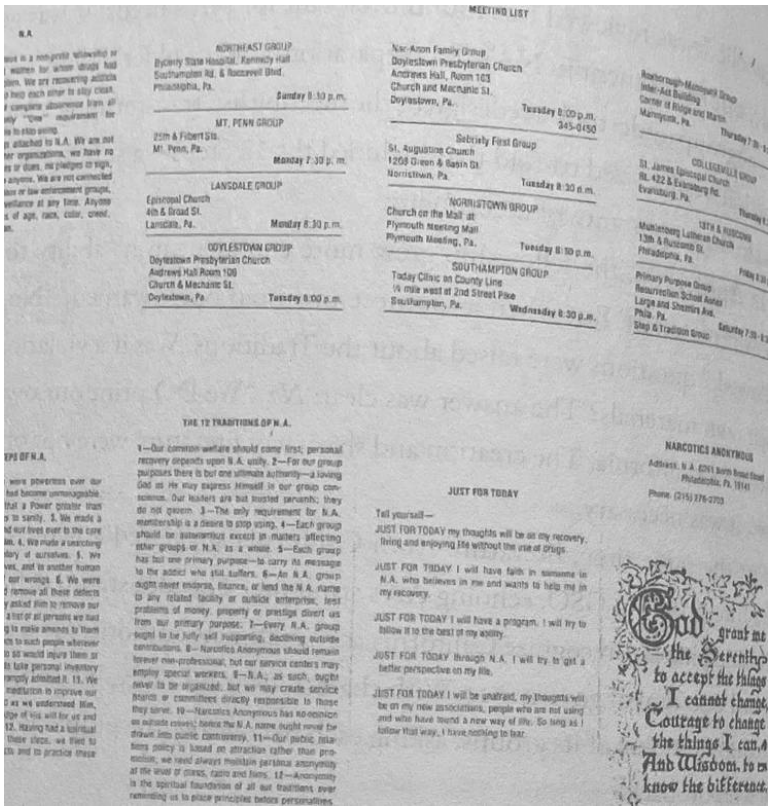
The question of changing NA literature sparked spirited debate. The Norristown Group revived its proposal to remove "honest" from the Third Tradition, but Ray clarified that "honest desire" appeared only in the Preamble. While Bob G. suggested submitting potential changes to California, Ray insisted the Steps and Traditions should remain unchanged. The group agreed to reach out to California before initiating any alterations to the White Book, viewing such texts as foundational and worthy of national consensus. The lack of original NA literature didn't just create a vacuum—it spurred creativity and experimentation. The Oaklane Group started incorporating spiritual readings from the "Golden Book"

series—14 booklets written by Father Ralph Pfau (known as Father "John Doe") that had long influenced early AA and now found a place in NA's developing culture. Books like AA Comes of Age and A Handbook for the Secretary were considered helpful reference materials. A well-meaning pamphlet borrowed from AA, titled "Sedatives, Stimulants & the

Alcoholic," was reviewed but found irrelevant for NA's needs. It was gently set aside, a quiet moment in NA's slow separation from its older sibling. The group undertook a redesign of the meeting list, transforming it into a more practical, wallet-sized tri-fold that included the 12 Steps—a subtle but powerful nod to the importance of accessibility. In April 1975, the fellowship grew more confident in its ability to generate its own materials. But when a footnote in an old book warned, "No Reprints Allowed," questions were raised about the Traditions. Was it a violation to print their own materials? The answer was clear: No. "We DO print our own books," they told California. The creation and sharing of literature were not only acceptable, it was necessary. At the same time, literature from California suggested a name change for the Intergroup to GSO, echoing AA's structure. The idea stirred debate. Would Philadelphia NA recognize California as the ultimate authority? It was a foundational question of governance. With characteristic humility, Intergroup deferred to the autonomy of its groups, asking each to consider the proposal individually and report back.

A revised meeting list was also drafted, with the careful removal of the word "honest" from the phrase "honest desire" —a small linguistic shift with spiritual depth, rooted in NA's evolving clarity of message Following the August Intergroup meeting, a new meeting list was produced-this time in a compact, booklet-style format focused on the meetings in and around Philadelphia. The list included eleven active groups, but what made this edition stand out was its thoughtful design. Alongside meeting times and locations, it featured the Twelve Steps, the Twelve Traditions, and a short explanation of what Narcotics Anonymous was all about. More than just a schedule, this small booklet became a powerful and accessible tool-something members could hand to newcomers and curious professionals alike, offering both information and inspiration in a single, well-crafted package.

God grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change, courage to change the things I can, and wisdom to know the difference.



MEETING LIST

NORTHEAST GROUP
Byberry State Hospital, Kennedy Hall
Southampton Rd. & Roosevelt Blvd.
Philadelphia, Pa.
Sunday 8:30 p.m.

MT. PENN GROUP
25th & Filbert Sts.
Mt. Penn, Pa.
Monday 7:30 p. m.

LANSDALE GROUP
Episcopal Church
4th & Broad St.
Lansdale, Pa.
Monday 8:30 p.m.

DOYLESTOWN GROUP
Doylestown Presbyterian Church
Andrews Hall Room 109
Church & Mechanic St.
Doylestown, Pa.
Tuesday 8:00 p.m.

Nar-Anon Family Group
Doylestown Presbyterian Church
Andrews Hall, Room 103
Church and Mechanic St.
Doylestown, Pa.
Tuesday 8:00 p.m.
345-0450

Sobriety First Group
St. Augustine Church
1268 Green & Basin St.
Norristown, Pa.
Tuesday 8:30 p.m.

NORRISTOWN GROUP
Church on the Mall at
Plymouth Meeting Mall
Plymouth Meeting, Pa.
Tuesday 8:30 p.m.

SOUTHAMPTON GROUP
Today Clinic on County Line
½ mile west at 2nd Street Pike
Southampton, Pa.
Wednesday 8:30 p.m.

THE 12 TRADITIONS OF N.A.

JUST FOR TODAY

Tell yourself—

JUST FOR TODAY my thoughts will be on my recovery, living and enjoying life without the use of drugs.

JUST FOR TODAY I will have faith in someone in N.A. who believes in me and wants to help me in my recovery.

JUST FOR TODAY I will have a program. I will try to follow it to the best of my ability.

JUST FOR TODAY through N.A. I will try to get a better perspective on my life.

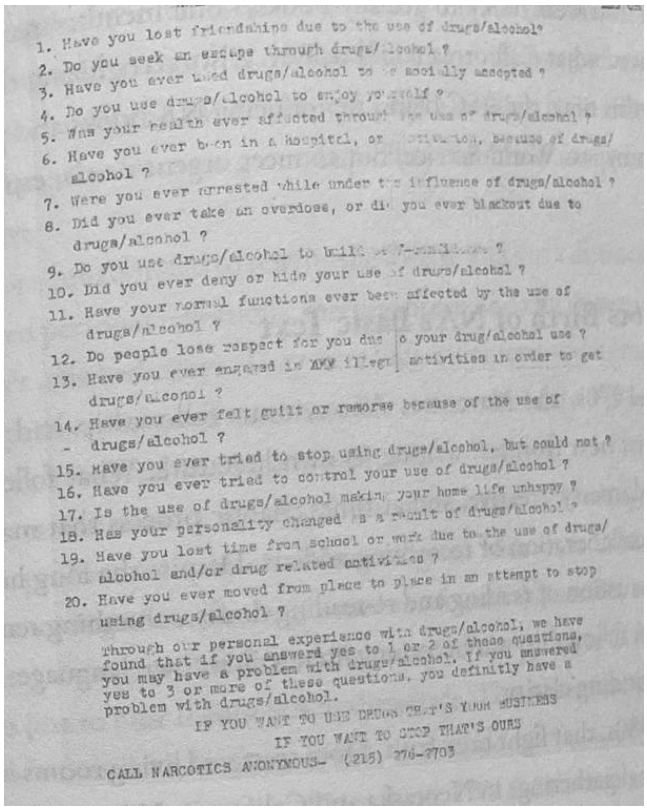
JUST FOR TODAY I will be unafraid, my thoughts will be on my new associations, people who are not using and who have found a new way of life. So long as I follow that way, I have nothing to fear.

NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS

God grant me the Serenity to accept the things I cannot change, Courage to change the things I can, And Wisdom to know the difference.

The desire to distinguish NA from AA grew stronger. October's Intergroup Confirmed that NA would use its own literature and reject AA-related announcements during meetings. Literature debates flared briefly. The use of Day by Day was questioned but ultimately approved. The Doylestown group voted to exclude AA announcements, aligning with the growing consensus. Meanwhile, a member named Bill A.

contributed something enduring: the "Twenty Questions," a piece that would eventually become part of NA's archival legacy, marked with the Intergroup's stamp of approval.



1. Have you lost friendships due to the use of drugs/alcohol?
2. Do you seek an escape through drugs/alcohol ?
3. Have you ever used drugs/alcohol to be socially accepted ?
4. Do you use drugs/alcohol to enjoy yourself ?
5. Was your health ever affected through the use of drugs/alcohol ?
6. Have you ever been in a hospital, or institution, because of drugs/alcohol ?
7. Were you ever arrested while under the influence of drugs/alcohol ?
8. Did you ever take an overdose, or did you ever blackout due to drugs/alcohol ?
9. Do you use drugs/alcohol to build self-confidence ?
10. Did you ever deny or hide your use of drugs/alcohol ?
11. Have your normal functions ever been affected by the use of drugs/alcohol ?
12. Do people lose respect for you due to your drug/alcohol use ?
13. Have you ever engaged in ANY illegal activities in order to get drugs/alcohol ?
14. Have you ever felt guilt or remorse because of the use of drugs/alcohol ?
15. Have you ever tried to stop using drugs/alcohol, but could not ?
16. Have you ever tried to control your use of drugs/alcohol ?
17. Is the use of drugs/alcohol making your home life unhappy ?
18. Has your personality changed as a result of drugs/alcohol ?
19. Have you lost time from school or work due to the use of drugs/alcohol and/or drug related activities ?
20. Have you ever moved from place to place in an attempt to stop using drugs/alcohol ?

Through our personal experience with drugs/alcohol, we have found that if you answerd yes to 1 or 2 of these questions, you may have a problem with drugs/alcohol. If you answered yes to 3 or more of these questions, you definitly have a problem with drugs/alcohol.

IF YOU WANT TO USE DRUGS THAT'S YOUR BUSINESS
IF YOU WANT TO STOP THAT'S OURS

CALL NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS- (215) 276-2703

Tensions surfaced over language. Some groups had been opening meetings with a modified AA preamble, simply replacing "Alcoholics Anonymous" with "Narcotics Anonymous." Harry P. spoke up, cautioning against this. Bill A. followed, reminding everyone that NA had its own preamble, born from its Own experience and spirit. The moment highlighted a subtle but important thread-NA's journey to find its voice independent of AA's towering legacy.

Norristown's new name was formalized in the meeting list, which itself underwent changes-paper would now replace cards, and the group approved a unique stamp for their own literature, a mark of ownership and legitimacy. The Twelve and Twelve project continued, and plans were made to send it to California for further review. Literature, it was agreed, would now be purchased exclusively through the Literature Committee, further centralizing and standardizing the fellowship's resources.

An additional roadblock to obtaining NA literature was caused by a pulp and paper strike in the Pacific Northwest in late 1978, literature supply was

severely limited. Some areas were authorized to produce their own emergency photocopies. "You were lucky to get any books," one member recalled. The demand outpaced what California could deliver. Also, recognizing the scarcity of literature at this time, the ASC began reproducing NA books and pamphlets locally—not to bypass World Service, but to meet urgent needs, especially for newcomers.

The Grassroots Birth of NA's Basic Text

By the late 1970s, the Narcotics Anonymous fellowship had matured enough to face its next frontier: writing its own literature. What followed was a deeply spiritual, messy, creative, and at times chaotic process that marked the first true global collaboration of recovering addicts. Despite the long hours, the conflicts, the exhaustion of reading and re-reading drafts, something remarkable was happening. A fellowship was becoming literate in its own language. A voice, long stifled, was finding clarity.

By the early 1980s, that fight bore fruit. From scattered living rooms in Bucks County to national gatherings in Nebraska and California, NA members began stitching together what would become the very heart of the program-the Basic Text.

The Push Toward an Original Voice

NA was finding its footing-but it was doing so in borrowed shoes. Meetings were growing, the message was spreading, and addicts were getting clean-but much of the fellowship's language was still drawn from Alcoholics Anonymous. That dependence began to wear thin. Something deeper was stirring: a longing for NA's own voice. That hunger-to express NA in its own language-grew into a movement. In 1977, members began contributing to what would become the Basic Text. Philadelphia Intergroup sent stories, rewrites, and community-crafted steps. They wanted more than adapted AA ideas—they wanted a book that belonged to them.

Long before the Basic Text took its final form, Philadelphia-area members were pushing back against the limits of AA literature. They wanted more than substitution-they wanted authorship. NA needed its own message, its own language, its own mirror. In church basements and smoky meeting halls, members began crafting that language from the ground up. They didn't wait for permission. They started writing. Some groups collaborated to rewrite the Twelve Steps in a distinctly NA voice. Others drafted personal reflections, meeting notes, and raw literature fragments. These weren't polished essays. They were blue-collar texts—unfiltered, heartfelt, and often typed on borrowed machines. But they carried the rhythms and dialects of real addicts, living real recovery, in real time. The frustration wasn't merely about semantics. For many, AA's literature—while profoundly helpful-felt misaligned with their lived experience as addicts. In meeting after meeting, members found themselves scratching out "alcohol" and writing in "addiction," cutting across paragraphs with pens and highlighters just to hear themselves in the words. This was more than editing. It was an act of survival.

Jeanne M. clung tightly to her White Book. "We didn't have a Basic Text yet, so we crossed out the word alcohol and wrote addict. We made it work. We even sent things back to California—but they'd get knocked down. That was OK. It was a good fight."

"We tried harder and harder to change that book to suit our needs," recalled John F., an early member deeply involved in the effort. "So as we understood NA as a separate program-a viable program, a program that stood on its own two feet-this yearning and hunger for NA literature just became greater and greater and greater."

The yearning turned into action. In 1977, momentum behind the creation of a Narcotics Anonymous "Big Book" began to build. Committees formed.

Notes were gathered. Voices from across the country-and especially from hubs like Philadelphia—began submitting personal stories and working drafts. The Philadelphia Intergroup was among the earliest contributors, offering not just stories but early rewrites of the Twelve Steps themselves. Some of these revised

versions would later find echoes in the drafts of what became known as the Basic Text.

In 1977, John S. of Kingston, Pennsylvania and Bob P. of Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania separately submitted their personal stories to WSO for potential inclusion in the forthcoming "NA Big Book." Bob's story was published as "A Gift Called Life," in the first edition of the Basic Text. A 1997 archival note from the WSC Interim Committee identified John's ten-page typescript dated 1977 among Jimmy K.'s estate documents.

What emerged in these years wasn't a top-down literary campaign—it was a grassroots movement, a creative uprising. This wasn't just about literature. It was about identity. It was about a fellowship that had for so long been the younger sibling in the 12-Step family, finally realizing that it had something of its own to say.

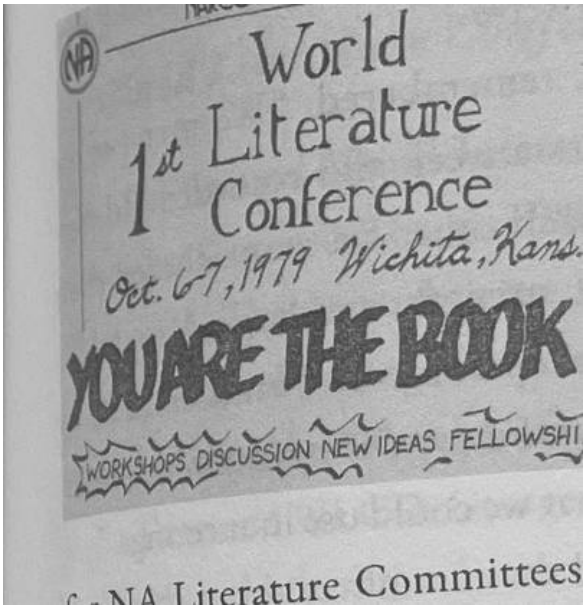
But the path toward NA's own literature wasn't smooth. Much of what was sent to the early literature committees-especially those based in California—was rejected. "We'd highlight, cross things out, and then send it back," Jeanne explained. "Of course, it would get knocked down anyway. But that was OK-it was a good fight."

This steady current of homegrown material flowed outward-from city groups to area committees, from area committees to the broader movement—becoming part of the growing national effort to produce the Basic Text. Though no formal path existed for contributions, the process was porous, hungry for content, and full of improvisation.

"You Are the Book"

A letter sent from the NA Literature Conference Committee to the fellowship on August 31, 1979 inviting groups, areas, and committees to send information to compile new NA literature. "We can unite Narcotics Anonymous when we carry the message to the newcomer by giving him (her) a Narcotics Anonymous Big Book. Attaining literature of any sort is, and has been a problem. We need more distribution points throughout the United States so we may attain needed literature more rapidly. We, in Wichita, are stockpiling literature for our

group's use and the use of other groups in our area. We need your support for the World Literature Conference in Wichita."



The first World Literature Conference, (WLC-1), was held in a modest Chamber of Commerce community room in Wichita, Kansas on October 6–7, 1979. It brought together 35 members from Kansas, Ohio, Nebraska, Georgia, California, Tennessee, and Virginia. Together, they drafted chapter outlines and began gathering material. From that initial gathering came “The Handbook for NA Literature Committees,” approved at the 1980 WSC and distributed widely to facilitate grassroots literature work.

Hulmeville's Rebellion

Shortly after the Sunday Steppers Group began in Bucks County, Pennsylvania, members started altering AA's Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions for use in their meetings. They replaced words like "alcohol" with "drugs" and crossed out "Alcoholics" on the cover, writing "Narcotics" above it so the book read "Narcotics Anonymous." They relied on this marked-up literature for their recovery.

In May 1980, after returning from the WSC, Bob P. attended the RSC meeting in Camp Hill. George showed him the altered 12 & 12. Bob said NA groups could no longer use AA literature and that any group doing so would not be listed in the NA World Directory. "Open the AA book-what does the copyright say?" he asked. It read, "Copyright by AA." He added that literature written by NA members could be read at NA meetings. The message was clear: if NA wanted its own voice, it would have to write it.

Frustrated with continued reliance on AA material, members formed the Hulmeville Step Reform Committee and began writing their own steps the following week.

"Kenny and I had gotten an apartment together," Phil S. recalled. "It became the social center of NA in our area." The committee-five to ten committed members—met in Kenny's Lakeview Manor apartment in Bristol, taping personal shares on each step from One through Twelve.



Pete B. remembered: "We met two or three times a week and recorded a different step each time. Everyone shared their experience, strength, and hope. I'd take the tape recorder home and transcribe it by hand. Then I'd type it on my old Underwood—about 45 words a minute—into a format we could use in meetings."

At that same May RSC meeting, Bob P. told the committee about the World Literature effort to write an NA "Big Book" and gave them Bo S.'s phone number. A week or two later, George R. called and learned that a group in Marietta, Georgia, was also writing NA literature.

George later reflected: "We were working on the NA Steps in Bristol while Bo's team was in Marietta working on the book. When I called, they were in the middle of a writing session. We agreed to meet at the upcoming East Coast Convention "

Bo's group had considered skipping the event because of concerns about traveling near Three Mile Island, the site of a nuclear reactor accident, but both groups recognized the need to meet face-to-face.

In June 1980, members from both efforts gathered at the first East Coast Convention in Lewisburg, Pennsylvania. They met like-minded members from Georgia, California, Kansas, and Nebraska. Beyond the scheduled events, a broader Collaboration emerged. They learned of the NA World Literature Committee, led by Bo S. in Georgia. Soon after, at a mini-convention in Greenville, South Carolina, Bo gave George Public Information and Literature handbooks and The N.A. Tree, encouraging him to strengthen local service structure. The Hulmeville group registered with the World Literature Committee and became known as the "Bristol Literature Committee." With national support and weekly correspondence, they formalized their work. They drafted outlines

for each step, typed and copied submissions, and mailed them to Georgia. Their purpose was simple: carry the message through the written word.

World Literature Conferences and Supporting Events

The Second World Literature Conference (WLC-2) met in Lincoln, Nebraska, September 8-14, 1980. Participants felt the presence of a Higher Power at work. They agreed to use the White Book as a template—retaining its eight chapters and adding Chapters Nine and Ten. They outlined each chapter and sorted roughly 700 pages of material accordingly. To attend W LC-2, George sold his washer and dryer and used the $70 to travel. He brought the Bristol committee's step work, though he never knew how much was used. At the conference's close, Bo, Bob B., Greg P., Jim N., and Motorcycle Ed developed what became known as the "Cut and Paste" method. Using scissors and glue, they assembled the first six pages of the book and read them aloud to the conference.

Back in Norristown, the September 14 ASC revisited literature. Groups had submitted writings on the Twelve Steps. They agreed to copy and distribute completed steps immediately rather than wait for the full set. In Philadelphia, the Oxford Circle Group took on the Fifth Step as part of a fellowship-wide effort—twelve groups, each drafting one step of what would become the Basic Text.

After WLC-2, Bo sent Chapter Eight, "We Do Recover," to the Bristol group.

They organized the material according to the outline and started cutting and pasting. George was to bring the completed work to Memphis for review and editing-a sign of growing urgency to formalize NA literature.

Meanwhile, momentum spread to Northeast Philadelphia, where many newer members were eager to help. George recalled: "I was going to Oxford Circle, and Deb and John were hosting gatherings at their place. People weren't happy with California. But when they heard Atlanta was involved, they wanted to be part of it." As John Sw. recalled, "We were meeting at Debbie S. and John D.'s apartment in Wissinoming, writing the steps for the Basic Text."

With Bo's approval, the Philadelphia members were assigned Chapter Ten "More Will Be Revealed." They met in Debbie S.'s one-bedroom apartment.

often with 15 to 25 members crowded inside. The group became known as the Philadelphia Literature Committee. The committee sorted through the material by hand and reorganized it with scissors and glue until a unified draft emerged.

Their completed chapter would also go to Memphis for review.

oe later reflected on those not directly involved: "Who are the people without a voice? That voice is heard in meetings. More people helped write the Basic Text than any other piece of literature, but only a small percentage got involved in service, approval, or even reading it."

On October 18, five areas-Philadelphia, Delaware, Scranton, Lebanon, and Ohio-met at the RSC in Camp Hill. George distributed copies of the Twelve Steps to each area, symbolizing unity in literature development.

As he prepared for the W LC-3 in Memphis, George reviewed Chapter Ten and set it on his nightstand. The next morning, he left for the airport—without it. He called Pete, who rushed to the Philadelphia airport with the chapter, found a stranger flying to Memphis, and asked her to deliver it. She agreed and handed Chapter Ten to George at the Memphis airport.

January 31 to February 9, 1981, at Memphis State University, WLC-3 commenced, not in the usual sense of structured sessions, but as an unbroken nine-day immersion-twenty-four hours a day—of writing, editing, and visioning. It was here that George R., Jim M., and Kathy crafted NA's first style guide, giving the text a unified voice and tone that would become its signature. Each chapter was taken apart, added to, corrected, proofread, and edited about six times. The miracle of the book seems to keep growing stronger, and every known group in the Fellowship received a review copy. The work was more than technical; it was deeply intentional. Al R. recalled the spirited discussions that circled around one core principle: inclusivity. The stories had to reflect every shade of experience within recovery-young and old, devoutly spiritual, and firmly atheist, every kind of addict. It was a turning point, ensuring that no reader would feel unseen within the pages. A few months later, on April 3-5, WLC-4 convened in Santa Monica, California. Here, for the first time, a complete manuscript was edited and assembled.

It was, by many accounts, a brilliant and moving document—some called it the finest version ever created. And yet, in a twist that remains unexplained to this day, this draft vanished. Whether misplaced, lost, or deliberately removed, its disappearance remains one of the most mysterious footnotes in the fellowship's literary history. At the May 10 Philly ASC meeting, George R., having just returned from the WSC, reported that the conference decided that no Nar-Anon meetings would be placed on NA meeting lists. This would violate the NA traditions. The conference also had a controversy over the phrase " an honest desire to stop using which appears in NA literature Many wanted it changed to simply "a desire to stop using," arguing that early motives weren't always pure. For now, literature would remain unchanged. Determined not to lose momentum, members gathered again June 28 to July 5, in Warren, Ohio, for WLC-S. The setting was far from glamorous—a dilapidated schoolhouse—but the energy was electric. Writers and editors worked 20-hour days, breaking only briefly for "conscience meetings" held at 11 A.M. and 11 P.M., where spiritual guidance and group clarity were sought.

After attending ECCNA-2 Al R. and Pete B. barely had time to unpack afterward-they immediately drove to Warren, Ohio, for the Sth WLC-5. Al recalled, We went home for about an hour, showered, threw some shit in a bag, and split again." Pete admitted he hadn't planned to go, but Al "hijacked me because I had By this time, the style sheet—later included in the appendix of the "Grey Book" -was already in place, guiding editors on language choices and stylistic consistency. Common edits involved replacing terms like "sobriety" with "clean, to better reflect the fellowship's unique language. In parallel, efforts were underway to gather proper story releases from contributors, some of whom had not yet formally signed off on their submissions.

From September 10-13, 1981, the World Convention of NA (WCNA-11), was held at the Marco Polo Beach Hotel in Miami, Florida. Though the approval form of the Basic Text was distributed at the time, the stories had not yet been finalized. Attendees from Pennsylvania included Bob P. from Midland, Dick B. and Kathy B. from Harrisburg, and Mason D. from York. The gathering

was vibrant and varied—addicts, delegates, and trusted servants coming together across borders and backgrounds.

Bob P. again represented Pennsylvania, and this time, a small literature conference was held during the convention. Its purpose: to compile a fellowship newsletter. Members voted on a name—"The Freedom Connection" -and generated a directory of the earliest known NA groups in various regions. Each attendee was asked to take this list home, expand it, and return their additions to the literature committee to aid in writing NA's history. Pete B., now Vice Chair of the World Literature Committee, facilitated a history workshop at the convention: "I asked what they wanted me to work on. They said: history."

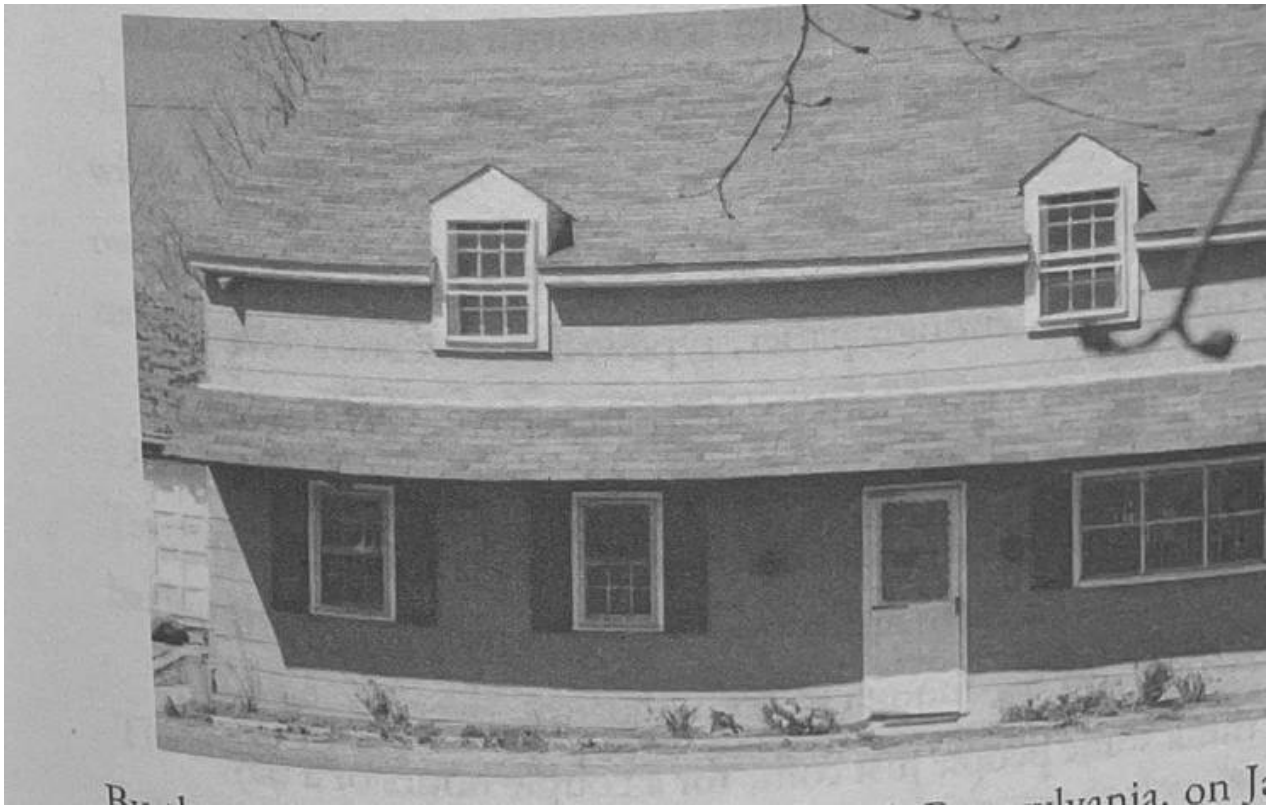
Jim D. recalled the high energy and wild spirit of the event:

The California Angels and Diana Ross were staying at the hotel. There were 700 or 800 addicts. They had an auction—Bob Berg, who chaired the Institutional Committee, was standing in his underwear raising money for H&I. I bought a little NA stamp:

Narcotics Anonymous, P.O. Box, Milwaukee, WI.

Four committed members, packed tightly into a Toyota Celica, drove from the northeast to Miami for WLC-6 on September 14-20. The mission was clear: finalize core content and limit further input to preserve consistency. Chapters 1 through 3 and 8 were officially closed to new contributions, and efforts focused intensely on refining the Fellowship's Traditions-specifically Traditions 5 through 10. Soon after the WCNA-11, a mini-literature conference was hosted in Ivyland on October 15-17. Topics included "Sponsorship," "Use of Medication," "Youth and Recovery," and a draft of the H&I Handbook. Input was forwarded to the Florida Region for their November event. Before the committee finished its workshop, they decided to meet again to work on the personal stories for the book. On November 22-29, the Mid-South RSC sponsored a Service Conference in Memphis, Tennessee, for the purpose of: (1) collating, bonding, packaging, addressing, stamping, and mailing the Approval Form of Our Book, our Basic Text on NA Recovery; (2) working

on proposed changes, revision and additions, in the existing Service Manual of Narcotics Anonymous and in WSC subcommittee handbooks; and (3) providing workshops for the review and compiling of material for future literature on NA It wasn't an official World Literature Committee meeting; it was a Thanksgiving celebration. Al R., Pete B., and Terica W. were present. An Approval Form of the Basic Text was mailed to the Fellowship. Every known NA group received a copy. The committee had reached a pivotal point in the development of what would become a foundational text. Specifically, they needed a host location where a diverse team could gather and begin editing the Stories section. Without hesitation, Terica pointed across the room at Al R. and Pete B. and declared, "They'll host it at their house." And just like that—without discussion or delay-the project found a home. In January of 1982, that home was in Ivyland, Pennsylvania. John Sw. described his experience, "well, it was just unbelievable… hearing people, the other guys were really strong recovery. Greg P., you know, a lot of them are from Georgia, Bo, Paige, Jim M., Kirby, from Memphis, Tennessee. I was young, so I was just kind of going with the flow and whatever they needed me to do, or just, they kind of had an open flow discussion."



By the time WLC-7 convened in Ivyland, Pennsylvania, on January 15-18, 1982, the manuscript had already begun to take shape in the world. Chapters One through Ten, painstakingly refined over months of collaboration, had been released in November 1981-a major milestone. But the work was far from over.

Set in a snow-covered farmhouse in Ivyland, the gathering unfolded like. winter encampment of purpose and passion. More than thirty addicts crowded into the modest space driven not by comfort, but by commitment. Sleepin arrangements were far from glamorous: people crashed in bathtubs, shared sleep. ing bags, closets, and every available nook. But what this setting lacked in luxury it more than made up for in spirit and purpose.

Here, the final pieces of the puzzle were laid into place. The focus turned to the stories section-the personal, powerful narratives that would breathe life and relatability into "the book." Over those few intense days, the story section was completed, cementing the text's emotional core.

Pete, one of the hosts, owned a tiny Toyota Corolla, and the snow piled so high it reached the car's floorboards. Despite the weather, there was no turning back. The team needed to assemble. Pete drove through the snow to pick up Bo and Linda from the airport. Linda M. arrived from Kansas—she was the secretary for World Literature at the time-and others followed. It was here, amid the snow and shared sacrifice, that something extraordinary took shape. A labor of love-rooted in lived experience, shaped by collective effort, and carried by a willingness to serve—began to crystallize into a lasting legacy. The cold outside was no match for the warmth and urgency inside. Al R. offered his experience on hosting a WLC event:

Our job, to make sure we got a copier, which was a crazy experience at the time. Paper, enough paper, typewriters, etcetera. We just went to the grocery store and took whatever funds that we had Or could dig up or could get people to donate and just bought a bunch of whatever. Coffee, number one. We need more coffee than anything. But I don't remember how we fed everybody. We didn't have a refrigerator big enough to host 60 people over the weekend.

And I think some people just come for a couple hours or a day.

As Pete B. later recalled, stories were collected from as far away as Hawaii, Japan, and West Germany. For many, the process itself-sitting in rooms crowded with paper, arguing over word choices, huddled around space heaters, running out

of oil during the coldest winter on record-was a spiritual awakening. Harvey D. remembered radical voices from California pushing for heavy edits, triggering memories of the rigidity and judgment many had fled in AA. Equally historic was the collective decision to approve the Grey Form—a nearly final draft-for publication. This version would go on to circulate widely among the fellowship, offering members a voice in its shaping and cementing a democratic spirit that had defined the entire process. Alice C. summed it up best: "The Grey Form was unique—it was written by addicts, for addicts, through a group conscience process that has never been repeated since. We were the Grey Form." What began in scattered rooms across the country had now, in a crowded farmhouse under winter's hush, become something tangible, cohesive, and real. The book was no longer just being written—it was becoming. Each decision, each hour, each mile traveled brought the book closer to completion. What began as scattered voices was slowly becoming a unified expression-an authentic, grassroots testament to recovery.

We Have a Book

From those early hip-pocket books to the polished, printed Basic Text, the story of NA literature in Pennsylvania is one of persistence and voice. And when the book finally arrived, it spoke in a voice that many recognized as their own. More than anything, it is the story of a fellowship writing itself into existence-page by page, meeting by meeting In February 1982, 47 personal stories were released for review. By May 5-9, 1982, at the Seventh WSC in Santa Monica, the final vote was taken: the Basic Text was approved as NA's first official book. The first printing would be hardback, sold for $25, and released at WCNA-12 in Milwaukee.

The ECCNA-3 marked a major milestone in NA's literature development.

The material for the Basic Text was nearly complete. The Mid-Atlantic Regional Literature Subcommittee hosted a mini-conference during the weekend to finalize editorial guidelines and lay the foundation for what would become a regional newsletter. For many, this was the moment the dream of Our Book became a tangible reality.

"When the book was finally printed," Joe remembered, "they put it in my hands. I forget how many copies they made, but they were selling them for $20 to raise funds. I remember saying, "I'll never read it." I was just so tired of reading after the review process." In a moment both symbolic and personal, he added "We threw away so many manuscripts. We filled up an entire trash can. I just prayed to get rid of all that stuff."

And yet, it was never really discarded. Those drafts, those stories, those scribbled-out versions of the Steps—they were the compost from which NA's literature would grow. The book that finally arrived in members' hands was more than a publication. It was the birth of a voice. And behind that voice stood hundreds of nameless contributors-some in basements, some in prisons, some in coffee shops—crossing out "alcoholic" and writing in "addict," until the words finally fit.

A City's Voice

Philadelphia's role in the Basic Text creation-through drafts, feedback, and a refusal to settle for borrowed language—Was vital. Group-written steps and hand-typed drafts made their way into the final version. For members across the region, the book felt like theirs because, in so many ways, it was. This deep involvement gave members in the Philadelphia region a profound sense of ownership. The book was not something handed down. It was something built, brick by brick, from their own lived experience. Group conscience, so often invoked in NA's traditions, had taken tangible form-through the typewritten pages, mailed drafts, and collective labor of hundreds of unnamed contributors. John F., an early contributor, captured the chaotic grace of it all. "We had access to all these English matrices," he recalled. "So I wrote the assigned step and then forgot about it. Somehow, it ended up in the massive pile of materials flowing toward Bo." The "Bo" he referred to was Bo S., one of the early coordinators of the Basic Text effort, who often served as a funnel for the incoming avalanche of content.

Later, with a First Edition copy of the Basic Text in hand, John stumbled upon something unexpected. "I read that step," he said, "and I thought, 'Wow, this looks familiar.' They had taken it lock, stock, and barrel."

It was a startling moment-of recognition, of validation, and perhaps even of astonishment. A step he'd written, casually and anonymously, had found its way into the final draft of the book that would define NA for generations to come. His experience was emblematic of what many in Philadelphia felt: that NA's foundational literature wasn't just written about them-it was written by In the end, Philadelphia's role in shaping the Basic Text was not about credit. It was about voice. It was about a city—and a fellowship-finding the courage to speak in its own language. NA's Basic Text offered a clearer message and language tailored for addicts. Key readings like "Who is an Addict?" resonated deeply and helped newcomers understand they weren't alone or broken.

THE EAST COAST AWAKENS



By 1977, the scattered NA communities of the northeast were still in their early phases of fellowship, yet the seeds of connection were already being sown. That year, two members from Sunbury, Pennsylvania, attended a second Young People's AA Convention held in a convent in Harrison, New York. They brought with them NA literature and distributed it to curious young alcoholics. The event not only sparked interest in NA but planted a bolder idea: Could NA host its own convention on the East Coast? Later that fall, a few NA members from northeastern Pennsylvania set out to test the waters. John S. purchased NA's World Directory and mailed out nearly 100 letters of interest for hosting an east coast convention to various groups, service representatives, and committees. He used PO Box 1521 in Kingston, Pennsylvania, as the return address. More than 90 letters came back marked undeliverable. Those who did respond, while supportive, explained they lacked the resources or group strength to take part in a convention. Connecticut was the lone bright spot, offering genuine enthusiasm. Still, with little momentum, the idea of an East Coast Convention was quietly shelved.

At the October 22, 1978 PA North RSC meeting in Dunmore, Pennsylvania, the idea of an East Coast Convention was re-introduced-to bridge distance, unify regions, and make fellowship gatherings more accessible.

In July of 1979, talk resumed-this time with purpose. Members from Williamsport and other Pennsylvania towns gathered to reignite the idea. They proposed the convention be held the following July in Lewisburg, Pennsylvania. The theme was chosen: Never Alone. With it came a renewed sense of unity and a mission to build bridges between NA groups up and down the East Coast.

In September, WCNA-9 themed "I Can't. We Can," took place at the Sheraton Hotel in Atlanta, Georgia. Among those attending WCNA-9 were Bob P., Egon B., Guido A., and John S., all representing Pennsylvania. Their involvement at the convention sparked further action. On the long ride back to Pennsylvania, a draft proposal for a first East Coast Convention was scribbled on the back of the WCNA-9 convention package envelope. Soon after, a group of members proposed hosting an ECCNA, and a convention committee was elected to begin the process.

By January 1980, convention flyers began circulating. Yet, by March, only 50 registrations had come in. Doubt loomed over the planning committee. Still. they reasoned, if even 50 addicts believed in the vision, it was enough to carry On. Dances were hosted in Williamsport to raise money. Slowly, registrations doubled-just enough to make the dream viable. A message from co-chair Guido A. was sent out to the fellowship, updating members on the progress:

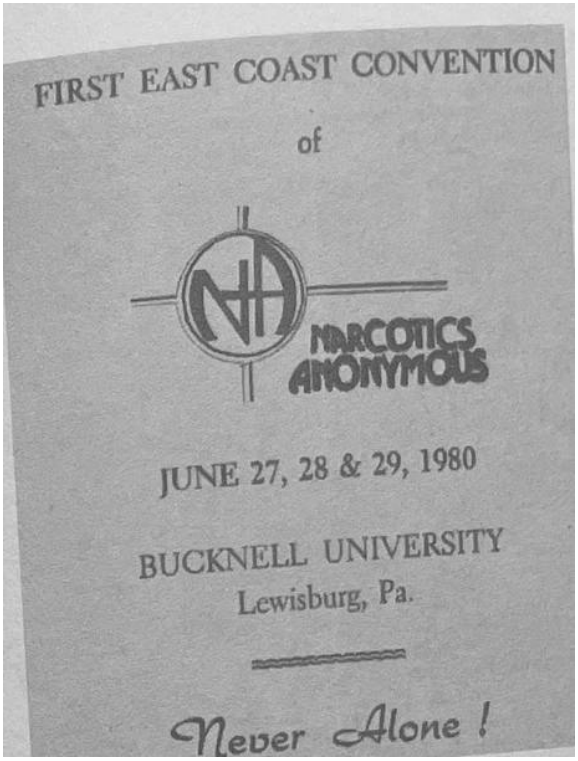
Our thanks go out to you-for without your support, this convention could never be possible... In March, only S0 people had registered, making things look grim. But since 50 people wanted the convention to happen, that was enough to keep us going. We now have double the amount of people registered. Our program committee has had a lot of response to the search for speakers.

Williamsport NA groups held dances to support the convention, which turned out great.

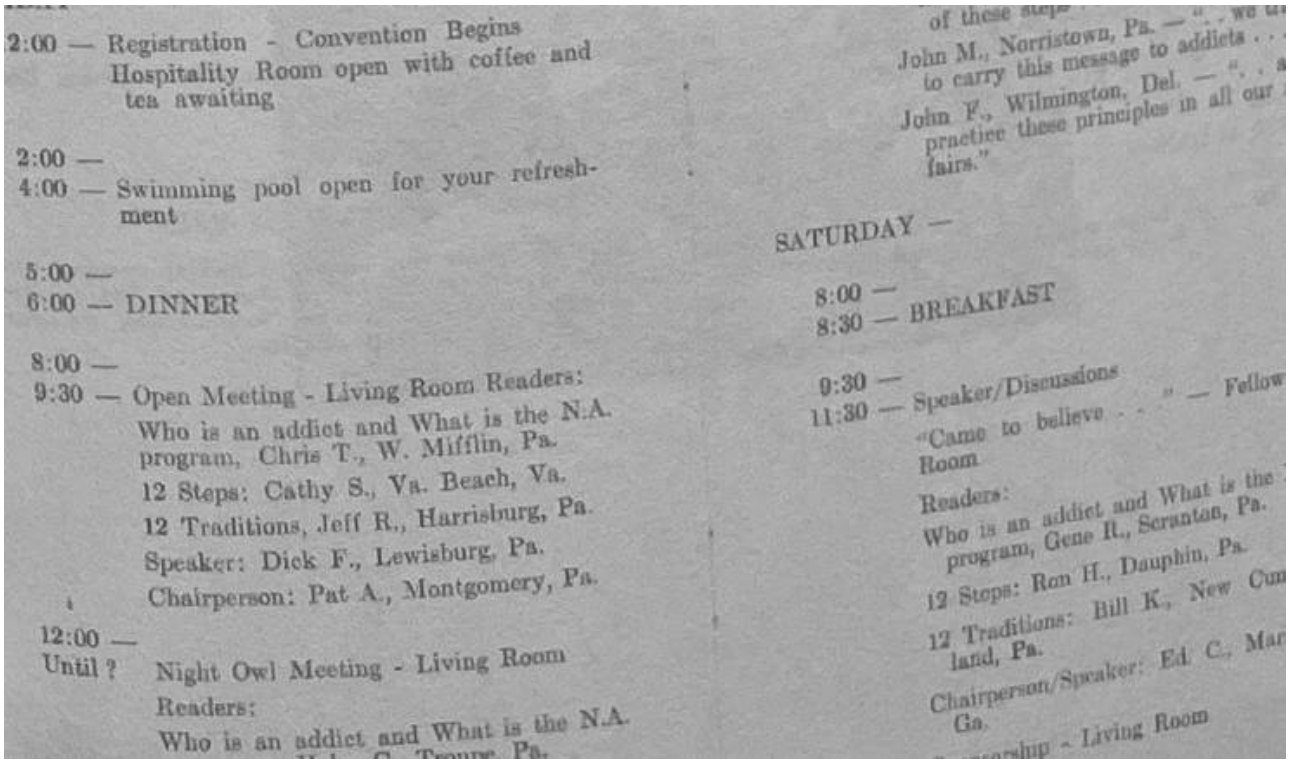
Bucknell University had been chosen deliberately. Inspired by the experience of attending ICYPAA at the University of Pennsylvania in 1976, the committee saw the benefits of a university setting. It offered dorm lodging, meeting space, recreational facilities, and meals in a single, affordable package. The cost for ECCNA-1: just $48 for the full weekend. Credit cards were not accepted.

FIRST EAST COAST CONVENTION OF NARCOTICS ANONYMOUS June 27, 28 & 29, 1980 Bucknell University, Lewisburg, Pa.

Never Alone!



The first East Coast Convention was held June 27–29, 1980, at Bucknell University in Lewisburg, Pennsylvania, with 190 addicts in attendance from 15 states and Canada. The theme “Never Alone” echoed through the halls of Bucknell. Guido and Paul S. served as chair and co-chair. Bob P., fittingly, was the DJ. The weekend’s program included speaker meetings, workshops, and plenty of fellowship.


2:00 — Registration - Convention Begins
Hospitality Room open with coffee and tea awaiting

2:00 —
4:00 — Swimming pool open for your refreshment

5:00 —
6:00 — DINNER

8:00 —
9:30 — Open Meeting - Living Room Readers:
Who is an addict and What is the N.A. program, Chris T., W. Mifflin, Pa.
12 Steps: Cathy S., Va. Beach, Va.
12 Traditions, Jeff R., Harrisburg, Pa.
Speaker: Dick F., Lewisburg, Pa.
Chairperson: Pat A., Montgomery, Pa.

12:00 —
Until ? Night Owl Meeting - Living Room
Readers:
Who is an addict and What is the N.A.

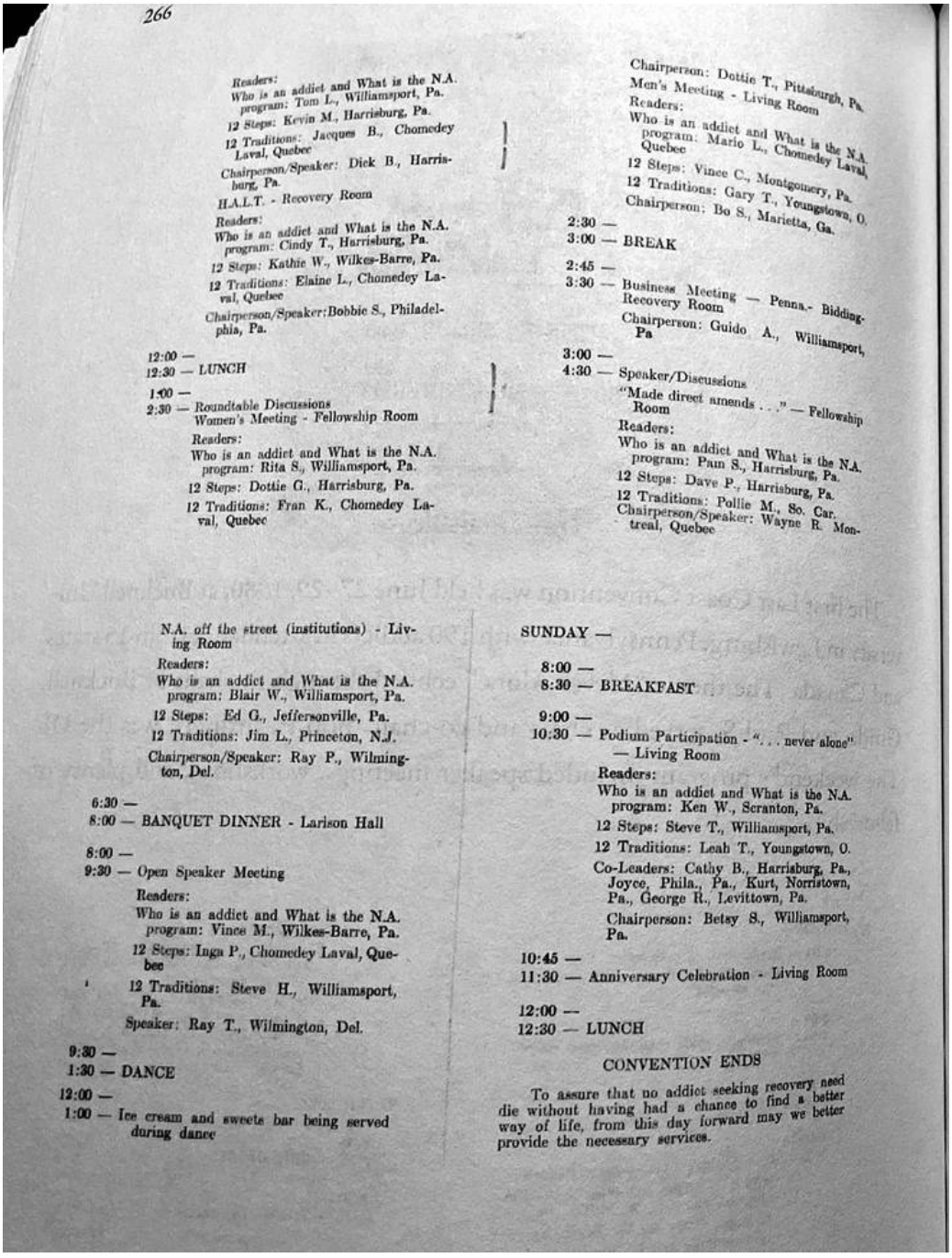
of these
John M., Norristown, Pa. —
to carry this message to addicts
John F., Wilmington, Del. —
practice these principles in all our
fairs."

SATURDAY —

8:00 —
8:30 — BREAKFAST

9:30 —
11:30 — Speaker/Discussions
"Came to believe
Room
Readers:
Who is an addict and What is the
program, Gene R., Scranton, Pa.
12 Steps: Ron H., Dauphin, Pa.
12 Traditions: Bill K., New Cum
land, Pa.
Chairperson/Speaker: Ed C., Mar
Ga.
Living Room

First East Coast Convention — original program



266

Readers:
Who is an addict and What is the N.A. program: Tom L., Williamsport, Pa.
12 Steps: Kevin M., Harrisburg, Pa.
12 Traditions: Jacques B., Chomedey Laval, Quebec
Chairperson/Speaker: Dick B., Harrisburg, Pa.

H.A.L.T. - Recovery Room

Readers:
Who is an addict and What is the N.A. program: Cindy T., Harrisburg, Pa.
12 Steps: Kathie W., Wilkes-Barre, Pa.
12 Traditions: Elaine L., Chomedey Laval, Quebec
Chairperson/Speaker: Bobbie S., Philadelphia, Pa.

12:00 —
12:30 — LUNCH

1:00 —
2:30 — Roundtable Discussions
Women's Meeting - Fellowship Room

Readers:
Who is an addict and What is the N.A. program: Rita S., Williamsport, Pa.
12 Steps: Dottie G., Harrisburg, Pa.
12 Traditions: Fran K., Chomedey Laval, Quebec

Chairperson: Dottie T., Pittsburgh, Pa.
Men's Meeting - Living Room
Readers:
Who is an addict and What is the N.A. program: Mario L., Chomedey Laval, Quebec
12 Steps: Vince C., Montgomery, Pa.
12 Traditions: Gary T., Youngstown, O.
Chairperson: Bo S., Marietta, Ga.

2:30 —
3:00 — BREAK

2:45 —
3:30 — Business Meeting — Penna.- Bidding-Recovery Room
Chairperson: Guido A., Williamsport, Pa

3:00 —
4:30 — Speaker/Discussions
"Made direct amends . . ." — Fellowship Room
Readers:
Who is an addict and What is the N.A. program: Pam S., Harrisburg, Pa.
12 Steps: Dave P., Harrisburg, Pa.
12 Traditions: Pollie M., So. Car.
Chairperson/Speaker: Wayne R. Montreal, Quebec

N.A. off the street (institutions) - Living Room
Readers:
Who is an addict and What is the N.A. program: Blair W., Williamsport, Pa.
12 Steps: Ed G., Jeffersonville, Pa.
12 Traditions: Jim L., Princeton, N.J.
Chairperson/Speaker: Ray P., Wilmington, Del.

6:30 —
8:00 — BANQUET DINNER - Larison Hall

8:00 —
9:30 — Open Speaker Meeting
Readers:
Who is an addict and What is the N.A. program: Vince M., Wilkes-Barre, Pa.
12 Steps: Inga P., Chomedey Laval, Quebec
12 Traditions: Steve H., Williamsport, Pa.
Speaker: Ray T., Wilmington, Del.

9:30 —
1:30 — DANCE

12:00 —
1:00 — Ice cream and sweets bar being served during dance

SUNDAY —

8:00 —
8:30 — BREAKFAST

9:00 —
10:30 — Podium Participation - ". . . never alone" — Living Room
Readers:
Who is an addict and What is the N.A. program: Ken W., Scranton, Pa.
12 Steps: Steve T., Williamsport, Pa.
12 Traditions: Leah T., Youngstown, O.
Co-Leaders: Cathy B., Harrisburg, Pa., Joyce, Phila., Pa., Kurt, Norristown, Pa., George R., Levittown, Pa.
Chairperson: Betsy S., Williamsport, Pa.

10:45 —
11:30 — Anniversary Celebration - Living Room

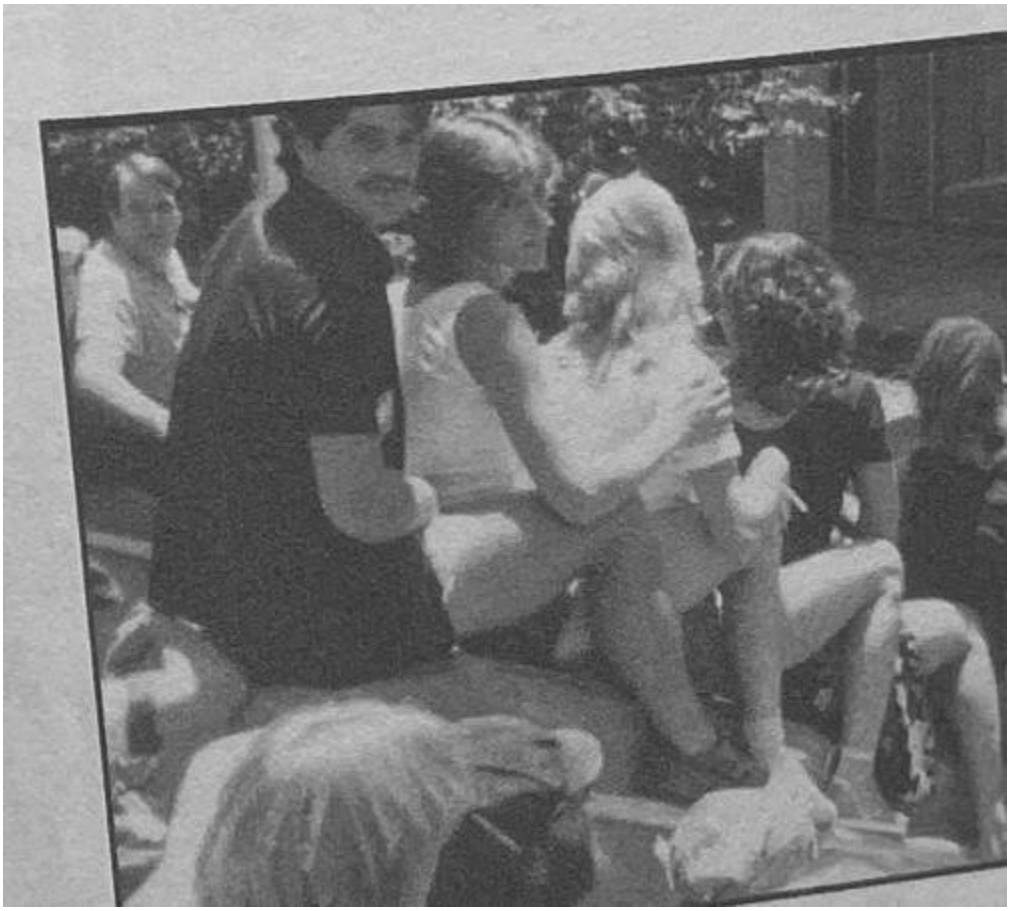
12:00 —
12:30 — LUNCH

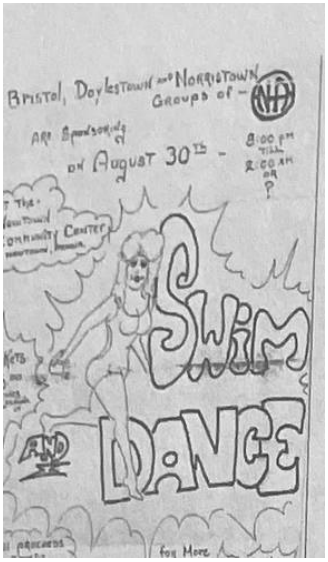
CONVENTION ENDS

To assure that no addict seeking recovery need die without having had a chance to find a better way of life, from this day forward may we better provide the necessary services.



An unplanned but memorable photograph captured Bobby B., Bobby F., and Sharon sitting on the campus steps—an image that would later evoke the spirit of the moment.

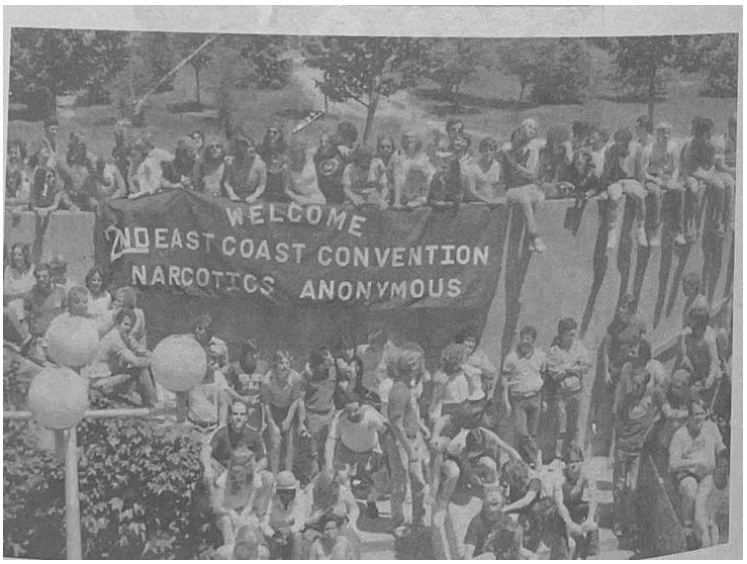




For many, ECCNA-1 was transformational. George W. likened it to “Woodstock, but without the drugs.” Al R. said it opened their eyes to other communities beyond Philadelphia. “We didn’t even know places like Pittsburgh or Williamsport had NA.” Pete B. returned home and found himself suddenly in demand: “I was speaking like 3–4 times a week all over.” Kurt E. captured the feeling of awe: “There were maybe 200 addicts, and I thought it was like the skies had opened up.”

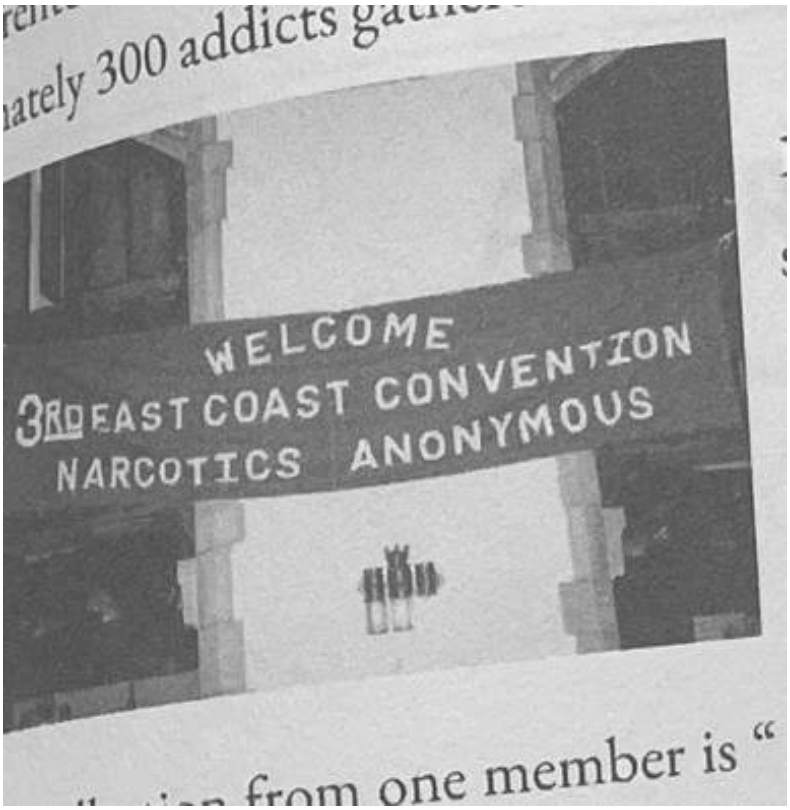
Fundraising for the ECCNA-2 began as early as August, 1980, with a “swim and dance” sponsored by the Bristol, Doylestown, and Norristown groups of NA.

Meeting at the YMCA in Norristown on January 11, ECCNA preparations were underway, inclusive of Nar-Anon and gay meetings.



The second East Coast Convention was held June 26–28, 1981, at Trenton State University in New Jersey. The theme was “Glad to be Alive.” Originally, Philadelphia was intended to host, but no suitable facility could be secured. So

Trenton became the site-despite a weekend of unrelenting rain. Still, approximately 300 addicts gathered.



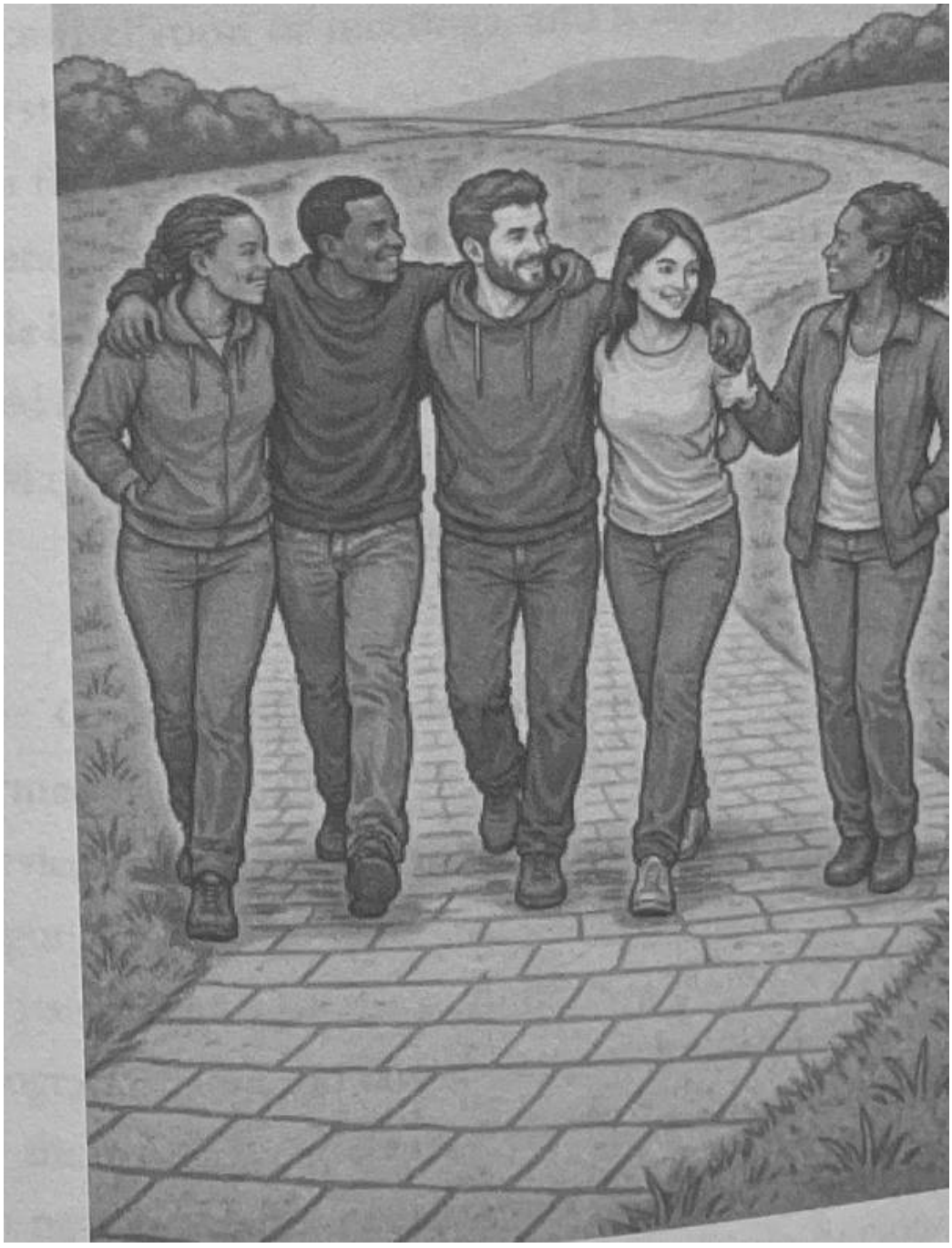
The third convention, held June 25-27, 1982, brought ECCNA to western Pennsylvania for the first time. Hosted at Robert Morris College in Moon Township outside Pittsburgh, ECCNA-3 carried the theme "Miracles Happen." Bob P. served as chairman. Over 300 attendees participated. The recollection from one member is " .. that it really blew up from there. Like the second East Coast Convention was something that you really didn't hear about, or at least I didn't. I mean, I kind of heard about it, but it wasn't a push. But when it came to the third East Coast of Pittsburgh, that's when it all blew up."

What began in 1977 as an idea whispered through returned mail and hopeful conversations eventually grew into a multi-state movement. The East Coast Convention gave NA a home base outside of California and served as a proving ground for the larger mission of unity, service, and literature development. In the years that followed, ECCNA would become a vital thread in the NA fabric—its story told not just in flyers and meeting lists, but in the memories and voices of those who were there.

As Pete B. later recalled: "There's a new energy in NA-that's a little different.

We should listen to this... because it's coming into its own."

AFTERWORD



From a scattered beginning with one addict with a White Book, to meeting in hospital basements, borrowed church halls, and the kitchens of willing families, Narcotics Anonymous began to take shape in the 1970s and early 1980s by "paving the road as we went." Nothing was promised; nothing was certain. Meetings were fragile, sometimes vanishing as quickly as they appeared, and the White Book was passed from hand to hand until its pages wore thin. Yet from these fragile threads, a fabric was slowly woven. Addicts wrote letters across counties, answered phones in the night, and opened their homes and hearts to strangers. They walked into prisons, hospitals, and halfway houses with trembling courage, carrying a message that was still rough around the edges but already alive with power: we do recover.

What was forged in those years was more than an organization-it was a fellowship, a culture, a way of belonging for those who had long felt beyond reach. Out of chaos and improvisation grew a voice that addicts could finally call their own. By the early 1980s, NA had found its foundation: a body of literature, a growing constellation of meetings, and a language that spoke directly to the addict who still suffers. The years ahead would bring new tests, wider horizons, and growth far beyond what those first members could have imagined. Yet the gift of this era remains: proof that even from the smallest sparks, a fire can spread. From fragile beginnings, a fellowship rose—built on hope, sustained by service, and destined to carry its message across the world, one addict at a time.

At the May 1983 WSC John F. Greater Philadelphia RSR submitted his report:

The Greater Philadelphia Regional Service Committee was formed in the Fall of 1982, when the then-Philadelphia Area Service Committee disbanded. The old Philadelphia ASC was first begun in 1972 [sic] and had grown incalculably in the ten years of its existence. By the summer of 1982, it encompassed a wide geographic area and served over one hundred NA meetings. Out of sheer practical necessity, the Philadelphia ASC divided. Seven new area service committees were formed from its remains.

Two of those areas joined the Mid-Atlantic Region. The other

five—Philadelphia, Southern New Jersey, Montgomery County.

Delaware-TriCounty, and Bucks County-now comprise what we call the Greater Philadelphia Region.

There are 81 Narcotics Anonymous meetings in the Greater Philadelphia Region. There are 25 prison and institution meetings. A recent census estimated that there are two thousand drug addicts recovering in the NA program in Greater Philadelphia During the group conscience meetings at our Service Conference, NA member after NA member in greater Philadelphia expressed their dismay at the recent development concerning the changes made in Our Book" and the problems involved in the book's printing, particularly the question of the missing funds raised to Publish it. The almost unanimous group conscience of the members of Narcotics Anonymous in Greater Philadelphia is expressed in its endorsement of a plan developed by the Greater Philadelphia RSC to decentralize and restructure the World Service Office and the Board of Trustees-a plan we hope to propose at this World Service Conference. Philadelphia is proud of its long NA history and is anxious to share its experience, strength, and hope with the rest of our Fellowship.

Several years ago a member in Philadelphia wrote a book called Living Clean, which is intended to be a guide to the newcomer to the program. Since then several review committees under the direction and with the approval of the Greater Philadelphia RSC have polished and revised the book. We now feel Living Clean is ready to share with other NA members and have brought copies

with us to distribute to members of this Conference. We would like to submit the book to whatever approval process is considered necessary.

Living Clean is Greater Philadelphia's gift to the Fellowship of Narcotics. Anonymous.

Dick B., Mid-Atlantic RSR submitted his report:

In the past year the Mid-Atlantic Region has developed into three regions. The Mid-Atlantic Region as it stands now comprises New Hampshire, Connecticut, Massachusetts, South Central Pennsylvania, North Central Pennsylvania, Little Apple Area of Allentown, Northeastern NJ, and New Jersey for a total of eight areas.

Those areas represent 139 groups - 20 institutional meetings - 6 hotlines. Our closest estimate of active members comes up to 630 addicts in the Mid-Atlantic Region.

This isn't just structure, it's survival. It's us learning how to serve what saved our lives.

The Unforeseen Reach of the Vision

When Narcotics Anonymous first took shape, even its earliest visionaries could not have imagined the scope it would one day achieve. As Al R. reflected, Jimmy K.-one of the fellowship's most influential figures-carried a deep sense of purpose for NA's future. Yet, in those formative years, the horizon seemed far closer than the reality we now know. Dave F., who had personally visited the WSO and attended a WSC, spoke with admiration about the fellowship's progress. "NA is certainly so much bigger now, and I think NA's done a pretty good job-really, I do. They've done a remarkable job of getting the message out to the world that we exist, that we are a separate fellowship." Dwayne S. saw this growth not only as a matter of numbers, but as proof of NA's ability to remain relevant in a changing world. "I realized the changes

were... the society changed," he said. "And so that change in the recovery process changed. But NA has always been able to-how I put it—adapt to sit with society.

With the addict."

Together, their reflections form a bridge between NA's modest beginnings and its unprecedented global reach—a living testament to a vision that, though humble in origin, found its way to every corner of the world.

An Invitation to Keep the Story Alive

This book isn't just about the past-it's about us. Every meeting you've sat In, every coffee shared after a speaker, every moment you've watched someone's eyes light up with hope... that's NA history too.

What you've just read is one piece of a much bigger picture, and that picture isn't finished. Our fellowship's story keeps unfolding every day-in home groups, In prisons, in recovery houses, and in far-off places where NA is still finding its voice. If you were there when something happened, you are part of that history. Maybe you remember the first time a meeting opened in your town, or the night a newcomer said something that stuck with you forever. Maybe you've seen NA grow in ways no one expected-or you've watched it weather storms and still stand strong. We invite you to help keep this story alive. Share your memories. Lend your voice. This book belongs to all of us, and your part matters. After all, our history isn't just about where we' ve been—it's about where we're going, and how we keep carrying the message to the addict who still suffers.

We are still paving the road as we go!

QUESTIONNAIRE

In May 2015, four addicts-Dave F., Rob U., Danny M., and Brian M.-met for the first (and last) time at Dave's house with the hope of writing a history of the Greater Philadelphia Region. Before they disbanded they agreed on the interviewees, and created a release form and a questionnaire-the same one used for this Philadelphia NA Book Project. At that time, the timeline had not yet been defined, so questions about the "language wars," which became more apparent after 1982, were not asked of the interviewees for this project.

The members selected for the Philadelphia NA Book Project were given the Opportunity to review the questions prior to being interviewed. At that time, they were informed that the questions simply were a guide for their recollections, and that they were encouraged to expound beyond the limitations of those questions. In many cases, the interviewees dug deep into their collective memories and Offered a wealth of historical material that would not have been captured had they restricted their responses to the twenty-four questions.

The Philadelphia NA Book Project

1. When and how did you first hear about NA?
2. Where was your first meeting? Who took you?
3. Had you ever been to a 12-Step meeting before that?
4. Did you also go to AA? Did you continue to do so?
5. What NA meetings did you attend?
6. How did you feel about the message you heard there?
7. Did you get a sponsor? Did you get involved in service? Were you aware of/did you attend any H&I meetings? Did you start any meetings?
8. Did you attend any conventions, conferences, roundups, or any other special events?
9. Were you aware of/did you attend intergroup or area service committee?
10. What did you find different about NA from other fellowships?
11. What literature was used?
12. Are there any memories you have of events that stand out in your mind?
13. Did NA work for you? Did you ever relapse? What is your clean date?
14. How do you feel that modern NA measures up to the NA you found when you first got involved?
15. If you are a female or a member of a minority, were there any special challenges or concerns you had about NA?
16. Did you attend any meetings which were not reported on meeting lists (NA secret meetings)?
17. Did you experience any efforts to change the language and the way that addicts express themselves in meetings? Were you witness to the “language wars”?
18. Were you a witness to or did you have direct experience with anyone requesting or demanding that you use different language at the meeting to identify yourself and to identify your recovery?
19. If you were in a treatment center/rehab, were there any meetings there?
20. If you were incarcerated, was there any literature or were there meetings in the institution?
21. What rituals did you observe in NA, such as hand holding, hugging, or recitation of prayers?
22. Were you ever asked to leave a meeting for any reason?
23. Do you still attend NA meetings?
24. Is there anyone else you can think of who can contribute to this project? (added 3/15/23)